

Blazing A Path

In his first column for *Chess Life*, GM Daniel Naroditsky begins his endings investigations with a look at pawn-only endgames.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IT IS WITH GREAT PLEASURE THAT WE introduce our new endgame column and columnist, GM Daniel Naroditsky's "The Practical Endgame." You can read more about "Danya" in the April *Chess Life* and on page 16 of this issue. The column's title resurrects a title from decades ago in this magazine, penned by the late GM Edmar Mednis. The focus will be on endings by American players.

Endgames can be divided into two categories: theoretical endgames, in which the correct move or plan (and the result of the game) has already been determined by prior analysis, and practical endgames, in which it is impossible to rely on endgame theory as a crutch. Both are equally important, but I will focus on the latter. Practical endings arise more frequently in tournament practice, and they are replete with complex and aesthetically pleasing motifs. My endgame credo is simple: there is no replacement to a healthy mix of verbal and analytic explanations. With that, I invite you to join me in blazing a path through the sea of practical endings!

Fittingly enough, we will start with endgames involving no pieces at all. Pawn endings are tremendously difficult to play and master, simply because one hasty or inaccurate decision—one incorrect king move, for example—could instantly alter the result of the game. King plus pawn versus king endgames have been thoroughly examined, and it is tempting to assume that if you know about opposition and triangulation, you have mastered pawn endings. However, this naïve belief could not be farther from the truth. In the following two games, we will see just how intricate and complex pawn endgames—even those with just one or two pawns for each side can be.

(see diagram top of next column)

The position appears to resemble a stereotypical case of an outside passed pawn deciding the outcome of the game: since Black's king cannot move from the

Don't stereotype!

GM Robert James Fischer

GM Arthur Bisguier

U.S. Championship (1), New York, 12.18.1959



AFTER 43... Ke5

fifth rank (he cannot allow Kd4), White must simply await the perfect opportunity to sacrifice his passed pawn in order to expose Black's vulnerable kingside pawns. Unfortunately, the immediate 44. g5 does not quite work: 44. ... Kf5 45. Kd4 Kxg5 46. Kxc4 and Black is in time to defend his pawns: 46. ... Kf6 47. Kd5 Ke7. Fischer panics not: he simply moves his king back and forth, forcing Bisguier to advance his own pawns and make them easily accessible to White's king.

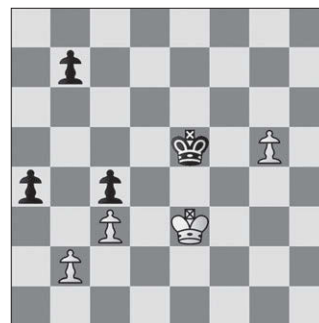
44. Kf3 a5 45. Ke3 a4

Forced. 45. ... b5? 46. g5 Kf5 (trading pawns does not help: 46. ... b4 47. g6 bxc3 48. bxc3 Kf6 49. Kd4 and White will pick up both pawns) 47. Kd4 Kxg5 48. Kc5 and Black's neglectful king, in his own greedy pursuits, has left his pawns to the wolves.

46. g5

(see diagram top of next column)

The attempt to induce a further advance of Black's pawns with 46. Kf3 could have backfired: 46. ... Kf6 47. Kf4 Kg6 48. g5 b6 and now White is best advised to settle for a draw with 49. Ke4, since 49. Kg4?? actually loses to 49. ... b5! 50. Kf4 b4 51. cxb4 c3! and it suddenly turns out that



Black's pawns—as weak as they are—have succeeded in breaking through on their own. Once again, the consequences of regal neglect are put on full display.

46. ... Kf5 47. Kd4 Kxg5 48. Kxc4 Kf4 49. Kb4 Ke3 50. Kxa4 Kd2

Unfortunately for White, the immediate 51. Kb5? does not work on account of 51. ... Kc2 52. Kb6 Kxb2 53. c4 Kb3 54. c5 Kb4, so Fischer tries to patiently outmaneuver Black's pesky king before advancing his pawns.

51. Kb3 Kd3 52. c4 Kd2

Black's king cannot travel too far back. After 52. ... Kd4? 53. Kb4 Kd3 54. Kb5 Kd4 55. b4 Black cannot stop 56. c5 followed by 57. Kb6.

53. Ka4 Kc2 54. Ka3

Fischer continues his patient triangulation, trying to reach a position in which Black must either move his b-pawn or move his king to an unfavorable position. Such a strategy works 99 cases out of a 100 ...

54. ... Kd3 55. Kb3

At this point, Fischer must have breathed a sigh of relief. 55. ... Kd2 allows the c-pawn to move forward, and 55. ... Kd4 allows the b-pawn to advance uncontested. Clearly under the same impression, Bisguier folds:

55. ... b6??

This is clearly tantamount to capitulation, but what else could be done? As

Zugzwang!

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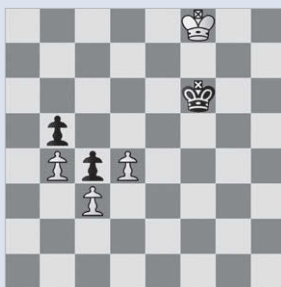
See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

Samuel Reshevsky

Jaime Sunye Neto

Lone Pine op (7), Lone Pine, California
03.28.1977



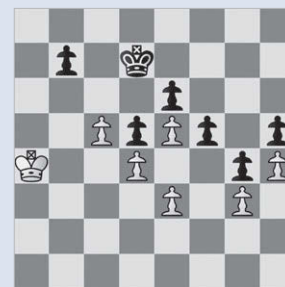
WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

Pal Benko

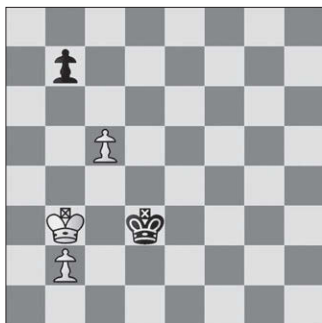
Mato Damjanovic

Monte Carlo (12), Monte Carlo MNC
04.15.1968



WHITE TO MOVE

we've already seen, 55. ... Kd4 56. Kb4 Kd3 57. Kb5 is curtains, but what about 55. ... Kd2? Bisguier evidently thought 56. c5 won on the spot, but—and I hope you are sitting in a chair while you are reading this—White cannot make progress after 56. ... Kd3!



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

White's main problem is that he cannot leave the b2-pawn unattended. To this end, the straightforward 57. Kb4 Kc2 58. b3 (58. Kb5 wins after 58. ... Kb3? 59. Kb6 Kb4 60. b3!, but the paradoxical 58. ... Kd3! does not allow the same trick: 59. Kb6 Kc4 60. b3+ Kb4! and Black has the last laugh!) 58. ... Kd3 59. Kb5 Kc3 60. b4 Kb3 leads nowhere. White can try 61. Ka5!?, but the calm 61. ... Kc4! draws immediately. Amazingly, White simply has no way to force Black into *Zugzwang* or keep his b-pawn protected:

A. 57. Ka4!? is tricky, but achieves little after 57. ... Kc4 58. b4 Kd4 59. Kb5 Kc3 60. Ka4 Kd4! (not 60. ... Kc4?? 61. Ka5, with b4-b5 to follow) 61. Kb5 Kc3 and White cannot make progress.

B. 57. Ka3 allows an immediate draw with 57. ... Kc4 58. b4 Kb5 followed by ... b6. A one-of-a-kind drawing mechanism!

56. Kb4 Kc2 57. Ka3! Kd3 58. Kb3

A final triangulation, and this time, Black runs out of tricks.

58. ... Kd2 59. Ka4 Kc2 60. b4, Black resigned.

The importance of king activity in the endgame is well-known, but as we could

see, even in the most hopeless-looking pawn endgame, king activity can defy all conventional notions.

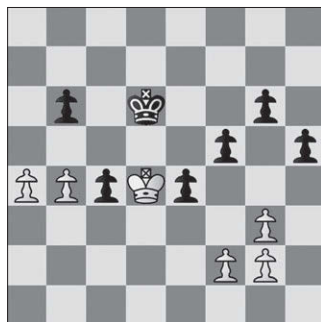
Now, as a lighthearted encore, let us take a look at the flip side of the coin: those rare cases in which bloodthirsty (promotion-thirsty?) pawns do vanquish an active king.

Bloodthirsty pawns

IM Norman Weinstein

Michael Rohde

Lone Pine op (4), Lone Pine, California, 03.23.1977



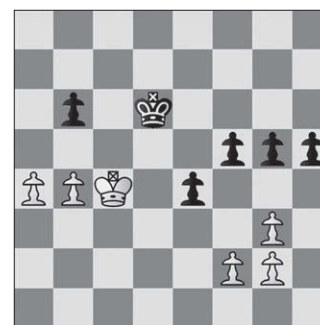
AFTER 39. a4

Black is a pawn up, but not for long. White will recapture the doomed pawn on c4, and reach a familiar scenario: an outside passed pawn lethally distracting the opponent's king. This time, Black seems unable to put up any resistance: his pawn chain is extremely vulnerable. Thus, Rohde's only conceivable chance is to organize some kind of kingside counterplay and his next move is practically forced:

39. ... g5 40. Kxc4

(see diagram top of next column)

Black's kingside pawn armada sure looks intimidating, but White needs only one move—Kd4 or a4-a5—and it will be permanently put out of commission. For instance, the indolent 40. ... Kc6? fails to impress after 41. Kd4 Kd6 42. a5 bxa5 43. bxa5 Kc6 44. Ke5 and the game is over. Evidently, disheartened, Rohde went down without a fight:



40. ... h4? 41. gxh4 gxh4 42. Kd4 Ke6 43. a5 bxa5 44. bxa5 Kd6 45. a6 Kc6 46. Ke5 Kb6 47. Kxf5 Kxa6 48. Kxe4, Black resigned.

But was Black's counterplay really non-existent? Let's return to the diagrammed position after White's 40th move. With White's king temporarily distant from the kingside, it is clear that Black must create a passed pawn in his own right. The paradoxical 40. ... g4, intending 41. ... f4 42. gxf4 h4, certainly makes sense. However, White's king comes to the rescue yet again: 41. Kd4 f4 42. Kxe4 and Black is dead. But what about 40. ... f4? In that case, 41. Kd4? actually loses to 41. ... f3! 42. gxf3 h4, but Rohde evidently thought that 41. gxf4 gxf4 42. Kd4 was hopeless. Hopefully, you can see that this is not the case. By sacrificing the e- and f-pawns, Black paves the way for his remaining kingside pawn in study-like fashion: 42. ... e3! 43. fxe3 f3! 44. gxf3 h4 45. Ke4 h3 and the pawn is unstoppable; White's own pawns fatally impede the king's movement.

It is crucial to remember that in practical endgames, you must determine in which cases general principles apply. Even in pawn endings, an active king might be powerless against a passed pawn (Weinstein-Rohde), and an ostensibly overwhelming material advantage might actually not be enough to win (Fischer-Bisguier). Ironically, in both cases, Black was so convinced that his position was unsalvageable that he failed to discover the hidden counterplay. ♠

Knight Endings

As in pawn endings, knight endings require precise calculation, else disaster lurks around the corner.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IN LAST MONTH'S COLUMN, WE SET out on our endgame voyage with a discussion of pawn endings, which can be improbably complex. One slight miscalculation—one impulsive decision—and hours of work could easily go down the drain. Paradoxically, knight endings, the subject of this article, are practically no different.

The reason is twofold. First, the probability of a knight trade is very high, and the resulting pawn endgames must be scrutinized by both players. Intuition is hardly applicable in such instances—evaluations such as += or +/- are meaningless in pawn endgames! Second, knights can be (read: often are) terrible at restraining passed pawns. Thus, knight endgames are laden with tactical possibilities, and mistakes are rarely forgiven.

As GM Jonathan Rowson notes in his excellent book *The Seven Deadly Chess Sins*, the best way to unravel the complexities of a position is to simply “plunge in and get your hands dirty.” In examining the following two brilliant (and unknown) games, be prepared to not only exercise your calculational abilities and logic, but also to redefine your preconceived notions of what a mere king, knight, and pawn(s) can achieve!

No Cigar

Harry Nelson Pillsbury

Isidor Gunsberg

Hastings (21), Hastings, England, 09.02.1895



BLACK TO MOVE

The position seems nearly ripe for the players to call it a day. White has a formidable protected passer on c5 and a pleasant space advantage, but if Black can maneuver his knight to c6, push his a-pawn to a5, and close up the kingside, White will simply have no conceivable way to make progress. As such, both 26. ... f5! 27. g5 a5 28. Kd2 Kd8 (the immediate 28. ... Nb8 is worse on account of 29. Ne5) 29. a3 Kc7 and 26. ... a5!? 27. f5 g5 28. fxe6 Nb8! followed by ... Nc6 and ... Kxe6 seem to do the trick. Gunsberg, however, decides to take care of the knight maneuver first:

26. ... Nb8?

From a general standpoint, Black's move is perfectly fine. He needs one more move (... Nc6) to solidify his position, and 27. Nb4 leads nowhere after 27. ... a5, since 28. c6? fails to 28. ... Kd6. However, Black has temporarily retreated his knight to a very passive square, and has left his king and pawns to their own devices (if only for one move). Pillsbury has no time to waste, and he knows it:

27. f5!

A real “grandmaster” move. With Black's knight vacationing on b8, Black's pawn structure has become rather fragile. After 27. ... gxf5 28. gxf5 exf5 29. Nf4, for instance, the d5-pawn is suddenly indefensible and White's connected passers will be unstoppable after 29. ... Nc6 30. Nxd5+ Kf7 31. Kd2 followed by Kc3 and a timely Nf4. Still, Gunsberg thinks that he has everything planned out:

27. ... g5

With this move, Black takes the crucial f4-square under control and renews the “threat” of ... Nc6. True, the d5-pawn is weakened after 28. fxe6 Kxe6, but it is safely controlled by the king and Black will ingrain his knight on c6 before White has a chance to push the e-pawn. Thus, the only way that White can conceivably

prolong the game is to wrest the c6-square from Black's control. With the black king relegated to the defense of the e6-pawn, the c-pawn advance could—under lucky circumstances—be rather dangerous for the knight.

28. Nb4 a5

At this point, Gunsberg must have breathed a sigh of relief (I was tempted to add “and taken a whiff of his cigar,” but according to the 16 June 1889 *New York Times*, uncovered by chess historian Edward Winter, Gunsberg “neither smokes nor drinks”). After the knight's seemingly imminent retreat, Black will finally play ... Nc6 and construct an impenetrable fortress. However, as I have mentioned, treacherous tactics frequently hide behind the peaceful façade of a knight endgame. Out of the clear blue sky, using the weakness of Black's pawn structure introduced by White's 27th move (f4-f5), Pillsbury uncorks a stunning combination:

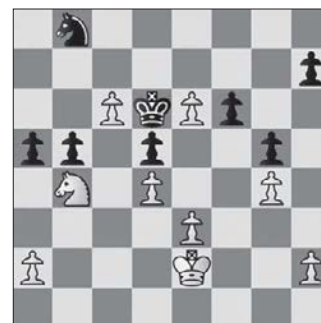
29. c6!

Has White gone crazy? Embarking on a suicide mission with the pride of his position? White's pawn will promote after 29. ... axb4?? 30. c7, but Black's king happily assists the sleeping cavalier:

29. ... Kd6

But now, the lethal consequences of Black's negligent 26th move are revealed:

30. fxe6!!



Knights

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See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2697)
GM Varuzhan Akobian (FIDE 2611)
2008 Montreal International, 08.25.2008



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Roman Dzindzichashvili
IM Francisco R. T. Trois
Buenos Aires olm, 1978



WHITE TO MOVE

A beautiful concept! Both of Black's pieces surround White's passers, but they cannot be stopped without fatal concessions. Since 30. ... axb4 31. e7! Kxe7 32. c7 is curtains, Gunsberg is forced to enter a hopeless pawn ending:

30. ... Nxc6 31. Nxc6 Kxc6 32. e4!

An elegant finesse. White establishes connected passers deep in Black's territory. With his king out of commission, Gunsberg will not be able to save his pawns.

32. ... dxe4 33. d5+ Kd6 34. Ke3 b4 35. Kxe4 a4 36. Kd4

Close, but no cigar! Unfortunately for Black, the thematic 36. ... b3 37. axb3 a3 38. Kc3 leads nowhere.

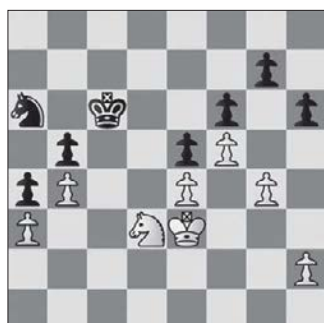
36. ... h5 37. gxh5 a3 38. Kc4 f5 39. h6 f4 40. h7, Black resigned.

A magnificent display, played at a time when general endgame knowledge was still practically nonexistent.

Fast forward 118 years. Even though endgame finesse and tactical mastery are now commonplace, it is easy to be lulled to sleep by the apparent innocence of a position. In the following game, ultra-experienced IM Jay Bonin puts on a tremendous endgame display after his opponent makes an outwardly trivial inaccuracy.

Just one inaccuracy ...

IM Jay R. Bonin (2420)
Benjamin W. Krause (2294)
2013 World Team (2), 02.16.2013



WHITE TO MOVE

Analogous to the Pillsbury-Gunsberg game, White has a nice space advantage and Black's pieces are rather passive. However, two factors make it exceedingly difficult for White to make progress. First, Black threatens to ensconce a knight on c4 (via d6), where it will attack the weak a3-pawn. Even if White succeeds in winning the battle on the kingside, he might lose the war on the queenside! Second, and most importantly, Black does not actually have any weaknesses. The b5-pawn can be defended by the knight, and the g7-pawn by the king.

43. Kf3 Kd6 44. Kg3 Ke7 45. Kh4 Nc7?

With time to spare, Black decides to improve the position of his knight—and why not? If it reaches d6, the tables could suddenly turn in Black's favor. In a sense, White's plan can be determined by process of elimination. Where must White's knight be to stop ... Nd6? You guessed it: b7!

46. Kh5!

Patience is the hallmark of a strong endgame player. Before penetrating with his knight, Bonin improves the position of his king to the maximum. This improvement might or might not be significant, but it certainly will not hurt.

46. ... Kf7 47. Nc5 Ne8 48. Nb7!

On b7, White's knight not only takes away the d6-square from its adversary, but—and this detail must have been overlooked by Krause—will force Black's king to retreat as well.

48. ... Nc7 49. Nd8+!

Interestingly, White had another way to win: 49. Nd6+! Ke7, and now White refrains from the impulsive 50. Kg6?? Kxd6 51. Kxg7, which loses after 51. ... Ke7 52. h4 Ne8+ 53. Kxh6 Nd6 54. Kg7 Nxe4 55. h5 Ng5, and plays 50. Nc8+ Kf7 51. Na7! instead. Black is in *Zugzwang* and must allow the decisive king penetration to g6.

49. ... Kg8

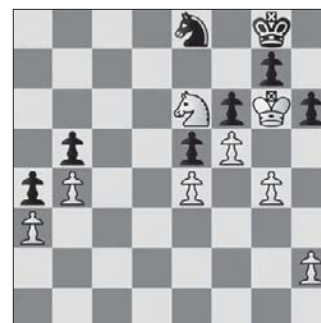
Krause must have overlooked that after 49. ... Ke7, White wins with the elegant 50. Ne6!. Black loses in every variation:

A. 50. ... Nxe6 51. fxe6 Kxe6 52. Kg6 Ke7 53. Kxg7.

B. 50. ... Na6!? 51. Kg6 Nxb4 looks scary at first sight, but White is in time to stop the pawn after 52. axb4 a3 53. Nc5 a2 54. Nb3. Black can try to hold on with 54. ... Kf8, but he loses after 55. Na1 Kg8 56. h4! followed by 57. g5.

C. 50. ... Ne8 is the most resilient defense, but Black is in a lethal *Zugzwang* yet again after 51. Kg6 Nd6 52. Nxc7 Nxe4 53. Nh5!.

50. Kg6 Ne8 51. Ne6



Another *Zugzwang*! This time, Black's position collapses.

51. ... Nd6 52. Nxc7 Nf7 53. Kxf6, Black resigned.

In fact, Black *did* have a draw! Had he simply left his knight on a6 (at least for some time), White would have had no way of penetrating. For instance, after 45. ... Kf8! 46. Kh5 Kf7 47. h4 Nb8! 48. Nc5 Nc6 Black's knight reaches d4 in time: 49. Nb7! Nd4 50. Nd6+ Ke7 and the king will return to f7.

In both games, an ostensibly natural and strong move decided the outcome of the game, changing the evaluation from drawn to losing. This is why knight endgames are so difficult to play! However, if you are tactically vigilant and do not hurry to make seemingly obvious moves, you will be just fine. ♠

Courage versus Caution

A titanic bishop versus knight battle

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

WITHOUT A DOUBT, MY FAVORITE endgames are ones that feature some type of material imbalance. This month we examine a titanic fight between the bishop and knight, two pieces that have been engaged in perennial battle. When analyzing a particularly complex endgame, it is sometimes difficult, as it were, to simply enjoy the art being created on the board. Be prepared to think, but also be prepared to witness a comeback of epic proportions.

Dead in the water?

GM Roman Dzindzichashvili (FIDE 2550)

GM Lubomir Kavalek (FIDE 2570)

Buenos Aires, Argentina, 1978



WHITE TO MOVE

By all measures, Black should be dead in the water. He is down a piece for two pawns, and it is hard to imagine that his “fortress” will hold up against White’s hyperactive, impeccably coordinated forces. However, endgames are notoriously impervious to logic, and White must approach the position from a concrete point of view in order to actually win the game. As it turns out, it is actually quite difficult to penetrate with straightforward maneuvering. For instance, White could try to entrench a knight on e5 with 42. Nd3 Ke6 43. f4 Kd6 44. Ne5, but Black has the annoying rejoinder 44. ... Ne5! and matters are annoyingly complicated after 45. Kc3 Ne4+ 46. Kc2 Nxc3. I would not have been surprised if White eked out a victory with

accurate play, but Dzindzichashvili found a far more convincing solution:

42. Nxd5+!

Simple, thematic, and strong. It is always tough to part with material in the endgame, but the resulting knight versus bishop looks totally hopeless for Black.

42. ... cxd5 43. Kxd5

Black’s position is a sorry sight: the b6-a5 pawn chain is doomed, and by the time Black gets anything going on the other flank, White will have two queens on the board. He can try passive defense 43. ... Ke7 44. Kc6 Kd8, but the precise 45. f4! Kc8 46. Bc4 Kd8 47. Bf7 ends his dreams of a miraculous defense. To put up any kind of resistance, it is clear that Black cannot tarry.

43. ... g5!

Kavalek refuses to die peacefully. While Black’s desperate attempt at counterplay can be quashed in a variety of ways, White is still forced to demonstrate his calculational ability. Dzindzi (if I were to spell out his full name every time, I would end up in the nearest psychiatric facility) pays little heed to Black’s apparent tomfoolery:

44. Kc6!?

There is absolutely nothing wrong with this move per se, but in my opinion, White had a far more straightforward way to suppress Black’s pesky activity: 44. f4. In his annotations (presumably from *Chess Informant*, although they are given on ChessBase without attribution), Dzindzi asserts that Black attains counterplay with 44. ... g4, but Black’s knight will need eons of time to actually capture the g3-pawn and set his own pawns in motion. For instance, after 45. Kc6 Nc5 46. Kxb6 Ne4 (on 46. ... Nxb3, the most accurate response is 47. Bd3! Kg6 48. Bc2 Nd2 [48. ... Nd4 leads nowhere after 49. Bd1, and the “active” knight is entirely restrained by the “passive” bishop] 49. Kxa5 Nf1 50. Kb5 Nxc3 51. a5 Ne2 and

although the pawns will promote simultaneously, Black’s scattered pieces will stand no chance against the vicious queen and bishop: 52. a6 g3 53. a7 g2 54. a8=Q g1=Q 55. Qe8+ and White picks up the knight) 47. Kxa5 Nxc3 48. Bg2, the position resembles a NASCAR race in which Black has chosen to drive an Edsel. The bishop specializes in restraining passed pawns, while the clumsy knight stands no chance against an active king and mobile passers: 48. ... Ne2 49. Kb6 Nxf4 50. Bb7! (this is a lot more accurate than 50. a5?! Nxc2 51. a6 Nxc4 52. a7 g3 53. a8=Q Kg5, when White still has to deal with some unpleasant business on the kingside) 50. ... Ne6 51. a5 f4 52. a6 f3 53. a7 f2 54. Bg2 and Black goes down in flames. Of course, it is quite difficult to calculate all of this during a game (especially in time pressure), but from an intuitive standpoint, it should be perfectly clear that Black stands no chance in a pawn race of this sort.

44. ... Ne5+ 45. Kxb6 Nxf3

So far, so good, Dzindzichashvili must have thought. Black still has not actually created a passed pawn, and even when he does, White’s bishop will never allow it to move forward. However, as you might have guessed, there is far more to the position than meets the eye.

46. Kxa5

Natural and strong. In all probability, 46. hxc5+ would have transposed to the game, but White keeps his options open. Paradoxically, Black’s position is rather easy to play—he has only one feasible way to continue the resistance:

46. ... Nd2!

(see diagram top of next column)

Now, White is faced with an irksome dilemma—should he take on g5, or move the bishop? In fact, he must only choose between 47. Bg2 and 47. hxc5+, since neither 47. Be2?? g4 (threatening ... f5-f4

Bishop versus Knight

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See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

IM Daniel Naroditsky (FIDE 2486)

GM Julien Martinez (FIDE 2580)

Benasque, 2013



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Garry Kasparov (FIDE 2820)

GM Oscar Panno (FIDE 2450)

Buenos Aires, 1997



WHITE TO MOVE



and ... g4-g3, when the pawn will actually be unstoppable!) nor 47. b4?? gxh4 48. gxh4 Nxf1 49. b5 Ne3 50. b6 Nc4+ 51. Kb5 Nxb6 are any good for White. Analyzing this with the help of an infallible, nerveless machine, it is easy to become obsessed with objective evaluations and forget to approach the position from a practical standpoint. I will mention at the outset that both moves lead to victory, but only one does so without shedding a drop of blood. Evidently, Dzindzi was under the impression that both moves win easily, and chose almost at random:

47. hxg5+?

Once again, this does not give the win away, but it sets White up for the disastrous blunder that will occur a few moves later. After 47. Bg2, Black's chief problem is that he simply cannot make a dent in White's kingside pawn formation. He can restore the material balance or win the bishop, but White's pawns are still clearly unstoppable in every variation:

A. 47. ... Nxb3+ eliminates one of the passers, but simply passes the torch to its colleague: 48. Kb4! f3 50. Bxf3 (this looks sketchy at first sight, but it is easy to underestimate just how unstoppable White's passers will be) 50. ... Nxf3 51. a5 Ne5 52. a6 Nc6+ 53. Kc5 with b4-b5-b6 (b7-b8=Q!) to follow.

B. 47. ... gxh4 48. gxh4 f4 is not much better: 49. Kb4! f3 50. Bxf3 (this looks sketchy at first sight, but it is easy to underestimate just how unstoppable White's passers will be) 50. ... Nxf3 51. a5 Ne5 52. a6 Nc6+ 53. Kc5 with b4-b5-b6 (b7-b8=Q!) to follow.

During analysis, with an infallible machine assisting you at every turn, it is tempting to call Dzindzi's choice and subsequent play inexplicable. But place yourself in his shoes: with absolutely no counterplay in sight and White's passed pawn only a few short steps away from queening, what could possibly go wrong?

47. ... Kxg5



With his last move, White has merely postponed the dilemma: where should the bishop go? Clearly, the a-pawn will be unstoppable irrespective of its placement (after ... Nxb3+ Kb6, the knight will be chased away and the pawn will move forward. Therefore, White has to make a decision based on Black's kingside counterplay. Intuitively speaking, the best way to ensure that Black's king does not penetrate to g4 is 48. Be2, and this move turns out to be—wait for it—absolutely crushing! Endgames *can* be impervious to logic, but this is not always the case. After 48. ... Nxb3+ 49. Kb6 Black can resign, since there is no way to stop Bc4/Bd1 and no counterplay in sight. For instance, 49. ... Kf6 50. Bc4 Nd2 51. Bd5 Ke7 52. a5 Kd8 53. a6 and White promotes. Yet again, Dzindzichashvili operated under the impression that “everything wins”—after all, what difference will it make if Black's king reaches g4?

48. Bg2??

This—and not 47. hxg5, as Dzindzichashvili asserts in his annotations—is the real culprit. Not only does this allow

Black's king to access g4, but ... Kxg3 will now come with gain of tempo! White still wins the pawn race, but even the queen will not be able to deal with a knight, king, and far-advanced passer.

48. ... Kxg4!

Kavalek pounces. The greedy 48. ... Nxb3+?? would have allowed White to undo the damage with 49. Kb6 and 50. Bd5.

49. Kb6 Kxg3

The dreadful effect of 48. Bg2 on full display. Unfortunately for White, he cannot move his bishop past e4, since the knight will interdict its control over the h1-square.

50. a5

White comes close after 50. Bd5 Ne4 51. a5 h4 52. a6 h3 53. a7 h2 54. a8=Q h1=Q, but all of Black's pieces are defended and there is no way to make progress.

50. ... Kxg2 51. a6 h4 52. a7 h3 53. a8=Q+ Ne4!

A convenient interposition. The tempting 53. ... Nf3 is far less clear after 54. Qg8+ Kf2 55. Qh8 with b3-b4 to follow.

54. Qg8+ Ng3!

Another terrific defensive resource. With the f5-pawn defended and White's king a mere spectator, White's only way to stop ... h3-h2 is by delivering perpetual check.

55. Qd5+ Kf2 56. Qd2+ Kg1, Draw agreed.

A breathtaking, jaw-dropping endgame! Above all, it should be interpreted as a warning against carelessness and premature relaxation, but you should also keep in mind that the knight is a devilishly resilient piece in spite of its characteristic endgame incompetence. You cannot be too accurate or calculate too much, especially in minor-piece endgames. Sometimes we must follow Martin Luther King, Jr.'s advice and “substitute courage for caution!” ♠

An Endgame "Selfie"

An example of saving a draw from a seemingly disastrous position.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

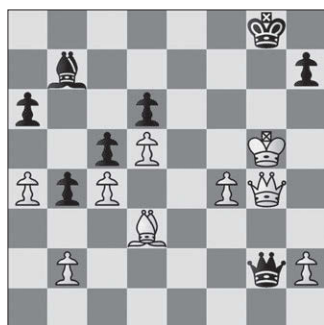
IN ALL ASPECTS, THE 2014 U.S. Championship was an unforgettable event. The conditions were impeccable, the commentary thrilling, and the countless chess fans who made their way to the club or watched online contributed to the atmosphere of fighting, tooth-and-nail chess. There were many memorable games and brilliant individual performances, and endgame fans (yes, those do exist!) were treated to some captivating action in both sections. This month, I am examining one of my own endings from the tournament. I try to avoid tooting my own horn whenever possible, but I feel that this endgame—and I will not reveal anything more at this point—is worthy of an exception. Without further ado, let's plunge in and get our hands dirty!

A king intrusion

GM Alexander Onischuk (2742)

GM Daniel A. Naroditsky (2632)

2014 U.S. Chess Championship (10), 05.18.2014



BLACK TO MOVE

After a disastrous blunder in a dead equal position, I lost a crucial pawn on f5 and was forced to allow White's king way inside my camp. Indeed, the position on the board appears utterly hopeless for Black: the queen trade loses immediately since 47. ... Qxb2 48. Qe6+ Kh8 49. Qe8+ Kg7 50. Qe7+. With an extra passed pawn, an active king, and an unthinkable passive bishop on b7, though, trading queens

equates to suicide as well. Nevertheless, I decided to make a few more moves before resigning—miracles can still happen, or so the platitude goes ...

47. ... h6+

The immediate 47. ... Qxg4+ is even worse, since Black will have to deal with a weak pawn on h7.

48. Kh4+ Qxg4+ 49. Kxg4 a5

Paradoxically, hopeless positions are usually the easiest ones to play. Of course, Black cannot allow 50. a5, burying the bishop alive. For instance, 49. ... Kg7 50. a5 Kf6 51. Kh5 Kg7 (51. ... Bc8 52. Kxh6 Bg4 53. Kh7 is hopeless as well) 52. Bf5 Kf6 53. Be6 Kg7 54. f5 and Black is in *Zugzwang*.

50. b3

Cementing the pawn chain and (ostensibly) preventing any monkey business with ... Ba6.

50. ... Kg7 51. Bf5

Black's bishop has been confined to a maximum security prison!

51. ... Kf6

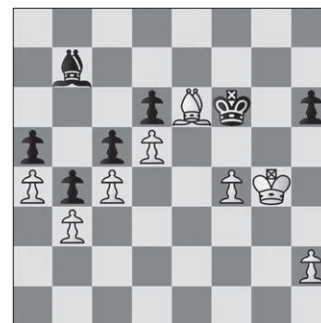
To reel in the full point, White must devise a plan. In principle, this is not very difficult; with the bishop incarcerated, White needs to find a way to win the h-pawn while keeping Black's bishop locked out. To this end, White will maneuver his king to h5 and push the f-pawn as long as necessary to distract Black's king from the h6-pawn. After that, it will be a simple matter of pushing the unstoppable h-pawn.

Onischuk clearly arrived at the same conclusion, and confidently initiated the seemingly decisive sequence:

52. Be6

(see diagram top of next column)

Regardless of the position, the notion of counterplay should never be scoffed at or



underestimated. Understandably enough, my opponent deems this position an exception to the rule. Black's only conceivable source of counterplay is the bishop, which will never be able to reach c8. The brazen ... Ba6-Bxc4 also looks absurd, since White's bishop will have plenty of time to stop the b-pawn—or so we both assumed, until I realized that this assertion is flawed. Unless White brings his pawn to h5 and as long as Black's king remains on f6, Bf5 will always fail to ... h6-h5+. Moreover, Bg8 meets with ... Kg7, forcing the bishop back to e6! I pounced without a second thought.

52. ... Ba6!

Only now did my opponent realize that his planned 53. Kh5 leads only to a draw after 53. ... Bxc4! 54. bxc4 b3 55. Bg8 (55. Kg4 actually loses after 55. ... b2 56. Bf5 and now the aforementioned 56. ... h5+ seals the deal) 55. ... Kg7 56. Be6 Kf6. In fact, White has only one way to prevent ... Bxc4:

53. h4

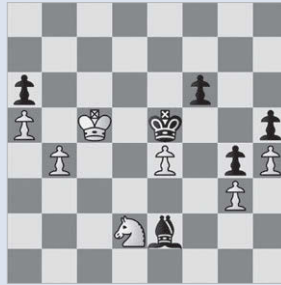
An elegant idea. 53. ... Bxc4 54. bxc4 b3 appears to work, but White secures the f5-square with 55. h5! and is just in time to stop the pawn. However, I now realized that f5+ will never be possible, since the pawn will block the b1-h7 diagonal and ... Bxc4 will actually win the game. White's only chance, then, is to induce *Zugzwang* and force my bishop away from a6, but how does White evict the king from the sixth rank?

The endgame cavalry

The great Soviet chess master and trainer Orest Averkin repeatedly claimed that endgames are at least 90 percent tactics. To be sure, this is somewhat of an exaggeration, but even though an ending might appear perfectly straightforward, improbable saving motifs have a way of materializing out of the clear blue sky. Always expect the unexpected.

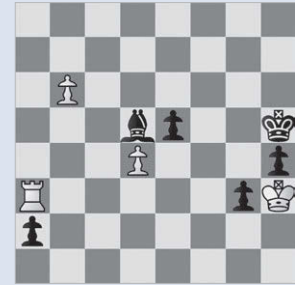
See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level
GM Joshua Friedel (FIDE 2610)
GM Timur Gareev (2757)
 St. Louis, 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level
WIM Viktorija Ni (2308)
Ashritha Eswaran (2208)
 St. Louis, 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

53. ... Kg6

For a second, I grew rather worried that 54. Bd7 wins the game, since 54. ... Kf6 allows 55. Kh5 Kg7 56. Bg4 and White is back on track, but the improbable 54. ... h5+ 55. Kf3 Bxc4! actually wins! After 56. bxc4 b3, it turns out that White has no way to get his bishop on the right diagonal: 57. Ke4 b2 58. Bf5+ Kf6 and White cannot defend his bishop and move his king away at the same time.

54. Kg3

White's problem is exacerbated by the fact that he will never be able move the h-pawn, as h4-h5 will lock the king out once and for all. With this move, White initiates a series of maneuvers designed to trick me into allowing *Zugzwang*, but by now, pure determination had taken over.

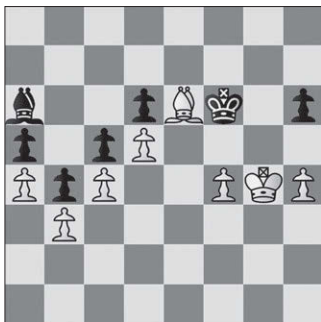
54. ... Kf6 55. Bh3 Bb7

With the king removed from g4, Black's bishop can take a break. As soon as White moves his king to g4, it must reposition back to a6 to parry Kh5.

56. Bd7

Of course, 56. Kg4 Bc8+ leads nowhere.

56. ... Ke7 57. Be6 Kf6 58. Kg4 Ba6



After Black's 53rd move, the same position arose—with Black's king on g6. Fortunately, for me, this makes no difference, since 59. Kh5 meets the familiar

59. ... Bxc4 60. bxc4 b3 61. Bg8 Kg7 with a draw.

59. Bd7 Ke7 60. Bf5 Kf6 61. Be6

White is trying very, very hard to make progress, but his efforts are in vain.

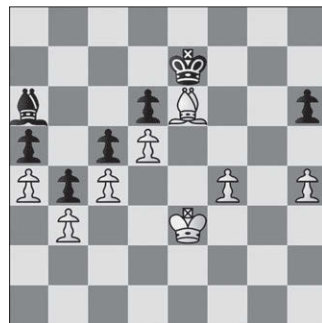
61. ... Kg6

Of course, the extremely cooperative 61. ... Bb7?? lost after 62. Kh5 Kg7 63. f5 with f6+ to follow.

62. Kf3 Kf6

As it turns out, the audacious 62. ... h5 drew as well, since White has no way of stopping ... Bxc4, winning the h-pawn, and stopping ... Bf5 at the same time. For instance, 63. Ke4 Kf6 64. Bd7 Bb7 65. Be8?! Bc8 66. Bxh5 Bf5+ 67. Ke3 Bc2 and White must now tread carefully!

63. Ke3 Ke7



Time to rest the king. Of course, there was nothing wrong with 63. ... Bb7 or 63. ... h5.

64. Ke4 Kf6

Back to work!

65. Bd7 Ke7 66. Bh3 Kf6 67. Kf3 Bb7 68. Bd7 Ba6 69. Kg4 Ke7 70. Bf5 Kf6 71. Bc2

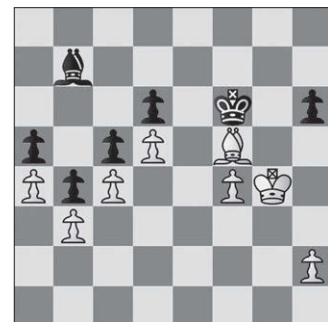
Finally! With simple maneuvering leading nowhere, my opponent tries to trick me one last time, but in doing so, finally releases the bishop out of its cage.

71. ... Bc8+ 72. Kh5 Kg7 73. f5 Bd7

My opponent spent almost all of his remaining time calculating 74. f6+, and came to the conclusion that White is unable to make progress. Indeed, after 74. ... Kxf6 75. Kxh6 Bg4 White's bishop is tied to c2, and White has nothing better than to repeat moves with 76. Kh7 (76. h5 Be2 and White must force a draw with 77. Bd3 Bd1 78. Bc2) 76. ... Kf7 77. Bg6+ Kf8 (the careless 77. ... Kf6 actually loses to 78. h5 Bd1 79. h6 Bxb3 80. Kg8 Bxd5+ 81. h7 Bxc4+ 82. Kf8 and the pawn promotes) 78. Bc2 Kf7.

74. Kg4, Draw Agreed.

I was elated after saving this endgame, but I was still convinced that White missed a win somewhere. Let us return to the position after 51. ... Kf6:



In perfect hindsight, it is clear that White has no time to spare; after 52. Be6 Ba6, White had to waste golden time on stopping ... Bxc4, allowing Black's king to reach g6 in time. But what about the immediate 52. Bd7? Then, on 52. ... Ba6 53. Kh5, 53. ... Bxc4 is no longer possible: 54. bxc4 b3 55. Be8! (this is the key difference; on e6, the bishop does not have an equivalent route to the b1-h7 diagonal) 55. ... b2 56. Bg6 and White stops the pawn. 52. ... Kg6 is therefore forced, but now White is able to reach the target position: 53. Kh4 Ba6 54. Bg4 and White will prevail in familiar fashion, trading the f-pawn for the h-pawn. Even now, I find it very difficult to believe that White's 52nd move actually let the win slip. ♣

The Fighting OCBs

“It is a cliché that most clichés are true, but then like most clichés, that cliché is untrue.” —Stephen Fry

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

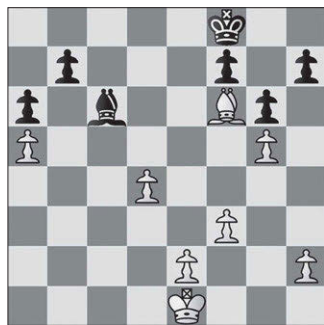
MUCH OF THE TIME, OPPOSITE-colored bishop (OCB) endgames live up to their drawish reputation. It is so difficult to induce *Zugzwang* or to promote a passer that even an ostensibly decisive material advantage can mean nothing in the face of an uncontested bishop and an active king. I am always wary of endgame generalizations, but before writing this month's column, I had no idea just how accurate some clichés turn out to be. Read on ...

Frustrating Kamsky

GM Gata Kamsky (2785)

GM Aleksandr Lenderman (2609)

38th Annual World Open (4), 2010



WHITE TO MOVE

Gata Kamsky—and I can attest to this firsthand—has an innate ability to outplay his opponent from an apparently unwinnable position. This game is a case in point. Lenderman sacrificed a pawn in the opening and obtained a fearsome initiative, but Kamsky somehow extinguished the fire and traded off both queen and rooks while retaining his material advantage. Unfortunately for White, though, reeling in the full point will not be a simple matter. If and when Black's king reaches d7 (or e6), White will be hard-pressed to make any progress. For the moment, though, it is clear that he has no alternative but to advance his central pawns.

44. e4

Frequently, the only way to actually win an OCB endgame is to deprive your opponent of key defensive squares for his king and bishop. If you succeed in attaining a sizeable space advantage, your opponent might suddenly end up in *Zugzwang*, with no choice but to make a serious concession. In this case, of course, Kamsky simply has no alternative.

44. ... Bb5 45. d5 Ke8 46. Bd4

A typical grandmaster move. Kamsky transfers his bishop to c5, where it will prevent ... b7-b6 and cut off Black's king.

46. ... Kd7 47. Bc5 Bc4

White has improved the position of his bishop and pawns to the maximum, so it is high time to bring in the monarch.

48. Kf2 Bb5 49. h4

This was not strictly necessary, but it certainly cannot hurt. In the unlikely event that White's king reaches g7 and captures the h7-pawn, he will have the additional option of trading the g6-pawn in only two moves (Kh6 and h4-h5). Such “intuitive calculation” is a crucial tool in an experienced endgame player's arsenal.

49. ... Bc4 50. Ke3 Bf1 51. Kd4 Bg2

Lenderman could have continued waiting with 51. ... Bb5, but he smartly chooses to restrict White's possibilities by practically forcing White's reply.

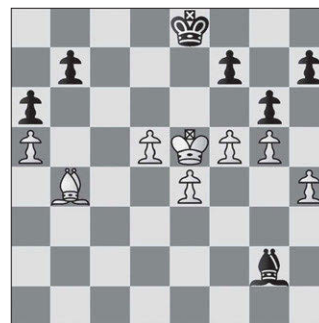
52. f4

There was no sense in playing cat-and-mouse with 52. Ke3, since the f-pawn will eventually have to advance anyway.

52. ... Bf3

Another prudent choice. By keeping his bishop on the a8-h1 diagonal, Lenderman ties White's king to the defense of e4. Since 53. e5 is obviously counterproductive (Black will have an immediate fortress after 53. ... Bg2), White's options are limited yet again—he must push the f-pawn.

53. Bb4 Ke8 54. Ke5 Bg2 55. f5



Already, menacing storm clouds begin to gather over Black's position. He can hardly allow another passed pawn on the kingside, so 55. ... gxf5 loses quickly after 56. exf5 Bh1 57. h5 Bf3 58. h6, when he cannot stop the threats of g5-g6 and Kf6-g7-xh7 simultaneously. Therefore, he must sit tight and keep waiting.

55. ... Bf3 56. f6

White has made substantial progress. With the pawn on f6, his e- and d-pawns have become rather intimidating.

56. ... Bd1!

The only way to stay alive. Negligently keeping the bishop on the long diagonal with 56. ... Bg2?? would lead to calamitous consequences after 57. Kd4 Bf3 58. e5 Bg2 (it is too late for 58. ... Bd1: 59. Kc4! [taking away the crucial b3-square from the bishop] 59. ... Be2+ 60. Kc5 Bg4 61. e6! fxe6 [61. ... Bf5 62. exf7+ Kxf7 63. Kb6 is even worse] 62. d6 e5 63. Kb6 and Black is powerless against the threat of Kc7 followed by either f7+ or d7+, when he will lose the bishop) 59. e6 Bh3 60. exf7+ Kxf7 61. Kc5 Ke8 62. Kb6 and once again, Black cannot stop the pawns without giving up his bishop.

57. Kd6 Bc2

Walking the tightrope indeed! Black cannot allow the king to reach c7.

58. e5 Bb3 59. e6

In 15 moves, Black has literally been

Problems: Opposite-Color Bishops

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

GM James Tarjan (2535)

GM Lev Alburt (2570)

Greenville, Pennsylvania, 1983



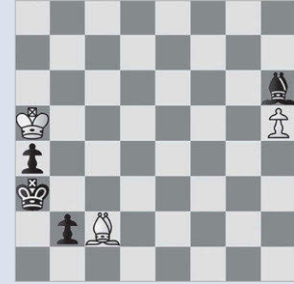
BLACK TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Peter Acs (FIDE 2602)

GM Ray Robson (FIDE 2562)

Paks, Hungary, 2010



BLACK TO MOVE

driven to the edge of the board. It appears that White simply needs to move his king away and capture the f7-pawn to force resignation, but are things ever so simple?

59. ... Ba2

And now the insanity begins. First and foremost, it turns out that the tempting 60. exf7+ Kxf7 61. Kc5, which looks completely winning at first sight, actually does not win. After 61. ... Ke8 62. d6 Kd7 63. Kb6 Bd5 Black constructs a fortress, and White has no way to force *Zugzwang* (since 64. f7 Bxf7 65. Kxb7 Bc4 leads nowhere). But Kamsky does not hurry to resolve the central tension, making a crucial improvement in his king position first.

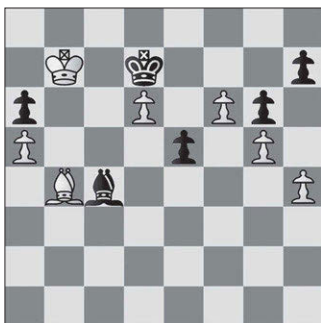
60. Kc5!

Now, 61. exf7+ becomes a threat—after 61. ... Kxf7 62. d6 Ke8 63. Kb6 Black is not able to defend b7 and play ... Kd7 at the same time. Lenderman's reply, therefore, is forced yet again.

60. ... fxe6 61. d6

White threatens 62. Kb6 Kd7 63. f7, so Lenderman must get the self-obstructive e6-pawn out of the way immediately.

61. ... e5! 62. Kb6 Kd7 63. Kxb7 Bc4

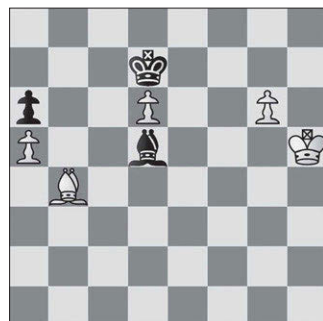


Against all odds, Black is still breathing. His bishop and king restrain White's passers, and White cannot tarry for too long—Black threatens to erect an impenetrable fortress by trading his e-pawn for White's d-pawn. Kamsky, evidently cha-

grined by Lenderman's incredible resilience, loses patience.

64. f7?!

An unfortunate miscalculation that allows Black to draw by force, although for reasons that will soon become clear, this is not technically a mistake. We must not forget, of course, that fatigue and time trouble play major roles in the endgame, and Kamsky's inability to keep his cool is quite understandable. As it turns out, after the correct 64. Kb6 e4 65. Kc5 Be6 66. Kd4 Black must give up the pawn, since his bishop has to remain on the a2-g8 diagonal. I nearly stopped my analysis here the first time around, since White's position following 66. ... Bf7 67. Kxe4 Bg8 68. Kd4 Kc6 (a sad necessity, since 68. ... Bf7 69. Kc5 followed by Kb6 and f7 is hopeless) 69. f7! Bxf7 70. Ke5 appears completely winning. He will simply capture the h7-pawn, and win by creating another passed pawn. But let's take this variation just a bit further: 70. ... Kd7 71. Kf6 Bb3 72. Kg7 Bc4 73. Kxh7 Bd3 74. Kh6 Bf5 75. h5 gxh5 76. Kxh5 Be4 77. g6 Bd5 ...



... and while everything has seemingly gone according to plan, things are far more complicated than they look.

In order to win, White must promote the g-pawn, but after 78. Kh6 Ke8! it turns out that White cannot actually make progress. At first, I could not believe it either, but White's problem is that he simply cannot play g7 while simultaneously

safeguarding the g8-square. For instance, after 79. Kh7 (79. g7 Bg8 is an immediate draw, since Black will simply play ... Kd7-e8-d7 and, if necessary, ... Kc6) 79. ... Be4! 80. Kg7 Black keeps his bishop on the b1-h7 diagonal with 80. ... Bd3, and White's king cannot reach h8 or g8 (of course, 81. d7+ Kxd7 82. Kf7 Bxg6+ is an immediate draw, since the bishop is of the wrong color). 81. Kf6 Bc2 82. Ke6 also leads nowhere, since the alert ... Bb3+ forces him back to square one.

An improbable draw! In fact, I do not think that I have ever seen a bishop and king successfully restrain two separated passers that are so far-advanced. I would certainly urge you to commit this position to your endgame memory.

Now, back to the text:

64. ... Bxf7 65. Kxa6 Kc6 66. Ka7 Bc4

White's king is caged in, since Kb8 will always be met with ... Ba6.

67. a6 e4 68. Bc5 Bb5 69. d7

Kamsky demonstrates his signature fighting spirit, but with his king so far from the kingside and with Black's passer so far advanced, the result of the game is decided.

69. ... Kxd7 70. Kb7 Bc6+ 71. Kb8 Ke6 72. a7 Kf5 73. a8=Q Bxa8 74. Kxa8 Kg4 75. Bf2 Kf3

Black could have drawn immediately after 75. ... Kh5 and 76. ... h6, but Lenderman certainly has some time to kill before White's monarch reaches the kingside!

76. Be1 e3 77. Kb7 Kg4

The more direct 77. ... Ke2 78. Bb4 Kf1 79. Kc6 e2 80. Kd5 e1=Q 81. Bxe1 Kxe1 82. Ke4 (but not 82. Ke6?? Kf2 83. Kf7 Kg3) also leads to a draw.

78. Kc6 Kh5 79. Kd5 h6, Draw agreed.

Perhaps clichés have a grain of truth to them after all! Transposing to a presumably lost OCB endgame is a defensive mechanism that we should take to heart. ♠

The Moment of Truth: Rook Endings

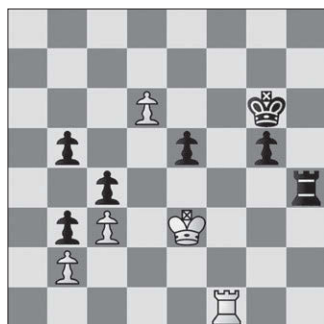
“[Rook endings] are often so complex, so replete with tactical nuances and daunting calculation tasks that even grandmasters tend to slip up at critical junctures.”

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

ROOK ENDINGS. WHAT NEEDS TO BE said? They are often so complex, so replete with tactical nuances and daunting calculation tasks that even grandmasters tend to slip up at critical junctures. The following captivating encounter between two of the strongest American chess players of all time is a case in point.

The moment of truth

IM Edmar Mednis
GM Arthur Bisguier
New York, 1959



Black is two pawns up, but his material advantage will turn meaningless if he is unable to restrain the d-pawn. Bisguier, who let several promising (and risk-free) opportunities slip by earlier in the endgame, needlessly resorts to passive defense:

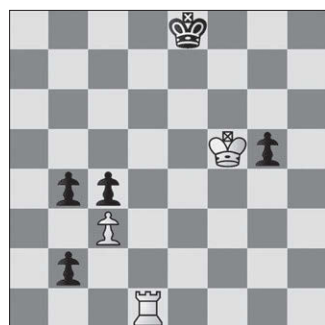
49. ... Rh8??

A very instructive moment. Optically, Bisguier's move is perfectly logical. After all, what better way to stop the passed pawn than to control its promotion square? In *My System*, Aron Nimzowitsch famously agreed with Dr. Tarrasch's assertion that “The Rook's proper place is behind the passed Pawn, whether it be his own or an enemy one.” Of course, blindly adhering to endgame dogmas is not the recipe for success, **but a passive rook rarely stands a chance against a far-advanced passed pawn supported by the king**. Furthermore, Bisguier should have intuited that his own

passed pawns are not far enough advanced to generate serious counterplay. Black had two ways to contain the passer from behind, but only one kept the advantage:

A. 49. ... Rh3+? 50. Ke4 Rd3 is the most straightforward option, but it allows White's king to break free and lend crucial support to the ailing pawn. After 51. Kxe5 Rd2, White has a choice between the adventurous 52. Rf8 and the cautious 52. Rb1. Let's dive in headfirst!

A1. 52. Rf8 Rxb2 (52. ... b4?! is less testing: 53. cxb4 Rxb2 54. d7 Re2+ 55. Kd4 Rd2+ 56. Kxc4 Rxd7 57. Kxb3 with an immediate draw) 53. Rg8+ (but not 53. d7?? Re2+ 54. Kd6 Rd2+ 55. Kc7 b2 56. Rf1 b4 57. cxb4 c3, when the pawns are unstoppable) 53. ... Kf7 54. d7 Re2+ 55. Kf5 (the key difference: White's king is able to stay away from the d-file) 55. ... Rd2 56. d8=Q Rxd8 57. Rxd8 b2 58. Rd7+ (forcing the king back) 58. ... Ke8 59. Rd1 b4 and a fascinating position arises.



At first sight, White's position appears utterly hopeless, since 60. cxb4?? c3 followed by ... c3-c2 is curtains. However, White has a few moves before Black actually promotes, and he utilizes this respite to create improbable counterplay against Black's vulnerable monarch: 60. Ke6!! bxc3 61. Rh1 Kf8 62. Kf6 Kg8 and now White uses his last tempo to remove the king's only remaining protector: 63. Rg1! c2 64. Rxc3+ Kh7+ 65. Rh5+ Kg8 66. Rg5+

Kf8 67. Rh5 Ke8 68. Ke6 and Black's king will never evade his bloodthirsty pursuants. This king-chasing motif features prominently in chess compositions, but it seldom occurs in actual games.

A2. 52. Rb1 leads to the same result, albeit in a far less spectacular way. After 52. ... Kf7 53. Rf1+ Ke8 54. Ke6 Re2+ 55. Kd5 Rxb2 56. Re1+ Kd8 57. Re5! White's piece activity compensates for his material deficit. After 57. ... Ra2 58. Rxc5 Kd7 White has nothing better than to repeat moves with 59. Rg7+ Kd8 60. Rg8+.

B. 49. ... b4! is the second way to contain White's passer from behind. The key difference between this move and 49. ... Rh3+ is that after 50. cxb4 Rd4, White's king remains cut off and the passed pawn falls immediately. The b-pawn is also unsupported, and after 51. b5 Rxd6 52. Rc1 Rb6 53. Rxc4 Rxb5 White's drawing chances are minimal. A far more resilient defense is 50. d7, but even here, after 50. ... Rh3+ 51. Ke2 (51. Ke4 Rd3) 51. ... Rh8 (an unfortunate necessity, since 51. ... Rd3? looks like a draw by perpetual after 52. Rd1 bxc3 53. Rxd3 cxd3+ 54. Kf2 cxb2 55. d8=Q b1=Q 58. Qe8+) 52. cxb4 Rd8 53. Rc1 Rxd7 54. Rxc4 Rb7 I seriously doubt that White has any real saving chances.

Phew! Of course, there is no way one can accurately calculate even a third of these variations during the game, but my point is to demonstrate just how concrete, just how dependent on ostensibly inconsequential details rook endings can be.

50. Ke4!

Mednis must have breathed a sigh of relief at this point. Indeed, Black is now unable to generate enough counterplay to stop White's pawn from promoting.

50. ... g4!?

The best practical chance. Houdini initially suggests 50. ... Re8, but 51. Kd5 e4

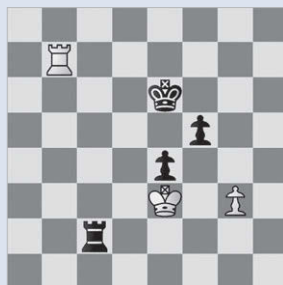
Rook Endings

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column and whose solution is hinted at by the subtitle above. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solvable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

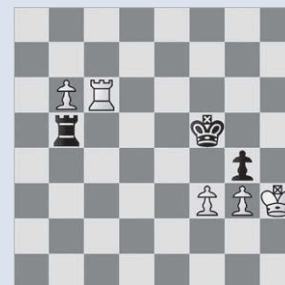
Paul van der Sterren
Larry Christiansen
Tjentiste, 1975



BLACK TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

IM Keaton Kiewra (2413)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2535)
Santa Clara, 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

52. d7 Ra8 53. Re1! is devastating. For instance, after 53. ... b4 (there is not much else; 53. ... Kf5 54. Rxe4 Rd8 55. Re7 loses immediately) 54. cxb4 c3 55. bxc3 b2 and now the “plebeian” but extremely strong 56. Rb1! seals the deal.

51. Kxe5 Kg5



If Black had no pawn on b5, Bisguier would have instantly resigned. Black has no chance whatsoever in the pawn race, so his only chance is to somehow exploit his queenside pawn superiority with a timely ... b5-b4. Mednis, presumably after a period of intense calculation, decided that the first order of business was to eliminate the irksome b5-pawn:

52. Kd5?

Bisguier's inability to tackle the Herculean calculational task on move 49 is understandable, but this position is far more straightforward and Mednis was certainly capable of exhaustively analyzing it at the board. 52. d7 suggested itself, when Black is forced to reply 52. ... g3. Now, after the hasty 53. Kd6? Kg4 54. Kc7? (54. Rg1 still draws) 54. ... g2 55. Rd1 Kf3 56. d8=Q Rxd8 57. Kxd8 White wins the pawn race, but loses the game after 57. ... Kf2 58. Kc7 g1=Q 59. Rxc7 Kxc7 60. Kc6 b4! and Black breaks through in the nick of time. However, White can save not one but two tempi with the *Zwischenzug* 53. Rd1!. Black is forced to block the pawn with 53. ... Rd8 (53. ... g2 fails to 54. d8=Q+ Rxd8 55.

Rxd8 g1=Q 56. Rg8+), but now after 54. Ke6 Kg4 55. Ke7 Black's rook is attacked, and he must waste another tempo to eliminate the d-pawn: 55. ... Rxd7+ 56. Kxd7 Kf3 57. Kc6 Ke2 58. Rb1 Kd2 59. Rg1! with an easy win.

In general, moves such as 53. Rd1 can be found by thinking backwards: you find the general idea first (promoting the pawn), and then find its most accurate execution.

52. ... g3 53. Kc6 Rh6!?

This is somewhat more accurate than 53. ... Kg4?, after which Black would have to deal with 54. Kxb5 g2 55. Rg1 Kf3 56. Kxc4. In fact, Black still draws rather comfortably with 56. ... Kf2 57. Rd1 g1=Q 58. Rxc1 Kxc1 59. Kxb3 Kf2 (take my word on this one), but Bisguier's move is even more convincing.

54. Rd1 Kf4 55. Kxb5 g2

The point. Now, 56. Kxc4 is strongly met by 56. ... Rxd6, and although both 57. Rxd6 g1=Q 58. Kxb3 (an idea we will see again) and 57. Rg1 Kf3 58. Kxb3 Kf2 59. Rc1 hold the draw, Black is clearly in the driver's seat.

56. d7 Rh8 57. Kxc4

Sadly, this is forced. Mednis might have been relying on 57. Kc6?? Kf3 58. Kc7 from afar, but White has wasted too many moves and Black wins the king race after 58. ... Kf2 59. d8=Q Rxd8 60. Kxd8 g1=Q 61. Rxc7 Kxc7 62. Kc7 Kf2 63. Kc6 Ke2 64. Kc5 Kd3 65. Kb4 Kc2 66. Ka3 Kb1 and White's monarch is pushed off the cliff!

57. ... Rd8

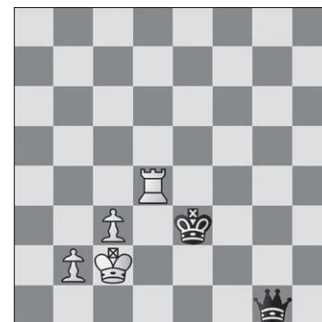
The simplest. Black finally eliminates the pernicious d7-pawn, forcing White to scramble for the draw.

58. Kxb3 Rxd7 59. Rxd7

There was no sense in asking for trouble with 59. Rg1, although the computer indicates that 59. ... Kf3 60. Kc4! Kf2 61.

Rxc2+ Kxc2 62. b4 is still a draw. Mednis allows Black to promote, but constructs an impenetrable fortress using his rook and two pawns.

59. ... g1=Q 60. Rd4+ Ke3 61. Kc2



Usually, in these types of positions it is possible to force the rook onto a vulnerable square using *Zugzwang*, but in this case, White's king simply has too many squares. The game is essentially over.

61. ... Qg6+ 62. Kb3 Qf5 63. Ka2 Qc2 64. Ka3 Qb1 65. Kb3 Qa1 66. Kc2 Qa2 67. Kc1 Qa1+ 68. Kc2 Qa6 69. Kb3 Qb5+ 70. Kc2 Qf5+ 71. Kb3 Qc8 72. Kc2 Qa6 73. Kb3 Qb5+ 74. Ka3 Qc6 75. Kb4 Qb6+ 76. Ka3 Qa5+ 77. Kb3 Qa6 78. Kc2 Qe2+, Draw agreed.

This game truly epitomizes the mind-bending complexity of practical rook endgames. In my opinion, we must simply accept our imperfection: sometimes, exhaustive calculation is humanly impossible and tactical mistakes are inevitable. But finding one correct move, outfoxing your opponent in one particular instance, can be the difference between a win and a loss. As Edmar Mednis himself remarked, “once you are in the endgame, the moment of truth has arrived.” ♣

In addition to the On-Line Viewer of the current issue, archival Chess Life PDFs and .pgn files are available on uschess.org, Chess Life Magazine, Downloadable Files. Issues are archived starting with October 2008.

Channeling Karpov

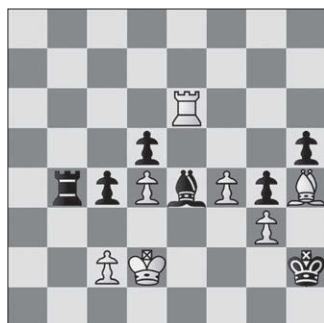
GM Fabiano Caruana's opening preparation and calculating ability are world class, but one does not become a super-grandmaster without exceptional endgame technique to complete the package.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IN HONOR OF FABIANO CARUANA'S monumental performance at the 2014 Sinquefeld Cup (see November 2014 *Chess Life*), I am dedicating this column to an aspect of the Italian-American's play that has been paid very little attention throughout his chess career: his endgame technique. Fabiano's primary strengths are indisputably his opening preparation and calculational ability. Nonetheless, his endgame play has always been superb, so let's examine two of his best endgame victories from recent years.

Let's take this in a new direction

GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2773, ITA)
GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2843, NOR)
Sao Paulo, 2012



WHITE TO MOVE

Caruana's position is rather unpleasant, but the worst is behind him. After the cold-blooded 79. Kc1 Ra4 80. Kb2 I cannot see any way for Black to make progress. The tricky 80. ... c3+!? is convincingly met with the subtle 81. Kb3! (81. Kxc3?! allows the irksome 81. ... Ra3+ 82. Kd2 Rxc3! 83. Bxc3+ Kxc3 and White is living dangerously, although 84. Re5 is still a draw according to Houdini), and White secures sufficient counterplay after 81. ... Rxd4 82. Re5 Kg2 83. f5. However, Fabiano was understandably sick and tired of defending, and in mutual time pressure, radically alters the course of the game:

79. Rxe4??!

What? A speculative Exchange sacrifice

against the strongest endgame player of all time? Indeed, objectively speaking, this move is a grave error. However, a move should not always be judged solely on the basis of its objectivity (or lack thereof). Carlsen was prepared for a war of attrition, and now—in severe time pressure—he will have to find “only” moves to avoid calamity!

79. ... dxe4 80. f5

With time ticking down, Magnus tries to maintain the status quo with a very natural move:

80. ... Kg2?

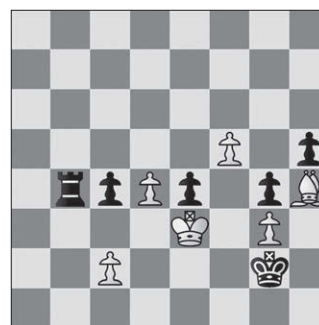
Evidently focused on getting his passer moving, Magnus gives Caruana a golden opportunity to blockade the pernicious e-pawn. Black had to activate the rook as soon as possible with 80. ... Rb1!, stopping White's king from reaching e3 and preparing to sacrifice the rook for the f-pawn at a convenient moment:

A. 81. f6 is the trickiest move, but it meets with the devastating 81. ... Kg2!! The fine point of Black's concept is that he keeps his rook flexible for as long as possible. Unfortunately, 82. d5 no longer comes with any effect: 82. ... Kf3 83. Bg5 83. ... Rb7! and Black restrains the passers from the side. The crushing ... h5-h4, followed by either ... g4-g3 or ... e4-e3, cannot be stopped. Neither 82. Ke3!? Re1+ 83. Kf4 e3 84. d5 Kf2 85. f7 Rf1! nor 82. Ke2 Rc1 83. Kd2 Rf1 promise any relief.

B. 81. d5 is also a worthy attempt, but Black has the gorgeous reply 81. ... c3+!, paving the way for the rook and e-pawn. After 82. Ke3 (82. Kxc3 Rd1 is even worse) 82. ... Re1+ 83. Kd4 e3 84. d6 e2 85. Ke3 Rd1 Black eliminates the d-pawn and reaches a completely winning position.

Magnus's move allows White's king to reach an optimal post, and the rook will not be in time to chase it away.

81. Ke3!



With the rook stranded on b4, this move now comes with great effect. Magnus exacerbates the issue with another blunder:

81. ... Rb2??

Yet again, Magnus underestimates the potential of White's two passers—capturing the c2-pawn is a luxury that he simply does not have time for. Two moves yielded the draw, but the flashy 81. ... Rb3+! (81. ... Rb1 is the alternative) is more convincing. 82. Kxe4 is forced (After 82. cxb3?? cxb3 83. f6 b2 84. f7 b1=Q 85. f8=Q the pawns promote simultaneously, but White loses his queen after 85. ... Qd3+ 86. Kf4 Qf3+), and after 82. ... Rc3 83. d5 Rxc2 84. d6 c3 85. Bg5 Re2+ 86. Kd5 Rf2 White has no choice but to repeat with 87. Ke4.

82. d5!

Fabi pounces! Magnus was probably expecting 82. f6, when 82. ... Rxc2 83. f7 Rf2 stops the pawn, but two advanced passers supported by the bishop constitute a rather menacing force. Black has no time to create his own passed pawn.

82. ... Rxc2

Passive defense was not an option: 82. ... Rb7 83. d6 Rd7 84. f6! (84. Be7?! allows the irksome 84. ... h4) and the d6-pawn is untouchable on account of f6-f7. White will simply bring the king over to e6, drive away the rook, and promote.

83. d6 c3 84. d7 Rd2

Black will give up his rook for the d-

Match wits with Fabio

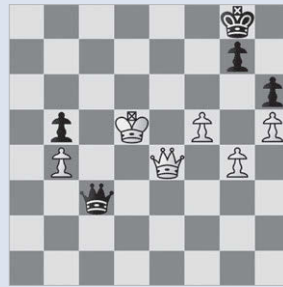
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See the solutions on page 69.

Problem I: 1500 Level

IM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2444)

IM Bandyopadhyay Raktim (FIDE 2365)
Andorra, 2006

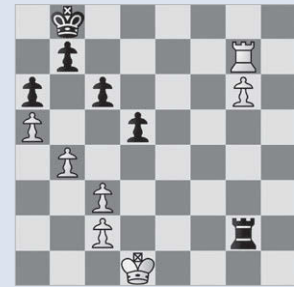


WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2767)

IM Bragi Thorfinnsson (FIDE 2421)
Reykjavik, 2012



WHITE TO MOVE

pawn and try to conjure up some desperado counterplay, but Caruana's technique is impeccable.

85. d8=Q Rxd8 86. Bxd8 h4!?

The best practical chance. 86. ... c2 looks intimidating, but White easily restrains the pawns with 87. Kd2 e3+ 88. Kxc2 e2 89. Ba5.

87. gxh4 g3 88. f6!

Black has three far advanced passed pawns, but they are all immobilized for one reason or another.

88. ... c2

Perhaps 88. ... Kh1 was a better chance, but surely Caruana would have found the accurate 89. Bb6! g2 90. Ke2.

89. Kd2 e3+ 90. Kxc2 e2 91. Ba5, Black resigned.

A fascinating battle. Caruana was ultimately rewarded for his bravery, even with Carlsen's uncharacteristic sloppy play. It is not easy to play like a machine after more than 70 moves of torturous defense!

Next, Caruana crushes Dutch GM Loek Van Wely from a drawn-looking position.

Drawn? Not really.

GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2782, ITA)

GM Loek Van Wely (FIDE 2672, NED)

Wijk aan Zee, 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

Black has tremendously active pieces but is down two pawns. Caruana finds the only good move to maintain his chances:

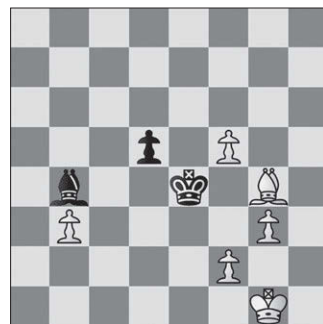
53. Ra4!

A true grandmaster move. It is crucial to keep White's bishop on c2 at all costs—otherwise, Black's rook will infiltrate the second rank with dire consequences.

53. ... e3?

Yet again, the most natural move is the decisive mistake! Black does force a trade of pawns, but he can't both defend his weak pawns and restrict White's passers. Black has two ways to obtain significant drawing chances:

A. 53. ... Rb4?! would have led to a fascinating opposite-colored bishop endgame after the practically forced sequence 54. Rxb4 Bxb4 55. Bxe4 Ke5 56. Bc2 Kxd5 57. Bd1 Ke4 58. Bxg4 d5



White has three(!) extra pawns, but Black's active pieces provide nearly enough compensation. Nevertheless White is able to win by rapidly advancing his pawns and overextending Black's forces: 59. f6 d4 60. f7 d3 61. f4 Ke3 62. Kg2 Bd6 63. Kh3 Be7 64. Bf5 d2 65. Bc2 and with the bishop safely restraining the pawn, White's four passers are crushing.

B. 53. ... Kxf5! was the way to go. Van Wely evidently did not like 54. Rxe4 Kg5 55. Rf4 (but after something along the

lines of 55. ... Rb7 or even 55. ... Rb4) Black's position is extremely tough to crack. White should eventually win by trading (or winning) the g4-pawn, but he has a long and difficult road ahead.

54. fxe3 Bxe3+ 55. Kf1

Now, 55. ... Kg5 is no longer effective on account of 56. Re4 Bc5 57. Re6, and Black must resort to miserably passive defense with 57. ... Rg8. Still, this would have been the lesser evil. Van Wely tries to muddy the waters, but his feeble attempt is mercilessly rebuffed.

55. ... Rc8 56. Bd3 Rg8?

With 56. ... Kg5 Black could have still resisted, although 57. Re4 Bd2 58. Re6 is obviously rather problematic. After the text move, Caruana crashes through.

57. Re4 Bc5 58. b4!

With the rook no longer on b8, this move is possible and it is devastating. Black loses the d6-pawn as well, and he is unable to generate even an iota of counterplay.

58. ... Ba7 59. Re6+ Kf7 60. Rxd6 Bb8 61. Rg6!

The more direct 61. Re6 Bxg3 62. Kg2 Bf4 63. d6 Rd8 64. Bc4 was possible as well. But the opposite-color bishop ending (after a rook exchange) will be hopeless as well.

61. ... Bxg3 62. d6! Rxg6 63. fxe6+ Kf6 64. d7 Bc7 65. b5 g3 66. Kg2 Kg7 67. Bf5 Kf6 68. Kf3 Kg7 69. d8=Q!

The last finesse. White gives up one of his passers to eliminate Black's only remaining trump card.

69. ... Bxd8 70. Kxg3 Kf6 71. Kf4 Bc7+ 72. Ke4 Bb6 73. Kd5, Black resigned.

Curtains. Black's king is tied to the g-pawn, and the bishop will eventually have to sacrifice itself for the b-pawn. Fabiano's technique in this game is reminiscent of Karpov in his finest years! ♠

Rook versus Bishop

The material imbalance of rook against bishop can be improbably favorable for the defending side.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IT IS WELL KNOWN THAT MATERIAL advantages are usually weightier in the endgame than in the middlegame. Unless you have clear-cut compensation or you have reached a theoretically drawn endgame, playing down a pawn or an Exchange makes it essentially impossible to save the game. However, one material imbalance in particular—rook against bishop—often proves improbably favorable for the defending side.

The bishop is an expert at picking off weak pawns, and the rook—even an active one—often finds it difficult to prevent mass pawn exchanges, leading to a theoretically drawn rook versus bishop or (even a rook and pawn versus bishop) ending. In the following game, GM Sam Shankland demonstrates just how resilient bishops tend to be.

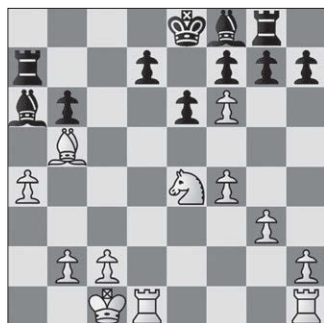
The resiliency of bishops

GM Jose Luis Fernandez Garcia (FIDE 2433, ESP)

GM Sam Shankland (FIDE 2581, USA)

XIV Open Internacional d'Escacs de Sant,

Hostafrancs i La Bordeta Grup A, Barcelona, 2012



WHITE TO MOVE

The opening has been a disaster for Sam, and his experienced opponent pounces with a lovely tactic:

20. Nd6+! Bxd6

This is forced, since 20. ... Kd8 21. Nxf7+ Ke8 22. Ne5! creates a deadly double attack (Bxd7+ and f7+).

21. Rxd6 Bxb5 22. Rxb6!

The point. In order to thwart checkmate along the back rank, Black must either sacrifice an Exchange or acquiesce to a hopeless double-rook ending.

22. ... gxf6!

This is definitely the best practical chance. The materialistic option, 22. ... Ra8, leads to a depressing double-rook endgame after 23. Rxb5 gxf6 24. b3 f5 25. Rd1. Black is “only” a pawn down, but his prospects are grim: White’s connected queenside passers should decide matters.

23. Rb8+ Ke7 24. Rxc8 Rxa4 25. Re1



The position appears utterly hopeless for Black. Not only is he an Exchange down for no compensation, his pawn structure is irreparably damaged as well! White is objectively winning, but an active rook and bishop constitute a formidable defensive force. White must still demonstrate accurate technique to win.

25. ... Bc6 26. Rh8 Be4

Black has managed to defend the h7-pawn in the nick of time, but the Spanish GM exploits an unfortunate defect in Black’s position to force the trade of rooks.

27. b3! Ra1+ 28. Kd2 Rxe1 29. Kxe1 Bxc2 30. b4

Another unfavorable development for Black. He now has a pawn for the Exchange, but the lone bishop can not both

protect the weak h7-pawn and restrain White’s ferocious passer. But Sam—always a fighter—is not ready to raise the white flag just yet.

30. ... Be4 31. b5 e5

Black desperately tries to muddy the waters and induce a tactical blunder. The lackadaisical 31. ... Kd6 32. Rc8 h5, hoping to construct a fortress, fails miserably after 33. Kd2 Bb7 (there is nothing else: 33. ... f5 34. Ke3 f6 35. h4! and Black is in *Zugzwang*) 34. Rh8 Bf3 and now the simple 35. Ke3 decides the matter, since 35. ... Bg4 allows 36. Rc8 followed by b5-b6. Even though Black is completely lost from an objective standpoint, why not make Fernandez sweat until the final move?

32. b6!

Irreproachable technique. The pawn is now alarmingly close to promotion and Black must abandon his weak pawns in order to retard its progress. The simple 32. Kd2 won as well, but perhaps Fernandez was worried about 32. ... d5!? 33. b6 d4 34. Rxh7 Bd5, even though 35. Rh5 Ke6 36. h4 is an easy win—Black’s passed pawns will not go very far!

32. ... Kd6 33. Rf8?!

But this is a step in the wrong direction. Both the prosaic 33. Rc8, cutting off Black’s king, and the computeresque 33. f5! (33. ... Bxf5 34. b7 promotes) won quickly. White’s move spoils nothing, but it allows Black to prolong the resistance.

33. ... Bd5 34. b7!

This move still wins, but there was no need to give up the monstrous passer. It was not too late for 34. Rc8.

34. ... Bxb7 35. Rxf7 Ke6 36. Rxh7 Be4 37. Rh6 d6?!

Sam’s wish to complicate matters by keeping the pawns on the board is understandable, but this move falls prey to a fine tactical blow. Liquidating with 37. ... exf4 38. gxf4 Kf5 39. Kf2 Kxf4 40. Rxf6+

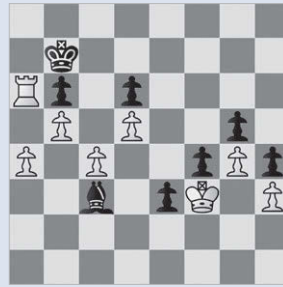
Rook versus Bishop

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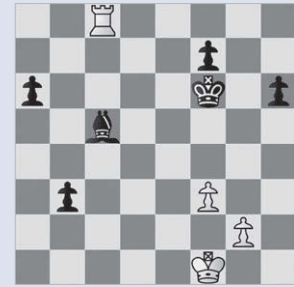
GM Klaus Bischoff (FIDE 2541)
IM Shakhriyar Mamedyarov (FIDE 2580)
Leon, 2001



WHITE TO MOVE

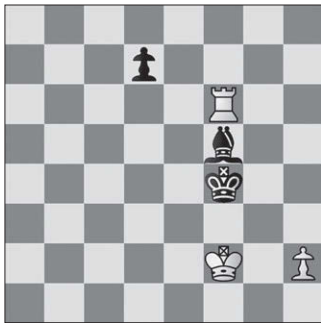
Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Ruslan Ponomarev (FIDE 2704)
GM Levon Aronian (FIDE 2724)
Khanty-Mansiysk, 2005



BLACK TO MOVE

Bf5 was more resilient, but Black is still theoretically lost.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

In *Dvoretsky's Endgame Manual*, IM Mark Dvoretsky concisely summarizes the central principle of rook-plus-corner-pawn versus bishop endings:

"With the king in the 'safe corner' [i.e. a1/h8 if the bishop is light-squared, h1/a8 if it is dark-squared], the position is winning only if the corner pawn has not yet crossed the fifth rank."

We will discuss the underlying reasons (and the winning mechanism) a bit later, but suffice it to say that the d-pawn does not change the essence of the position.

38. Kd2?!

It is Sam's lucky day! The powerful 38. g4! won on the spot, since 38. ... exf4 is impossible on account of 39. g5. If 38. ... Kf7, then 39. f5 (39. g5 works too) 39. ... d5 40. h4 d4 41. Rg6 Bf3 42. h5 e4 43. Kf2! wins, since White promotes first.

38. ... Kf7 39. fxe5 dxe5 40. Ke3

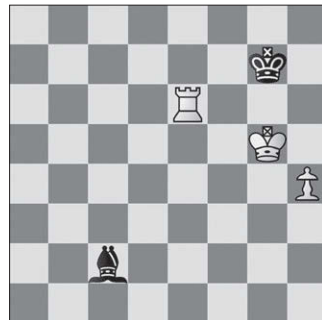
Black has come tantalizingly close to building a fortress, but even with limited material, he is unable to keep his position together for very long. White will soon force a transition to the aforementioned rook-plus-h-pawn versus bishop ending.

40. ... Bg6 41. Rh8 f5 42. Ra8 Kf6 43. Ra6+ Kg5

Black loses patience. It was certainly worth trying 43. ... Kf7, but the annoying 44. h3 Bh5 45. Rb6 Bd1 46. Rb4! Bh5 47. g4 fxg4 48. hxg4 reaches another the-

oretically winning position (confirmed with Nalimov's Endgame Tablebases).

44. h4+! Kh6 45. Re6 f4+ 46. gxf4 exf4+ 47. Kxf4 Kg7 48. Kg5 Bc2



And there we have it. The fifth-rank rule has been around for more than 150 years, and most players who have intensively studied theoretical endgames are aware of it. However, actually recalling the winning mechanism is an entirely different kettle of fish. Essentially, **the central idea is to push the pawn only when it induces Zugzwang or wins by force.** A premature h4-h5 deprives White of a key evacuation route for his king (see note to White's 52nd move), enabling Black to build a "stalemate fortress". Fernandez starts out well:

49. Re7+ Kg8 50. Kh6 Bd3 51. Rg7+ Kf8

By far the most testing defense. After 51. ... Kh8 52. Rd7 Bc4 White wins with a method indicated by French player Eugene Lequesne in the 19th century: 53. h5! (in this particular instance, the pawn can be pushed through to h7 by force) 53. ... Be6 54. Rd8+ Bg8 55. Kg5 Kh7 56. h6 Be6 (56. ... Bf7 succumbs immediately to 57. Rd7 and 58. h7+) 57. Rd6! Bh3 (the bishop must stay on the c8-h3 diagonal to stop Rd7+) 58. Rf6 Bg2 59. Rf7+ Kh8 60. h7 followed by Kh6 and Rf8, mating.

Fernandez was evidently under the impression that 51. ... Kf8 did not change anything, and confidently pushed the pawn:

52. h5??

This grave error enables Black to draw the game! With the king on f8, White will be unable to drive the bishop away from the b1-h7 diagonal and the pawn will never reach h7 (as compared to the 51. ... Kh8 line, in which White used the threat of mate to force the bishop onto an undesirable square). In fact, the position before 52. h5 arose 10 times according to my database, and Fernandez was the only player who failed to win. The simplest path to victory, as indicated by Guretsky-Kornitz in 1863 and (and summarized in *Dvoretsky's Endgame Manual*), consists in bringing about *Zugzwang* through a series of subtle (but fairly straightforward) rook maneuvers: 52. Rg5 Kf7 53. Rg3 Bc2 54. Kh5 Kf6 (54. ... Bd1+?! 55. Kg5 Kg7 56. Rc3 Be2 57. h5! [once again, the pawn reaches h7 because the bishop is kept off the b1-h7 diagonal] 57. ... Bb5 58. h6+ Kh7 59. Rc7+ Kh8 60. h7, Black resigned, Augustin-Uhlmann, Halle, 1976) 55. Rg5! (intending 56. Kg4, thereby forcing Black's reply) 55. ... Bd1+ 56. Kh6 Kf7 57. Rg7+! Kf6 (57. ... Kf8 58. Kg6! with Kf6, Rg5, and h4-h5-h6 to follow) 58. Rg1 Be2 59. Rg2 Bd3 60. Rf2+ Bf5 61. h5. The king is driven onto the e-file, and the pawn promotes unobstructed.

The mechanism is perfectly described by Dvoretsky: "By positioning a rook on g5, White creates the threat of Kh5-g4 (this is why it is so crucial to keep the pawn on h4 for the time being). If the bishop parries the threat, it will lose control over the b1-h7 diagonal, allowing White to execute the Lequesne Method. If Black's king tries to interfere with ... Kf7 and ... Kf6, the rook will drive him even further away from the pawn with a timely check along the f-file."

52. ... Bc2 53. Rg3 Kf7 54. Rc3 Bb1 55. Rc8 Bd3 56. Kg5 Kg7 57. h6+ Kh7 58. Rc7+ Kh8 59. Rg7 Bc2 60. Kf6 Bd3 61. Rd7 Bc2 62. h7 Bxh7 63. Rd8+ Bg8 64. Kg6, Stalemate.

Whatever the concrete circumstance, always remember that a bishop's worst enemy is not an advanced passer, but an active piece! ♠

The Heart of a Devil

Shortly after becoming *Chess Life's* endgame columnist, GM Daniel Naroditsky played what he describes as “the most fascinating endgame ... in my chess career.”

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

I RECENTLY PARTICIPATED IN THE Qatar Masters Open, an historic event featuring 93 grandmasters, 14 of them over 2700. I scored a respectable 5½/9, but still came away with my hopes largely unfulfilled. I had two consecutive opportunities to score the victory of a lifetime, and I let the opportunity slip both times. In round seven, I outplayed Ukrainian Super-GM Pavel Eljanov, but my inexcusably sloppy endgame technique allowed him to construct an improbable defensive mechanism and snatch half a point from under my jaws. The following round, against Georgian GM Baadur Jobava, I found myself with a golden opportunity to right the wrongs of the previous day.

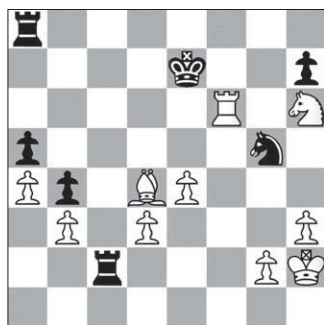
In this month's column, I am analyzing the endgame from my clash with Jobava. I will not reveal anything more at this point—merely that it is the most fascinating endgame that I have ever played out in my chess career.

Fascinating

Baadur Jobava (2722)

Daniel Naroditsky (2620)

Qatar Masters Open, Doha, 12.03.2014



BLACK TO MOVE

The opening was disastrous for me, but after a premature Exchange sacrifice, I found myself right back in the thick of things. White does have three pawns to the good, but the b3-pawn lacks protection and my pieces are fairly active. At the

moment, White is threatening to ravage Black's monarch with 34. h4 Ne6 35. Nf5+ Kd7 36. Rf7+, so the sleeping rook must be deployed to quench the fire.

33. ... Rf8!

A healthy start. Without the rook, White's two pieces will have a very hard time holding their own against Black's murderous tandem. And by the time his connected passed pawns become meaningful, Black will have already eliminated the b3- pawn.

34. Nf5+ Ke8 35. Kg3?

As we have established, allowing the rook trade is a very serious concession that immediately turns the tables in Black's favor. With 35. Rd6! White could have kept his most important piece on the board and preserved the initiative. To be sure, Black is more than alive after 35. ... Nf3+ 36. Kg3 Nxd4 37. Nxd4 Rc3 38. Nc6 Rxb3 39. e5, but White is certainly the one calling the shots.

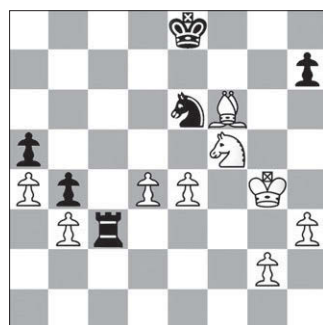
35. ... Rxf6 36. Bxf6 Ne6

To make matters worse for White, my knight is now ready to wreak havoc on White's pawns with ... Nc5.

37. d4

White takes the c5-square under control, but the rook is never against a free meal either.

37. ... Rc3+ 38. Kg4



During the game, I spent most of my remaining time (30 minutes were added after move 40) trying to determine whether or not to capture on b3 immediately, or after a preliminary ... Kf7. The reason I did not particularly care for 38. ... Rxb3 was twofold: I was not exactly sure what to do after 39. d5, and I was not thrilled about the knight maneuver 39. Nd6+ Kd7 40. Nb7. I did not have time for any kind of deep calculation; my intuition proved me right. While 39. d5 is not dangerous on account of 39. ... h5+, 39. Nd6+ should lead to a draw after 39. ... Kd7 40. Nb7 Rb2 41. d5 Rxb2+ 42. Kf3 Rc2 43. dxe6+ Kxe6 44. Ba1 b3 45. Nxa5 b2 46. Bxb2 Rxb2 47. Nc6 with a simple theoretical draw.

38. ... Kf7!

Now White is faced with a very difficult practical problem: where to move the bishop? Shaken by the sudden turn of events, Baadur replied quickly:

39. Bh4?

Of course, there is no such thing as a true 50/50 chance; you will always choose the wrong option. On h4, the bishop will support White's pawns, but it will do nothing to stop Black's b-pawn—and this will prove decisive. With 39. Be5! White could still have clung on to life and possibly survived. Black has nothing better than 39. ... Rxb3, and after 40. d5 Nc5 White has the nifty maneuver 41. Nd6+ Ke7 42. Nc4!. It is very hard to willingly part with the pride of your position, but desperate positions call for desperate measures. It seems to me that White should be able to hold the position after 42. ... Nxe4 43. Kf5 Ng3+ 44. Kg4 Rd3! 45. Nb2! Rxd5 46. Bxg3 Rd2 47. Be5 Rxb2+ 48. Kf3, although I'm not at all convinced that my conclusion is watertight. Whatever the objective evaluation, though, it is clear that 38. ... Kf7 confronts White with problems that are essentially irresolvable at the board, even for one of the strongest players in the world.

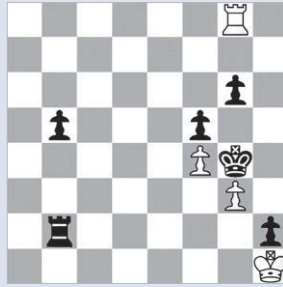
Capitalizing on your chances

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

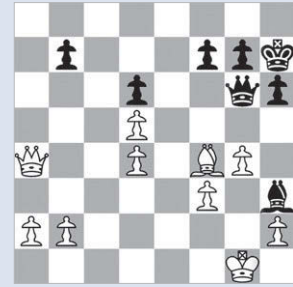
A.A. Mikhailov
L.G. Grigoriev
USSR, 1931



BLACK TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

Nidjat Mamedov (FIDE 2614)
Athanasios Mastrovasilis (FIDE 2503)
Athens, 2009



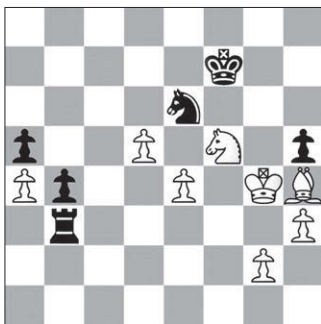
BLACK TO MOVE

39. ... Rxb3

Calmly taking care of business. When the time comes, Black will be able to sacrifice his knight to take White's two pawns out of the equation.

40. d5 Nc5

This move does the trick, but the most clinical approach was 40. ... h5+!, sacrificing a pawn to force the trade of knights.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

I saw the position after 41. Kxh5 Ng7+ 42. Nxg7 Kxg7, but was afraid that White's armada of passers would cause the rook some trouble. As a matter of fact, they cause the rook no trouble whatsoever; it is the b-pawn that causes the bishop a great deal of trouble. One sample line is 43. e5 (43. d6 Rd3 changes nothing) 43. ... Rd3 44. d6 b3 45. Bf6+ Kf7 46. Kg5 Ke6! and the pawn promotes.

41. e5 Rd3 42. e6+

I had anticipated this, of course. But now, with White's pieces impotently scattered on the kingside, the time is ripe to sacrifice the knight.

42. ... Nxe6!

White would have resigned rather than play 43. dxe6+ Kxe6—but Jobava has one more trick up his sleeve.

43. Nh6+!

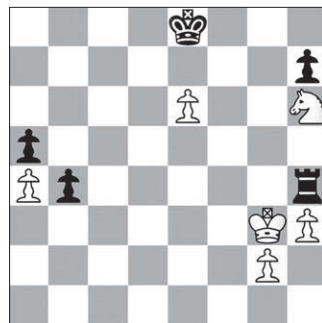
White's knight is thrown to the fire in

order to keep one of his pawns alive. The knight is untouchable: after 43. ... Kg6 44. dxe6 Black can neither play 44. ... Kxh6 (on account of 45. e7 Re3 46. Bg5+) nor a preliminary 44. ... Rd4+ due to 45. Kf3! when both pieces are untouchable and the tables are turned! As a matter of fact, Black can undo all of the damage with 44. ... Re3 followed by ... Rxe6 and ... b3, but I found an even cleaner way to reel in the point.

43. ... Ke8 44. dxe6

It looks like White has generated some counterplay—after all, 44. ... b3?? actually loses to 45. Nf5 followed by Ng7+ and e7+. But appearances are deceptive.

44. ... Rd4+ 45. Kg3 Rxh4!



Boom shaka-laka! White's bishop was the glue holding his entire flimsy construction together, and now that it is gone, Black can focus on his pawn. At this point, I was under the impression that White's knight will not be able to reach c3, a3, or d2 in time. But yet again, Jobava manages to prolong the game with an improbable last-ditch knight sally.

46. Kxh4 b3 47. Ng8!

The knight is able to reach c3 in the nick of time by delivering a check on f6, sacrificing the e-pawn to reach d5 with tempo, and then jumping to c3 while the pawn is on b2.

47. ... b2 48. Nf6+

All of the hard work is behind me—only a bit of straightforward calculation remains. Black's plan is obvious: he will need to eliminate the a4-pawn in the quickest way possible, and promote his a-pawn all before White's own king reaches the queenside. The best way to do this is clearly through the b4-square: once Black's king reaches b4, White will have to burn another tempo moving the knight. But during the game, I experienced a mental breakdown of sorts: for some unfathomable reason, I thought that the shortest route to the a4-pawn is through the center (yes, you read that right). My next move is probably one of the most embarrassing ones I have ever played:

48. ... Ke7??

This is not just a mere paint splotch on an otherwise flawless work; it throws everything away, allowing White's king to rush to the knight's rescue. After 48. ... Kd8! (or 48. ... Kf8) 49. e7+ Kxe7 50. Nd5+ Black plays not 50. ... Ke6, as I was forced to do in the game, but 50. ... Kd6!, when the win is elementary: 51. Nc3 Kc5 52. Kg3 Kb4 53. Nb1 Kxa4 54. Kf2 Kb3 55. Ke2 Ka2! 56. Nc3+ Ka1 57. Kd2 a4 58. Kc2 a3 with 59. ... a2 to follow. Curtains.

49. Nd5+ Kxe6 50. Nc3 Ke5

By needlessly taking the circuitous route, Black burns a crucial tempo, and White's king is just in time.

51. Kg3 Kd4 52. Nb1 Kd3 53. Kf3 Kc2 54. Na3+ Kb3 55. Nb1 Kc2, Draw agreed.

Black has nothing better than to repeat, since after 55. ... Kxa4? 56. Ke4 Kb4 57. Kd3 White is already in the driver's seat.

This was an incredibly painful game, but an awesome learning experience. The endgame frequently has the heart of a devil: it is just as easy to stumble on the simplest problem, when all of the work has apparently been done, as on the most complex task! ♣

Fasten Your Seatbelts

A virtually unknown endgame battle from 1972 that has a little bit of everything going on.

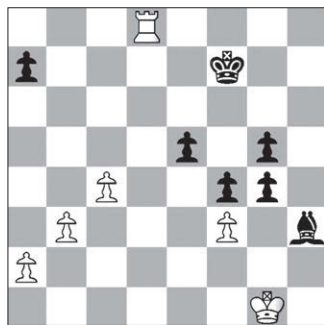
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IT IS NO FLUKE THAT DUTCH CORRESPONDENCE Master Ger Van Perlo published a 480 page volume on endgame tactics, and that Russian IM Orest Averkin frequently averred that “endgames are 90 percent tactics.” Though material is limited, the tactical element never disappears.

In this month’s column, I would like to examine a virtually unknown endgame struggle that is saturated with incredible tactical motifs, calculation challenges, and material imbalances of every kind. Wading through its complexities will be a Herculean task, but a rewarding and entertaining experience all the same. Buckle your seatbelts!

For the want of a tempo

Michael Stean
Adolf Herzog
Greifensee, 1972



BLACK TO MOVE

I stumbled upon this gem while flipping through GM John Nunn’s excellent work *Endgame Tactics* (George Allen & Unwin, 1981) a few years ago. Chess technology was still embryonic in 1981, and Nunn deserves the utmost praise for tackling this convoluted endgame without a computer. Unless otherwise noted, all commentary and analysis is my own.

Black appears to be in serious trouble. White is up an Exchange for a pawn, but more importantly, he must desperately generate enough counterplay to retard the c-pawn’s progress. Herzog is up to the task, and pulls a rabbit out of the hat:

32. ... gxf3!!?

Black leaves his bishop to the wolves, but creates a vicious armada of four connected passers in return. According to Nunn, both sides were in severe time pressure, so Herzog must have based this sacrifice purely on intuition—a courageous act indeed. As a matter of fact, the straightforward 32. ... Bf1!? 33. fxe4 e4 is also quite strong. In fact, it is White who must tread cautiously: Black’s two passers, supported by the bishop, are not to be sneezed at. To this end, the negligent 34. c5?—given by Nunn as the strongest continuation—leads to immediate calamity after 34. ... e3 35. Kg1 (35. c6?! e2 36. c7 e1=Q 37. c8=Q Qf2+ mates) 35. ... Be2!, and White is powerless to stop the f-pawn’s triumphant march. For instance, 36. Rd5 f3 37. Rf5+, trying to contain the pawn from behind, meets with total fiasco after 37. ... Ke6 38. c6 f2+ 39. Kg2 Bxg4 40. Rf8 Bh3+! 41. Kxh3 e2 and Black promotes anyway.

White should therefore bring the king over immediately with the cold-blooded 34. Kg1, and after 34. ... Be2 35. Rd5! (Not the only move, but the cleanest) 35. ... e3 36. Rxe5 f3 37. Rf5+ Ke6 38. Rf8 Black has nothing better than to force total liquidation with 38. ... f2+ 39. Rxf2 exf2+ 40. Kxf2 Bxg4.

What these variations lack in aesthetic appeal, they make up in instructive value!

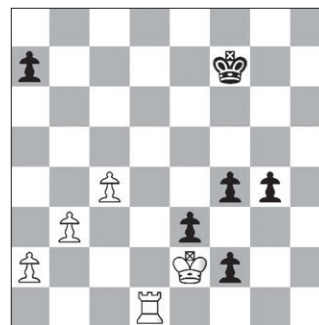
33. Kxh3 e4 34. Kg4!

Stean maintains his composure. The king moves closer to the pawn mass, ready to occupy a crucial blockading square on f3.

34. ... f2 35. Rd1

The rook arrives on the first rank in the nick of time. Luckily for both players, neither side has a choice of moves in spite of the position’s complexity. Of course, this will not remain the case for very long!

35. ... e3 36. Kf3 g4+ 37. Ke2



This is where the real fun begins! First of all, the attempt to win immediately with 37. ... g3 38. Kf3 g2 39. Kxg2 e2 is coolly rebuffed by 40. Rd7+! Ke6 41. Kxf2. Since Black’s pawn armada cannot surmount the king and rook on its own, the monarch will have to lend its support. But can he do so before the c-pawn reaches pay dirt?

There is clearly no place for abstract thinking; one must simply hunker down and calculate as much and as accurately as possible. Black should begin by considering the most tempting and natural move: 37. ... Ke6. After 38. c5 (clearly forced) 38. ... Kf5, Black threatens the deadly 39. ... Ke4, when the pawns will tear White’s king limb from limb—39. c6?? Ke4 40. c7 f3+ 41. Kf1 g3! is curtains. Nonetheless, White is able to hold the fort with 39. Rc1!, intending to drive away the king as soon as it reaches e4. As it turns out, neither side can make any progress: 39. ... Ke4 40. Rc4+ Ke5 is forced, when the rook must return to c1 in order to prevent ... g4-g3.

With his flag falling, Herzog understandably decides that it could not hurt to preemptively freeze White’s rook and king (showing chess can be a cruel game):

37. ... g3??

While perfectly sound from a general point of view, ... g3 enables White to win the game with a mind-blowing tactical motif. In the endgame, calculation frequently transcends logical reasoning.

Quietly devastating

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solvable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2764)
GM Rustam Kasimdzhanov (FIDE 2706)
Baku, 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

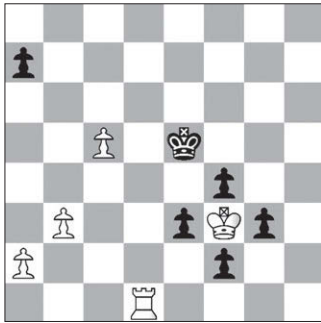
GM Wesley So (FIDE 2762)
GM Julio Becerra (FIDE 2547)
U.S. Chess League, 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

38. Kf3 Ke6 39. c5

The critical moment. Herzog was undoubtedly intending 39. ... Ke5, when ... g2 already becomes a threat and it appears that Black is doing rather swimmingly.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

White can draw the game with 40. c6? g2 41. Kxg2 e2 42. Rd5+! Kxd5 43. Kxf2 Kxc6 44. Kxe2, but he can definitely try for more by removing his rook from d1, taking the sting out of ... g2. The only plausible square seems to be c1, but Black is able to hold by the skin of his teeth: 40. Rc1 Kd4 41. c6 Kd3 42. c7 e2 43. c8=Q f1=Q+ 44. Kg4 e1=Q and now White has nothing better than to bail out with 45. Qc4+ Kd2 46. Qxf1 Qxc1 47. Qxf4+ Kc2 48. Qxg3 Kb1, when Black will win one of the pawns back and secure the draw.

When calculating, it is important to determine why a certain idea fell short. This will allow you to (hopefully) maximize its potency by determining the correct execution. In this case, the dreadful rook neglected Black's pawn flotilla entirely, allowing two consecutive promotions. But what if we try the outwardly ludicrous 39. Rf1, facing the pawns with a physical roadblock? After 39. ... Ke5 40. c5 Kd4 (40. ... a5 41. a3 or 40. ... Kd5 41. b4 do not change anything) 41. c6 Kd3 42. c7 e2 43. c8=Q, Black can no longer promote on f1 with check! Amazingly, the f2-pawn

—once the pride of Black's position—is now the bane of his existence: 43. ... exf1=Q 44. Qc4+ skewers the queen, and wins the game.

39. Rf1 is definitely one of the finest endgame motifs I have ever come upon. It might look like a computer move, but with accurate calculation, patience, and imagination, such ideas can be found by humans. Indeed, the text move is a clear indication that Herzog discovered the flaw in his calculations.

39. ... a5?!

An admirable attempt to muddy the waters, but it actually gives White a choice of wins. It was probably worth trying 39. ... Ke5 after all; if GM Nunn missed 39. Rf1 in his annotations, then it is very probable that Stean would have overlooked it with seconds left on his clock.

40. a3

Stean reaches time control and maintains the status quo. As a matter of fact, the insertion of the last two moves will open up another path to victory on the next move, but 40. Rc1 was a lot simpler. Black has nothing better than 40. ... Kd7 (he is too late after 40. ... Kd5 41. c6 Kd4 42. c7 Kd3 43. c8=Q), when 41. c6+ Kc7 42. a3 followed by b4-b4-b5-b6 is clearly decisive.

40. ... Ke5 41. Rc1?!

Amazingly, the seemingly inconsequential a-pawn advances make this move possible! A gifted analytic, Stean had plenty of time to examine this position during adjournment, so Herzog really had nothing to hope for. Of course, the aforementioned Rf1!! would have been just as strong here as before.

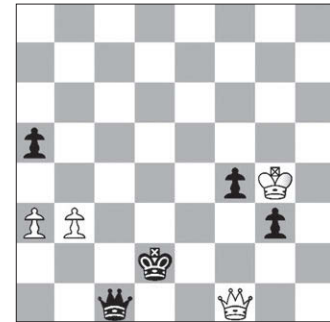
41. ... Kd4 42. c6 Kd3

According to Nunn, **Black resigned** at this point, evidently having determined that Stean had found the path to victory.

43. c7 e2 44. c8=Q f1=Q+

This is obviously forced; the amusing 44. ... e1=N?! only accelerates Black's fate after 45. Kg4 f1=Q 46. Qc4+.

45. Kg4 e1=Q 46. Qc4+ Kd2 47. Qxf1 Qxc1



This position—without the inclusion of ... a5 and a3, of course—is already familiar to us from the analysis of 39. ... Ke5. There, White had nothing better than Qxf4+ and Qxg3, but due to his newfound ability to create a passed pawn with b3-b4 (I know you're sick of hearing about passed pawns; bear with me for another few moments!), the queen trade wins the game!

48. Qxf4+ Kc2 49. Qxc1+! Kxc1 50. Kxg3 Kb2 51. b4 a4 52. b5 Kxa3 53. b6 Kb2 54. b7 a3 55. b8=Q+

Fittingly enough, the game is decided by one tempo.

Complexity leads to brilliance

In the middlegame, the sequence of events is often fairly logical; for instance, an inaccuracy leads to an attack, which intensifies and eventually culminates in a mating combination. In the endgame, on the other hand, the battle frequently unfolds in a nonlinear manner; the critical moments and decisive mistakes can be nearly imperceptible without deep analysis. But by working hard and using general reasoning to complement, rather than to replace, precise calculation, its complexities *can* be worked out, and brilliant ideas *can* be discovered! ♠

Fighting Tooth-and-Nail

A challenging endgame from the 2015 Tata Steel event in Wijk aan Zee.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

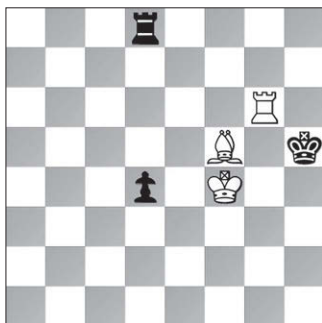
TATA STEEL IS A FAVORITE TOURNAMENT of many. With a generous prize fund and two elite groups, the tournament invariably produces 13 rounds of tooth-and-nail chess. This month let's examine the most scintillating and instructive endgame battle from this year's event in the Netherlands.

Theoretically drawn

GM Erwin L'Ami (2613)

GM Bart Michiels (2563)

Wijk aan Zee, 2015



BLACK TO MOVE

After a long and torturous middlegame, Belgian GM Bart Michiels has reached a theoretically drawn endgame. As a rule, drawing with a rook against a rook and bishop is not difficult, especially if you are acquainted with the principal drawing mechanism. However, in this particular instance, Black's king is nearly ensnared in a mating net, and the wretched d-pawn impedes the rook from delivering an important check on d4. The objective evaluation does not change, but Black must tread carefully.

87. ... d3!

A healthy start. By advancing his pawn, Black vacates the d4-square and diverts White's attention from his ailing monarch.

88. Rg7

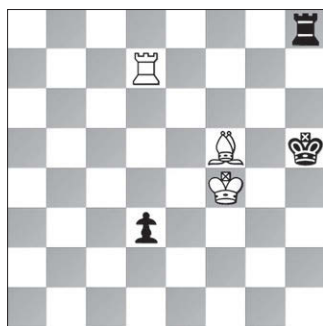
White threatens mate on h7, and confronts Black with an irksome predicament. Michiels does not sense the danger:

88. ... Rh8??

The most obvious move, but a massive blunder all the same. With Black's king in mortal danger, passive defense is the recipe for disaster. With 88. ... Rd6!, Black could have taken the sting out of 89. Rh7+ while keeping his rook fairly mobile. In fact, White can make no progress whatsoever: neither 89. Rh7+ Rh6 90. Rd7 Rb6 91. Rxd3 Kh6 92. Rd7 Kh5 nor 89. Rg3 Kh6 90. Bxd3 Rd5 poses Black any difficulties (other than suffering for the next 50 moves).

89. Rg5+?

After 89 moves of full-tilt grandmaster chess, both players are tired. With this ill-fated check, L'Ami relinquishes the grip on Black's king and justifies his previous move. With the accurate 89. Rd7!, White could have highlighted the central flaw of Black's passive approach.



Both Michiels and L'Ami evidently failed to perceive that Black's rook is imprisoned on the h-file. After 89. ... d2 (89. ... Kh6 90. Bxd3 essentially transposes) 90. Rxd2 Kh6 91. Rd7 Kh5 (forced, since moving the rook allows immediate checkmate on h7), White literally drives Black off the board with 92. Rc7! (any rook move along the seventh rank other than Rf7 and Rg7 does the trick) 92. ... Kh6 (92. ... Kh4 93. Rc1) 93. Kg4 and Black's king runs out of real estate! The only way to stave off immediate checkmate is with 93. ... Rg8+ 94. Kh4 Rg7, but 95. Rc6+! picks up the rook.

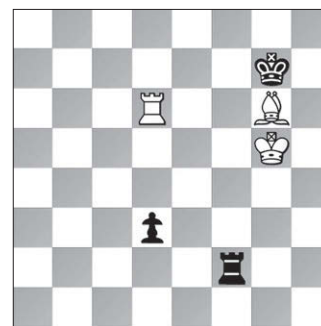
A very instructive and aesthetically pleasing sequence, culminating in a fairly

unusual *Zugzwang*. Even without any calculation, L'Ami should have noticed that the unfortunate position of Black's rook gave him a golden opportunity to decide the game in his favor.

89. ... Kh6 90. Rg6+ Kh7!

Black's king has evacuated the danger zone, and White has little to show for it.

91. Rd6+ Kg7 92. Kg5 Rf8 93. Bg6 Rf2?!



This is a particularly instructive moment. The position is completely drawn, but Black is not quite out of danger. With 93. ... Rf2, Michiels needlessly allows White to push his king back to the eighth rank, when making the draw will (once again) require the utmost precision. After the more prudent 93. ... Rf3!, Black nips White's idea in the bud: 94. Rd7+ Kf8 is no longer effective, since 95. Bf5 (95. Bxd3 Rf7!) 95. ... Ke8 forces the rook backwards. We will see in a moment why Black's rook should be placed on f3.

94. Rd7+ Kf8 95. Bf5!

With the rook on f3, 95. ... Ke8 would immediately solve all of Black's problems, but now White has 96. Rxd3, keeping the monarch imprisoned. Nonetheless, this would have been the lesser evil: following 96. ... Kf7 97. Rd7+ Ke8 White is unable to mobilize his king in time, and after 98. Rb7 Kd8 99. Kf6 Rd2 Black is able to set up an ideal defensive construction. But Michiels—understandably enough—decides to keep the pride of his position alive.

Biting and scratching

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

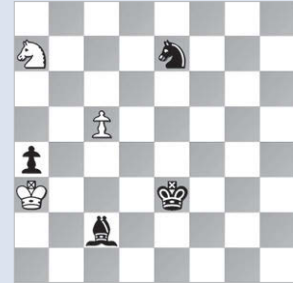
IM Gudmundur Kjartansson (FIDE 2439)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (FIDE 2602)
SPICE Cup, 2014



BLACK TO MOVE

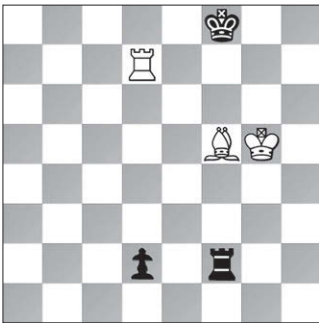
Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Viswanathan Anand (FIDE 2781)
GM Garry Kasparov (FIDE 2812)
Linares, 1999



BLACK TO MOVE

95. ... d2??



It is hard to believe that this natural move, which establishes an ostensibly monstrous protected passer on d2, loses the game. Indeed, how can White possibly generate any winning chances with his rook so tied down?

As usual, appearances are deceptive. In just two moves, Black will be forced to give up the pawn due to *Zugzwang*. Following its elimination, Black's monarch will be permanently entombed on the eighth rank, and the misplaced rook will be incapable of dealing with the ensuing mate threats.

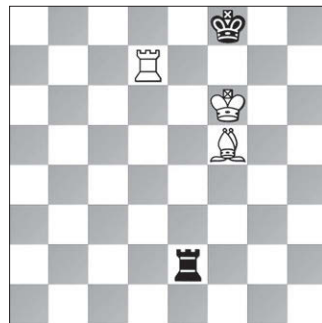
In order to survive, Black had to do everything in his power to set his king free. There were several ways to achieve this, but 95. ... Ke8! 96. Rxd3 Ke7 was the most precise. After 97. Rd7+ Ke8, Black threatens ... Rxf5+ and White has no choice but to loosen his grip on the enemy king. The best try is probably 98. Ra7, but with 98. ... Kd8 99. Kf6 Rd2! Black sets up an impervious defensive construction.

96. Kf6 Ke8?!

Total collapse. After this cooperative move, the win will be very straightforward. 96. ... Re2! was far more resilient, and after 97. Rd8+ Re8 98. Rxd2 Re7 99. Rd8+ Re8 100. Rd7 Re2 White still has work to do.

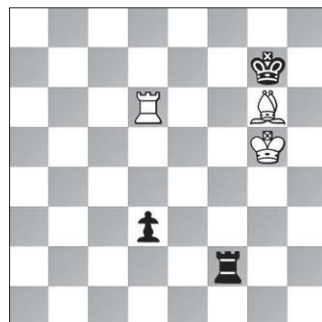
(see diagram top of next column)

White's main issue is that the tempting 101. Rh7?!, hoping for after 101. ... Kg8?



102. Rh3 Rf2 103. Rc3, is well met by 101. ... Rg2!, and White is back to square one. The winning mechanism is quite beautiful, and rather difficult to find: with a random move along the seventh rank—101. Ra7, for instance—White forces either 101. ... Re1 or 101. ... Re3. In both cases, the position of Black's rook does him in:

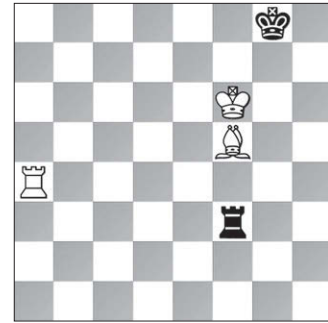
A. After 101. ... Re1 102. Rh7 Rg1, the stunning 103. Bh3!! decides the matter.



Black has nothing better than 103. ... Rg3 (103. ... Kg8 104. Rc7 Kh8 105. Rc4! Rg7 106. Rb4 and Black will lose his rook), but after 104. Be6 Rf3+ 105. Bf5 Rg3 106. Rf7+ Ke8 107. Rc7 it suddenly turns out that 107. ... Rd3 is impossible! The entire point of White's maneuver, then, was to compromise the position of Black's rook.

B. 101. ... Re3 is less tenacious: the fairly straightforward 102. Rh7 Kg8 (102. ... Rg3 103. Rf7+ Ke8 104. Rc7 transposes to the final position of variation A!) 103. Rh4! Rf3 104. Ra4 wins immediately, as

Black must give up his rook to stop mate.



Both of these variations, but especially line A, feature very instructive maneuvers that we must all take to heart.

97. Rd3! Rf3 98. Rxd2 Rf1

Michiels probably still harbored some faint hopes at this point, but L'Ami finds the quickest route to victory.

99. Rh2! Kd8

Tear down this wall, Mr. Gorbachev! Black's king needs only one more move to escape to freedom, but after ...

100. Rc2!, Black resigned.

It is all for naught. Black cannot stop Rc8 mate without giving up his rook, so Black resigned.

This game is not as spectacular as some of the previous battles I have examined in this column, but it is tremendously enlightening all the same. Even though a position might be theoretically drawn, theory and practice are two entirely different kettles of fish. With exhaustion and time trouble inevitably appearing at the end of a long game, it is inordinately tempting to let down your guard and switch on the autopilot. But one moment of negligence can nullify hours of hard work, and the ability to consistently exploit such negligence will bring you one step closer to endgame mastery. ♠

A World Turned Upside Down

An endgame featuring many beautiful motifs, twists-and-turns, and instructive moments.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE TACTICAL ELEMENT NEVER DIS-appears. Even with very few pieces left on the board, the game can resemble a complex middlegame battle. In this month's column, let's examine a fantastic endgame clash between two veterans of American chess that featured just such an "endgame middlegame." Read on!

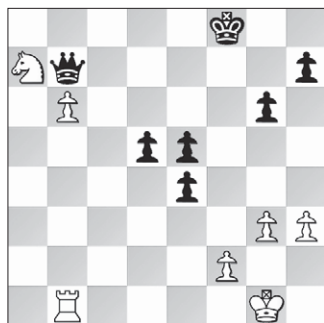
Topsy-Turvy

FM Joel Salman (2203)

IM Jay Bonin (2340)

2006 Nassau CC Championship (8),

Mineola, New York, 05.12.2006



WHITE TO MOVE

We join the battle in the midst of a wild tactical skirmish. After missing several opportunities to quell White's initiative in the middlegame, Bonin finds himself in a dire situation. Simply put, there is no way for the queen to neutralize White's vicious three-piece tandem.

31. Nc6!

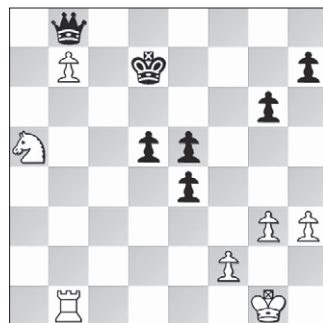
Terribly strong. The queen cannot afford to leave its post, but it will be forced to do so after the knight reaches a5 or d8. A desperate Bonin plays his last card:

31. ... Ke8?!

The slothful king will not stop the pawn, but at least a Rc1-Rc8 will not come with such after it reaches d7. The thoughtless 31. ... d4? would only hasten the defeat after 32. Na5 Qb8 33. b7 e3 34. fxe3! (but

not 34. Nc6?? Qxb7! 35. Rxb7 e2 36. Rb1 d3 and the tables are suddenly turned!) 34. ... dxe3 (34. ... e4 35. Kg2) 35. Nc6 and the queen, having conducted a valiant last stand, must accept the inevitable.

32. Na5 Qb8 33. b7 Kd7



Black is clearly on his last legs, but White still has work to do. The difficulty lies not in pushing the queen from b8, but in choosing the optimal way to accomplish this task. Salman—probably after a period of intense vacillation—decides on the most natural approach:

34. Rc1?

Simple, unstoppable, and crushing ... or so it seems. White threatens Rc8, when Black will have no choice but to give his queen up for the rook and pawn. With the king all the way on c8, Black's outwardly intimidating pawn flotilla will be easy pickings for the knight. From a logical standpoint, this move is perfectly correct, **but concreteness transcends logic 100% of the time.** Engrossed in the queen hunt, White overlooks a devastating tactical shot that instantly turns the tables. Do you see it?

34. ... e3!

With apologies to my English teacher: a bolt from the blue! The queen, ostensibly confined to a slow and miserable death, suddenly exudes unspeakable power. After 35. fxe3 e4 36. Kg2 Qf8!, Black threatens ... Qf3+ and White can do better than a

perpetual after 37. Rf1 Qb4 38. Rf7+ (or 38. h4 Ke8 39. Rc1 Kd7 40. Rc8 Qb2+ 41. Kh3 Qf6! 42. b8=Q Qf1+ 43. Kh2 Qf2+ and the newly-minted queen cannot stop the checks) 38. ... Ke8 39. Re7+!? Kf8! (39. ... Kxe7?? 40. Nc6+ would be rather sad) 40. Rc7 Qb2+ 41. Kg1 Qb1+ and the checks will keep on coming.

With the pawn untouchable, White has no choice but to eliminate the malevolent queen as quickly as possible:

35. Rc8

Now, however, the e3-pawn is left totally unchecked. 35. ... e2 forces an immediate perpetual, but Black is no longer playing for a draw:

35. ... Qxb7?!

An excellent psychological decision. A less courageous soul would have calculated that 35. ... e2 36. Rxb8 e1=Q+ 37. Kg2 Qe4+ 38. Kh2 Qf5 39. Rd8+ Ke6 40. Rd6+ Kf7 41. b8=Q Qxf2+ leads to perpetual, and would have pushed the pawn without vacillation. But Bonin correctly intuits that his pawn armada will neutralize the knight with room to spare.

36. Rd8+?

Practically illogical, and objectively flawed! Salman tries to be fancy, but he simply ends up tricking himself. Compare the position after 36. Nxb7 Kxc8 and 36. Rd8+ Kxd8 37. Nxb7+: in the latter, White has needlessly given Black's king a choice of squares. Much more importantly, though, the rook has lost its connection to the first rank, and this gives Black an amazing opportunity.

36. ... Kxd8?

Bonin probably recaptured instantly, and understandably so. When looking through this game for the first time (but several minutes later), an incredible thought came into my mind: does Black really have to capture? In fact, after the jaw-dropping 36. ... Ke7!! 37. Nxb7 e2,

The devil is in the details

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See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level

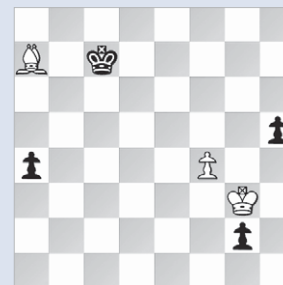
GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2786)
GM Vladimir Kramnik (FIDE 2793)
World Team Championship, Antalya, 2013



WHITE TO MOVE

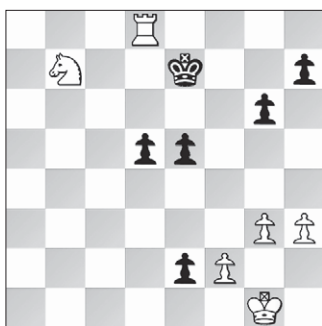
Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Christopher Lutz (FIDE 2610)
GM Michael Adams (FIDE 2716)
Frankfurt, 1999



BLACK TO MOVE

White cannot stop the pawn.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Some people can stare at the ocean for hours, but this position is no less captivating. White has a rook and a knight to the good, his king is right next to the passed pawn, and yet it is totally unstoppable. The desperado attempt 38. Rd7+!?, hoping for 38. ... Kxd7?? 39. Nc5+ followed by 40. Nd3, is coolly rebuffed by 38. ... Kf6! 39. Rd6+ Kg7 40. Rd7+ Kh6. The best White can do is 41. Nd8 (41. Rxd5 e1=Q+ 42. Kg2 Qe4+ picks up the rook) 41. ... e1=Q+ 42. Kg2, hoping to conjure up some counterplay against Black's king, but after 42. ... Qe4+ 43. Kh2 Qe2 his drawing chances are meager.

In the endgame, insane tactical opportunities frequently arise out of nowhere. A move is not forced until proven forced!

37. Nxb7+ Kc7 38. Nc5 e2 39. Nd3

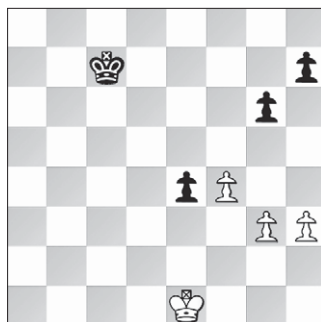
White's knight reaches d3 in the nick of time, and mass liquidation is inevitable. Note that an essentially identical position would have arisen after 36. Nxb7 Kxc8 37. Nc5 e2 38. Nd3. In the resulting position, the king on c8 (version c7 in the game) gives White an important extra move.

39. ... e4 40. Ne1 d4 41. f4!?

The knight obviously cannot restrain the pawn phalanx on its own, so the king will come to its support via f2. The more straightforward 41. f3 also led to Rome:

41. ... d3 (41. ... e3?? 42. f4 Kd6 43. Kg2 Kd5 44. Kf3) 42. Kf2 d2 43. Kxe2 dxe1=Q+ 44. Kxe1 exf3 45. Kf2 with a draw.

41. ... d3 42. Kf2 d2 43. Kxe2 dxe1=Q+ 44. Kxe1



Finally, after a fascinating back-and-forth sequence, the smoke has cleared. The e4-pawn is somewhat awkward, but with material so limited, White will be unable to induce any kind of Zugzwang.

44. ... Kd6 45. Ke2

An important moment. **In general, pawn endings featuring two or three pawns for each side can be calculated out to their conclusion.** Over-relying on intuition or playing a move that looks right is a recipe for disaster; one must simply hunker down and calculate. Instead, Bonin falls for temptation:

45. ... Ke6??

A painful blunder, but a very instructive moment all the same. Black's intention is clear: he wants to hold off on ... Kd5 until White's king reaches e3. Indeed, 45. ... Kd5 46. Ke3 looks like a textbook case of Zugzwang. But had he pushed general considerations aside, Bonin would have immediately realized that both 46. ... h6 and 46. ... h5 allow Black to "unzug" himself and secure an immediate draw:

A. 46. ... h6 is the simplest. After 47. g4 g5! 48. f5 Ke5 White creates a protected passer, but he can make zero progress. For instance, 49. Kf2 Kd5 50. Ke2 Ke5 51. Ke3 Kd5 and so on.

B. 46. ... h5!? is a slightly more, uh, computeresque method. It is rather hard to imagine that the position after 47. h4 (47. g4 hxg4 48. hxg4 g5! draws) 47. ... Kd6 48. Kxe4 Ke6 is drawn; White cannot make inroads despite his extra pawn!

After the text move, Salman is able to reach the same position with White to move—and this makes a crucial difference.

46. Ke3 Kd5 47. g4!

Uh-oh! Now, 47. ... h5 48. gxh5 gxh5 49. h4 is indeed Zugzwang, so Black's reply is forced:

47. ... h6 48. h4

With the pawn on h2, 48. ... g5 would have drawn, but now White can create a passer on the h-file with 49. fxg5 hxg5 50. h5, and White seals the deal with a beautiful triangulation maneuver: 50. ... Ke5 51. Kd2 Ke6 52. Kc2! Kf6 53. Kb3! Ke6 54. Kc4 Ke5 55. Kc3 and Black must give up his pawn. Bonin tries a different approach, but it loses even faster.

48. ... h5 49. g5 Kd6 50. Kd4 Ke7 51. Kxe4 Ke6

If not for White's next move, Black's strategy would have worked to perfection:

52. f5+!

Boom shaka-laka. White creates a fearsome protected passer on g5, and Black will be unable to keep material equality. The game is over.

52. ... gxf5+ 53. Kf4 Kf7 54. Kxf5 Kg7 55. Ke5!

Of course not 55. g6?? Kh6 56. Kf6 stalemate!

55. ... Kf7 56. Kd6 Kg7 57. Ke7 Kg6 58. Ke6 Kg7 59. Kf5, Black resigned.

After 59. ... Kf7 60. g6+ Kg7 61. Kg5 White wins the second pawn. ♠

Make sure you have registered to vote in the 2015 executive board election. Check your status at <https://secure2.uschess.org/voterregistration.php>

Ego Trip

Naroditsky had a brutal experience at the 2015 U.S. Championship, but here is an example of what went right.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

BOASTING A WORLD-CLASS FIELD, THE 2015 U.S. Championship produced 11 rounds of high-quality, fighting chess and left spectators on the edge of their seats. Coming off sensational victories in Gibraltar and London, GM Hikaru Nakamura was his typical unstoppable self, starting with two wins and never looking back. In the Women's Championship, GM Irina Krush reaffirmed her total domination over American women's chess and finished a full point ahead of her nearest pursuer.

Unfortunately, the championship was a brutal event for me. After losing the first two games, I completely lost my footing and finished in last place with 2½/11, dropping more than 20 rating points in the process. A disappointment, but I will learn from my mistakes and definitely come away stronger.

An event of this caliber always produces a litany of fascinating endgame battles. It is a real shame that we must limit ourselves to one. And I must admit, ego simply got the better of me this time!

Halting Holt

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2730)

GM Conrad Holt (2626)

2015 U.S. Championship (9), St. Louis, Missouri,
04.10.2015

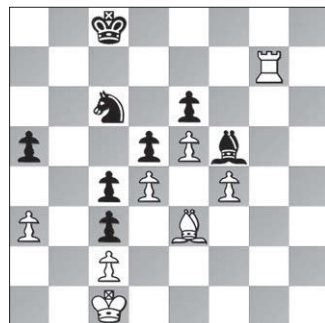


My only success of the tournament came in round nine, against GM Conrad Holt. After gaining the upper hand in a sharp French, I won an Exchange and managed

to liquidate into a rather unusual ending. White's material advantage should be decisive, but it is remarkably difficult to make progress. In order to untangle himself, White must find a way to eliminate the c3-pawn. To this end, my first inclination was to play 40. f3, intending an eventual Bf2-e1. However, following 40. ... a4 41. Bf2 Kb8! Black threatens the highly problematic ... Na7-b5, essentially forcing 42. Be1. After 42. ... Nxd4 43. Bxc3 Nxf3 Black gains a pawn for the Exchange and keeps his fortress alive. Not impressive.

With only a few minutes remaining, my eye was suddenly drawn to an improbable geometric construction: if White can clear the third rank while keeping the d4-pawn defended, there is nothing to stop the rook from picking up the c3-pawn!

40. f4!



There is still room for creativity in the endgame. Needless to mention, f2-f4 is a decidedly anti-positional move, but it is the only way to generate tangible winning chances. As usual, concrete calculation trumps general reasoning.

40. ... a4!

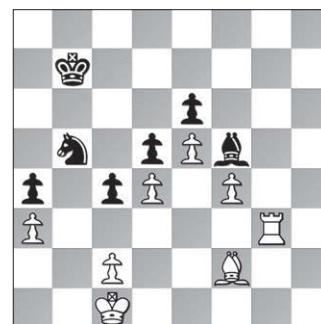
Conrad maintains his composure, finding the only way to retain drawing chances. By immobilizing the a3-pawn, Black ensures that a future knight maneuver to b5 will come with far greater effect.

41. Bf2

At this point, Conrad settled into a deep think. There is obviously plenty to ponder. Given only a few moves, White will snag the c3-pawn, move his rook back to g3, and slowly wear down Black's outwardly impregnable fortress. Clearly perturbed by the turn of events, my opponent simply loses the thread.

41. ... Kd8?!

A clear step in the wrong direction, and a precursor to the calamitous blunder on the next move. To generate counterplay, Black had to prepare the aforementioned ... Na7-b5 maneuver, and 41. ... Kb8! was the right way to do it. After 42. Rg3 Na7 43. Rxc3 Nb5 44. Rg3 Kb7 a fascinating position arises.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Amazingly, the absence of the c3-pawn does not make White's job any easier. There is simply no way to make inroads without giving back at least a pawn. White must choose between several equally tempting options:

- A. 45. Be1?! gives up the wrong pawn. After 45. ... Nxd4 46. Rg2 Kc6 Black has excellent drawing chances.
- B. 45. c3!? is a worthy try, but it seems to fall just short: 45. ... Nxa3 46. Kb2 Nb5 47. Be1 Kb6 and I can't see any compelling way to make inroads. For instance, 48. Rg8 a3+ 49. Ka2 Kc6 and White's bishop is perpetually tied down to the c3-pawn, rendering Black's fortress completely impenetrable.

Practically perfect

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Problem I: 1500 Level
GM Gata Kamsky (2762)
GM Conrad Holt (2626)
 2015 U.S. Championship (7)



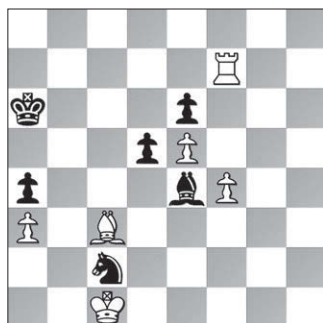
WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level
Apurva Virkud (2239)
GM Irina Krush (2549)
 2015 U.S. Women's Championship (4)

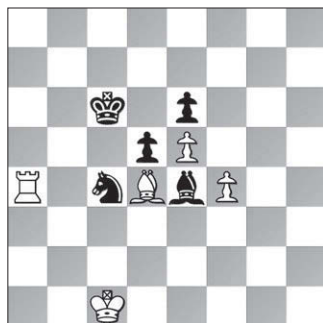


BLACK TO MOVE

C. 45. Kb2! is definitely the way to go, although it is hard to say whether White's position is winning. After the semi-forced sequence 45. ... c3+ 46. Kc1 Be4 47. Be1 Nxd4 48. Rg7+ Ka6 49. Bxc3 Nxc2 50. Rf7 White's pieces reach peak activity and f4-f5 becomes a deadly threat.



Even still, the game is far from over. Black reinforces the f5-square with 50. ... Ne3, and following 51. Bd4 Nc4 52. Ra7+ (52. f5, tempting as it looks, falls short after 52. ... Bxf5 and 53. Rxf5?? no longer works) 52. ... Kb5 53. Rb7+ Kc6! 54. Rb4 Nxa3 55. Rxa4 Nc4 ...



I would probably rate Black's drawing chances as slightly higher than White's winning chances. The torture will go on forever, but I cannot see a compelling plan to make progress.

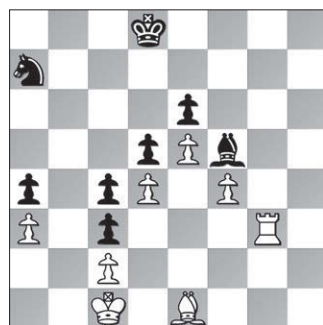
Amazing. It is very rare that such an

overwhelming material advantage does not turn out to be decisive.

42. Rg3 Na7?

The right idea, but a flawed execution. As it turns out, the position of Black's king on d8 will lead to his instant demise. It was not too late to get back on the right track with 42. ... Kc7! 43. Rxc3 Na7.

43. Be1!



This move came as a shock to Conrad, who was undoubtedly expecting 43. Rxc3. Instead, White abruptly shifts gears, choosing to capture on c3 with the bishop.

43. ... Nb5 44. Bxc3

Only now does everything become clear. With the king on b8, White's concept would have been ludicrous, but as it stands, the a3-pawn is untouchable on account of Ba5+! In an attempt to improve the position of his king, Black unintentionally corrupted the drawing mechanism by removing its key component.

44. ... Ke8

A sad necessity, but the damage is already done. With the bishop on c3, White has all the time in the world to lock up the queenside and penetrate.

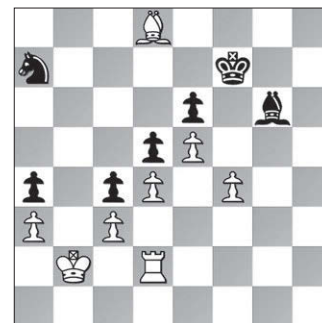
45. Kb2 Kf7 46. Rg2 Be4 47. Rd2 Bf5

Black is consigned to passivity, since 47. ... Kg6 48. Bb4 Kf5 would only accelerate the inevitable after 49. c3! Kxf4 50. Rf2+ Bf3 51. Rh2 with Rh7 to follow.

48. Ba5 Bg6 49. c3

Permanently locking up the queenside, and ending Black's hopes for counterplay once and for all.

49. ... Na7 50. Bd8



The last finesse. The bishop is transferred to an ideal square on f6, where it will restrict the knight and pave the way for the rook.

50. ... Nc6 51. Bf6 Be4 52. Rh2 Ke8 53. Rh8+ Kd7 54. Rg8 Kc7 55. Rg7+ Kb6 56. Be7 Bf5

Of course, 56. ... Nxe7 57. Rxe7 Bf5 offered no hope: White wins in rather comical fashion by bringing his king to f6 and taking on e6.

57. Bc5+ Ka6 58. Rf7!

Threatening Rxf5 followed by e6.

58. ... Bg4 59. Kc2, Black resigned.

The immediate 59. f5 won faster, but —seeing as how I was not exactly in top form—I decided to play it safe by bringing my king over.

A practical endgame in the purest sense. From the outset, both players faced concrete challenges that have little to do with theoretical knowledge or general understanding. Imagination, precise calculation, tenacity—these are the central attributes of a modern endgame player! ♣

Mistakes: The Best Way to Learn

The most instructive games are not always the most aesthetically pleasing.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

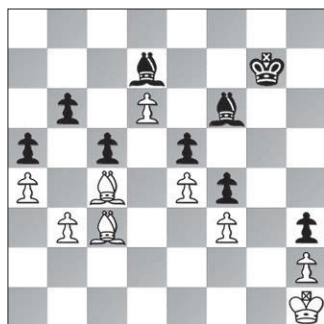
THERE IS A WELL-KNOWN RUSSIAN proverb: “On mistakes, we learn!” In chess, as in life, examining the mistakes we commit—and the underlying reasons behind them—greatly enriches our understanding of the game. As we are about to see, the most instructive games are not always pleasing to the eye!

Insipid?

GM Arnold Denker

GM Samuel Reshevsky

New York, 1959



WHITE TO MOVE

After a long and colorless middlegame, the players have liquidated into an even more insipid endgame—or so it seems. Objectively speaking, Black has indeed constructed an impenetrable fortress. But for the longest time, neither Denker nor Reshevsky realize that Black is still walking through a minefield.

39. Kg1 Kg6

Already, Reshevsky fails to identify the potential sources of danger. In fact, there is only one idea that he must watch out for: Bc4-b5, forcing a trade of bishops and clearing the way for White's passer. To this end, 39. ... Kf8 was a far more convincing way to draw. With the king so close to the pawn, Bb5 is never an issue, and White cannot make progress. A possible continuation is 40. Kf1 (40. Bb5?? is senseless: after 40. ... Bxb5 41. axb5

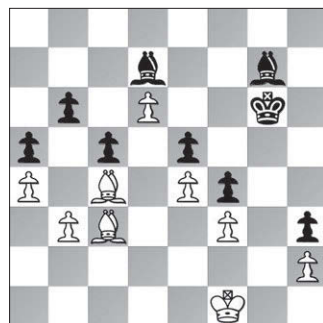
Ke8 42. Kf2 Kd7 Black wins the pawn and the game!) 40. ... Ke8 41. Ke2 Bc6 and White has nothing better than three-fold repetition with 42. Be6 Bd7 43. Bc4.

While the text move does no permanent damage, Reshevsky is definitely playing with fire by needlessly keeping his monarch so far away.

40. Kf1

40. Bb5 already made some sense, although Black is able to hold the fort with 40. ... Bxb5 41. axb5 Kf7 42. Bxa5! Bd8! (42. ... bxa5? 43. b6 and White promotes) and luckily for Black, the absence of the a-pawn makes no difference. Judging by the course of the game, though, I'm almost certain that the general possibility of Bxa5 slipped through the cracks of Reshevsky's tactical radar.

40. ... Bg7??



In the opening and middlegame, our sense of danger is automatically alerted by certain characteristics of the position (king weakness, structural deficiency, badly-placed pieces, open files, etc.). In the endgame, on the other hand, tactical shots often emerge out of the blue. **Therefore, no matter how impervious your position appears, it is crucial to scan the horizon for any and all of your opponent's potential resources.**

Evidently, both players were convinced that White cannot make progress, and this over-reliance on superficial reasoning results in several egregious tactical over-

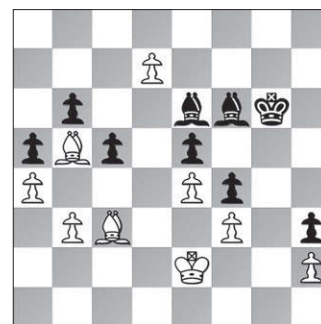
sights on both ends. With 40. ... Bg7, Black retreats his bishop to the worst possible square; Black will no longer be able to meet Bxa5 with ... Bd8.

41. Ke2??

Two can play that game! Denker makes the same mistake, assuming that Black's position is watertight. After 41. Bb5, Black's position falls apart in every line:

A. 41. ... Bxb5+ 42. axb5 Bf6 stops 43. Bxa5, but White strikes from the other side: 43. d7 and the abysmal position of Black's king does him in: 43. ... Kf7 44. Bxe5 Bd8 45. Bxf4 Ke6 46. Ke2 and the connected passers will seal the deal.

B. 41. ... Be6 is far more resilient. After 42. d7 Bf6, it turns out that the immediate 43. Bxe5? is impossible due to 43. ... Bxd7! 44. Bxf4 Bxb5+ 45. axb5 c4! 46. bxc4 a4 and things are far from clear. But the subtle 43. Ke2!! leads to an unusually and aesthetically pleasing Zugzwang position.



Both of Black's bishops must stay in place to hold the position together, but Black's king is unable to find an adequate retreat square:

B1. 43. ... Kg5/7 44. Bxe5 Bxd7 and now 45. Bxf6+ comes with check.

B2. 43. ... Kh5 44. Bxe5 Bxd7 45. Bxf6 and the king has lost contact with the f6-square, leaving White up a piece.

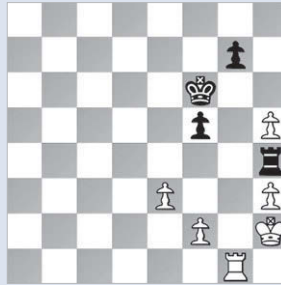
43. ... Kf7 is relatively best, but after 44. Bxe5 Bxd7 White has the devastating 45. Bc4+, keeping both bishops and winning the f4-pawn. Following 45. ... Ke7

Problems: Find the Resource!

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

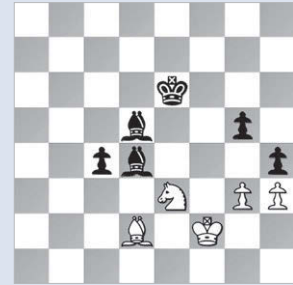
See the solutions on page 71.

Problem I: 1500 Level
 GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2775)
 GM Michael Adams (FIDE 2745)
 London Classic, 12.13.2014



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level
 IM Karthikeyan Murali (FIDE 2497)
 GM Pavel Eljanov (FIDE 2719)
 Qatar Masters, 11.26.2014



BLACK TO MOVE

46. Bxf4 Bd4 47. Bc7! the win is a matter of straightforward technique.

Quite an amazing and instructive exchange of mutual blunders! As it turns out, the fun is just beginning.

41. ... Kf6

Stabilizing the situation. Now, of course, 42. Bb5 is no longer effective.

42. Be1

Creating the rather prosaic threat of Bh4(+)-Bd8, and setting a vicious trap ...

42. ... Kg5??



... which Reshevsky falls right into! Once again, Black simply cannot afford to keep his king and bishop so far away from the d-pawn. 42. ... Bh6 was called for, when 43. Bh4+ is met by 43. ... Bg5 and White can make no further progress.

43. Bc3??

Such negligent play is seldom seen at a grandmaster level, and it is definitely painful to watch. However, through the lens of this comedy of errors, we can see just how important it is to approach every endgame position from a concrete perspective. 43. Bb5 wins in a familiar manner: 43. ... Be6 (43. ... Bxb5 44. axb5 Bf6 45. Bc3 is even stronger than last time) 44. d7 Bf6 45. Bc3 Kg6 46. Bb2! with a *Zugzwang* we have all come to love: 47. Bxe5 will follow regardless of Black's move!

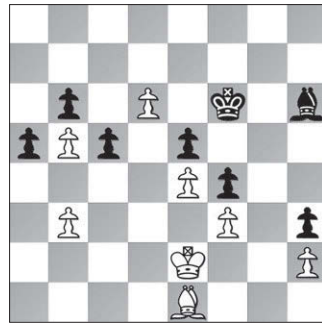
43. ... Kf6 44. Be1 Bh6!

Reshevsky does not repeat the same mistake twice, and Denker chooses the worst moment to plant a bishop on b5.

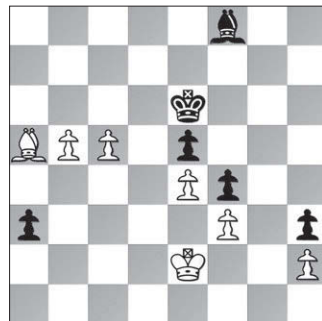
45. Bb5

At the worst possible moment!

45. ... Bxb5+ 46. axb5



Black is not completely out of the woods. The natural 46. ... Ke6 meets with 47. Bh4 Kxd6 48. Bd8, when his entire queen-side pawn chain falls apart. Reshevsky clearly evaluated this position as better (or even winning) for White, overlooking an elegant tactical sequence that saves the day: 48. ... c4! 49. bxc4 a4 50. Bxb6 (or 50. Kd3 a3 51. Kc2 a2 52. Kb2 Kc5 53. Kxa2 Kxc4 54. Bxb6 Kxb5 with a draw) 50. ... a3 51. c5+ Ke6 52. Ba5 and now the simple 52. ... Bf8! forces White to give up his c-pawn:



The avaricious 53. c6?? loses after 53. ...

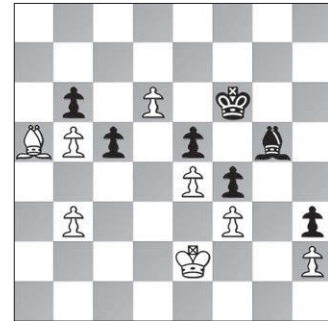
a2 54. Bc3 Bc5, when there is no way to stop the threats of ... Bd4 and ... Bg1.

In principle, Occam's Razor does apply to endgames; it is obviously to reach a desired position while allowing the least amount of tactical complications. After calculating (and incorrectly ruling out) 46. ... Ke6, Reshevsky probably started looking for a way to eliminate the d6-pawn without allowing Bh4-d8. Such a way does indeed exist:

46. ... Bg5??

Another disastrous blunder, and another instructive moment. In his quest to prevent White's bishop from reaching h4, Reshevsky simply forgot about the second tactical idea at White's disposal:

47. Bxa5!



Snap, crackle, pop! The king obstructs its own loyal servant from reaching d8, and neither piece can stop the b-pawn after 47. ... bxa5 48. b6. The game is over.

47. ... Ke6 48. Bxb6 Kxd6 49. Kd3 Bh4 50. Kc4 Bf2 51. b4

The final blow.

51. ... Ke6 52. Bxc5 Bg3 53. Bg1 Kd6 54. b6 Be1 55. Kb5, Black resigned.

As we know, endgames demand total concentration and precise calculation on every single move. In many cases, especially when the result of the game hinges on one particular tactical resource, there is simply no room for intuition. ♣

An Old-School Brawl

While long-time U.S. Champion Frank Marshall had a deserved reputation for his sharp tactical abilities, he has something to teach us in the endgame as well.

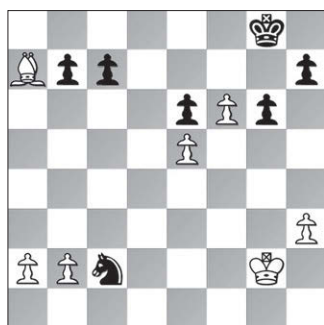
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

FRANK JAMES MARSHALL (1877-1944) was the undisputed king of early twentieth-century American chess. A tactical juggernaut, Marshall was the U.S. champion from 1909 to 1936 and regularly crossed swords with (and sometimes defeated) the world's elite. His victories at the 1904 Cambridge Springs International, the 1906 Nuremberg Chess Congress, and the 1911 New York Masters are especially notable.

While surfing through his games on MegaBase, I began to pick up on a surprising trend: Frankie was darn good at endgames too! The following epic battle, previously consigned to obscurity, is a must-see.

Back in the light of day

Mikhail Chigorin
Frank Marshall
Monte Carlo, 1901



AFTER 27. Bxa7

After a wild tactical melee in which both sides missed prime opportunities to secure a decisive advantage, the game has “fizzled out” into a rather unusual ending. Let’s start with a few basic observations:

- 1) In a semi-closed position of this type, the nimble knight usually reigns supreme. Indeed, while the bishop has no clear trajectory, the knight effortlessly targets White’s pawns (from d3, c6, or c4), or simply chills out on d5.

- 2) The protected passed pawn on f6 permanently ties down Black’s king.

The knight is capable of holding Black’s position together on its own, but Marshall must tread cautiously to secure the draw.

27. ... Nb4!

Natural and strong. The knight simultaneously attacks the a2-pawn and threatens a nasty fork on c6.

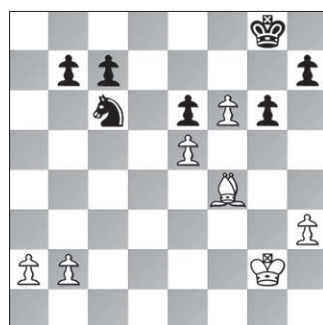
28. Bb8 Na6 29. Ba7 Nb4 30. Bb8 Na6 31. Ba7 Nb4 32. Be3!?

Like his opponent, Mikhail Chigorin was not a fan of premature draws. Instead of accepting the repetition, he finds an intriguing way to keep the battle alive.

32. ... Nc6

A reasonable answer, although 32. ... Nxa2 was even more convincing. After 33. Bd2 Black’s knight is paralyzed, but not for long: 33. ... c5! 34. Kf3 Kf7 35. Ke4 Nb4 36. Bxb4 (otherwise White is simply down a pawn) 36. ... cxb4 37. Kf4 h6 and in this unusual pawn ending, neither side can make progress; both kings must remain on the kingside at all times.

33. Bf4



33. ... g5!?

The start of a long and fascinating climax. Marshall drives the bishop to a less convenient square, but the g5-pawn will become a serious liability in the near future. The less adventurous course was

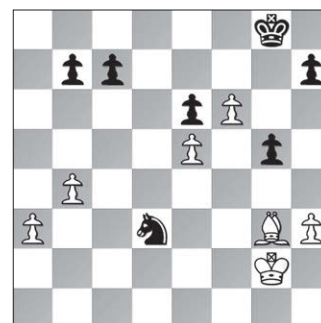
33. ... Nb4, reverting to the familiar drawing mechanism. After 34. Bd2 (34. a3? Nd3) 34. ... Nxa2 35. Kf3 White is a tempo up compared to 32. ... Nxa2, but it makes absolutely no difference: 35. ... c5 36. Ke4 Nb4 37. Bxb4 cxb4.

34. Bg3 Nb4

Marshall’s idea, of course, is that the bishop can no longer access the d2-square in one move. What both players failed to notice, though, is that 35. a3 is now possible, since 35. ... Nd3 no longer attacks the bishop.

35. Be1?!

This move does not change the objective evaluation, but it is the start of White’s troubles. After the precise 35. a3 Nd3 36. b4, Black’s knight suddenly finds itself unemployed:



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Black cannot afford to sit still: White threatens Kf3-e4, when the knight is suddenly in trouble. To maintain the balance, he must find a series of precise defensive moves: 36. ... h5 37. Kf3 Nb2! 38. Ke4 Nc4 39. a4 (the computer recommends 39. Be1, but after 39. ... Nxa3 40. Bd2 g4 41. hxc4 hxc4 42. Kf4 b6 Black erects an impenetrable fortress) 39. ... h4 40. Bh2 and now a rather amazing sequence: 40. ... Nd2+ 41. Ke3! (temporarily sacrificing the bishop!) 41. ... Nf1+ 42. Kf2 Nxh2 43. Kg2 Ng4! 44. hxc4 c6! and, once again, both kings are chained to the passed pawns and so a draw is inevitable.

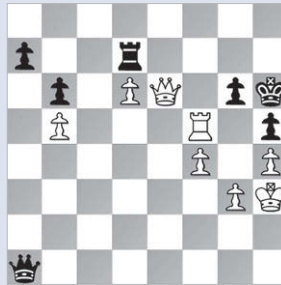
More Marshall brawls

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Problem I: 1500 Level

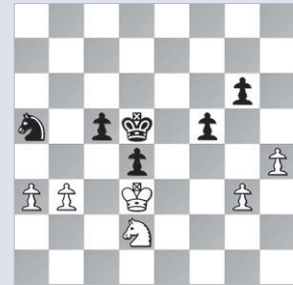
Frank Marshall
John Morrison
New York, 1913



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

Geza Maroczy
Frank Marshall
Monte Carlo, 1903



BLACK TO MOVE

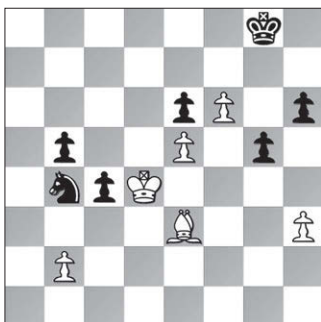
35. ... Nxa2 36. Bd2 c5 37. Kf3

In his calculations, Chigorin might have overlooked that 37. Bxg5 is highly inadvisable on account of 37. ... Nb4, when the newly-liberated knight will wreak havoc on White's position. After 38. Bd2 Nc6 39. Bf4 (Much worse is 39. Bc3 b5 40. b3 b4 followed by ...Na5.) 39. ... b5 40. Kf3 White can probably hold the draw, but Black is definitely calling the shots. Therefore, Chigorin correctly decides that keeping Black's knight restricted is far more important than restoring the material balance.

37. ... b5 38. Ke4 h6 39. Be3 c4 40. Kd4?!

A hard move to understand; why give the knight a free 'get out of jail' ticket? The straightforward 40. Bd2 forced an immediate draw, as Black has nothing better than to force liquidation with 40. ... b4 41. Kd4 c3 42. bxc3 bxc3 (Awful is 42. ... b3?? 43. Kd3) 43. Bxc3 Nxc3 44. Kxc3 h5.

40. ... Nb4



The knight is a real working-class hero, fighting two daunting enemies at once and winning the battle! Disconcerted by the turn of events (and quite possibly in time pressure), Chigorin loses the thread.

41. Bd2?

The Russian maestro fails to sense the danger, allowing Marshall to entrench his indefatigable cavalier on a dream outpost. The straightforward 41. Kc5! was White's last chance to reestablish equality: 41. ...

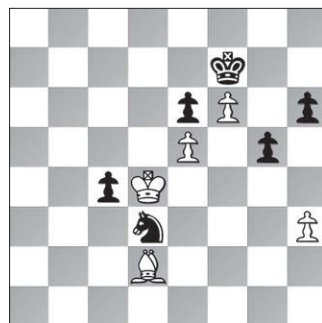
Nd3+ 42. Kxb5 Nxb2 (Dangerous is 42. ... Nxe5?! 43. Bd4 Nd7 44. Kxc4 when the b-pawn guarantees White at least a draw) 43. Bd4 Nd3 44. Kxc4 Nf4 and although Black wins the h-pawn, White's king is just in time to restrain the connected passers: 45. Be3 Nxh3 46. Kd3 g4 47. Ke2 h5 48. Kf1 h4 49. Kg2 with a fortress.

41. ... Nd3 42. b3

White is just hanging on, but good positions do not win games. Having played impeccably to this point, Marshall tragically falls for temptation:

42. ... Nf2?

We all occasionally fall into autopilot mode, and unfortunately for Marshall, it happens at the worst possible time. With this ultra-natural move, he allows Chigorin to capture the c4-pawn and to bring his king over in the nick of time. Instead, the counterintuitive 42. ... Kf7!! 43. bxc4 bxc4 would have placed White in a jaw-dropping Zugzwang:



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Try this on for size: if White could pass on a move, Black would have nothing better than 44. ... Nf2, basically reverting to the text (his king position makes no difference). As it stands, every single move wrecks White's delicate fortress:

- A. 44. Ke4 loses to 44. ... Nf2+ 45. Kd4 Nxh3 46. Kxc4 g4 47. Be1 Nf4 with ... Ng6-... h5-h4 (h3-h2-h1) to follow.
B. 44. Bc3 Nf2 45. Kxc4 Nxh3 and with

the bishop on c3, the knight returns to camp via f4 and effects a lethal regrouping: 46. Kd3 Nf4+ 47. Ke4 Ng6 48. Bd4 and now—wait for it—48. ... Nh8!! 49. Be3 Kg6 50. Bd4 Nf7. What an incredible maneuver! After completing an Odyssean journey across the board, the exhausted knight finally hands over the reins; White is powerless against the slow advance of the pawns. For instance, 51. Be3 h5 52. Bd4 h4 53. Kf3 Kf5 54. Bc3 g4+ 55. Kg2 Kf4 and it is all over.

- C. 44. Be3 meets with a similarly gruesome fate: 44. ... Ne1! 45. Kxc4 Nf3 46. Bd4 h5 and to stop the pawns, White's bishop must leave d4, giving up two pawns (and the game) in the process.

43. bxc4 bxc4 44. Kxc4 Nxh3 45. Kd3

And there's the rub: with the bishop on d2, Black's knight is unable to reach safety and will be imprisoned for good. The computer fails to recognize it(!), but White is set for life: as soon as Black's king reaches g6 and the pawn advances to h5, he will take on g5 (that f6-pawn again!).

45. ... Nf2+ 46. Ke3 Ng4+ 47. Ke4 Kf7 48. Bc3 h5 49. Bd2 Nxf6+

This is tantamount to a draw offer. It was worth trying 49. ... h4!? 50. Bxg5 h3, although White easily snags the half-point with 51. Kf3 Nxe5+ 52. Kg3 h2 53. Kg2! Nf3 54. Bf4 Kxf6 55. Bg3 and Black's material advantage is entirely inconsequential: ... e5 will always be met with Bxe5, reaching a famous theoretically-drawn ending.

50. exf6 Kxf6 51. Bc3+ Kg6 52. Ke5

The simplest. White gobbles up e6, and easily restrains the remaining two passers.

52. ... h4 53. Kxe6 g4 54. Bf6 Kh5 55. Be5 Kg6 56. Bf6 Kh5 57. Be5 g3 58. Kf5, Draw agreed.

Now this is what I call an old-school brawl between two world-class players! ♣

Remembering GM Walter Browne

Taking a look at the endgame virtuosity of our recently deceased former U.S. champion

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

ON JUNE 24, 2015, GM WALTER BROWNE passed away in his sleep at age 66. A six-time U.S. champion and winner of several elite international events, Walter's illustrious chess career spanned more than 30 years. This column will shed some light on a particularly noteworthy aspect of Browne's prowess: his endgame skill.

A tactical melee

GM Walter Browne (2560)

GM Ljubomir Ftacnik (2535)

It (cat. 12), Gjovik, 1983



BLACK TO MOVE

A rather unexceptional Gruenfeld has evolved into a mind-boggling tactical melee. With his last move (23. Bc4-e6), Browne intensifies the pressure and exploits a lovely tactical nuance: the rook is untouchable on account of 24. Bd4+, mating. Evidently stunned by this audacious sally, Ftacnik loses the thread.

23. ... h6?

Black creates much-needed luft for his king, but enables White to reach a favorable opposite-colored bishop ending. As Browne correctly points out in *The Stress of Chess*, "Black missed the brilliant retort 23. ... Rac8!," forcing White's bishop away from e6. After 24. Bxc8 Bxe7 is now possible, and the complications peter out to a draw:

A) 25. Bxf5? gxf5 26. Bd4+ Kg8 27. dxe7

Rxd4+ 28. Ke3 Rd3+ 29. Ke2 Kf7 with a clear edge for Black (Browne).



B) 25. Bd4+ Kg8 26. Bxb7 Bxd6 27. Ke3 is definitely the best try, but after 27. ... Bxf4+ 28. Kxf4 Rxd4 29. Bxa6 Kf7 a peaceful outcome is in the cards.



Needless to say, finding a brilliant tactical resource in a high-pressure situation is a tall order, even for a strong grandmaster.

24. Rf7!

A sobering blow.

24. ... Bxe6

Black must bite the bullet, since the alternatives were even less appealing. Browne notes that 24. ... b6 25. Bxf5 gxf5 26. Rxf6 bxc5 27. Ke3 Kg7 28. Rxf5 Rxd6 29. Rxc5 is rather unappetizing, and I will only add that Black's prospects after 24. ... Rf8 25. Bxf5 Rxf7 26. Bxg6 Rd7 27.

Rd1! (preventing ... Rxd6+ followed by Rd8) are similarly grim.

25. Rxf6 Bxa2 26. Rxc6



The smoke has finally cleared, and it is time to evaluate the situation anew. Generally speaking, the presence of opposite-colored bishops considerably increases a position's drawing tendencies, but concrete circumstances always transcend generic principles. In his usual incisive style, Browne indicates four positional factors that reveal the extent of Black's troubles:

- 1) "Black's pawns on h6 and e4 are very weak."
- 2) "White [will have] three passed pawns, one of which is already on the sixth rank."
- 3) "The white king is more centralized and may soon assist in a mating attack."
- 4) "White has two immediate threats: 27. Bd4+ and 27. Rxh6+."

Such a lucid and concise train of thought requires no elaboration. But as we all know, good positions do not win games!

26. ... Kh7 27. f5!

Retreat is for the weak! White not only advances his pawn and grabs space, but also opens up the possibility of Be3, zeroing in on the vulnerable h-pawn.

27. ... Bf7 28. Rf6 Bd5

A sad necessity since 28. ... Kg7 29.

Browne's endgame tactics

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Problem I: 1500 Level

GM Walter Browne (FIDE 2500)
IM Kick Langeweg (FIDE 2425)
Amsterdam, 1972



WHITE TO MOVE

Problem II: 2000 Level

GM Walter Browne (FIDE 2560)
IM Mark Dvoretsky (FIDE 2470)
Philadelphia, 1990



WHITE TO MOVE

Bd4 would merely exacerbate the problem; without a dark-squared bishop, Black is entirely helpless against the oncoming kingside avalanche. For instance, 29. ... Rac8 30. Ke3 Rc4 (creating the rather transparent threat of ... Rxd4, but White obviously strikes first) 31. Rg6+ Kf8 (31. ... Kh7 32. Rg7+ wins a piece) 32. Rxh6 and Black is torn to shreds.

29. Be3 h5 30. Rc1!

Browne mobilizes his last reserve, stretching Black's defenses to the limit. Material is even, but it appears that White's firepower is limitless—the hallmark of a legendary endgame player. Indeed, we could observe a similar paradox during the famous Germany-Brazil match in the 2014 FIFA World Cup: both teams had 11 men on the floor, and yet ...

30. ... Bc6

The most resilient defense. The alternative 30. ... Rac8 would go down in flames after 31. Rc7+! Rxc7 32. dxc7 Rc8 33. Bf4, with Rd6-d8 to follow.

31. Rc5!



Black's pieces are simply too passive to deal with the barrage of threats. While the f6-rook pins the monarch down, its friendly colleague will deliver the knockout blow.

31. ... Rd7

Ftacnik tries to minimize the damage by securing the seventh rank. It is worth

mentioning that 31. ... Re8 (to prevent Re5) offered little relief after 32. Rh6+ Kg8 33. Bd4, and I'm sure that Dexter Morgan (yep, that is a reference to the TV show Dexter. Yes, I highly recommend it. No, not instead of reading this column) would love to handle the white pieces here. A particularly gruesome finish would be 33. ... e3+ 34. Ke2 Rad8 35. Rh8+ Kf7 36. Rh7+ Kf8 (36. ... Kg8 37. Rg7+ Kf8 38. f6 forcing 39. Rxh5 and 40. Rh8 mate or heavy material loss) 37. Rxc6! bxc6 38. d7 Re4 39. Bb6, picking up the rook.

32. Rh6+?

Browne has played an impeccable game to this point, but no one is impervious to the effects of time pressure and fatigue. With this move, he initiates an unnecessary campaign to swap a pair of rooks, and gives Black significant drawing chances in the process. The straightforward 32. Re5! was crushing: Black is entirely defenseless against the multitude of threats. Perhaps Walter was a bit concerned about 32. ... Rg7, but after 33. Rh6+ Kg8 34. Bd4 Rf8 35. Re7! White crashes through.

32. ... Kg7 33. Re5 Rf8 34. Re7+ Rf7?



Ftacnik returns the favor, allowing a fantastic tactical sequence that culminates in checkmate. Understandably enough, both players failed to recognize that the eminently counterintuitive 34. ... Rxe7!! 35. dxe7 Rg8 gave Black serious drawing chances. White's outwardly intimidating

connected passers are safely restrained, and there is no clear way to make inroads. After thorough analysis, I'm convinced that White is still objectively winning, but he must tread with the utmost precision: 36. g3 Kf7 37. Bc5 Bd7 38. Rxh5 Kf6 39. Bd4+! Kxe7 40. f6+ Ke6 41. Rh7 Re8 42. Ke3 and Black's position slowly begins to fall apart.

Such oversights are never pleasing to the eye, but they are always very instructive. In severe time pressure, Ftacnik undoubtedly rejected 34. ... Rxe7 because of its unflattering appearance, but cold-hard calculation should always trump intuition.

35. Rg6+ Kh7 36. Rh6+

Draw? In your dreams! Browne is merely repeating moves to bring the game closer to move 40.

36. ... Kg8 37. Re8+ Kg7

A sad necessity, since 37. ... Rf8 38. Rg6+ Kf7 39. Ree6 Bd5 40. Rh6! would be rather depressing. Black is utterly tied up, and White has all the time in the world to round off the attack. For instance, 40. ... Rg8 41. Bd4 Kf8 42. Rhf6+ Rf7 43. d7 and White promotes.

38. Rg6+ Kh7 39. Bd4

The final blow. Black can defend against the immediate mate threat, but not against the ensuing onslaught.

39. ... Rxf5 40. Rg3 Kh6 41. Rh8+, Black resigned.

A fitting end to a magnificent game. 41. ... Rh7 42. Bg7 is checkmate.

Such outstanding displays of near-perfect technique featured prominently in Walter Browne's chess career. Let us raise our glasses to this veritable titan of American chess. Rest in peace, Walter. ♠

Chess Life will recap Browne's career in the October issue.

Never Say Never

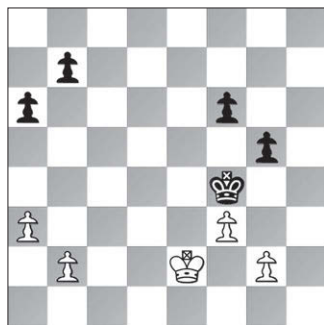
Pawn endgames and premature resignation

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

AT THE RECENTLY-CONCLUDED Politiken Cup, I witnessed a rather astonishing incident. Having finished my round five game early, I settled down in my room to watch the live transmission of the top boards. An intriguing encounter between Swedish GM Tiger Hillarp Persson and Austrian GM Markus Ragger caught my attention. After an intense tactical melee, the game fizzled out into an ostensibly unremarkable endgame:

DID THIS REALLY HAPPEN?

GM Tiger Hillarp Persson (FIDE 2563, SWE)
GM Markus Ragger (FIDE 2688, AUT)
Politiken Cup 2015 (5), Helsingør, Denmark,
07.28.2015



BLACK TO MOVE

Had it been White's turn, Kf2 followed by g2-g3+ and Ke3 would have pushed Black's king away and secured an immediate draw. But Ragger is not ready to call it a day just yet.

39. ... Kg3 40. Kf1 b5

Pawn endgames are devilish affairs. There is no room for error, and little use for intuition. The tiniest inaccuracy or lapse of concentration entails catastrophic ramifications. In this position, White must tread with the utmost caution to neutralize Black's active king.

41. b4!

Hillarp rises to the challenge, averting *Zugzwang* by the narrowest of margins. The tempting 41. Kg1?? enables Black to lock up the queenside on

his own terms: 41. ... a5 42. b4 (42. b3 b4 43. a4 f5 essentially transposes, as the queenside configuration changes nothing) 42. ... a4 43. Kf1 f5 44. Kf1 Kh2 45. Kf2 g4 and after both 46. f4 g4 47. Kf1 g3 and 46. f4 Kh1 47. Kg3 Kg1, Mr. *Zugzwang* rears his ugly head.

41. ... f5 42. Kg1

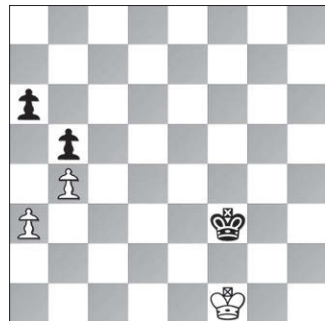
With the king on f1, 42. ... Kh2 would have decided the game in a familiar manner. As it stands, Black cannot pass the move without compromising the winning mechanism (42. ... f4 43. Kf1 Kh2 44. Kf2 is a case in point). As it turns out, however, two roads lead to Rome:

42. ... g4!

Ragger employs a deadly technique that IM Mark Dvoretsky calls widening the beachhead: "Trading off pawns, with the idea of clearing a path for the king." Indeed, if the kingside pawns magically disappeared, Black's king would have an unobstructed path to the queenside!

43. f4 g4 44. Kf2 f4, White resigned.

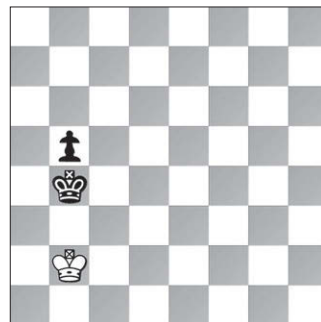
And there's the rub: White's king must leave f2, allowing ... Kg3 followed by ... f4-f3, completing the widening operation. After 45. Ke2 (or 45. Kg1) 45. ... Kg3 46. Kf1 f3 47. gxf3 Kxf3 (diagram), the triumph of Black's strategy is displayed in all its glory.



Black's monarch leisurely advances toward the queenside, while his counterpart can only bumble about on the first rank. Upon calculating this straightforward variation, Hillarp decided that

further resistance was futile and laid down his sword.

But an attentive reader will notice an amazing defensive resource concealed within the queenside pawn configuration. After 48. Ke1 Ke3 49. Kd1 Kd3, White saves the game with 50. a4!, a study-like thrust that places Black in a lose-lose situation: 50. ... bxa4 leaves him with two corner pawns, while 50. ... Kc3 51. axb5 axb5 52. Kc1 Kxb4 53. Kb2 reaches a well-known theoretical draw.



I was sure that the "0-1" was an error in transmission, and that Ragger, aware of 50. a4 all along, simply offered a draw after 44. ... f4. But a trip to the playing hall allayed my skepticism: the Swedish grandmaster actually did resign!

"A freak occurrence," I hear you saying, and that is exactly what Hillarp's premature surrender resembles. Upon closer investigation, however, it becomes clear that **pawn endgames regularly engender premature resignation**. The reason is quite simple: with material so limited, it is easy to trust appearances and calculate superficially, thereby overlooking a camouflaged saving idea. The following encounter between two elite grandmasters offers a brilliant illustration.

AN OPTICAL ILLUSION

GM Alexei Shirov (FIDE 2690, LAT)
GM Jan Timman (FIDE 2620, NED), Wijk
aan Zee (11), Hoogovens, Netherlands,
01.26.1996

(see diagram next page)

Instead of Resigning ...

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

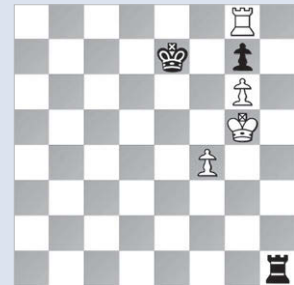
GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2690)
GM Veselin Topalov (FIDE 2783)
Morelia/Linares, 02.22.2007



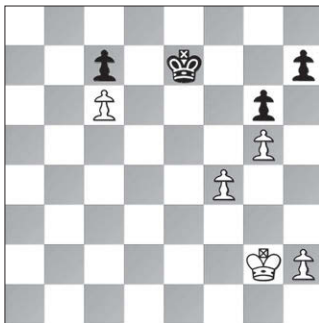
BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Wang Hao (FIDE 2727)
GM Boris Gelfand (FIDE 2739)
Moscow, 11.12.2010



BLACK TO MOVE

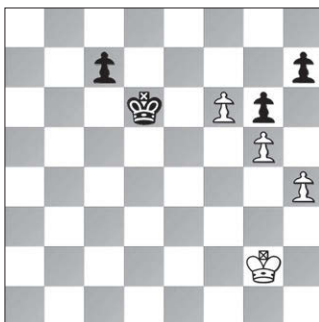


WHITE TO MOVE

Black is two steps away from reestablishing material equality and obtaining a life-saving outside passer. But Shirov thwarts his plan in the nick of time:

49. g5!, Black resigned.

After considering the situation, Timman saw which way the wind was blowing and promptly extended his hand. After 49. ... Kd6 50. h4 Kxc6 51. f5 Kd6 (51. ... gxf5 52. h5 Kd6 and White promotes with the typical breakthrough 53. g6 hxg6 54. h6!) 52. f6 (Diagram), White establishes a monstrous (usually winning) protected passer.

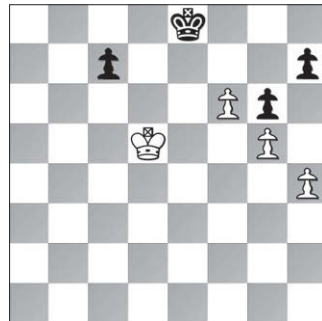


ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

There seems to be nothing to calculate: with Black's king eternally handcuffed to the f6-pawn, White's own monarch will eliminate Black's defenseless passer, and then finish the job on the kingside.

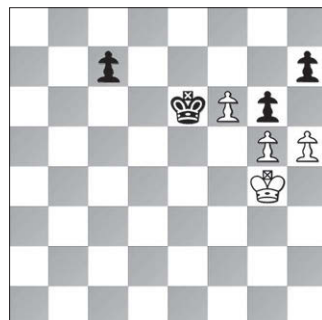
This is probably the line of reasoning that led Timman to flick over his king. In fact, it is based

on a terribly convincing optical illusion: the f6-pawn does not actually prevent Black's king from defending c7. To be sure, the king cannot go past the d-file, but it does have access to three squares from where it simultaneously defends the c7-pawn and restrains White's passer. Concretely, after 52. ... Ke6 53. Kf3 Kf7 54. Ke4 Ke6 55. Kd4 Kd6 56. Kc4 Ke6 57. Kc5 Kd7 58. Kd5 Ke8 White has no way to make progress.



Both 59. Kc6 Kd8 and 59. Ke6 Kf8 lead nowhere: White, not Black, is the one in *Zugzwang*! He can try 60. f7 (in the line 59. Kc6 Kd8) but after 60. ... Ke7 61. Kxc7 Kxf7 62. Kd7 Kf8 63. Ke6 Ke8 it is time to sign the scoresheets. Triangulation is similarly useless: Black's king stays between f7 and f8, meeting Kd5 or Kc5 with ... Ke8.

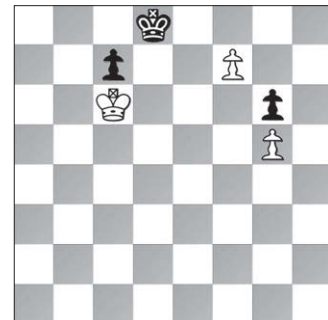
But that is not all: White can set a devilish trap with 54. Kg4!? Ke5 55. h5.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

There are two pitfalls that Black must avoid.

The first is 55. ... gxh5+?, which enables White to reach a theoretically winning queen endgame with 56. Kxh5 c5 (56. ... Kf7 57. Kh6 Kg8 58. f7+! is even worse, since White promotes first) 57. Kh6 c4 58. Kg7 c3 59. f7 c2 60. f8=Q c1=Q 61. Qf6+ Kd5 62. Kxh7. The only move is therefore 55. ... Kf7, but 56. hxg6+ confronts him with yet another dilemma. The most tempting recapture is 56. ... hxg6?!, but the absence of the h-pawns corrupts Black's drawing mechanism: following 57. Kf4 Ke6 58. Ke4 Kd6 59. Kd4 Ke6 60. Kc5 Kd7 61. Kd5 Ke8 62. Kc6 Kd8, the aforementioned 63. f7 comes with far greater effect.



The point is that 63. ... Ke7 64. Kxc7 Kxf7 65. Kd7 is no longer a draw, since Black will lose the g6-pawn (and the game) sooner or later. Thus, 56. ... Kxg6! 57. Kf4 Kf7 58. Ke5 c5 59. Kd5 h6! is the only path to a draw.

For once, the moral of the story can be expressed in three words: never say never! There are times when resigning is the morally and ethically correct thing to do, but it is your prerogative—and your obligation—to continue fighting until every defensive try has been exhausted. Savielly Tartakower said it best: **No game was ever won by resigning!** ♦

Did you know you could read archival copies of "The Practical Endgame" (and all columns and features)? Go to uschess.org and click on the "Archives" link below the "CHESS LIFE MAGAZINE" header and you will be taken to an archives page that dates to 2006. You can also download full-issue PDFs by clicking on the "Downloadable Files" link below the "Archives" link.

The Art of Liquidation

Picking up the theme of Joel Benjamin's recent book, we look at more examples of liquidating to a pawn endgame

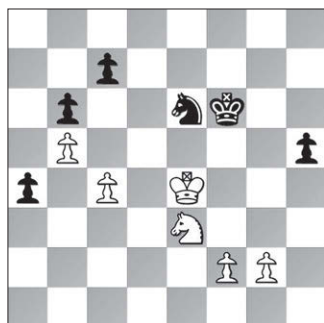
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IT WAS WITH GREAT EAGERNESS THAT I perused GM Joel Benjamin's recent work *Liquidation on the Chess Board: Mastering the Transition into the Pawn Endgame*. Despite the somewhat esoteric title, Benjamin tackles one of the most important (and underappreciated) aspects of endgame practice. Regardless of the concrete circumstances, entering a pawn endgame is a committal, hazardous decision that should not be undertaken without profound reflection. In this month's column, I analyze two games in which strong players liquidated without accurately evaluating the consequences. Boy, did they pay the price!

At the 2015 Riga Technical University Open, I faced Armenian GM Robert Hovhannisyan in a crucial round five encounter. After 49 moves of intense positional maneuvering, we reached the following intriguing knight ending:

KNIGHTMARE

GM Daniel Naroditsky (FIDE 2631, USA)
GM Robert Hovhannisyan (FIDE 2612, ARM)
5th International Chess Festival RIGA
TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY OPEN, Riga,
Latvia, 08.13.2015



WHITE TO MOVE

Material is equal, but that far-advanced little beast on a4 was sending chills down my spine. As nimble and versatile as they are, knights are not particularly adept at restraining passed pawns (the toughest ones for them to stop are "rook" pawns like this one), especially when their services are required elsewhere. To this end, my first

inclination was 50. Kd3, intending Kc3-b4 and leaving the knight in the center. However, with the monarch busy on the queenside, I was worried that its vis-à-vis would somehow infiltrate through the center. After a few moments of thought, I saw just the way to resolve this issue:

50. Nd5??

On the surface, this move appears perfectly logical. By flicking in this check, I centralize my knight and, most importantly, drive Black's king away from the center. Yet for all of its apparent virtues, this dreadful move is the cause of my downfall. Had I replaced verbal reasoning with calculation, I would have undoubtedly perceived its flaw and played 50. Kd3 instead. Black has several challenging options, but no way to avert a draw:

1) 50. ... Nf4+ 51. Ke4 Nxe2!? is a worthy attempt, but after 52. Nxe2 a3 53. Ne3 a2 54. Nc2 White stops one passer with his knight, and the other with his king: 54. ... Kg5 (54. ... h4?? actually loses after 55. Kf4 h3 56. Kg3 Ke5 57. Kxh3 Ke4 58. Kg4 and it turns out that 58. ... Kd3 is impossible due to 59. Nb4+) 55. Kf3 h4 56. Na1 Kf5 57. Nc2 and neither side can make progress.

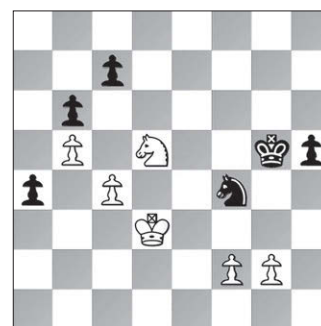
2) 50. ... Ke5 is the move I was concerned about, but it is nothing to worry about. White responds with 51. Kc3 Ke4 (51. ... a3 52. Kb3 draws) 52. Nd5, and Black does not have enough firepower to breach the fortress. For instance, 52. ... h4 53. Nf6+ Ke5 54. Nd5 a3 55. Kb3 Kd4 56. Ne7 (there is no need to rush with Kxa3; White's most important task is to eliminate the h4-pawn) 56. ... Nc5+ 57. Kxa3 Kxc4 58. Nf5 Kxb5 59. Nxb4 and the two sets of connected passers cancel each other out.

3) 50. ... h4 sets a vicious trap: the tempting 51. Kc3?? falls prey to 51. ... Nf4, creating the devastating (and unstoppable) threat of ... Nxe2. But 51. Nd5+ (now is the time!) 51. ... Ke5 52. Kc3 secures the draw.

50. ... Kg5 51. Kd3

For what it's worth, there was no turning back: both 51. f4+ Nxf4! 52. Nxf4 a3 and 51. Ke5 a3 52. Nc3 Nf4 would have expedited White's downfall.

51. ... Nf4+



Make no mistake: I had anticipated this move when playing 50. Nd5+, and spent quite a bit of time assessing its consequences. It is easy to determine that 52. Nxf4 Kxf4 is utterly hopeless. Using the a-pawn as a decoy, Black's king gradually "outshoulders" his nemesis, eventually capturing both of White's queenside pawns. For example, 53. Kc3 Ke4 54. Kb4 Kd4 55. g3 (55. f4 h4! wins) 55. ... a3 56. Kxa3 Kxc4 57. Ka4 Kc5 and White is toast. He can prolong the agony by advancing his f-pawn, but he will eventually have to remove his king from a4. This position reminds me of a typical scene from action movies, where a character is hanging on a cliff and his fingers are slowly losing purchase. After 58. f3 Kc4 59. f4 Kc5 White can choose between 60. Ka3 Kxb5 and the equally unappealing 60. f5 Kd5.

But I had calculated all of this, and found a cute way to avert liquidation. Or so I thought ...

52. Kc3

I had banked all of my hopes on this move, and sat back to watch my opponent admire my endgame skill ...

52. ... Nxd5+

Believe it or not, this move simply escaped my field of vision. For some unfathomable reason, I considered 52. ... Nxe2 to be forced, when 53. Nxc7 h4 54. c5! leads to simultaneous promotion and a quick draw: 54. ... bxc5 (54. ... h3? 55. cxb6 h2 56. b7 h1=Q 57. b8=Q and although Black promotes first, he is incapable of mounting any

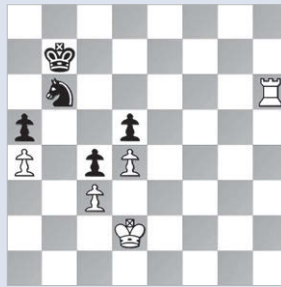
Liquidate, or Liqui-don't?

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

George Gossip
William Tullidge
Adelaide, 08.26.1887



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM Max Cornejo (2524)
FM Andy Lee (2392)
U.S. Chess League, 09.09.2015



WHITE TO MOVE

serious offensive against White's king) 55. b6 h3 56. b7 h2 57. b8=Q h1=Q and White delivers perpetual check with 58. Qg8+.

The pawn ending, on the other hand, is completely winning for Black. The slight difference in pawn structure makes zero difference: White's pawn is just as indefensible on d5 as on c4. The rest, as they say, is pure agony.

53. cxd5 Kf4 54. d6!?

A worthy last-ditch attempt, but Hovhannisyan responds with filigree accuracy.

54. ... cxd6 55. Kb4 h4

The last finesse. White's pawns are now completely immobilized, and Black's king, free of all distractions, leads the pawn to heaven and beyond.

56. Kxa4 Ke4 57. Kb3 Kd3 58. Kb4 d5 59. Kb3 d4, White resigned.

Painful though it was, this game is tremendously instructive all the same. Frequently, we are so engrossed in calculating a certain variation that we fail to appreciate the devastation that a simple trade can cause. As Hovhannisyan so ably demonstrated, this kind of negligence seldom goes unpunished!

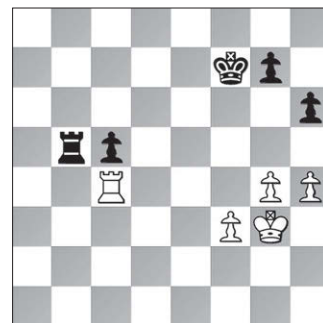
It is not enough to foresee the possibility of liquidation; you must also evaluate it correctly. As we have discussed several times before, pawn endings are enormously deceptive. Assuming that a certain position is winning or drawn on the basis of its appearance is, quite simply, a recipe for disaster. To this end, consider the following obscure 19th-century encounter:

TO TAKE, OR NOT TO TAKE?

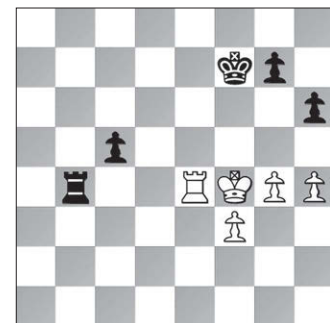
H. Wernich
George Mackenzie
New York, 1869

(see diagram top of next column)

Major H. Wernich had an interesting life. An 1879 obituary, uncovered by chess historian Edward Winter, points out that he was "in early life ... a gallant and meritorious officer of artillery in the



WHITE TO MOVE



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Prussian service," and became one of the strongest players in New York upon his immigration to the United States. In this game, he is on the verge of holding prominent Scottish-American master George Henry Mackenzie to a draw.

40. Kf4

There is nothing objectively wrong with this move, but it is the precursor to a disastrous miscalculation that will cost Wernich the game. 40. Ra4 was simpler, intending 41. Ra7(+). For instance, 40. ... Ke6 41. Ra7 c4 42. Kf2! g5 43. hxg5 hxg5 44. Ke3 and a draw is inevitable.

40. ... Rb4!

My guess is that Wernich simply overlooked this move, which forces the trade of rooks. Generally speaking, a pawn ending is in Black's favor due to his outside passer, but everything depends on the specific circumstances. White has an obvious choice between the immediate 41. Rxb4 and 41. Re4, intending to liquidate on his own terms. There is no alternative to cold-hard calculation: one move draws, and the other loses!

41. Rxb4??

Oh dear! The chief problem with this move is that Black's passer shifts to the b-file, forcing White's king to abandon the kingside pawns. Instead, the crafty 41. Re4!! (Diagram) would have saved the day.

(see diagram top of next column)

After 41. ... Rxe4+ 42. Kxe4, the crucial difference

is that White's king is able to restrain the passer and simultaneously guard the kingside. For instance, 42. ... Ke6 43. f4 g6 44. f5+ gxf5+ 45. gxf5+ (three checks in a row!) 45. ... Kf6 46. h5! (but not 46. Kd5?? Kxf5 47. Kxc5 Kg4 48. Kd4 Kxh4 49. Ke3 Kg3) 46. ... c4 47. Kd4 Kxf5 48. Kxc4 Kg5 49. Kd3 Kxh5 50. Ke2 and White is in time.

Perhaps Wernich saw this line, and simply assumed that 41. Rxb4 would not change the nature of the position. How wrong he was!

41. ... cxb4 42. Ke3 g5!

A sobering blow, paralyzing White's pawns and paving the way for a king march to f4.

43. hxg5 hxg5 44. Kd3 Ke6

With his 41st move, Wernich tasked his monarch with an impossible assignment (being in two places at once). The king is a powerful force, but it can only move one square at time!

45. Kd4 b3 46. Kc3 Ke5 47. Kxb3 Kf4 48. Kc3 Kxf3 49. Kd3 Kxg4 50. Ke4 Kg3, White resigned.

Fittingly, White resigned on move 50, the exact point at which I blundered against Hovhannisyan.

In the prologue to *Liquidation on the Chess Board*, GM Benjamin astutely points out that "Pawn endings do not arise out of nowhere; we know of course that every pawn ending started out as an endgame with more pieces on the board" (10). It is the mark of a true endgame master to seamlessly transition from the latter to the former. ♠

Hanging by a Thread

How adopting Teddy Roosevelt's attitude of unbridled, unwavering resilience in the face of adversity can improve your endgame play.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

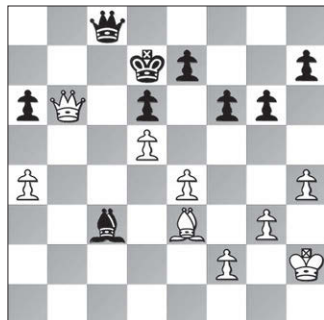
ON OCTOBER 14, 1912, A TERRIBLE TRAGEDY was averted by the narrowest of margins. While campaigning for the upcoming presidential election, Theodore Roosevelt was shot in the chest by an unemployed saloonkeeper named John Flammang Schrank. The bullet "passed through Roosevelt's overcoat, a 50-page manuscript, a steel eyeglass case, and lodged in his chest."¹

Coughing and sputtering, the 53-year-old ex-president conducted a brief self-diagnosis and determined that the wound was not fatal. Then, despite the exhortations of his doctors, Roosevelt took the stage and proceeded to deliver one of the most famous remarks in American history: "I don't know whether you fully understand that I have been shot—but it takes more than that to kill a Bull Moose."

On the chess board, adopting a Bull Moose attitude is often equally daunting. When we are under pressure, it is tremendously difficult to maintain the status quo, and even more challenging to remain objective. Yet the ability to endure a miserable position without cracking will—short-term considerations notwithstanding—bring you a wagonload of points. In this month's column, I examine an epic battle that underscores the importance of this ability.

BULLY FOR BATTLE

GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2867)
IM Kannappan Priyadharshan (2559)
Millionaire Chess Open 2 (3), Las Vegas,
Nevada, 10.09.2015



WHITE TO MOVE

Priyadharshan has landed himself in a very

precarious situation against the world number 6. Despite the limited material, Black's pieces are tremendously cramped, and his position is full of irreparable weaknesses (read: a6, c6, and e6). White does not have any immediate threats, but the prospect of a gradual kingside pawn advance is none too pleasant.

34. Qb1!?

An interesting practical try, re-routing the queen to the other flank and preparing to chip away at Black's kingside with h4-h5.

34. ... Ba5 35. h5 gxh5

There is nothing objectively wrong with this capture, but it makes Black's defensive task the tiniest bit more arduous. The intrepid 35. ... Qc4! would have essentially forced a draw, since White has nothing better than perpetual with 36. hxg6 hxg6 37. Qb7+ Ke8 38. Qb8+ Kd7 39. Qb7+.

36. Qf1

Now, Black's queen can no longer access c4, while its vis-à-vis hungrily eyes the vulnerable doubled h-pawns.

36. ... Kd8!

The most precise defense. Priyadharshan seals off the h-file and forces the queen to take a less effective route.

37. Qe2 Bc7?!

Most likely, Priyadharshan simply overlooked White's 39th move. Although the evaluation will not change dramatically, Black will no longer have a clear route to equality. The key to the position was to trade the dark-squared bishops as quickly as possible, even at the cost of several pawns: 37. ... Qb7! 38. Qxh5 Bb6!

This sequence is definitely not easy to find, but it is conceptually understandable: the presence of bishops enables White to hunt for pawns without having to worry about the safety of his king. 39. Qh6 is probably the objectively strongest continuation, but following 39. ... Bxe3 40. Qxe3 a5! Black establishes a stronghold on b4 and should have no trouble holding the fort.

38. Qxh5 Qd7 39. Qd1!

Whoopsy-daisy. White's queen trampolines from one flank to another, wreaking havoc wherever it goes. Having snagged the h5-pawn and thereby permanently crippled Black's kingside, it returns to lend much-needed support to the a-pawn.

39. ... Qe8?

This dreadfully passive move exacerbates an already-perilous situation, bringing Black to the brink of disaster. The only way to erase the damage was 39. ... h5!, putting a halt to White's kingside operations. The pawn will always be indirectly protected, and I cannot see a way to make any appreciable progress.

40. Qc2!

Shades of Capablanca! In boa-constrictor fashion, Fabiano continues to improve his position, preparing an eventual excursion to c6.

40. ... Qh5+ 41. Kg2 Qe5 42. Qd3!

Attacking the a-pawn and inducing a further concession.

42. ... a5 43. Bd4 Qg5 44. Qe3

The move 44. Qc3 would have been more to the point, since 44. ... f5 fails to impress due to 45. Qf3! fxe4 46. Qxe4 and Black's position starts to come apart at the seams.

44. ... Qg4 45. Qd3 h5?!

One can hardly blame Priyadharshan for losing his cool, but this move plays into White's hands by unnecessarily creating yet another weakness. Black was best advised to repeat moves with 45. ... Qg5, when White's task would still have been full of technical difficulties. Now, the situation truly grows dire.

46. f3 Qc8 47. Qb5 f5

A sad necessity. There was simply no more time to sit still, since 47. ... Qa8 would have fallen prey to 48. Kh3! Qc8+ 49. Kh4 and the vicious king delivers the final blow.

48. Qd3!

White's queen continues to demonstrate supernatural abilities. Like Rafael Nadal on the

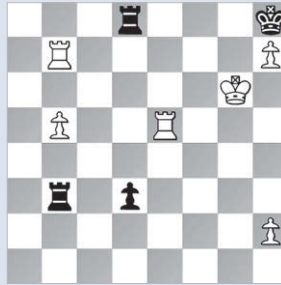
What Would Teddy Do?

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 69.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

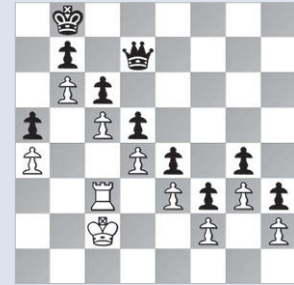
GM Vladimir Kramnik (FIDE 2770)
GM Peter Leko (FIDE 2635)
Tilburg, 10.05.1997



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

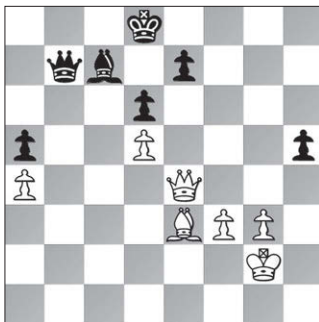
Josef Hasek
Study, 1956



WHITE TO MOVE

tennis court, it glides from one end of the board to the other with breathtaking agility!

48. ... fxe4 49. Qxe4 Qb7 50. Be3



Thus far, Caruana has demonstrated flawless technique, showing us exactly why he is one of the greatest players in history. Just as one would have expected Teddy Roosevelt to seek medical attention, one would expect Priyadharshan to make a few more moves “out of inertia,” flick over his king, and congratulate his opponent on a job well done.

But is that what a Bull Moose would do?

50. ... Qb2+ 51. Kh3 Qe2!

Already, a clear sign that Priyadharshan will die fighting. Make no mistake: Black's position is objectively lost, but White must now decide where to put his bishop.

52. Bh6?!

And Caruana immediately goes astray! The problem with this move is not so much that the bishop will be awkwardly-placed, but rather that the g3-pawn is left undefended, enabling Black's queen to whip up sudden and dangerous counterplay. The move 52. Bf4! was the way to go, and after 52. ... Qf1+ (52. ... Qxe4 53. fxe4 is obviously hopeless) 53. Kh4 Qh1+ 54. Kg5 Bb6 55. Kg6! Black is more or less busted, since he has no good way to simultaneously stop Kf7 and keep the h-pawn protected.

52. ... Qf1+ 53. Kh4 Qg2?!

Alas, even Bull Moose have moments of weakness. This move has the right idea—to

pressure the g3-pawn—but it enables White to reroute his bishop in the nick of time. Instead, the preliminary 53. ... Qh1+! 54. Kg5 would have sealed the bishop in a self-made prison, and now 54. ... Qg2! comes with far greater effect. Indeed, it appears that White has nothing better than 55. Kxh5 (55. Qf4 Qa2! is very unconvincing, as is 55. Kg6?! h4!) 55. ... Qxg3 (56. Bg5 Qh3+ 57. Kg6 Qd7 58. f4 Bb6 59. f5 threatens 60. Kg7 followed by 61. Qxe7+ Qxe7 62. Bxe7+ Kxe7 63. f6+ which may mean that 53. Qg2 is not dubious.—ed.) 56. f4 Qg8 57. Bg5 Qe8+ 58. Kg4 Qf7 and although White's winning chances are undeniable, Black has made tremendous progress toward repelling the pressure.

54. Bf4!

Now White is back on track, but Priyadharshan refuses to fold.

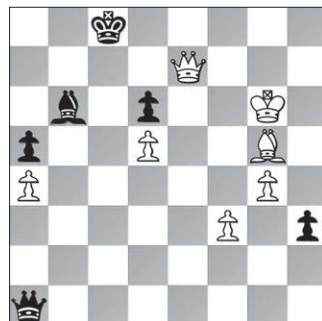
54. ... Qh1+ 55. Kg5 Bb6! 56. Kg6

The point, of course, is that White no longer cares only about the h5-pawn. Indeed, Black is powerless to stop or even to lessen the effect of Kf7 followed by Qxe7+. Resigning seems like a viable option, but Priyadharshan has one more trick up his sleeve.

56. ... h4!

Why not? The servile 56. ... Qa1 57. Bg5 Qe5 would have limited the damage from an optical standpoint, but 58. Qxe5 dxe5 59. d6! instantly decides the game.

57. g4 Qa1 58. Bg5 h3 59. Qxe7+ Kc8



It sure does take a lot to kill a Bull Moose. Mate is still nowhere in sight, and White's own king is

not exactly living a carefree life. In fact, White does have a forced win, but to find it in severe time pressure is a difficult task even for one of the strongest players in the world...

60. Bf4??

Hard task indeed! Judging by the course of the game, the possibility of ... Qxa4 simply escaped Fabiano's field of vision. Instead, the winning sequence was 60. Qe8+ Kb7 61. Qc6+ Ka7 62. Qd7+ Ka6 63. Qc8+ Ka7 and only now, after driving Black's king into the corner, does he play 64. Bf4!. 64. ... Qxa4 no longer works due to 65. Bxd6, but 64. ... Bc5 65. Qd7+ Ka8 66. Qe8+ Ka7 67. g5 does not offer too many defensive prospects either.

60. ... Qxa4!

Just like that, “Roosevelt” has “extricated the bullet from his chest.” White's attack evaporates, and he is left to deal with two vicious passers on opposite flanks.

61. Qe6+ Kb7 62. Qf7+ Bc7 63. g5!

Kudos to Fabiano for keeping his cool and finding the most accurate path to a draw.

63. ... h2 64. Bxh2 Qc2+ 65. Kg7 Qxh2 66. g6

Black is a full piece up, but the far-advanced g-pawn guarantees White a draw.

66. ... a4 67. Qd7 Qe5+ 68. Kh7 Qh5+ 69. Kg7 Qe5+ 70. Kh7 Qh5+ 71. Kg7 Qe5+, Draw agreed.

There was no way to play on: 71. ... a3 would have allowed a perpetual with 72. Qb5+ Kc8 73. Qe8+.

Not all of us are destined to become as famous as Teddy Roosevelt, but—in chess as well as in life each and every one of us can adopt his attitude of unbridled, unwavering resilience in the face of adversity. ♠

¹ From “Who Shot T.R.?” Theodore Roosevelt Birthplace. National Park Service, n.d. Web. 10 October 2015.

Keeping a Clear Head

How to use common sense, intuition, and calculation when you don't know the theory.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

A SIMPLE CHESS BASE SEARCH REVEALS an intriguing statistic: *before 1850, only 15 recorded games reached an opposite-colored bishop endgame.* As an endgame fanatic, I find this data appalling, but perfectly explicable: chess games in the romantic era seldom reached the endgame! Even disputes between world-class players frequently ended in a sanguinary middlegame battle, with sacrifice upon sacrifice leading to a dazzling mating combination (think Steinitz-Von Bardeleben).

It is particularly fascinating, then, to observe how early maestros approached the final stage of the game. Theoretical knowledge was scant, and players who felt perfectly comfortable among epic tactical complications were often lost at sea in an outwardly simple endgame. To this end, I would like to examine a wonderfully-instructive instance of an opposite-colored bishop endgame arising in nineteenth-century tournament practice. The point of this somewhat unconventional exercise is not to denigrate or belittle the players. Rather, we will try to understand how we can use our common sense, intuition, and calculation to compensate for a deficiency in theoretical knowledge. And unless you have read and memorized Dvoretsky's *Endgame Manual* as well as Averbakh's five-volume monograph, this is a problem that you will most certainly face!

ACCURACY NEEDED

Louis-Charles Mahé de Labourdonnais
Alexander McDonnell
London (3), 1834



BLACK TO MOVE

By the early nineteenth century, Labourdonnais

and McDonnell had established total dominance over the burgeoning European chess scene, and played a staggering six matches (45 games total) between June and October of 1834. Labourdonnais emerged supreme in four of the matches (with the last one being retired), but his victories did not come easy. This game is most certainly a case in point.

On paper, White's material advantage is decisive: he is two pawns up, and is the proud owner of connected passers that are itching to crown their bare heads. However, things are far from decided. Black has a far-advanced passer in his own right, and his pieces are ridiculously active. Indeed, the king is only a few paces away from reaching ultimate paradise on e3. Furthermore, the presence of opposite-colored bishops—as we have already witnessed multiple times in this column—considerably increases Black's drawing chances. To this end, if he could eliminate White's passers and give his d- and b-pawns in return, the position would still be utterly drawn.

It is clear, then, that McDonnell is on the verge of holding his own, but he must still demonstrate a great deal of accuracy.

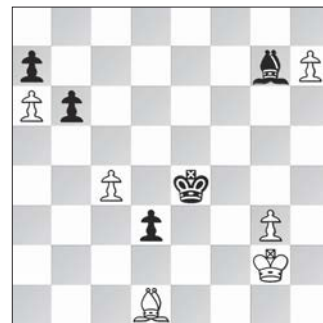
45. ... Kb4?

The right idea, but a fatally misguided execution! McDonnell is right to mobilize his king, but he must do so while keeping White's own monarch from reaching the center. Even without any calculation, it is intuitively clear that 45. ... Kd4! is superior in every respect. The king can still access c3 if necessary, but the crucial difference is that 46. Kf2 is powerfully met with 46. ... Ke4!, sealing off White's king and securing a positional draw.

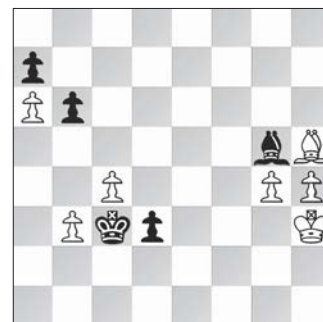


It appears that White is on the verge of breaking through—that he needs only one more timely check to set his pawns in motion—but there is little he can do:

A. 47. b4 Be7! and White has nothing better than to permanently cement the queenside with 48. b5, since 48. h5 fails to impress after 48. ... Bxb4 49. h6 Bc5+ 50. Kg2 Bf8 51. h7 Bg7.



B. 47. Kg2! is the only serious winning attempt, and it requires Black to act with tremendous precision. In order to draw, he must do everything in his power to mount enough counterplay to halt the progress of White's pawns: 47. ... Ke3 48. Kh3 Kd2 49. Bh5 (49. Bf3 Bd4! and 50. g4 meets with 50. ... Ke3, when the king returns to f4 and stops the pawns for good) 49. ... Kc3 and it suddenly transpires that 50. g4 loses to the spectacular 50. ... Bg5!!



White must burn a valuable tempo to bring his bishop back to f3, and this allows Black to save the day: 50. Bf3 Kxb3 51. g4 Kxc4 52. g5 Bd4 53. h5 b5 54. h6 Be3 55. Kg4 b4 56. Kh5 b3 57.

Play Like the Romantics!

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Carl Mayet

Tassilo von Heydebrand und der Lasa
Berlin, 1839



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Moheschunder Bannerjee

John Cochrane
Calcutta, 1850



WHITE TO MOVE

g6 b2 58. g7 b1=Q 59. g8=Q+ Kc3 and against all odds, Black seems to be holding on. He will give up his bishop for White's h-pawn, but the d-pawn should give him just enough to make the draw.

Make no mistake: neither McDonnell, nor any modern grandmaster has the mental capacity to calculate a variation of this length and complexity. However, 45. ... Kd4 can be arrived at through simple process of elimination: it has all of the benefits of 45. ... Kb4, while maintaining the possibility of shifting to the kingside. Common sense is a powerful tool in the endgame!

46. Kf2! Kc3 47. Ke3!

Labourdonnais pounces immediately. Black's king looks intimidating, but it is sealed off from White's pawns by its bloodthirsty vis-à-vis. Perhaps McDonnell was counting on his d-pawn to provide sufficient counterplay, but White's bishop is always ready to sacrifice itself if the occasion calls for it.

47. ... Bd4+ 48. Ke4?!

This move does not throw the win away, but it unnecessarily complicates the situation. 48. Kf4 would have won on the spot, since Black cannot stop the pawns from reaching pay dirt and beyond. For instance, the computer initially asserts that 48. ... Kd2 maintains drawing chances, but this is nothing more than an illusion: 49. Ke4! Bf6 50. h5! puts an end to Black's resistance. After 50. ... Kxd1 51. Kxd3, White will simply create a passer on the queenside (with b4-c5) and Black's bishop will be utterly helpless.

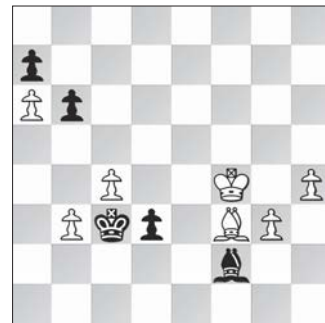
48. ... Bf2

There was no need to allow this move, which forces White to reposition his king and slows down the movement of his pawns.

49. Kf4 Kd2 50. Bf3 Kc3

(see diagram next column)

In the vast majority of endgames, there eventually comes a point that GM Edmar Mednis referred to as the "the moment of truth": the point when you must lay your intuition aside, hunker down, and calculate. The most tempting course of action is obviously 51. h5, but it is a move that should be



calculated to the end. In all likelihood, Labourdonnais fell into a psychological trap that catches players to this day: he assumed that, for one reason or another, pure calculation is invalid in an unbalanced endgame of this sort. This is obviously far from the truth: no matter how little material is left on the board, calculation is always a valid method of resolving a dilemma and finding the correct path. Instead, Labourdonnais begins to doubt himself, and goes terribly astray.

51. Bd1?

Technically speaking, this is not a mistake, since White can simply repeat moves and get back on the right track. However, it is already a step in the wrong direction, and Labourdonnais follows up with a disastrous blunder. In fact, the "complications" following 51. h5 were quite easy to calculate: after 51. ... Kxb3 52. g4 Kxc4 53. g5, it becomes clear that Black's counterplay is a day late and a dollar short. One particularly grotesque finale would be 53. ... b5 54. g6 Bd4 55. h6 and Black is clearly not in time. As you can see, the simple act of maintaining a clear head is in itself a very big step toward mastering the practical endgame!

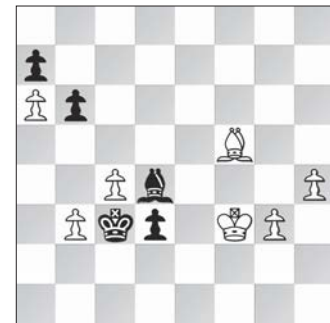
51. ... Kd2 52. Bg4??

After this, there is no going back. The bishop obstructs the g-pawn, and White will no longer be in time to promote.

52. ... Kc3 53. Kf3

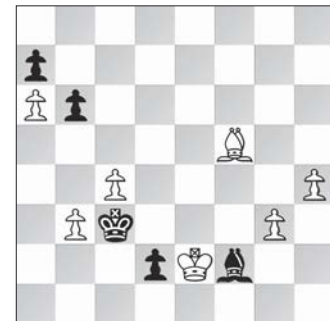
There is no going back: 53. Bd1 would lead to a three-time repetition after 53. ... Kd2.

53. ... Bd4 54. Bf5



Labourdonnais desperately tries to regroup, but McDonnell spears off one of his passers with a cute little tactic. Can you find it?

54. ... d2 55. Ke2 Bf2!



Boom! Just like that, White loses one of his pawns, and—with his king immobilized as well—he is left with nothing more than a symbolic advantage.

56. h5 Bxg3 57. Kd1 Bf4 58. Be6 Bh6 59. Bf5 Bg5, Draw agreed.

As we have already discussed multiple times, endgames are not inherently special. True, they require a great deal of theoretical knowledge, but the skills that allow you to succeed in any middle game position—common sense, self-composure, and above all, accurate calculation—are very much applicable in the endgame. ♠

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A Tale of Two Passed Pawns

Remembering Emory Tate

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

JULY 6, 2008 IS A DAY THAT I RECALL quite vividly. Having drawn my final game at the World Open, I walked over to the skittles room to hang out and play some blitz (read: bughouse). Oddly, most of the chairs were empty, boards and clocks left unattended. And then I saw them: 20 or 30 people clustered around a single board in the center of the room. Each and every one of them was transfixed by the man handling the white pieces. He was rifling through variations at breakneck speed, boom boom boom, sacrifice piling on top of sacrifice. Something special was going on.

For veterans of open tournaments, this scene will undoubtedly sound familiar. The man in the middle was, of course, International Master Emory Tate. He was showing his most famous game, a dazzling victory over GM Leonid Yudasin at the 1997 Chicago Open in which Emory demolished his formidable opponent with a brilliant sacrificial attack straight out of the opening. Upon the conclusion of most tournaments, Emory would set up shop in the skittles room and commentate his Mona Lisa for anyone willing to listen. And boy, did people listen!

To honor this inimitable juggernaut of American chess who just died at the age of 56 on October 17, 2015, I would like to dedicate this column to Emory. As you can guess, his games seldom reached the endgame; typically, the board resembled an apocalyptic wasteland by move 30. However, Emory had one game in particular—against none other than Maurice Ashley—that did reach the final stage of the game. What you are about to witness is no ordinary endgame, but it can still teach us many lessons and show us the kind of player that Emory was!

TATE.

FM Emory Tate (2325)
FM Maurice Ashley (2365)
New York Open, 1993

(see diagram top of next column)



BLACK TO MOVE

Things started getting crazy around move 14, when Emory sacrificed a bishop to keep Black's king in the center. What ensued was a smoldering mess of hanging pieces and tactical devilry, which rapidly transformed into the wild endgame that you see on the board. In such situations, the most prudent course of action is to leave calculation alone for a few moments, and simply figure out what is going on.

Material is approximately equal, but it is the gross disparity in piece placement and coordination that places White at the edge of the precipice. His rook and knight (especially the latter) are locked in a grotesque embrace with the light-squared bishop, leaving the tandem utterly impotent. On the other hand, each of Black's minor pieces is beautifully situated. We've already mentioned the light-squared bishop, but its colleague on g5 and the cavalier on f2 are also doing a fine job. Indeed, it appears that White is totally incapable of stopping the h-pawn from reaching pay dirt.

33. ... h5?

Ashley is under the same impression, but he fails to perceive a hidden and deadly source of counterplay that instantly turns the tables. Black should have started by eliminating White's knight: 33. ... Bxa8! 34. Rxa8 h5. This rather counterintuitive sequence will become clear as soon as you look at (or find) White's 34th move. As it stands, White's queenside counterplay is

much too slow, and he is forced to make extreme material and positional concessions in order to stop the h-pawn: 35. e6! (clearing the path) 35. ... fxe6 36. Ra6+ Kd7 37. Ra7+ Kd6 38. Rxc7 Bf6 39. Rg6 Nxe4. White definitely has practical chances, but Black's ultra-active pieces and two passed pawns should eventually seal the deal.

34. a4!

Needless to say, Emory pounces immediately. As ridiculous as the knight appears, its control over the b6- and c7-squares renders 34. ... bxa4 impossible due to 35. b5+. Black's reply is therefore forced:

34. ... Bxa8 35. axb5+

And there's the rub: this intermezzo creates White's own set of connected passed pawns, fully counterbalancing Black's activity on the other flank.

35. ... Kd7 36. Rxa8



36. ... Bf4?

Throughout my endgame experience, I've often found that the best way to deal with passed pawns is restrain them as soon as possible. A passer on the sixth or seventh rank, especially if supported by a heavy piece, can bring about a litany of undesirable tactical opportunities. This is the case here: 36. ... Be3! would have kept the b-pawn under control and

Tate's Endgames

(A rare occurrence!)

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

IM Emory Tate (2431)
Howard Cohen (1971)
Master Challenge, 1996



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM Emory Tate (2386)
Paul Fricano (1920)
17th Annual Chicago Open, 2008



WHITE TO MOVE

maintained the balance. Indeed, the game will end in a rather anticlimactic draw after 37. c4 h4 38. c5 h3 39. Ra7+ Kc8 40. Ra8+ Kd7 (40. ... Kb7 is also a draw after 41. Rh8 g5 42. e6! fxe6 43. c6+ Kc7 44. Rh7+ Kc8 45. Rh8+) 41. Ra7+. Calculation aside, there is a negatively proportional relationship between a pawn's distance to promotion and the damage it inflicts!

37. Rf8?!

By attacking the pawn, Tate draws the king further from the passer, but this move just doesn't have that extra oomph. Instead, the straightforward 37. Ra7+ Ke6 38. b6 would have won the game, since Black will have to give up the bishop (what was that about negatively proportional relationships?): 38. ... Nxe4 39. Ra8 Kxe5 40. b7 Kf5 41. b8=Q Bxb8 42. Rxb8 and Black is toast. The rook will easily restrain Black's outwardly intimidating trio of passers, while White's own phalanx will easily overrun Black's feeble defenses.

37. ... Ke7 38. Rh8 h4!

Now it is Maurice's turn to pounce! Black gives up the pride of his position, but in return he forces White's rook away onto a terribly awkward square. This will give Black a golden opportunity to set his second passed pawn in motion, as well as capture on e5 and take the b8-square under control.

39. Rxh4 g5 40. Rh8?

Tempting, natural, and ... wrong! Emory commits the all-too-common error of underestimating the speed with which the g-pawn will advance. The most important task was not to root out Black's bishop, but rather to eliminate the treacherous little imp on g5. This could have been accomplished with 40. Rh5!. Black can keep the g-pawn temporarily alive with 40. ... Ng4 41. b6 Nxe5 42. b7 Nc6, but 43. e5! forces Black to accept the inevitable.

40. ... Bxe5 41. Rg8 f6 42. b6 Kf7!

A nice little sequence, driving the rook away from the g-file. Passed Pawn Airlines flight 101 is cleared for takeoff!

43. Ra8 g4 44. Ra1?!

Understandably enough, Emory simply loses his nerve. It was crucial to leave the rook on a8 (to maintain the possibility of promoting the b-pawn), and leave the monarch to deal with the enemy. As it turns out, 44. Kd2 would have led to instant liquidation and a draw. Perhaps Tate was concerned about 44. ... Nxe4+, but there is absolutely nothing to worry about: 45. Ke2 Nxc3+ 46. Kf1 Nd5 47. b7 Nxb4 48. b8=Q Bxb8 49. Rxb8 and it is time to shake hands.

44. ... g3 45. Rg1 Nxe4

Now, White's pawn no longer constitutes a serious threat, and Black can focus all of his energy on getting the widower a new Lady. Many of us would simply fold at this point (mentally if not literally), but Emory was never one to go gentle into that good night.

46. c4 Ke6 47. Kd3 f5 48. Ke3

White could have muddled the waters somewhat with 48. c5 Kd5 49. Rc1, but 49. ... Kc6 50. Rc2 Nc3! puts an end to White's resistance: there is no way to stop ... f4-f3 (... f2-f1=Q).

48. ... Ng5!

A dagger. The knight seals off the king, and White is utterly powerless to stop the crushing march of the f-pawn.

49. c5 f4+ 50. Kd3 f3 51. Re1!

(see diagram top of next column)

Vintage Emory Tate. Nobody would have blamed him for resigning, but he has one last trick up his sleeve—and what a vicious trick it is. The cold-blooded 51. ... g2 would have won on the spot: 52. Rxe5+ Kxe5 53. b7 g1=Q 54. b8=Q+ Kf5 and Black will easily promote the second pawn. But Ashley—presumably in acute



time pressure—is unable to resist his instinct.

51. ... f2??

If one explained the phrase “natural move” to a Martian learning the rules of chess, this is the example he would show. And yet, by an absolute miracle, this move opens the tiniest crevice for White's king, enabling it to halt Black's passers in stunning fashion. Watch this!

52. Rxe5+! Kxe5 53. Ke2!

Simply incredible. Black needs three moves to promote (... Nh3 or ... Ne4-... g2 and ... f1=Q or ... g1=Q), but White will do so with check! He therefore has no choice but to relegate both of his pieces to utter passivity, acquiescing to an improbable draw.

53. ... Nf3 54. b7 Nd4+ 55. Kf1 Nc6 56. b5! Nb8 57. c6! Kd6, Draw agreed.

After 58. Kg2, neither side can make progress.

At the most general level, endgame mastery consists of three distinct elements. Most players are familiar with theoretical knowledge and practical understanding (the latter is the theme of this column), but few place a high premium on the third aspect: tenacity. And what Emory Tate lacked in the first two categories, he made up with his tactical wizardry and endless supply of perseverance. What this titanic battle lacked in objective quality, it more than made up for with instructive and entertainment value.

You will be sorely missed, Emory! ♠

Of Knights and Men

We real cool. We Left school. We Lurk late. We Strike straight. We Sing sin. We Thin gin. We Jazz June. We Die soon. ~Gwendolyn Brooks, 1960

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

GWENDOLYN BROOKS' POIGNANT DE-piction of the tragic path followed by countless American youths in the 1950s and '60s is one of the most notorious and influential poems of all time. It has been the subject of fierce literary and prosodic debate since its publication, but—to my amazement—no scholar has dared to approach this poem through the lens of our beloved game. Indeed, even a cursory analysis reveals that the mysterious we refers to—wait for it—knights. Knights are definitely real cool. They refuse to move in a conventional manner, so it stands to reason that they have not received a proper education. They strike straight through the heart of an unsuspecting king. They constantly violate positional principles. And unfortunately, their impudence often brings about an untimely demise.

In the endgame, all of these qualities are accentuated tenfold. To navigate the stormy waters of a knight versus knight endgame, calculation and theoretical knowledge is not enough; one must also understand and conceptualize how a knight operates under various circumstances. Hopefully, the following recent endgame battle will help us do just that.

WE STRIKE STRAIGHT

GM Baris Esen (FIDE 2562, TUR)

IM Eesha Karavade (FIDE 2379, IND)

Qatar Masters 2015, Doha, Qatar, 12.22.15



BLACK TO MOVE

White is obviously in the driver's seat. While the disparity in knight placement appears to counterbalance his extra pawn, this disparity is nothing but an illusion. Indeed, White needs only two moves to entrench his cavalier on d6, where it will wreak further havoc on Black's defenseless pawn. Sensing the danger, Karavade embarks on a last-ditch effort to hunt down White's vulnerable kingside pawns.

28. ... Ne3

The only way to maintain drawing chances: the knight heads for f1. Of course, Black's aim is not to restore the material balance, but rather to create a passed pawn as soon as possible.

29. Nb5

Esen follows through on his own plan, leading the knight to an imperial outpost on d6. These two moves alone illustrate **just how skillfully knights target and eliminate undefended pawns.**

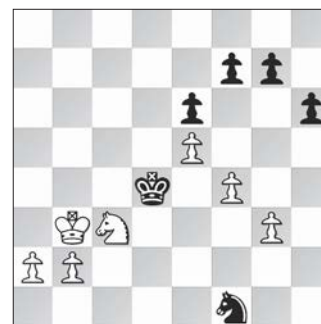
29. ... Nf1 30. Nd6 Nxh2 31. Nxb7 Nf1

The first critical point has been reached. Even without calculating, it is evident that the game will eventually boil down to a pawn race. It is equally clear that White will have an advantage in this race; after all, he is the one with connected passers, and Black does not even have a passed pawn yet. To this end, it is very tempting to get the ball rolling with 32. a4. However, following 32. ... Nxg3 33. a5 Kc7 34. Nd6 h5 it transpires that Black's king is more than equipped to restrain the a-pawn. White can squeeze out a draw with the computer-like 35. Nxf7! (Just plain awful is 35. a6? Kb6) 35. ... Ne4 36. a6 Kb6 37. Nd6!, but this is not the kind of finale one would envision. This brings us to a second important point: **knights are very poor at close-quarter combat against the king.** The king's mobility is limited, but its ability to move in any direction usually enables it to circumvent the knight's influence. With this idea in mind, White must make every effort to halt Black's kingside progress:

32. Nc5+! Kc6 33. Ne4

We strike straight! With the g3-pawn safely protected, a2-a4 becomes a serious threat. Hence, Black has no choice but to draw her king further away from the queenside.

33. ... Kd5 34. Nc3+ Kd4?



Karavade's choice is perfectly understandable: 34. ... Kc5 meets with 35. Ne2, when it appears that Black's counterplay evaporates for good. However, the text move simply loses by force: Black will succeed in capturing on g3, but he will stand little chance in the ensuing pawn race. In fact, the game is far from over after 34. ... Kc5 35. Ne2 g5! The problem is that 36. fxg5 hxg5 37. a4 is unconvincing due to 37. ... Nd2+ 38. Kc3 Ne4+, when 39. Kd3 falls prey to 39. ... Nf2+ 40. Kc2 (White loses one of his jewels after 40. Ke3 Nd1+) 40. ... Kb4. The king paralyzes White's connected passers, and it is only a matter of time before the dreadfully weak pawn on e5 suffers a gruesome fate. Thus, White should try 36. Kc2 gxf4 37. gxf4, granting Black an outside passer but keeping the kingside pawns intact. Following 37. ... Ne3+ 38. Kd3 Nd5, we reach a fascinating position:

(see diagram next page)

My intuition screams that White should eventually set his pawns in motion, but this is much easier said than done. After tackling this incredibly complex position with a strong

Striking Through Passed Pawns

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Andre Cheron
Study, 1952



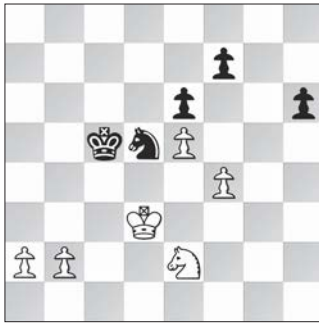
WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2786)
GM Vladimir Kramnik (FIDE 2793)
World Team Championship, 2013



WHITE TO MOVE



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

computer, I uncovered a long and tenuous path to victory starting with 39. Ke4.

All of this goes to show that **knight endgames are often tremendously complex despite the limited material**. As I've stressed previously, the most prudent course of action is to embrace this complexity, and trust your intuition when you cannot make sense of the complications.

35. a4?!

This ruins nothing, but it gives Black an unnecessary opportunity to prolong the game. 35. Kb4! would have been more accurate.

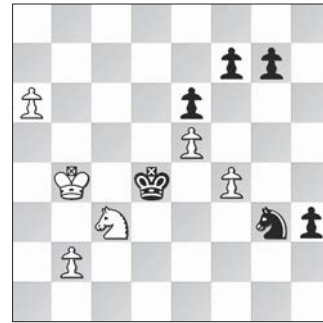
35. ... Nxg3?!

Karavade returns the favor. The repentant 35. ... Kc5 would have held on for a while longer, although 36. Ne4+ Kb6 37. Kb4 is obviously hopeless in the long run.

36. Kb4 h5 37. a5 h4 38. a6 h3

(see diagram top of next column)

Without the knights, 39. a7 would decide the game immediately, but things are less simple in their presence. Apparently, the Turkish grandmaster was so intent on promoting as fast as possible that he temporarily forgot one of the knight's greatest virtues: it's ability to stop passed pawns.



39. a7??

Given this position as an exercise, a player of Esen's caliber would undoubtedly find 39. Nd1! h2 40. Nf2 in an instant. Black can resign, since 40. ... Ke3 fails to 41. Ng4+ and 40. ... Ne4 is coolly rebuffed by 41. Nh1. It is no coincidence that White had this resource: **because of their unique movement, knights can often reach a pawn's queening square from almost any corner of the board**. Make no mistake: in the long run, a king and far-advanced passer will surmount the knight's blockade, but the knight's ability to deliver forks (40. ... Ke3 41. Ng4+!) frequently renders such an operation time-consuming. When calculating any knight endgame, never assume that a pawn will simply promote once it has started its march.

39. ... h2 40. a8=Q h1=Q 41. Qa7+ Kd3 42. Qxf7 Qc6!

The key. Black will lose two pawns, but her excellent piece coordination and lasting initiative provides more than enough compensation.

43. Qxg7 Nf5 44. Qg1 Qc4+?!

After mounting a heroic (albeit somewhat lucky) resistance, Karavade begins to lose the thread. This is not a major transgression in itself, but there was no need to go pawn hunting. The straightforward 44. ... Ne3! would have drawn on the spot; 45. Qb1 is strongly

met with 45. ... Nc2+, and White must accept perpetual with 46. Ka5 Qc7+ 47. Ka6 Qc6+.

45. Ka5 Qxf4 46. Qb1+ Ke3 47. Qe1+ Kf3?

Mistakes, one wise human being once remarked, rarely stand alone. Karavade evacuates her king out of the danger zone, but gives White a golden opportunity to coordinate his forces and set the b-pawn in motion. Instead, the intrepid 47. ... Kd3! would have maintained equality. Following 48. Qe2+ Kd4 49. Nb5+ Kc5 there is nothing to fear. White must give up the e5-pawn to deal with the threat of ... Qb4+, so the time is ripe to sign the scoresheets.

48. Qe2+ Kg3 49. Ne4+ Kh3 50. Qh5+!

In addition to centralizing his knight, White continues to harass the king, forcing Black to cripple her position even further.

50. ... Nh4

An unfortunate necessity, since 50. ... Kg2 enables White to trade queens with 51. Qg5+.

51. Nc5 Kg3 52. b4 Qc1?

This loses on the spot, although Black's defensive task was unenviable to say the least. Karavade should have tried 52. ... Qe3, but after 53. Ka4! I doubt that the position is salvageable from a human standpoint.

53. Ne4+ Kh3 54. Nf2+ Kg3 55. Qg4+!

We die soon!

55. ... Kxf2 56. Qxh4+ Kf3 57. Qf6+, Black resigned.

This is the kind of working-class, meat-and-potatoes endgame that will probably never be annotated in a magazine (other than *Chess Life!*) or featured in an endgame manual. Nonetheless, it offers a tremendously instructive (and quite entertaining) journey into the heart of a complex knight endgame. It is my sincere hope that you have now arrived at a fuller understanding of the mysterious, inimitable, straight-shooting, piece that we call the knight. ♠

Dirty Rotten Trades

When faced with a trade, don't make a gut decision.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IN A SENSE, TRADING A PIECE IS ANALOGOUS to making a large investment in a startup firm. In each case, three distinct scenarios are possible:

Scenario 1: The firm blossoms, and you become a rich person. In the same vein, an outwardly risky trade may ultimately expose a certain weakness in your opponent's position, paving the way for a decisive attack.

Scenario 2: The firm is moderately prosperous, and you are repaid in the amount of your initial investment. Similarly, the trade does not change the evaluation of the position: you ended exactly where you started.

Scenario 3: Disaster strikes, and the startup collapses. You sustain irreversible financial losses. Analogously, the trade—for one reason or another—backfires, creating fatal weaknesses in your own camp and leading to an imminent loss.

In both the arena of business and the world of chess, the final scenario is, unfortunately, all too common. No matter how assiduously we strive to alter our nature, humans are and always will be prone to impulsive, emotional thinking. While such unrestrained, “hot” decision-making contributes to our survival skills in the real world, it almost invariably brings about the dreaded third scenario in the land of 64 squares.

In the endgame, we must take especially great care to avoid making moves purely on the basis of intuition or instinct. When faced with a trade, the temptation to do so increases hundredfold, simply because it is easy to form a subconscious judgment about the soundness of the trade long before one actually starts calculating. With material limited, an imprudent capture—especially one that takes the game into a highly volatile pawn or knight ending—will lead to instant calamity.

In this article, I would like to investigate this common pitfall through the lens of a recent endgame battle between two elite grandmasters. In the course of our analysis, we will derive

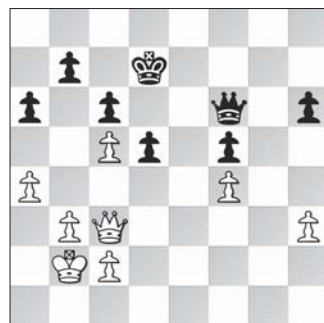
several mental “hacks” that will enable you to limit the amount of careless mistakes that you make in the endgame, especially ones that involve assessing a trade and its consequences (hint: take careful note of those last two words!).

HAMLET'S SOLILOQUY, TATA STEEL EDITION

GM Magnus Carlsen (2844)

GM Hou Yifan (2673)

Tata Steel Chess 2016 (11), Wijk aan Zee,
North Holland, 01.29.2016



AFTER 44. Qc3

(Note: this game is also annotated in our *Wijk aan Zee* article on pages 41-42. ~ed.)

You are probably well aware that Magnus Carlsen, true to his reputation, stormed through the field and claimed his fifth Tata Steel title. Viewed through the lens of this convincing victory, Carlsen's round 11 game against Hou Yifan may appear like a typical Magnus win: he attained a slight edge from the opening, expanded it in the middlegame, and reeled in the full point with sparkling endgame technique. However, a closer and more objective look reveals that things were not nearly as one-sided.

From a purely visual standpoint, it seems that White is the one on top. Although his queenside pawn structure is somewhat weakened, the pawn on c5 does hold back Black's entire pawn chain, securing two potential passageways for the monarch along the dark squares (c3-d4-e5, and c3-b4-a5-b6).

Consequently, the dilemma that stands before Hou Yifan is one of life-or-death implications: to trade, or not to trade?

When faced with such a dilemma, inexperienced players often find themselves at a loss. Where do I start? Do I try to calculate all of the alternatives, or do I rely primarily on my intuition? There is obviously no foolproof algorithm that will enable you to arrive at the correct decision 100% of the time, but my experience has led me to believe that the following three-step process will greatly eliminate your chances of committing a blunder when confronted with a possible trade:

Step 1. Calculate the consequences of the trade first. If the trade clearly leads to a desired result, *there is no need to spend more than a few seconds on the alternatives*. If, however, you do not arrive at a clear-cut conclusion, *immediately move on to step 2*.

Step 2. Consider the different possible ways that you can decline the trade. Do they all lead to the same position? If yes, try to understand the nature of the arising position, and calculate as much as you can. If not, evaluate each move *separately*—not all ways of declining a trade are created equal!

Step 3. If you cannot decide between trading or not trading (or between two ways of declining the trade), use your intuition in an intelligent way. Rather than choosing randomly, try to determine which continuation yields the greatest margin for error. Usually, entering a pawn ending in which you are unsure if you can hold presents a far greater risk than leaving the queens on the board, when your opponent has slightly more active pieces.

Now, let us apply this method to the position on the board:

Step 1. The move 44. ... Qxc3+ is obviously very tempting. After 45. Kxc3, though, Black must deal with the dual threats of Kb4 and Kd4. To this end, 45. ... Ke6 allows 46. Kb4

Horns and legs

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2628)
IM Puranik Abhimanyu (2442)
Qatar Masters, Doha, 12.24.2015



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM Daniel Naroditsky (2472)
GM Robin Van Kampen (2592)
Philadelphia Open, 03.29.2013



WHITE TO MOVE

Kd7 47. Ka5 Kc7 48. b4, and White will break through with b4-b5 (note that it is not important to continue calculating; it is clear that Black is on the verge of losing, so we will return to this position only if there are no better alternatives). Plugging the hole with 45. ... Kc7 loses to 46. Kd4, while 45. ... a5 seems to entail dire consequences after 46. Kd4 Ke6 47. c3 Kf6 48. b4 axb4 49. cxb4 and White crashes through with b4-b5, creating a deadly outside passer.

It is entirely possible that Black can salvage a draw within these complications (and she can, as we will see), but it is clear that she is hanging by a thread in every line. As a consequence, there is simply no reason not to at least consider declining the trade.

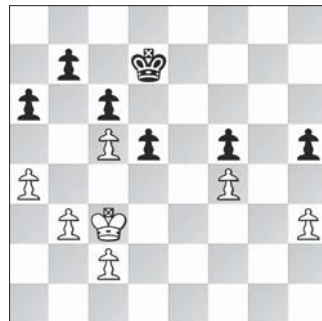
Step 2. There are obviously two ways of declining the trade: Black can retreat with his queen, or block the diagonal with 44. ... d4. Even without calculating a single variation, the first option does not seem particularly appealing: something like 44. ... Qg6 allows 45. Qe5, when White attains total domination. Once again, the objective evaluation ceases to matter until we have considered all the alternatives. Indeed, after 44. ... d4 45. Qd3 Kc7 we have another kettle of fish entirely. Black's queen is ideally placed, and White's own dame cannot depart her post on account of ... d4-d3+. White's only conceivable way to make progress is by expanding on the queenside, but following 46. b4 Kb8 Black simply shuffles his king back and forth, and White has no way to make progress. For instance, 47. Kb1 (47. Kb3 Qe6+ 48. Qc4 Qe3+ 49. Kb2 Qxf4) 47. ... Kc7 48. b5 axb5 49. axb5 cxb5 50. Qxb5 Qa6 and White is the one who must tread cautiously.

And there it is, folks. Regardless of the computer's evaluation (which has little bearing in a game between two humans, unless one of them is cheating), 44. ... d4 is the move that maximizes Black's chances for success. The game, of course, took a very different turn:

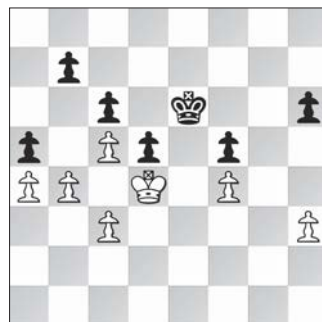
44. ... Qxc3+?!

Make no mistake: this move does not throw the draw away, but it compels Black to find several very difficult ideas in succession, a tall order even for elite grandmasters. On the other hand, 44. ... d4 would have essentially "forced" Black to find the correct moves, since he physically cannot do anything but move his king around!

45. Kxc3 h5??



After the game, commentators seemed incredulous that a player of Hou's caliber did not find the path to a draw: 45. ... a5! 46. Kd4 Ke6 47. c3 Kf6 48. b4 and now, instead of the aforementioned (and outwardly forced) 48. ... axb4, Black simply ignores the "threat" with the paradoxical 48. ... Ke6!!



To me, finding a move of this sort several moves deep into one's calculations is a tremendously difficult task, even if it does not seem

that way when the computer runs in the background. Indeed, White appears to triumph with 49. bxa5 (49. b5 Kf6 leads nowhere) 49. ... Kf6 50. c4 dxc4 51. Kxc4 Ke6 52. Kb4, when the threat of a6 looks devastating. But Black saves the day with 52. ... Kd5!, and the pawns promote simultaneously: 53. a6 bxa6 54. Ka5 Kxc5 55. Kxa6 Kd4! (but not 55. ... Kb4?? 56. a5 c5 57. Kb6 c4 58. a6 c3 59. a7 c2 60. a8=Q c1=Q and 61. Qa5+ picks up the f5-pawn and the game) 56. Kb6 c5 57. a5 c4 58. a6 c3 59. a7 c2 60. a8=Q c1=Q and it is time to shake hands.

So, now does it make sense that 44. ... d4 was a more sensible move?

46. Kb4!

The king reaches a5, and it is all over. The presence of the pawn on c2 gives White a crucial extra move, which he will use to place Black in *Zugzwang* at the right moment.

46. ... Kc8 47. Ka5 Kc7 48. h4!

Zugzwang numero uno!

48. ... Kb8 49. Kb6 Kc8

Black has no choice but to passively await her fate, since after 49. ... d4 White wins with 50. b4 Kc8 51. b5 axb5 52. axb5 cxb5 53. Kxb5 Kc7 54. Kc4, picking up the pawn.

50. b4 Kb8 51. b5 cxb5 52. axb5 axb5 53. Kxb5 Kc7 54. c3, Black resigned.

Zugzwang numero dos, and it is all over. After every king retreat, White picks up the d5-pawn with Kb6 followed by c5-c6.

In almost every column, I have mentioned the importance of remaining objective. While the pursuit of objective excellence should be the primary goal of every aspiring chess player, we should also occasionally acknowledge our own fallibility. It is our job as humans to find ways to limit the possibility of a mistake, even if it means occasionally sacrificing a modicum of objectivity. ♠

(Un)Perpetual Check

Avoiding the ugly specter of perpetual check when a win is in sight.

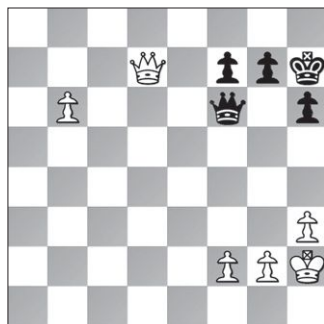
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE SPECTER OF PERPETUAL CHECK hangs over every queen endgame. One tactical misstep, one lapse in concentration, and your king is trapped in a cat-and-mouse game. Even with six passed pawns one square away from promotion; heck, even with three queens on the board—it is more than possible to blunder the win away.

However, many players assume that the king never has a chance to escape a barrage of queen checks. As a consequence, they take every precaution to shelter the monarch against threats real and imaginary. What many players forget is that **the king is extremely skilled at escaping checks on an open board.**

Allow me to explain. When we think of “perpetual check,” we often imagine a tragic scenario of the following type:

RUN RUN RUDOLPH!



STUDY POSITION

White is completely, utterly, totally winning. The straightforward 1. Qd3+ followed by 2. b7, or even the sober 1. Qc7, decides the game on the spot. But all roads lead to Rome, don't they?

1. b7?

As you might guess, my question was of the rhetorical variety. This negligent advance allows a typical perpetual check:

1. ... Qf4+ 2. Kg1

The alternative 2. g3 offers no relief after 2. ... Qxf2+. The unfortunate position of White's queen does not allow him to interpose the check with Qg2.

2. ... Qc1+ 3. Kh2 Qf4+

... and White has to acquiesce to the inevitable.

Blunders of this sort occur quite frequently, especially in tactically-charged situations when both players are in time pressure. However, when the king is not incarcerated in a self-made prison, he is often tremendously adept at escaping the lady's wrath. There are three primary reasons for this:

- 1) On an open board, the queen faces obstacles: pawns that control or block important checking squares, as well as the possibility of an interposition.
- 2) The king can “aim” toward a certain square—often on the opposite side of the board—that is insulated from checks by either his own or his opponent's pieces.
- 3) Even when a perpetual check does exist, finding the right sequence of checks can be a tremendously difficult task under tournament conditions.

As my 11th grade physics teacher used to say after explaining a concept, all of this may seem a bit “hand-wavy.” Hopefully, the following simple yet instructive example will clear things up.

ONLY TWO SCENARIOS

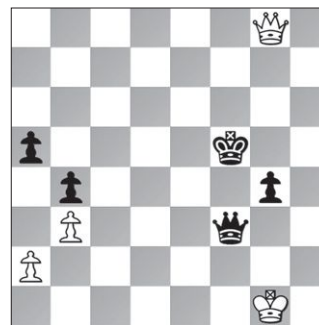
GM Alex Sherzer (2490)

FM Istvan Almasi (2375)

Hungary, 1995

(see diagram top of next column)

Black is playing for two results. In fact, only two scenarios are possible: either Black uses



AFTER 63. ... Kg1

his extra pawn to win (either by promoting it, forcing a winning pawn endgame, or using it as a decoy to capture White's queenside pawns), or White delivers perpetual check. When seeing this position for the first time, my inclination was to start with a few checks: 63. ... Qd1+? 64. Kg2 Qc2+ 65. Kg3. Clearly, Black has achieved nothing other than enable White's king to reach an ideal post.

That leaves 63. ... g3. The first thing to notice is that all stalemate tricks are out of the question: White's wretched a2-pawn spoils all the fun, and he has no time for something like a2-a4 (Black could even capture *en passant*, leaving the b-pawn free to move!). White must therefore start checking, and the battle will revolve around the king's ability (or lack thereof) to find a shelter from the checks. Note that there is no need to do any preemptive calculations: regardless of the outcome, Black should follow the Dutch school of chess' mantra: move first, think later!

63. ... g3 64. Qc8+

Now, the time has come to start thinking. When faced with a barrage of checks, it is important to develop a general strategy, even if you do not calculate everything to the end. It is tempting to remain on the kingside, but after something like 64. ... Kg5? 65. Qg8+ Kh4 66. Qh7+ Qh5 67. Qe4+ White simply continues checking. Black can interpose to his heart's

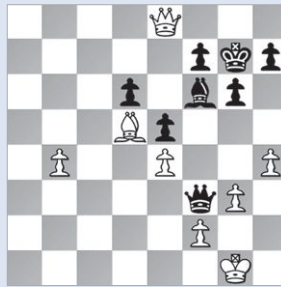
Find the Perpetual

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

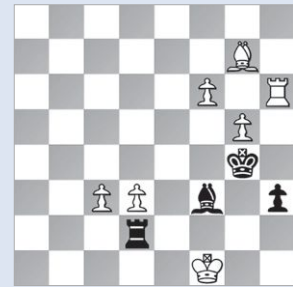
GM Michael Adams (FIDE 2740)
GM David Navara (FIDE 2724)
Biel (variation), 07.20.2015



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Teimour Radjabov (FIDE 2726)
GM Sergey Karjakin (FIDE 2767)
Tashkent (variation), 2014



BLACK TO MOVE

content, but there is no way to cover all checking squares.

The other possibility is to seek shelter on the opposite flank; but where exactly? In these situations, all you have to do is pick a square; in nine cases out of 10, the king will find a way to get there. Once you have guided your thinking in the right direction, that square is not difficult to locate: a3!

64. ... Ke4

Let the journey begin. The rest is a matter of simple technique, but Black must remain vigilant until the end.

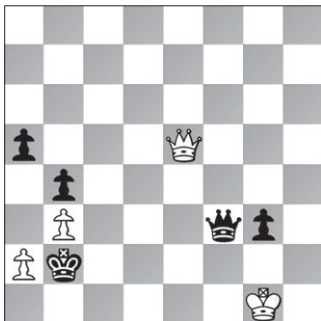
65. Qe6+ Kd3 66. Qc4+ Kd2 67. Qd4+ Kc2

The alternative 67. ... Qd3 also does the trick, but there is no need to get distracted. After 68. Qb2+ White is still in the game.

68. Qc5+

Note the role of obstacles: White would have loved to deliver a check on e4 (or even f2), but even the queen cannot make something out of nothing.

68. ... Kb2 69. Qe5+!



"Now wait a minute," I hear you say. "69. ... Kxa2 70. Qxa5+ Kxb3 and White is out of checks!" That is correct, but **you should always be extra vigilant when your opponent's king has no more squares.** With the

pawn on a2, these tricks went out of the window. But once Black has captured the pawn, White can draw immediately with the thematic 70. Qb2+.

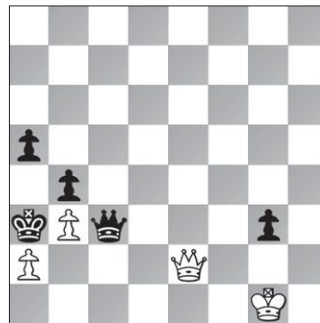
69. ... Qc3!

Now this is a different story! Only now, after his king is safely entrenched on a nearly optimal square, is it time to interpose.

70. Qe2+

This allows the king to complete its journey, but White had no hope anyway. 70. Qxa5 would have merely accelerated the inevitable after 70. ... Qe1+ 71. Kg2 Qf2+ 72. Kh3 Qh2+ 73. Kg4 g2 (also notice the queen on h2 stops Qe5+).

70. ... Ka3



And there we have it. The king has reached its "new" castle, and White is done for. As long as Black avoids stalemate tricks, the game is over.

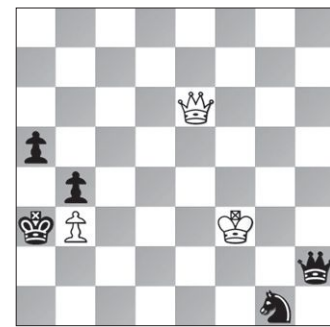
71. Qe6 Qa1+ 72. Kg2 Qxa2+ 73. Kh3 Qh2+ 74. Kg4 g2

Sherzer would have been best advised to resign at this point, but—as the Russians say—inertia kept him going.

75. Kf3 g1=N+

(see diagram top of next column)

A bit of a comeuppance, wouldn't you say? The rather straightforward 75. ... g1=Q would



have been a bit faster, but Almasi takes no chances.

76. Ke4 Qe2+ 77. Kf5 Qxe6+, White resigned.

It's about time!

In general, I am not a big fan of overly-simple examples because they frequently conceal the nuances of a certain concept. In the case of perpetual check, though, there really is no subtlety. Two outcomes are possible, and there is only strategy that will enable you to find your way out of the labyrinth: choose a square or general area of the board, and run! Along the way, do not forget to check for timely interpositions and be wary of stalemate tricks.

Before you move on, a word of advice to those trying to give perpetual check. Not all checks are the same; do not assume that every check will lead to the same result. Rather, try to calculate as much as possible, minimizing the risk of interposition and keeping the opposing king within the bounds of a no-escape zone. If you pretend that you are in full command of the situation, an inexperienced opponent might pleasantly surprise you with a draw offer. Don't be that inexperienced opponent! ♠

US Chess will hold an election in 2016 for two at-large positions on the US Chess Executive Board. For full details, please refer to the Call For Nominations published in the October and November 2015 issues of Chess Life.

False Friends

A false friend in chess is an idea, method, or concept that is valid in one type of position, but that a player mistakenly applies in another.

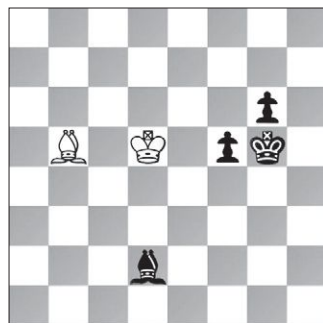
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

TO ANY CURRENT OR FORMER STUDENT of a foreign language, the title of this month's column will likely bring on a score of traumatic memories. The term false friend refers to "a word that is often confused with a word in another language with a different meaning because the two words look or sound similar."¹ As a small child, I would frequently confuse the Russian word *magazin* (store) with the English word magazine, and—as a first-year Spanish student in sixth grade—the Spanish word *carpeta* (folder) with its English false friend carpet.

I believe that this irksome yet valuable concept is applicable to the endgame world as well. To this end, **a (chess) false friend is an idea, method, or concept that is valid in one type of position, but that a player mistakenly applies in another.** This definition is a bit unwieldy (I will not apply for a job at Merriam-Webster's Dictionary anytime soon), but it outlines a very common and important (endgame) phenomenon. Generally, it is impossible to master a theoretical position through rote memorization alone; you must also *understand* the underlying drawing or winning mechanism. At the same time, the **slightest change in the dynamic of a position often renders this mechanism invalid.** Hence, a crucial part of endgame mastery consists in the ability to determine whether a certain technique is applicable in a given position. The following endgame, which recently arose in a game between two strong European grandmasters, serves as a tremendously instructive cautionary tale!

DECISIONS, DECISIONS ...

GM Jon Ludvig Hammer (FIDE 2701, NOR)
GM Nils Grandelius (FIDE 2646, SWE)
Norway Chess Qualifier, Stavanger,
Norway, 03.23.2016



AFTER 59. ... Kg5

If it were Black to move, ... f5-f4 would decide the game instantly. Following Ke4 Kg4, Black plants his king on g3 and the pawns inexorably roll forward. However, it is White's turn, and he must use this opportunity to set up a defensive construction. White can attempt this in one of two ways:

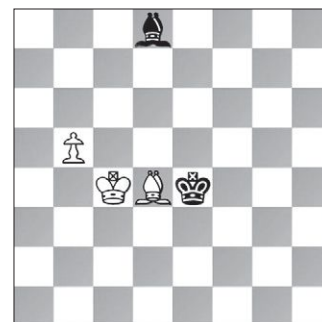
- 1) Bringing the king back via d4, d3, and e2. If White can situate his king and bishop in a way that will a) prevent Black's pawns from moving forward and b) tie down Black's king, he will most likely secure a draw.
- 2) Attacking from the rear with Ke6 (possibly followed by Kf7). This strategy is tactically justified in that 60. Ke6 Kf4? fails to 61. Kf6 g5 62. Bd7 Bc3+ 63. Kg6, and White snags the f-pawn. Thus, it potentially forces Black's hand and may enable White to win material or immobilize Black's passers.

With only three minutes on the clock, Hammer had little time for deep calculation. Hence, it is very probable that he leaned on his existing endgame knowledge to make this critical decision. In particular, this position is somewhat reminiscent of the following (in)famous position:

(see diagram top of next column)

INFAMOUS

GM Mark Taimanov
GM Robert Fischer
Buenos Aires, 1960



AFTER 83. Bd4

Obviously, the situation is different in many ways: the bishops are of the same color, and White has one extra pawn instead of two. Yet the contours of the position are largely the same: Black's king is cut off from the battlefield, and the result of the game hinges on White's ability to advance his pawn one square forward.

A lesser mortal might have despaired, but Fischer drew upon his extensive endgame knowledge to make a quick and sure draw. A century earlier, the Italian chess player Luigi Centurini conducted an extensive survey of bishop plus pawn versus bishop endgames, providing guidelines for both sides. From the defensive perspective, the main lesson is that drawing chances are maximized when the king defends *from the rear*. In this position, the road back is sealed—83. ... Kf5 is met by 84. Kd5—but Black draws by applying the Centurini method:

83. ... Bc7 84. Kc5 Kd3! 85. Kc6 Kc4!

The king and bishop work in amazing harmony, tying down White's forces and immobilizing the pawn. After **86. Bb6 Bf4 87. Ba7** (87. Ba5 Be3 is equal) **87. ... Bc7** Taimanov acquiesced to the draw.

Now, let us go back to Hammer-Grandelius. Consciously or subconsciously, the Norwegian

¹ Definition adapted from the Cambridge English Dictionary Online, <http://dictionary.cambridge.org/us>.

Find the Unconventional Idea!

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

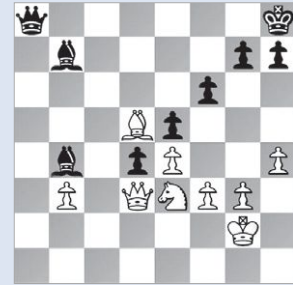
GM Zurab Azmaiparashvili (2660)
GM Daniel Campora (2540)
San Roque, 1996



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM Ogulcan Kanmazalp (2468)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2622)
Benasque, 07.05.2015



BLACK TO MOVE

grandmaster undoubtedly recalled the Centurini method, and decided to follow in its spirit:

60. Ke6?

Creative, perfectly understandable, and wrong! Although opposite-colored bishops appears to make the Centurini method even more effective, the presence of connected passers alters the entire dynamic. The Centurini method works because the defending side can give up its bishop as soon as the pawn advances. With two pawns, however, the bishop will no longer be able to sacrifice itself for the greater good. As a consequence, the king will only throw more oil into the fire by encouraging Black's pawns to move forward.

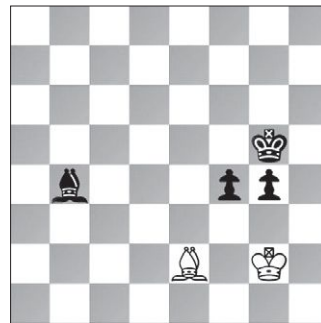
Make no mistake: 60. Ke6 comes awfully close to drawing, but my conceptual explanation is meant to illustrate a larger point. Namely, you should never assume that a certain technique will succeed in a position other than that for which it is intended. Put another way, just because a method is effective in one type of position does not mean that it is likely to work in another. It may work, but you should not give it preferential treatment over other candidate moves.

As it turns out, 60. Kd4! draws fairly easily. After 60. ... Kf4 61. Kd3 Bb4 (61. ... Kf3!? 62. Kxd2 Kf2 looks a bit scary, but White draws immediately with 63. Bd3) 62. Ke2 g5 (62. ... Kg3 63. Bd3 and Black must go back) 63. Bd3 g4 64. Kf2 Kg5 65. Kg2 f4 66. Be2 White reaches a famous theoretical setup that Mark Dvoretsky terms "pawns in the crosshairs."

(see diagram top of next column)

Essentially, White has succeeded in constructing the type of fortress outlined in the note to the initial position. ... f3+ will always be met with Bxf3 (surprise, surprise), and Black's king will never be able to abandon the g-pawn. Time to shake hands!

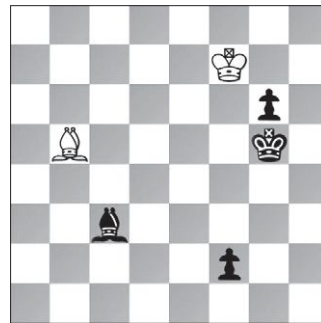
60. ... f4!



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Grandelius pounces. Now, it is too late to double back: 61. Ke5 f3 62. Ke4 Kg4 and Black wins in self-explanatory fashion (... Kg3 followed by ... g5-g4, when he can promote in many ways).

61. Kf7 f3 62. Bc6 f2 63. Bb5 Bc3!



There's the rub: White's king is temporarily cut off, giving Black just enough time to push the g-pawn one square forward.

64. Bf1 Kh6 65. Be2

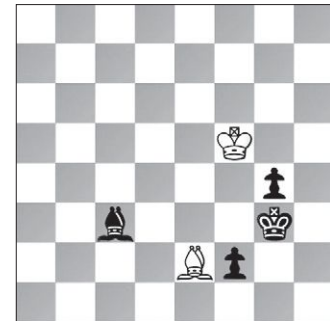
65. Ke6 changes nothing after 65. ... g5 66. Kf5 Kh5.

65. ... g5 66. Ke6 Kg6!

Black continues to "outshoulder" White's king, pushing White's flimsy defensive construction to the brink of collapse.

67. Bd3+ Kh5 68. Kf5 Kh4 69. Be2 Bd2!

A crucial finesse. The hasty 69. ... g4?? would have fully justified White's concept, enabling him to reach a version of the Centurini position with 70. Bf1 Kg3 71. Be2.



By placing his bishop on d2, Black once again cuts off White's hapless monarch, clearing the way for the decisive pawn march.

70. Bf1 Kg3 71. Ke4 Kh2 72. Kd3 Kg1 73. Ke2

White's king has finally, finally made its way home after a tragic misadventure, but it is way too late.

73. ... g4, White resigned.

A picturesque final position, highlighting the total failure of White's defensive strategy!

Let's expose the elephant in the room: mastering practical endgames is a long, arduous process that is fraught with anguish, frustration and, of course, false friends. What is applicable in the utopian world of theoretical positions is often unusable in the apocalyptic realm of practical endgames. Sometimes, the only way to navigate this unforgiving world is by abandoning your preconceived notions, and examining a position from an impartial and unencumbered perspective. And if you calculate hard enough and think logically enough, you may very well find that even the thorniest predicaments can be successfully resolved. ♠

A Comedy of Lessons

GM Irina Krush and WFM Jennifer Yu's epic endgame at the 2016 U.S. Women's Championship

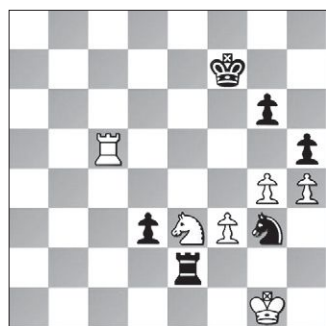
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

AS EXPECTED, THE 2016 U.S. CHAMPIONSHIPS were a spectator's dream, with magisterial performances and Hollywood-like intrigue aplenty. In the men's championship, Fabiano Caruana turned in a brilliant performance, finishing with a mouthwatering 8½/11 and crossing the 2800 barrier once more. The women's section featured a true photo finish, with IM Nazi Paikidze defeating the pre-tournament favorite GM Irina Krush to seize gold from Tatev Abrahamyan's clutches. Unfortunately, yours truly was unable to participate due to certain academic commitments, but I observed the entire event with bated breath (I may or may not have skipped a few lectures to watch the games live).

While my conscience is telling me to dedicate this article to one of GM Caruana or IM Paikidze's endgame victories from the event, the stated purpose of this column is to provide as much instructive and entertainment value as possible. As such, I would like to analyze a fascinating endgame that satisfies both objectives ad infinitum: Irina Krush's epic struggle against the talented junior WFM Jennifer Yu. Seat belts buckled? Good. Tight? Even better.

THRILLA IN MISSOURIAH

GM Irina Krush (2533)
WFM Jennifer Yu (2315)
2016 U.S. Women's Championship (9), St. Louis, Missouri, 04.23.2016

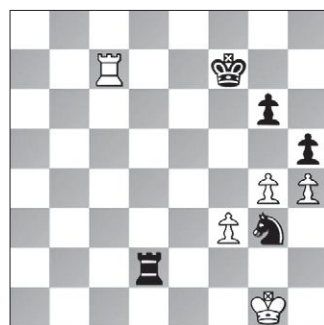


AFTER 58. ... Re2

We join the battle at a critical moment. After her reverse Benko Gambit failed to yield adequate compensation, Krush found herself on the ropes, and she is currently hanging by the flimsiest of threads. While the limited material works in White's advantage, Black's monstrous d-pawn is two moves away from promotion. More importantly, it appears that White's pieces are too scattered and passive to do anything about it! In reality, White does have a way to save the game, but she must tread with the utmost caution.

59. Ng2?

From a conceptual standpoint, this move is understandable: Irina takes the e1-square away from Black's rook, and shelters her own king in a kind of defensive cocoon. However, White simply cannot afford such positional niceties when Black's pawn is on the verge of queening. Indeed, this move gives Black the opportunity to win the game with a series of elegant tactical blows. Instead, the somewhat counterintuitive 59. Nc4! would have enabled White to save the game. The tactical justification is that 59. ... Rc2? falls prey to 60. Ne5+ Ke6 61. Nxd3, and White miraculously eliminates the pawn while keeping the rook defended. Hence, Black is obliged to play 59. ... d2, and after 60. Nxd2 Rxd2 61. Rc7+ (Diagram) an incredible position arises on the board.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

This position—and the subsequent analysis—demonstrates the importance of approaching each and every situation from a concrete standpoint. Visually, White's position looks entirely hopeless; it is easy to assume that Black's king will easily evade the checks and assist the rook and knight in mounting a quick mating attack against White's own defenseless monarch. In reality, though, Black cannot escape the checks without giving up his remaining pawns. Take a look:

- 1) 61. ... Ke8 62. Rc8+ Kd7 (62. ... Ke7 63. Rc7+ Rd7 64. Rxd7+ Kxd7 65. Kf2 Nh1+ 66. Kg2 is a draw, as in line 2) 63. Rg8! Ne2+ 64. Kf2! and Black's knight is unable to reach the magic square on f4 due to Ke3. He must settle for something like 64. ... Nc1+ 65. Ke3 Rd6 66. Rh8 hgx4 67. fxg4, when White will easily eliminate Black's remaining pawn and reach the drawn rook versus rook and knight endgame.
- 2) 61. ... Ke6 62. Rc6+ Ke5 (62. ... Rd6 63. Rxd6+ Kxd6 64. Kf2 Nh1+ 65. Kg2 is even) 63. Rxd6 Kf4 looks terribly intimidating, but is coolly rebuffed by 64. g5 Kxf3 65. Rf6+ Kg4 66. Rf2! and it is time to shake hands.
- 3) Finally, 61. ... Kf6 62. Rc6+ Kg7 63. Rc7+ leads nowhere, since 63. ... Kh6 64. g5 mate would be, shall we say, a rather sad finale.

Irina can hardly be blamed for her decision, but this analysis shows just how crucial it is to put sober calculation above general reasoning.

59. ... hgx4?

Strictly speaking, this is not a mistake, but it is the start of Jennifer's troubles. Instead, the immediate 59. ... d2 60. Rd5 Re1+ would have won on the spot. 61. Kh2 Nf1+ is curtains, while 61. Kf2—and this is the detail both players most likely overlooked—fails to the beautiful 61. ... Nh1 mate! The text move unnecessarily

The Best of the 2016 U.S. Championship

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

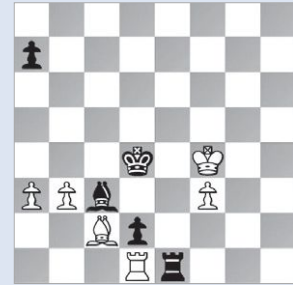
GM Fabiano Caruana (2870)
GM Alexander Onischuk (2745)
St. Louis, 04.20.2016



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

WIM Agata Bykova (2267)
WIM Ashritha Eswaran (2262)
St. Louis, 04.24.2016



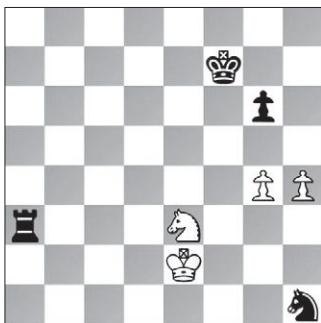
BLACK TO MOVE

gives White's king more breathing room, but it certainly does not throw away the win.

60. fxd4 d2 61. Rd5 Ne4

Many years ago, my coach GM Lev Psakhis shared a nugget of endgame wisdom that has stayed with me ever since. Psakhis observed that when one misses a simple win in the endgame, a kind of domino effect ensues in which each subsequent win becomes more and more complex, and the player—frustrated at his or her inability to finish the opponent off—continues to miss winning opportunities until his or her opponent comes up with a miraculous save.

This exact process can be observed in the current game: Jennifer was probably subconsciously aware that she had missed a straightforward win, and proceeds to lose her sense of urgency and direction. In fact, 61. ... Re1+ was still completely winning; after 62. Kf2 Nh1+ 63. Kf3 d1=Q+ 64. Rxd1 Rxd1 Black's knight will be liberated in a few moves. It is easy to be tempted to buy into appearances, but following 65. Ne3 Rd3 66. Ke2 Ra3 White can resign.

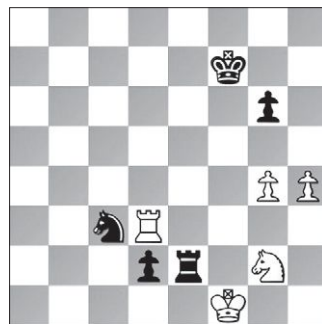


Again, one might wonder how a strong and talented player with enough time on her clock missed such a straightforward win. And the answer, in my opinion, is psychological in nature: instead of settling for a slightly murkier win, Jennifer continues to look for a clean victory, although the chance for such a victory has already passed.

62. Kf1 Ng3+ 63. Kg1 Ne4 64. Kf1 Nc3?

This does not throw away the win just yet, but it is the prelude to a tragic blunder. Of course, it was not too late to revert to the winning strategy with 64. ... Ng3+.

65. Rd3



The computer points out that the somewhat inhuman 65. ... Kf6! would have maintained excellent winning chances, since White is forced to go for 66. Ne3 Rxe3 67. Rxd2 Ne4, when I doubt that save Magnus Carlsen or Stockfish would have serious chances to salvage half a point. But Jennifer's mind is set:

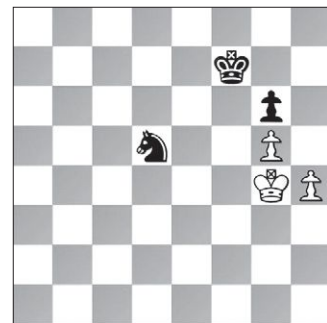
65. ... Rxd3?

As a general rule, endgames that feature two pawns against a knight and pawn are always (dangerously) close to a draw, and this case is no exception. To make any progress, Black has to "outshoulder" White's king while preventing him from trading off the last pawn, and this is way too unrealistic an order given the abysmal placement of Black's knight.

66. Kxg2 d1=Q 67. Rxd1 Nxd1 68. Kf3!

Krush kills two birds with one stone, advancing the king while forcing the hapless cavalier to take a circuitous route to the kingside. The immediate 68. g5?? would have met with 68. ... Ne3+ 69. Kf3 Nf5 70. Kg4 Ng7 and Black's knight reaches paradise in the nick of time!

68. ... Nc3 69. g5 Nd5 70. Kg4



A study-like draw if there ever was one. If Black's king were on e6, 70. ... Ne3+ would decide instantly, but now it meets with 71. Kf4 Nf5 72. h5. This might seem like a freak occurrence—and some luck is definitely at play here—but the result of the game is no coincidence. The trajectory of the game followed Psakhis's model, with the margin of error continuously shrinking until Black tempted fate one too many times.

70. ... Ne3+ 71. Kf4 Nf1 72. Kg4 Ne3+ 73. Kf4 Ng2+ 74. Kg4 Nxh4

A dollar late and a day short (yes, the words have been switched deliberately).

75. Kxh4 Ke6 76. Kg3 Ke5 77. Kf3 Kf5 78. Kg2 Kxg5 79. Kg3 Kf5 80. Kf3 g5 81. Kg3 g4 82. Kg2 Kf4, Draw agreed.

It is important to note that there is no one-to-one correlation between aesthetic and instructional value. While this endgame is no polished masterpiece, it nonetheless affords several valuable lessons to those who dare to penetrate its secrets. ♦

See more about the U.S. and U.S. Women's Championships in our cover story beginning on page 28.

In Search of Perfection

Correspondence chess can offer useful endgame lessons for over-the-board players, especially about balancing calculation and intuition.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

CORRESPONDENCE CHESS HAS LITTLE in common with over-the-board chess. Let me clarify: the rules themselves do not change. Checkmate is still checkmate. A mating attack is still a mating attack. A draw is still counted as half a point for both players. Yet the fundamental difference lies in the notion that modern correspondence chess has no distinction between the practical and the objective; they are one and the same. Chess computers are so potent, so farsighted, that the importance of intuition is minimized, and the concept of a “practically strong, but objectively questionable” move ceases to exist.

Make no mistake: I hold correspondence chess in the highest esteem. Laboring over an infinitely complex position for days—not to mention winning a game against a fellow cyborg—is no easy undertaking. However, for the purposes of *practical* chess improvement, the kind of heavily-computerized, intuition-less chess seen in modern correspondence play is of relatively little use.

But that is not always the case. Occasionally, a correspondence game can offer useful lessons for the student of over-the-board chess, particularly with respect to the proper balance between calculation and intuition. The game we are about to examine is wildly entertaining, aesthetically pleasing (to put it mildly), and—most importantly—wonderfully instructive.

A TALE OF TWO ROOKS

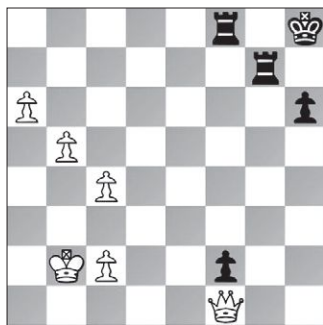
Georg Halvax (correspondence rating 2020)

Alina Ivanova

Correspondence, 2012

(see diagram top of next column)

At first glance, the outcome seems to be decided. Despite his impressive pawn armada, there is no way to stop ... Rg1 followed by ... f1=Q, when Black will have two extra rooks. White can stave off defeat with 48. a7, but after 48 ... Rxa7 and 49 ... Rg7 White is back to



WHITE TO MOVE

square one. By this point, faithful readers of my column should be well aware that connected passed pawns often possess superpowers, especially when they are a few squares away from promotion. Though resigning seems like an option, why not make your opponent sweat first?

48. b6 Rg1 49. Qxf2 Rxf2

In only three moves, the landscape has undergone a dramatic shift. Black is two—yes, two—rooks to the good, but they are currently far removed from the back rank. White must seize his opportunity, but which pawn should he advance? At this point, I encourage you to set this position up on a real board (if you haven't already done so), put down the magazine (or close your laptop), and calculate as much as you can.

50. b7!

Why this one? Before we analyze the dickens out of this position, it is worth making two general observations about endgame calculation:

1) Even in unconventional endgames, it is frequently easier to calculate long variations simply because there is less material left on the board. This means that the board is easier to visualize and that lines have less potential to branch off.

2) When passed pawns are involved, the difference between similar-looking moves is

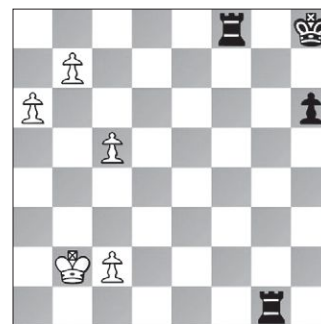
often great. To this end, you should never assume that two moves that have the same goal will lead to the same result; calculate each one separately.

With these observations in mind, ascertaining the difference between 50. b7 and 50. a7 becomes a matter of sober calculation. Following 50. a7?? Rg8, Black will give up one of his rooks to destroy White's pawn armada:

- 1) 51. b7 looks tempting, but is coolly rebuffed by 51. ... Rff8 52. c5 Ra8! 53. bxa8=Q (No better is 53. c6 Rxa7) 53. ... Rxa8 and Black wins.
- 2) 51. c5 is a better try, but Black wins with 51. ... Rf7!. With the pawn on b7, as in the game, 52. c6 would come to the rescue, but now Black has 52. ... Rxa7! 53. bxa7 h6 and the game is over.

While the position after Black's 49th move looks daunting indeed, it is actually quite easy to work through the complications and find the right sequence of pawn advances.

50. ... Rf8 51. c5!



Now, of course, 51. ... Rg7 is no longer effective on account of 52. c6 and 52. ... Rxb7+ 53. cxb7 is of no use. Therefore, Black has no choice but to push his own passer and hope to win the race. And with two extra rooks, it looks like he is poised to do just that.

51. ... h5

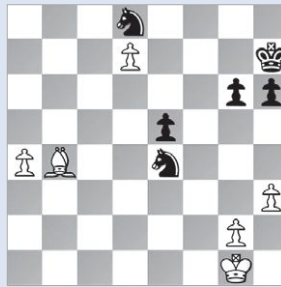
Calculate!

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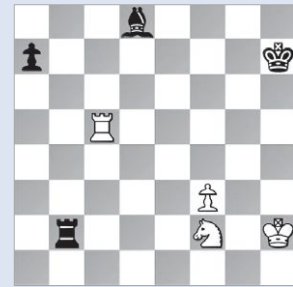
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2633)
GM Dmitry Jakovenko (2742)
Tsakhkadzor, 2015



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Evgeny Somov-Nasimovich
Study, 1936



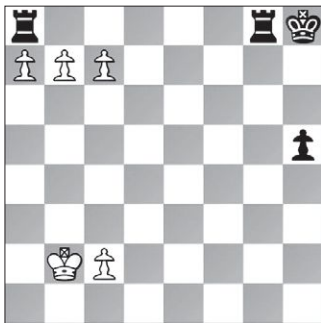
WHITE TO MOVE

The continuation 51. ... Rgg8 52. c6 Rb8 53. c7 h5 54. cxb8=Q Rxb8 sets a prosaic trap (55. a7?? Rxb7+) that is easily sidestepped with 55. Ka3! followed by a6-a7.

52. a7 Rgg8 53. c6 Ra8!

This is the only way to keep the game going. After 53. ... h4 54. c7 h3 55. b8=Q h2 56. a8=Q, White promotes a second queen and simultaneously stops Black's passer.

54. c7!



This position merits four diagrams, but in the interest of space I will limit myself to one. Black's towers are optimally placed, but they are utterly defenseless against the march of White's pawns. While the game is not over yet, the rest is a matter of straightforward technique.

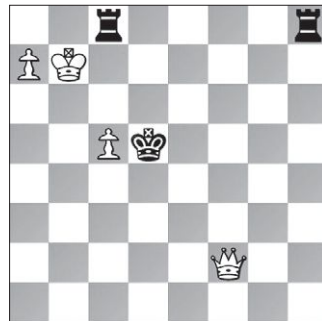
54. ... Kg7 55. b8=Q h4 56. Kc3

White's plan is very simple: the threat of marching his king to b7 will force Black to push his h-pawn. As soon as the pawn reaches h2, White will promote the c-pawn, and trade the newly-created queen for Black's passer. Following that trade-off, Black will be permanently consigned to passivity and White will gradually advance the second c-pawn until a tactical opportunity presents itself.

56. ... h3 57. Kc4 Kf6 58. Kb5 Kf5 59. Ka6 h2

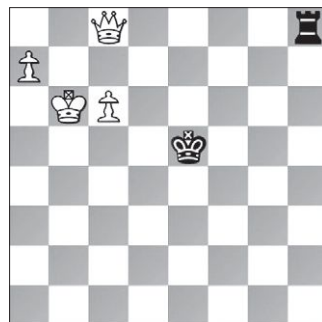
Black has no other choice: something like 59. ... Kg4 60. Kb7 offered little relief.

60. c8=Q+ Rxc8 61. Qxh2 Rh8 62. Qf2+ Ke4 63. c4 Rac8 64. c5 Kd5 65. Kb7!



Black's main problem is that the rooks cannot leave the eighth rank under any circumstances. To this end, 65. ... Rxc5—hoping for the hasty 66. a8=Q?!, which reaches a theoretically winning endgame queen versus rook ending but offers Black some hopes of a resistance—would meet a rather harsh punishment in the form of 66. Qf6!, and Black must allow the second pawn to promote.

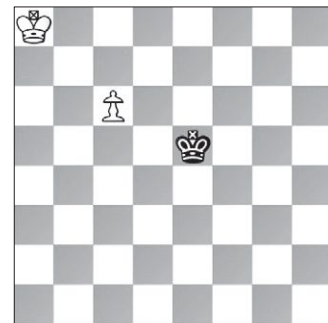
65. ... Rcf8 66. Qc2 Rf7+ 67. Kb6 Rff8 68. c6 Rc8 69. Qf5+ Kd6 70. Qd7+ Ke5 71. Qxc8!



The simplest. In a non-correspondence game, I would have preferred to minimize the risk with 71. c7 (and only then Qxc8), but with

more than a day to double, triple, and quadruple-check all of the possible defenses, why not have a laugh at your opponent's expense?

71. ... Rxc8 72. Kb7 Rh8 73. a8=Q Rxa8 74. Kxa8



It is hard to say why Black played until mate, but I have observed this tendency in many correspondence games. Perhaps Black was hoping for some sort of failure to submit a move in a timely fashion? In any case, Ivanova was all out of luck, and Halvax—a strong over-the-board player as well—demonstrated a unique ability to deliver checkmate with king and queen against king.

74. ... Kd6 75. Kb7 Ke7 76. c7 Kd7 77. c8=Q+ Ke7 78. Qc6 Kf7 79. Qh6 Ke7 80. Kc6 Kf7 81. Kd6 Kg8 82. Ke5 Kf7 83. Qh7+ Kf8 84. Ke6 Ke8 85. Qe7 mate.

Looking back at the starting position, it is rather difficult to predict that the game would develop in such an orderly, easy-to-follow manner. Yet its surprising trajectory is yet another reminder that the endgame often resembles a peaceful forest rather than an unconquerable safari. Don't always treat it like the latter!♠

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Happy Birthday, *Chess Life*!

Looking back at the 1946 U.S. Championship held during *Chess Life's* inaugural year.

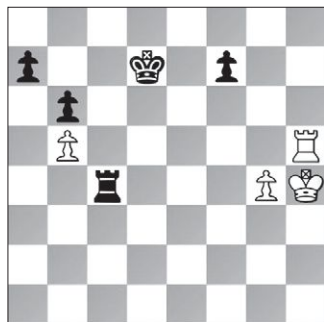
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE 70TH ANNIVERSARY OF *CHES LIFE* magazine is upon us. The United States of America has survived 10 and three score years of ordeals. From the Korean War, to the Vietnam War, to the Iranian hostage crisis, to the tragic events of 9/11, to the financial crisis of 2007-08, to a tumultuous election that will take this country to directions to unknown and unpredictable, this country has seen it all. And how fitting that the most widely circulated chess magazine in the world—a treasure trove of eloquent writing, instructive material, and brilliant reporting—has withstood the trials and tribulations of the past 70 years. May it continue to do so for another 70!

In honor of this great moment in chess history, I would like to examine two fascinating endgame encounters that were played in the 1946 U.S. Championship, held in New York City—an event, place and time that (I hope) require little explanation. Though relatively unknown, both games feature the kind of resourcefulness, fighting spirit, and entertainment value that have set American chess apart for more than a century.

A DEADLY TANGO

Gustave Drexel
Israel Horowitz
U.S. Championship, New York, 1946



AFTER 49. Kh4

Let us start with a few simple observations. Black is up a pawn, but the nature of the

position seems to render his material advantage meaningless. White has an active king, and by means of a simple regrouping—Kg3 followed by Rh1-a1—he can pare down the remaining material and reach a drawn theoretical ending. Black has no time to waste: something along the lines of 49. ... Rb4? enables White to carry out his plan. For instance, after 50. Kg3 Ke7 51. Re5+ Kd6 52. Rf5 Ke6 53. Rh5 and there is no way to make progress.

When your opponent is close to securing a draw, it often pays to look for a (preferably forced) way to alter the nature of the position. In a rook ending, this can be done with a trade. Had Black's rook stood on any other file, Mr. Drexel would have probably dined at Delmonico's that night, ecstatic about holding one of the strongest players in America to a draw. As it stands, Black has a golden opportunity that radically transforms the course of the game. Do you see it?

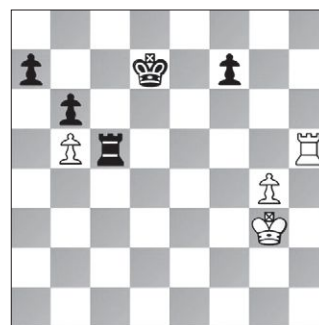
49. ... Rc5!

This is not a difficult move to see, but such committal decisions should be accompanied by careful consideration. Furthermore, it does not win the game immediately. Drexel's predicament is a thorny one: 50. Rxc5 bxc5 is suicide, while the counterattacking 50. Rh7 loses to 50. ... Ke6, and Black picks up the pawn (51. Rh6+ Ke7 offers no relief). But Drexel picks up on a fascinating tactical quirk: Black is not actually threatening anything, since ... Rxh5+ allows gxh5, establishing an outside passer that guarantees White at least a draw. Note that the b5-pawn does an impeccable job of freezing Black's queenside pawns. Hence:

50. Kg3!

(See diagram top of next column)

The beginning of an amusing king-and-rook tango in which both players demonstrate enviable tenacity and resourcefulness. As we have established, the naïve 50. ... Rxh5?? actually loses after 51. gxh5 Ke6 52. Kg4 Kf6 53. Kf4



Kg7 54. Kg5 and Black can resign. But Horowitz notices a reciprocal pattern: it is now *White* who does not threaten anything! The rook is still immobilized, so all he can do is move his king around. Since White's monarch cannot travel past the fourth rank, what is stopping his vis-à-vis from embarking on a leisurely voyage to g6?

50. ... Ke6!

Why, nothing at all! Though nothing extraordinary has transpired, it is hard to deny that this position (and subsequent cat-and-mouse game) is aesthetically pleasing in a rather unique way. The rooks are tied down to their respective posts, and it is up to the monarchs to decide the game.

51. Kf4 Kf6

The moment of reckoning has been reached. Black's threat is dreadfully straightforward; 52. Ke4 is met by 52. ... Kg6, and White is not in time after 53. Rxc5 bxc5 54. Kd5 Kg5 55. Kxc5 Kxg4. I'll stop here: skeptics can play out the rest of the game themselves!

A lesser mortal might have raised the white flag here, but Drexel has one more ingenious trick up his sleeve.

52. Rf5+!

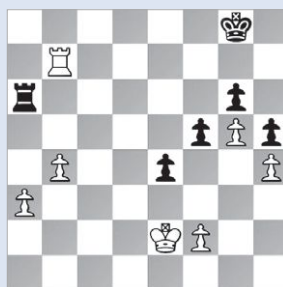
The temptation to capture on f5 must have been great. After all, how many endgames a clear pawn up are not winning? But this is just

Easy Does It!

For this month's column, I tried to pick two games that are somewhat less sinuous than our usual fare. This is a deliberate choice. After all, we have a birthday party to attend, and it is time to get dressed! Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating. *See the solutions on page 71.*

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

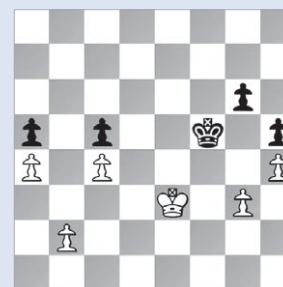
Anthony Santasiere
Stefan Kowalski
U.S. Champ., New York, 1946



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

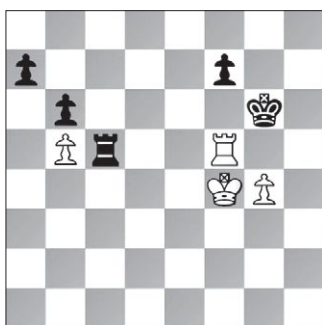
Sol Rubinow
Olaf Ulvestad
U.S. Champ., New York, 1946



BLACK TO MOVE

such an exception: following 52. ... Rxf5+? 53. gxf5, and draws. White suddenly claims the opposition and his far-advanced f-pawn immobilizes Black's king.

52. ... Kg6!!



The clincher! As it turns out, White's clever check has done nothing to stop Black's main idea, and now White is all out of tricks. He is still not in time to take on c5, and there is no way to maintain the opposition. And yet, Drexel continues to fight until the last drop, forcing Horowitz to demonstrate filigree accuracy until the scoresheets are signed.

53. Ke4 Rxf5! 54. gxf5+ Kg5 55. Ke5 Kg4

This is the classic "outshouldering" procedure that has been outlined in countless books. As soon as the f-pawns are liquidated—and White cannot do anything about it—Black's queenside majority will prove lethal.

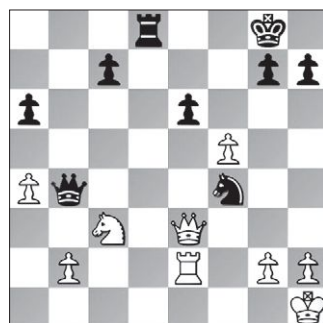
56. Ke4 f6 57. Kd4 Kxf5 58. Kd5 Kg4, White resigned.

The "race" is a rather lopsided one: 59. Kc6 f5 60. Kb7 f4 61. Kxa7 f3 and that is all she wrote.

Now, let this monarchic tango be balanced by a cute petite combination. The author: IM Herman Steiner. And the victim? Well, you live by the sword, you die by the sword ...

THE TAMING OF THE BACK RANK

Israel Horowitz
Herman Steiner
U.S. Championship, New York, 1946



AFTER 29. ... Rxd8

We join the battle in an exceptionally complex middlegame position that is somewhat beyond the scope of this column. Horowitz, presumably in time pressure, fails to notice a hidden tactical resource and stumbles:

30. Rf2?

Though it is hard to believe, this innocuous retreat is in fact the decisive mistake. The situation was delicate, and White's only path to a draw was 30. Rd2!, forcing the trade of rooks. Following 30. ... Rxd2 31. Qxd2 exf5 Black is a pawn up, but White forces a perpetual with 32. Qd7 g6 (Just plain awful is 32. ... Qxb2?? 33. Qe8 mate) 33. Qxc7 Qxb2 34. Qc4+ Kg7 35. Qd4+ and Black cannot go to h6, since White will pick up the knight with check.

30. ... Qxc3!

Boom shaka-laka! This is a pure example of what I like to call a "liquidational" combination: it does not win on the spot, but it transforms the game to a winning endgame. My guess is that Horowitz simply overlooked this tactic. Capturing on c3 obviously allows a back-rank checkmate, so White's options are severely limited.

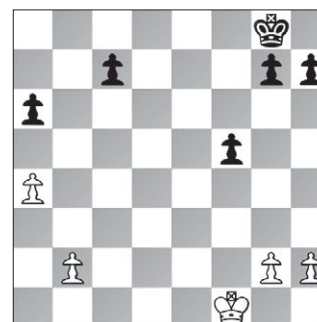
31. Qxf4

Not one to rest on his laurels, Steiner strikes while the iron is hot (at this point, I would encourage you to lay the magazine aside and try to work out the winning line on your own):

31. ... Qe1+ 32. Rf1 Rd1!

White's back-rank woes continue. He is not out of defensive resources quite yet, but the denouement is approaching.

33. Kg1 Qxf1+! 34. Qxf1 Rxf1+ 35. Kxf1 exf5



And there it is: the end of Black's five-move combination. As long as he prevents White from miraculously creating a passed pawn on the queenside, the ending will be a matter of straightforward technique.

36. Ke2 Kf7 37. Kd3 Ke6 38. Kc4 g5!?

Black's pawn majority is overwhelming.

39. b4 c6 40. Kc5 Kd7 41. Kb6 f4!

The point: 42. Kxa6 g4 is curtains, so White is forced to return.

42. Kc5 g4 43. Kd4 Kd6 44. Ke4 f3!

The last finesse. Black temporarily sacrifices the pride of his position to draw White's king away from the newly-exposed queenside.

45. gxf3 gxf3 46. Kxf3 Kd5, White resigned. ♠

No Pain, No ~~Gain~~ Draw

Decisions, decisions. Sometimes you just have to take the plunge.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

I HAVE YET TO MEET A HUMAN BEING, much less a chess player, who likes to make decisions. In fact, I don't remember the last time I ate in a restaurant and was truly satisfied with the dish I chose. Even if the Spaghetti Bolognese was very tasty, a part of me will regret not ordering the famous Pizza alla Diavola, while a second part of me will regret choosing this overpriced pizzeria over the cheap Thai place around the corner. Then, a third part of me will tell my second and first parts that I'm at a tournament, and that I'm here to play good chess and not to digest.

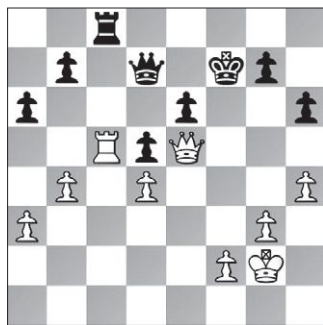
Analogous decision-making problems befall every chess player throughout each game. Should I trade bishops here? Swap queens there? Should I sacrifice an Exchange for an attack? Is that pawn really hanging, or does my opponent have something up his sleeve? Most experienced players have more or less come to terms with the fact that one cannot make decisions with 100 percent accuracy, **yet we all suffer from a tendency to put off important decisions because of our fear of being wrong.** In the endgame, when each decision has the potential to decide the outcome, this tendency is particularly evident. In this month's column, we will examine one of my recent endgames in which I grappled with this exact problem.

DECISIONS

IM Rasmus Svane (FIDE 2549, GER)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (FIDE 2634, USA),
Xtracon Chess Open, Elsinore, Denmark,
07.31.2016

(see diagram top of next column)

This game was played in the all-important last round of the Xtracon (formerly Politiken) Open in Denmark. Having mixed up my preparation (as usual), I landed in trouble straight out of the opening and my talented opponent kept up the pressure all the way to a

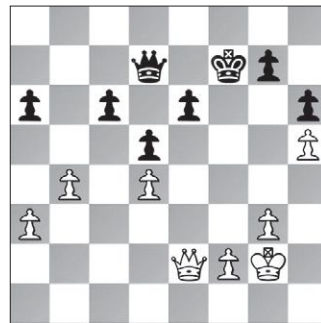


AFTER 30. h4

heavy piece ending. White has a massive space advantage, impeccable pawn structure and piece coordination, and Black is saddled with a permanent weakness on e6. I had long since abandoned my hopes of winning the game, but it is clear that the limited material should give Black excellent drawing chances. It quickly dawned on me that I had three equally tempting candidate moves: 30. ... Rxc5, leading to an unpleasant but possibly drawn queen ending; 30. ... b6, trying to force a queen ending on my own terms but allowing an annoying queen infiltration after 31. Rxc8 Qxc8 32. Qd6; and 30. ... Rc6, simply maintaining the status quo.

When faced with a decision of this magnitude, it is infinitely tempting to choose the path that seems to entail the least risk; in this case, it is to pass the turn with 30. ... Rc6. But the key word here is "seems". **Indeed, players often choose to keep the status quo rather than alter the position in their favor because they are afraid of exacerbating the situation.** To make a (rather cringeworthy) analogy, players often choose the equivalent of passing the basketball to an opposing player because they are afraid of missing the shot. In the same vein, 30. ... Rc6 gives White a perfect opportunity to improve his position and prevent Black from reaching a slightly worse queen ending. After 31. Qh5+ Kg8 32. Qe2! White repositions his queen to a more favorable location. Now, 32. ... b6 is no longer possible (the a6-pawn hangs after

33. Rxc6 Qxc6) and White has the positional threat of intensifying the c-file pressure with Qc2. For instance, 32. ... Kf7 33. h5 Kg8 34. Qc2 Kf7 (34. ... Rxc5 35. bxc5 might be better, but White reaches a favorable version of the endgame after 30. ... Rxc5 31. bxc5 [see below] which itself isn't too appetizing for Black) 35. Rxc6 bxc6 36. Qe2! and Black is in trouble.



His queen will be tied down to the a6-pawn, and White's plan is to slowly (or not-so-slowly) advance his kingside pawns. I don't doubt that a computer can draw this position, but from a human perspective, White's winning chances are excellent.

Having avoided this psychological trap by soberly calculating 30. ... Rc6, I moved on to assessing the other two options. My inclination was to play 30. ... Rxc5 31. bxc5 Qc6, intending to liquidate with ... b6. I felt a brief urge to go with my gut, but cooler heads prevailed: after 32. Qf4+ Ke7 33. h5 it transpires that 33. ... b6 is harshly punished by 34. Qb8! bxc5 35. Qg8!, and the queen will devour the kingside and guide the h-pawn to glory. And 35. ... Kf6?? would only make matters worse after 36. Qf8+ Kg5 37. Qxg7+ Kxh5 38. Kh3, and *c'est fini*.

That left 30. ... b6, an option which I had initially rejected due to 31. Rxc8 Qxc8 32. Qd6. This brings us to the second key quality of good decision-makers: **since endgames tend to be so concrete, your intuition is often plain wrong. While you should not disregard**

Breakthrough!

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

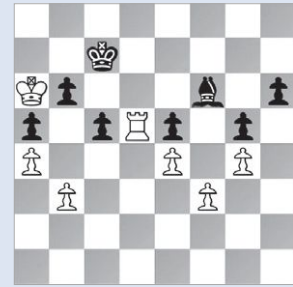
GM Boris Gelfand (2718)
GM Michael Adams (2746)
London Classic Rapid, 12.15.2013



WHITE TO MOVE

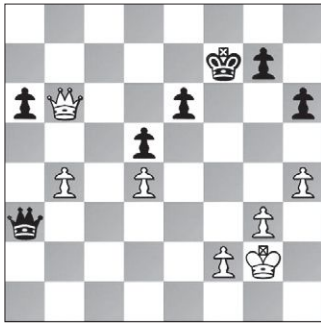
PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2628)
IM Siva Mahadevan (2400)
Qatar Masters, 12.20.2015



WHITE TO MOVE

your instinct entirely, make sure that it is supplemented by cold-blooded calculation. Once I realized that the world does not necessarily end with 32. Qd6, I discovered a golden opportunity: with Black's king protecting the kingside, Black has a chance to mobilize his queen with 32. ... Qc3, intending to meet 33. Qxb6 with 33. ... Qxa3.



Unlike the kind of positions we saw after 30. ... Rc6 and 30. ... Rxc5, here White has no more positional advantage, so it is simply a matter of determining whether or not White has any concrete refutation. The answer, as I was all too happy to discover, is no.

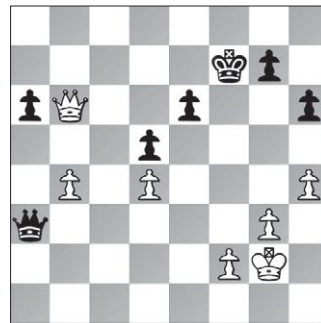
30. ... b6!

Played after around seven minutes of thought, around half of which were spent evaluating the position after 33. ... Qxa3. It is a misconception that you have to spend at least 15 minutes on a critical moment: if you are disciplined, methodical, and focused, it is not necessary to triple and quadruple-check your conclusions. With around 15 minutes left for 10 moves, I wanted to make sure that I had enough time to deal with any surprises.

31. Rxc8 Qxc8 32. Qd6

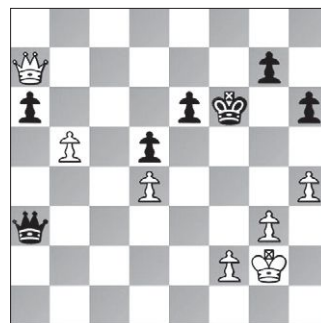
White has no other choice: if he bides his time with 32. h5, Black consolidates with 32. ... Qc2!

32. ... Qc3 33. Qxb6 Qxa3



And so we've reached the position from my calculation. At first, I was worried about the prospect of the queen wreaking havoc on my exposed monarch, but there is simply nothing to fear: after 34. Qc7+ Kf8 35. Qd8+ Kf7 36. Qd7+ Kf6 White's "attack" runs out of steam, and the queen must attend to the b4-pawn. However, my opponent had one more attempt to make progress in his arsenal:

34. Qc7+ Kf8 35. Qb8+ Kf7 36. Qa7+ Kf6 37. b5!



This looks devastating, but—once again—it is important to look past appearances and focus on a move's true nature. While Black has no way to stop the pawn from running, White is so embroiled in his tactical shenanigans that he has entirely abandoned his own king. And as we know, the queen is very skilled indeed at delivering perpetual check. I had foreseen this trick when evaluating 30. ... b6, and it is not

too hard to see the path to a draw:

37. ... Qd3! 38. bxa6

The other continuation, 38. Qxa6 Qe4+, changes nothing.

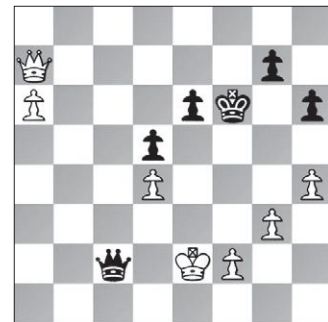
38. ... Qe4+

For some reason, the black queen reminds me of Andy Dufresne in *The Shawshank Redemption* ("freedom at last ..."), while the king resembles Samuel Norton, the warden (if you haven't seen this movie, watch it and then come back to the article).

39. Kg1

Another way to repeat was 39. Kh2 Qe2 40. Kg2 Qe4+.

39. ... Qe1+ 40. Kg2 Qe4+ 41. Kf1 Qb1+ 42. Ke2 Qc2+ 43. Kf1 Qb1+ 44. Ke2 Qc2+ 45. Ke3 Qc3+ 46. Ke2 Qc2+, Draw agreed.



As beginners, we are often sagely advised to go with our gut or stick to our first instinct. While this might be worth following in real life, the endgame has its own rules. To successfully crack a thorny dilemma, you must find the right balance between intuition and calculation, and—most importantly—you must avoid the illusion that it is better to do nothing than to risk worsening the position. As a famous Russian proverb goes, "those who do not risk do not drink champagne!" ♠

See more from Naroditsky in "Counterplay" on page 6.

Going Against the Flow

When you find yourself in a losing endgame, you must look for defensive resources until the bitter end.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IN LIFE, WE ARE OFTEN TOLD TO “GO with the flow” or “roll with the punches,” to accept the circumstances as they are. On the chessboard, we often unwittingly follow the same advice. When faced with near-imminent defeat, many players assume that they cannot change the course of the game, and they put up an anemic resistance aimed toward prolonging the game rather than contesting the result.

The allure of going with the flow is amplified a hundredfold in the endgame. After a long and arduous battle that has not gone your way, it is tempting to say “this one just didn’t work out for me” and shuffle your pieces a few times before resigning. We’ve all had those games in which we give up hope but continue to push wood in order to build up an illusion of tenacity.

This month we examine a fascinating endgame in which one of the strongest endgame players in history—as well as several eminent annotators—were guilty of going with the flow. Had Anatoly Karpov found the inner strength to ignore his position’s hopeless appearance and actively search for defense resources, he could have ... well, I won’t spoil it for you. Read on!

NO WAY? YES WAY!

GM Anatoly Karpov (2725)

GM Viswanathan Anand (2635)

Linares, 1991



AFTER 35. Qd2

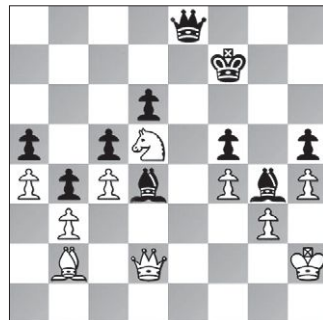
It has not been Karpov’s best day. After an off-kilter opening, he fell under massive

positional pressure and has stumbled his way into a rather one-sided endgame. With his next move, Anand seemingly pushes White’s last finger from the precipice:

35. ... Bf3

In *Mastering Complex Endgames (MCE)* I called this “a terrific move which pushes the annoying knight back.” That is indeed the purpose it fulfils, because 36. Bb2 now fails to 36. ... Qh8! (36. ... Bxb2 37. Qxb2 Bxd5 38. cxd5 Qe8 as I gave in *MCE* is less accurate due to 39. Kg2! Qe4+ 40. Kf2 Qxd5 41. Qe2 and Black’s vulnerable king affords White drawing chances) 37. Bxg7 Qxg7, and White is helpless against the oncoming invasion of Black’s queen. For instance, following 38. Qf2 Be4 39. Qe2 Kg6! Black calmly secures all the bases and will infiltrate to d4 or a1 with decisive effect.

In spite of its logical appearance, however, 35. ... Bf3 is actually a grave error that makes possible a stunning turnaround. Though one cannot even begin to blame Anand for not calculating all the way through, it is worth mentioning that 35. ... Qe8! was the only way to win the game. The tactical justification of this move is that 36. Bb2, White’s only feasible continuation (36. Ne3 Bd4 37. Nc2 Bc3 followed by ... Qe4 is curtains), loses to the admittedly “Stockfish-esque” 36. ... Bd4!!



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 36. ... Bd4!!

It transpires that Black’s idea is not to deliver checkmate, but to force White into a losing

knight versus bishop ending: 37. Bxd4 cxd4 38. Qxd4 Qe2+ 39. Kg1 Qd1+! 40. Qxd1 Bxd1 and the bishop impales the entire queenside. This is not the most human of lines, but it is beautiful nonetheless. To see a sequence of this sort during a game, it is important to keep an open mind. Just because Black’s queen is better placed than its vis-à-vis, you should not automatically rule out variations in which the queens are traded. Remember: in the endgame, concrete considerations always transcend general principles.

36. Ne3 Be4

Now, the bishop is ideally placed and everything is in place for the decisive invasion. Or is it?

37. Bb2 Bxb2 38. Qxb2 Qf6!

When I selected this game for *MCE*, I was intending it to be a demonstration of the power of the queen-and-bishop tandem. The annotations I had consulted—GM Zoltan Ribli in MegaBase and Steve Mayer in his excellent work *Bishop v. Knight: The Verdict*—as well as the course of the game led me to believe that the rest requires little explanation. All of us, including Karpov himself, were making the mistake of going with the flow, assuming that White has nothing left to play for. Before stopping the clocks, Karpov made a few perfunctory gestures of resistance:

39. Qxf6+

This seems forced, since withdrawing the queen will allow Black’s own queen to plant itself on d4 or c3.

39. ... Kxf6 40. Kg1 Bb1!

A devastating maneuver. The bishop worms its way to a2, tying down White’s knight and paving the way for a decisive queenside breakthrough.

41. Nf1 Bc2 42. Nd2 Ke6 43. Kf2 d5 44. cxd5+ Kxd5 45. Ke3 Bd1!

Punching Back!

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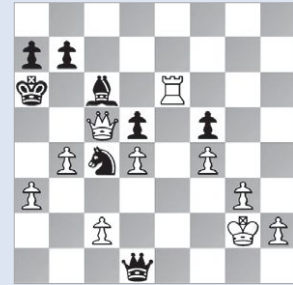
GM Julio Granda Zuniga (2652)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2622)
Benasque, 07.09.2015



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Viktor Korchnoi (2655)
GM Rafael Vaganian (2585)
Skelleftea, 1989



BLACK TO MOVE

The last finesse. 45. ... c4 was winning, but it gave White some hope after 46. Nxc4 Bxb3 47. Nxa5. 45. ... Bd1 places White in *Zugzwang*.

46. Kd3 Bxb3, White resigned.

For obvious reasons, the pawn endgame after 47. Nxb3 c4+ offers White little hope.

Let us now return to the position after 38. ... Qf6:



Perhaps the only solace one can take in defending so dismal a position is that one has nothing to lose! This is the essence of going against the flow: having accepted your likely fate, you nonetheless strive to make life as difficult as possible for your opponent.

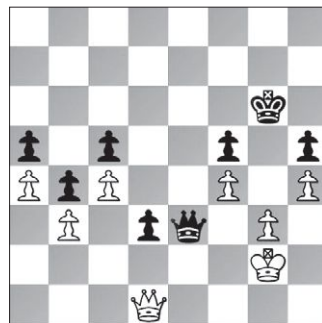
With that in mind, it makes sense to keep the queens on the board: this is best achieved by 39. Qe2, gaining a tempo by attacking h5. After 39. ... Kg6, White continues 40. Nd1!, maneuvering the horse to f2 and contesting the bishop's dominance (there's some Clinton-Trump going on between the knight and bishop—and that is my last election joke). Black has no way to directly access White's queenside, so he must break through with 40. ... d5 before White completes his regrouping. Following 41. Nf2 Qd4 (41. ... dxc4?! hoping for 42. Nxe4?? Qe6! leads nowhere after 42. Qxc4) 42. Nxe4, Black can recapture the bishop three different ways:

- A) 42. ... fxe4?! leaves Black with a queenside superiority, but after the straightforward

43. cxd5 Qxd5 44. Qa6+ Kf5 45. Qc8+! the king is unable to escape the queen's clutches.

- B) 42. ... dxe4?! also fails to impress. Following 43. Kg2 Qc3 44. Qd1 Black is unable to make any progress due to the constant threat of perpetual along the d-file.

- C) 42. ... Qxe4! This, and only this. The idea of this recapture is that 43. Qxe4 is met not with 43. ... dxe4, when White has a fortress, but with 43. ... fxe4!, and the pawns break through after 44. cxd5 c4. White must decline the trade with 43. Qd1 (hoping for 43. ... dxc4? 44. Qd6+), but after 43. ... d4 it looks like his days are numbered. With the passed pawn on the d-file, Black does not have to worry about perpetual and he can simply push the pawn until White runs out of board space. The most likely continuation is 44. Kg1 Qe3+ 45. Kg2 d3 (Diagram), when resigning is an enticing option.



White is totally paralyzed. Moving the queen along the first rank allows ... d2, while 46. Qf3 loses to the pretty 46. ... Qe4!. Of course, White cannot move his king because it is tied down to the g3-pawn. When annotating this game for MCE, I was about to move on when I noticed something.

First of all, I was going with the flow. I was assuming that the king cannot move without

actually calculating any variations. But take a good, hard look at the position after 46. Kf1 Qxg3. White's kingside is no more, but—yeah, that's right—his king is stalemated. Black has pushed White off the board to the point where he literally has no more squares. This makes possible a fantastic, study-like blow that one rarely has the chance to execute in an actual game: 47. Qxh5+!! I will not mar the beauty of this move with excessive commentary; you can verify everything for yourself. Suffice it to say that 47. ... Kxh5 is stalemate, while moving the king allows 48. Qg5+, when the tables actually turn in White's favor. Even more impressively, Black can do nothing to halt this mechanism. 46. ... d2 allows 47. Qe2, intending a familiar perpetual along the e-file, whereas moving the queen from e3 is met by 47. Kf2, when the king has more than enough breathing room. In a twist of irony, Black's king is the one responsible for his downfall. In fact, the drawing line starting from 39. Qe2 is virtually forced. It is seldom that the evaluation of such a complex position hinges on a single freak tactical resource, but that is indeed the case here. Simply amazing.

The purpose of this column is not to blame Karpov for failing to discover this resource. Perhaps he would have played 39. Qe2 on a better day, but that is beside the point. Rather, it is to emphasize that “not giving up” does not mean “making a few more moves before resigning.” Not giving up means actively looking for chances even in the bleakest of circumstances. If you bring this attitude to the board day in and day out, Caissa might smile on you one day. ♠

Note: This game is also featured in my book Mastering Complex Endgames (MCE). I occasionally refer to my earlier notes, but these annotations are entirely new and updated.

Stoicism

“If you are distressed by anything external, the pain is not due to the thing itself, but to your estimate of it; and this you have the power to revoke at any moment.” ~Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

NBC'S *THE BLACKLIST*, STARRING JAMES Spader and Megan Boone, is the latest victim of my incessant nighttime binge-watching. At the start of the show, high-profile criminal Raymond Reddington (Spader) strolls into FBI headquarters, his hands in the air and his face twisted into a smirk. In exchange for immunity and protection, Reddington begins to reveal the identities and whereabouts of ghastly criminals with whom he had interacted in the past. *The Blacklist* is an exceptionally well-produced show, and I highly recommend it to my faithful readers.

What fascinates me most about the show is Reddington's personality and behavior. He is repeatedly shot (at), threatened, beaten, tortured, blackmailed, abandoned, yelled at, called all manner of adjectives, and yet he remains stoic throughout. The things he says—voice perfectly level—with eight guns pointed at his arched eyebrows, give his persona a subtlety and likability rarely seen in Hollywood.

On the chessboard, and especially in the endgame, we must strive to emulate this stoicism. Like Reddington, we are constantly faced with unpleasant surprises. Yet it is the mark of a strong player to take these misfortunes in stride, and to fight as if everything is perfectly normal. This month, I show one of my own games from more than a decade ago—a game in which I was able to push aside my negative emotions and roar back from a miserable situation.

THE AURELIUS VARIATION

Weston Leavens (1681)

Daniel Naroditsky (1875)

Spring Tuesday Night Marathon (7), San Francisco, 05.10.2005

(see diagram top of next column)

This position arose after only 12 moves. In a Smith-Morra, I made the inexcusable mistake of weakening my d6-square with ... e7-e6. This transgression was swiftly punished, and I am



AFTER 12. Nxa8

down an entire rook with the queens off the board. Time to resign? Well, would Raymond Reddington resign?

12. ... Nxe4

Take what you can get. I was not exactly in the mood for pawn-hunting, but allowing e4-e5 would be a death sentence. The cheeky 12. ... b5, intending to corner the entrapped knight with 13. ... Bb7 (12. ... b6 would allow 13. Bf4), meets a ghastly refutation in 13. Bxb5 Bb7 14. Ne5! Rf8 15. Rd1 and the knight gladly sacrifices itself for the greater good. Black is crushed.

13. Bf4

Logical and strong. If White can extricate his knight from a8, the game is immediately over. To extend the game, Black must try his very best to stop this from happening.

13. ... f6!?

The computer frowns upon this move, but from a practical perspective it is certainly the way to go. White cannot immediately extricate his knight due to 14. ... e5, so he must think of a more creative way to keep the cavalier safe.

14. Bc7+?!

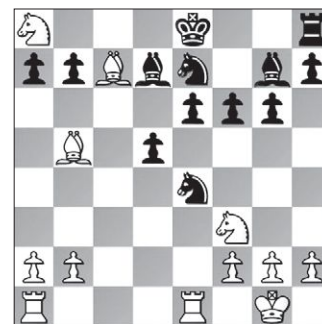
White's intentions are obvious: by driving the king to e8, White will have the later possibility of evacuating the knight with check. While this move keeps a decisive advantage,

the temporarily awkward placement of the bishop will soon turn into White's greatest nightmare. The simplest path to victory was rather anticlimactic: 14. Rfe1 d5 15. Rad1!, threatening Rxe4 and inducing further concessions. 15. ... Ke8 meets with 16. Nc7+, while the more natural 15. ... Bd7 is crushed by 16. Rxe4! dxe4 17. Bxe6, a detail that my opponent probably overlooked.

14. ... Ke8 15. Rfe1 d5

Looking back on this game, I am reminded of something that Magnus Carlsen shared after he pulled off a miracle defeat of Hikaru Nakamura at the 2014 Zurich Chess Challenge: “That’s what it’s about, keeping the game one move longer.” This quote captures the essence of defense: rather than looking toward the (bleak) future, focus on making life as hard as possible for your opponent in the current moment.

16. Bb5+ Bd7



This move met with an exasperated gasp by my opponent, who was apparently expecting/hoping for 16. ... Kf7. White has not made any objective errors, but the path to victory now resembles a mountainous highway with many hairpin turns rather than a freeway.

17. Bd3??

A classic example of losing the thread. My opponent saw the immediate danger—17. Bxd7+? Kxd7 and the knight is trapped—but

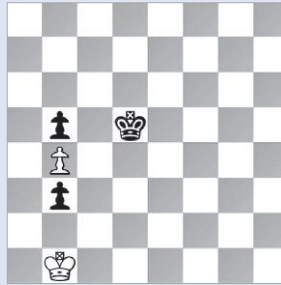
One Move Longer

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 69.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

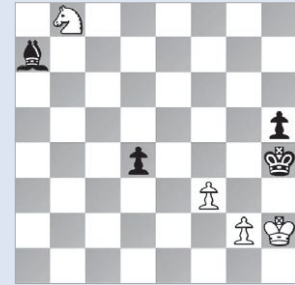
Frederick Yates
Savielly Tartakower
Bad Homburg, 1927



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Alexei Troitzky
Study



WHITE TO MOVE

he did not pay attention to Black's other threat. After the knight is captured, White's advantage will be reduced nearly to rubble. The elegant 17. Bf4! was the only way to keep the knight on the board. Black simply has nothing better than 17. ... Bxb5 18. Nc7+ (the point!) 18. ... Kf7 19. Nxb5 a6 20. Nd6+ and although some technique is still required, White is, after all, a full rook ahead.

17. ... Kf7! 18. Bxe4?!

Reeling from the turn of events, my opponent begins to drift, and even though he is nowhere near worse, the momentum shifts entirely in my favor. The sober 18. Nb6! would have kept some advantage after 18. ... axb6 19. Bxb6 Rc8 20. Rac1, though with such an impressive center Black has excellent chances to hold.

18. ... dxe4 19. Rxe4 Rxa8

This is a good moment to discuss the second main lesson that this game imparts. When the game has taken a sudden turn in your favor, it is crucial to recognize that your demoralized opponent is prone to continue blundering. Do not be satisfied with the status quo, and certainly do not be fixated on the objective evaluation. Even though this position is about equal, I wouldn't have even considered taking a draw or bailing out.

20. Rb4 Nd5!



No concessions! The insipid 20. ... b6 would have enabled White to trade rooks with 21. Rd4 Bc6 22. Rd8, while the text move forces the tower back onto an awkward square. The tactical justification of this move is rather pretty: 21. Rxb7 is refuted not by ... Bc6, which meets with 22. Rb3 Nxc7 23. Rc3!, but by 21. ... Bc8!, and after 22. Rb8 Nxc7 there are no shenanigans to speak of.

21. Rc4?

Textbook "drifting." If my memory serves me right, my opponent played this move quickly, as a kind of reflex reaction to 20. ... Nd5. While the bishop is protected, White's pieces will now be tangled up and subjected to a bishop-led massacre of epic proportions. Almost anything else—21. Rd4 or even 21. Rb3!? (hoping for 21. ... Nxc7?? 22. Rxb7 Rc8 23. Rc1), would have maintained dynamic equality.

21. ... Rc8

Pinning the bishop, and forcing White's other rook out of its cage.

22. Rac1 Bh6!

Black's pieces, once mere spectators to imminent defeat, now cooperate in a flawless ensemble of threats and tactical blows. White's rooks are tied to the c-file, and the walls begin closing in.

23. R1c2 Bb5 24. Rc5 Bd3!

When Raymond Reddington escapes from his enemy's clutches, the latter quite often begins to regret the day he was born. The same could be said of White's rooks!

25. Rxd5?!

Going down without a fight. The cold-blooded 25. Bg3! would have yielded more chances, although following 25. ... Re8 26. Rd2!? Bxd2 27. Nxd2 Rd8 Black has excellent winning chances.

25. ... exd5 26. Rc3 Be4

It is hard to believe that the initial diagrammed position and this one come from the same game. It is now Black who has an extra pawn, and—more importantly—White's pieces are too entangled and passive to afford any real chances of a resistance.

27. Nd4 Bd2! 28. Rc5 Bb4 29. Rc1 Bd2

Repeating moves to gain time (and, I must admit, to taunt my opponent).

30. Rc5 Bb4 31. Rc1 Bd6 32. Nb5 Be5

The bishop has come full circle, intensifying the pin and forcing White to give up further material.

33. f4

An ingenious try, but the time for creativity has long passed!

33. ... Bxb2 34. Nd6+ Ke6

Nice try, except I wasn't about to give up a second rook for free.

35. Nxc8 Bxc1

Now it is all over: Black's bishops guide the passer to coronation.

36. Bb8 d4 37. Bxa7 d3 38. Kf1 d2, White resigned.

One might argue that I simply got lucky, and Caissa definitely smiled on me on that Tuesday evening 10 years ago. Nonetheless, this game represented a formative experience in my development in that it convinced me that the words "never give up" actually mean something on the chessboard. My opponent is a very competent club player, yet by constantly setting annoying problems—by maintaining my composure and by trying to "keep the game one move longer," I was able to make Raymond Reddington proud. ♠

Executive Board nominating petitions and filing fee must be postmarked by December 31! See the October/November issues for further details.

How Magnus Does It

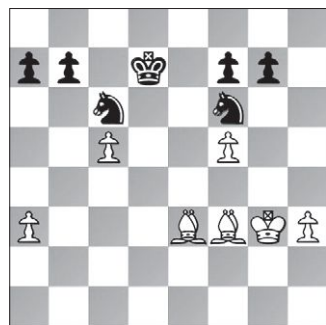
Analyzing an ending that won't win a tournament's brilliancy prize, but that will bring the dedicated analyst a great deal of instructional value and satisfaction.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THIS MONTH WE HAVE A FASCINATING endgame between two titans of modern chess: GMs Magnus Carlsen and Hikaru Nakamura. Rather than address this endgame at a superficial level, we will delve as deep as we possibly can, seeking meaningful justifications and explanations over engine analysis. We will focus not only on what is going on, but also on unearthing the trains of thought that led the players to make certain decisions. Much like our recent presidential election, this will be a trying process. And perhaps a rewarding one as well.

A REWARDING GAME

GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2834, NOR)
GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2793, USA)
LONDON CHESS CLASSIC 2015 (7),
London, England, 12.11.2015



AFTER 42. ... Kd7

This unconventional minor-piece endgame arose after a lengthy stage of endgame maneuvering. It appears the time is ripe to declare a truce: White's bishop pair is counterbalanced by his abysmal pawn structure, and Black's twin cavaliers are keeping every point of infiltration under firm control.

But don't jump to conclusions. Black is devoid of any counterplay, and White's pawns, especially the ones on c5 and f5, are nicely holding back their counterparts on b7 and g7. White has all the time in the world to improve his position, so why not make a few more moves?

43. Kf4 Ne8 44. Kg5

A healthy start. Now, 44. ... f6 is obviously suicidal due to 45. Kg6, so the air grows even thinner for Nakamura.

44. ... Ke7 45. Bf4

Another classy move, closing off c7 street.

45. ... a6

White has improved his piece placement to the maximum, and the time has come for more concrete measures. What exactly are those measures? When you are dominating your opponent but have no clear way forward, a very common—and very effective—technique is “carving:” using a pawn(s) to physically carve out a path for your king and other pieces. Carving takes a lot of patience and precision; one misstep, and you might accidentally release your opponent from the gridlock. Of course, “precision” and “Magnus Carlsen” are synonyms.

46. h4!

In this position, there is only one way to carve: by slowly and carefully advancing the pawn to h4, weakening the f6-square. In doing so, White must take care not to allow the knights any freedom, and not to allow Black's king to land on f6 before White takes the square under control.

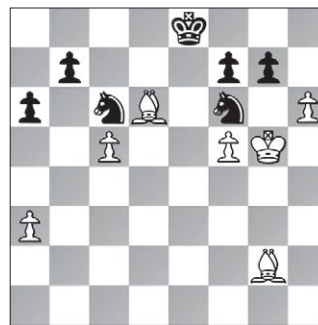
46. ... Kf8 47. Bg3

There was nothing wrong with the immediate 47. h5, but Carlsen prefers to torture his opponent first. In general, the psychological strategy of pretending that you cannot find a way to make progress, and then—after your opponent has gotten his hopes up—to suddenly crash through, is tremendously effective.

47. ... Nf6 48. Bd6+ Ke8 49. Kf4 Nd7 50. Bg2 Kd8 51. Kg5 Ke8 52. h5! Nf6 53. h6!

(see diagram top of next column)

Carving at its best. It appears that White has walked right into a perpetual, but Magnus



seamlessly interweaves small tactical tricks to ensure that everything remain under his control.

53. ... Nh7+ 54. Kh5 Nf6+ 55. Kg5 Nh7+

Draw?

56. Kh4!

No way! Through his outwardly meaningless maneuvers, Magnus has imprisoned Black's king, and this sacrifice is obviously temporary. On the other hand, the weakness of the f6-square will be permanent.

56. ... gxh6

This is forced; the stubborn 56. ... g6 would have led to even more disastrous consequences after 57. fxg6 fxg6 58. Bd5 Nd4 59. Bf4! (but not 59. Bxb7?? Nf5+), and Black has no way to stop the dual threats of Bxb7 and Bg8.

57. Kh5 Nf6+ 58. Kxh6 Ng4+?!

This does not lose, but it exacerbates an already difficult situation. Black should sit tight with 58. ... Kd7, when I cannot see a direct way to break through. The point is that 59. Kg7 is met by 59. ... Ne8+, and Black saves the game by a hair's breadth after 60. Kxf7 Nxd6+ 61. cxd6 Nd8+!! This crucial intermezzo let's Black halt the progress of White's f-pawn and trade off his remaining pawn on the queenside.

Obviously, 59. Kg7 is not forced, and White can continue to torture Black with various bishop-related shenanigans ad infinitum.

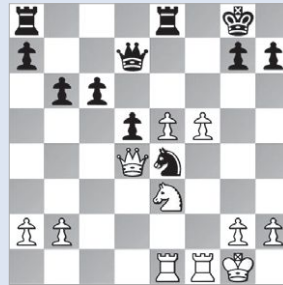
Brilliant Magnus Tactics

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

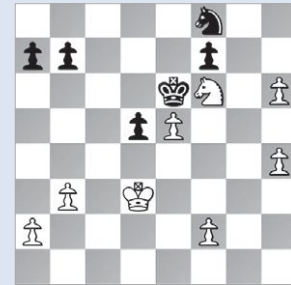
GM Magnus Carlsen (2772)
GM Dmitri Jakovenko (2742)
Nanjing Pearl Spring, 10.09.2009



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Magnus Carlsen (2851)
GM Vladimir Kramnik (2801)
Stavenger, Norway, 04.27.2016



WHITE TO MOVE

59. Kg7!

Typical Carlsen fare: rather than retreat with 59. Kg5, he seizes his opportunity and penetrates further. In my opinion, it is this ability to pounce on the first chance he gets that truly separates Carlsen from the rest of the elite gang: he operates with ruthless precision 100 percent of the time.

59. ... Nd4 60. Be4 Nf2 61. Bb1!

How nimbly the bishops move across the diagonals! Black's knights are more active than ever before, but they are incapable of covering all of the bases.

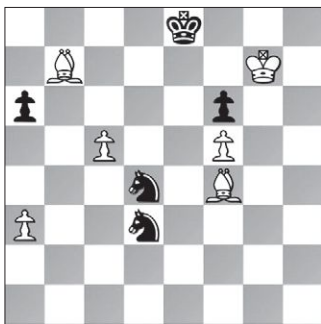
61. ... Ng4 62. Bf4

The bishop has done its job on d6, and now it moves to f4 to circumscribe Black's knight.

62. ... f6 63. Be4 Nf2 64. Bb1 Ng4 65. Be4 Nf2

Once again, Carlsen has led Nakamura to believe that he is on the verge of conceding a draw, but a draw is the last thing on his mind right now.

66. Bxb7 Nd3!



The critical point has been reached. In fact, this position constitutes much of the reason I am showing this game. In the endgame, various evil forces often induce uncharacteristic mistakes: in particular, the most common manifestation, fatigue, is an increased temptation to

take an easy way out. In this case, it would appear that White has two candidate moves: 67. Bd6, defending the pawn, and 67. c6. But if we force ourselves to calculate them out, as Magnus certainly did, we see that neither of them do the trick:

- 1) 67. Bd6? is a draw after 67. ... Nxf5+ 68. Kxf6 Nxd6 69. cxd6 Kd7 70. Bxa6 Nc5, and Black picks up the d6-pawn.
- 2) 67. c6? looks impressive, but is coolly refuted by 67. ... Nxf4 68. c7 Nxf5+ 69. Kxf6 Nd6 70. Ke5 Kd7!.

Having calculated these lines, Magnus undoubtedly forced himself to go outside the box: we know that knights are usually hapless at dealing with passed pawns, and that the light-square bishop (rather than its colleague) is the crucial piece in this position. So, the question is: does White really need the dark-square bishop?

67. Kxf6!!

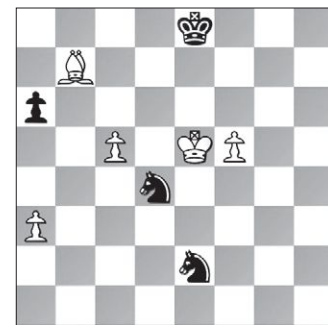
This is a fantastic move that sent the commentators and fans (including myself) into a frenzy. But the point I am trying to make in this column is that it was arrived at through logical, understandable thinking: thinking that we can all strive to emulate in every game that we play. As it turns out, Black's knights are pushed back rather easily, and White's twin passers easily run through Black's position.

67. ... Nxf4 68. Ke5 Nfe2

(see diagram top of next column)

69. f6?

Even Magnus is mortal. As it turns out, this move—tempting as it—actually allowed Black to almost steal the game from his clutches. The thing to understand is that pushing the pawn is actually in Black's favor, since the pawn becomes of a more strength than a liability. The simple 69. c6 would have forced Black to



give up his knight and won easily. For instance, 69. ... Nxc6+ 70. Bxc6+ Ke7 71. Bd5 Nc3 72. Bc4 a5 73. Kd4 Nd1 74. Bb3 Nf2 75. Kc5 and the game is over: White picks up the a-pawn, while the bishop drops back to c2 to keep f5 protected.

69. ... a5 70. a4 Kf7 71. Bd5+ Kf8??

Nakamura returns the favor, although I would argue that Magnus certainly deserved the full point after demonstrating such incredible technique. As it turns out, the highly counterintuitive 71. ... Kg6 would have drawn: after 72. c6 Nxc6 73. Bxc6 Kf7 74. Bd5+ Kf8, and White simply cannot make progress. When White's king leaves the f-pawn's zone, Black plays ... Nc3-xa4 and follows up with ... Kf7. This is why it would have been so much better to keep the pawn on f5!

72. Ke4!

Now, it is all over: Black is in *Zugzwang*.

72. ... Nc2

Or 72. ... Ke8 73. Bc4 followed by Ke3, winning easily.

73. c6 Nc3+ 74. Ke5 Nxa4 75. Bb3 Nb6 76. Bxc2 a4 77. c7 Kf8 78. Bxa4, Black resigned.

This is not the kind of game that wins a brilliancy prize in a tournament, but it is the kind of game that brings its dedicated analyst a great deal of instructional value and satisfaction. ♠

Framing

“Play the board or play the opponent?” is a dilemma that goes back at least to Ruy Lopez. Here is a modern take on it.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

A VERY FAMOUS CONCEPT IN THE psychological study of decision-making is the notion of **framing**. Studies reliably demonstrate that humans are loss-averse, meaning that they will consistently choose a different option in a scenario that is framed in terms of loss than in an identical scenario that is framed in terms of gain.

In the most famous of these studies, conducted by behavioral economists Amos Tversky and Daniel Kahneman, the experimenters gave the subjects two scenarios that both involve a medical patient who is considering a cutting-edge, but potentially risky, operation. In scenario one, Tversky and Kahneman explained that out of every 100 individuals who undergo this operation, 90 survive and emerge illness-free. In scenario two, they stated that out of every 100 individuals who undergo this operation, 10 lose their lives. The question to the subjects, of course, was whether the patient should undergo the operation.

I think you get the drift. The majority of people chose the operation in scenario one because it was framed in terms of survivors (and 90 survivors out of 100 people is a lot). In scenario two the majority recommended the patient forego the operation, because it was framed in terms of losses (boy, 10 dead out of 100 sounds ominous. That's one out of every ten!). There are many, many variations on this study that all demonstrate a similar trend: (1) people are not perfectly rational beings (but we knew that already), and (2) the way you ask a question matters almost as much as what is being asked!

Now, what does all this have to do with chess? Let me explain. My own experience has led me to believe that psychology plays a very prominent role in chess, and that **it is frequently possible to subtly influence your opponent's thinking pattern and move choice through various psychological hacks**. In the endgame, psychological savvy and cunning can enable you to pull a rabbit out

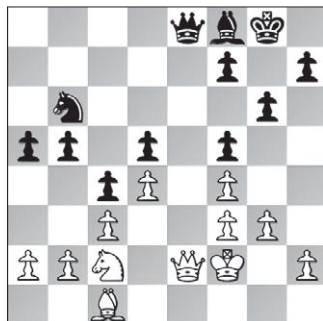
of a hat (not in the literal sense, of course). All of this may appear rather vague, but please withhold your judgment until you see the following game, one of my proudest endgame moments in which I was able to put chess psychology to good use.

USING PSYCHOLOGY

IM Pierre Bailet (2476)

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2587)

4th International Chess Festival RIGA
TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY OPEN, Riga,
Latvia, 08.23.2014



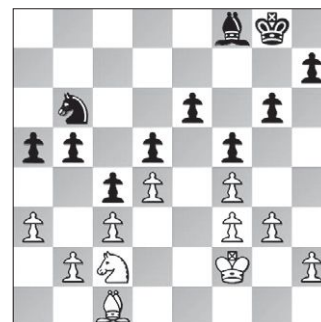
AFTER 29. Qe2

My opponent has been playing very solidly (if passively) throughout the game, and he has essentially succeeded in constructing an impenetrable fortress. Now, Black's pawn chain on the queenside sure looks impressive, but even a Ferrari won't drive without gas; in fact, after 29. ... Qxe2+ 30. Kxe2, 30. ... b4? meets with 31. cxb4 axb4 32. Bd2! when Black is the one who must tread carefully. Declining the trade with 29. ... Qc6 is a more reasonable option, but after 30. a3 Na4 31. Qe5! Bd6 32. Qf6! White's queen gets too active, and Black can do little more than shuffle his pieces and acquiesce to a draw.

After coming to terms with the objective evaluation of the position, I remembered Kahneman and Tversky's study (which I had read about earlier that summer!) ...

29. ... Qe6!?

Yeah, yeah, yeah. I hear you. 30. Qxe6 fxe6 31. a3 is a dead draw, and it is.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 31. a3

Black has only one idea: to break through with ... b5-b4. To do so, he must first bring his king over to the queenside. Let's take a look: 31. ... Na4 32. Ke2 Kf7 33. Kd2 Ke7 34. Kd1 ("chillin' ...") 34. ... Kd6 35. Kd2 Kc6 36. Kd1 b4. Everything has gone according to plan, but following the ultra-simple 37. axb4 axb4 38. Nxb4! Bxb4 39. cxb4 Kb5 40. Kc2 Kxb4 41. Bd2+ it's time to call it a day. The king is pushed back, and Black has no other way to penetrate.

This is a long line to be sure, but it is still easy to calculate. In addition, my opponent had shown that he was not unwilling to enter an endgame (he had, after all, offered an exchange in the initial position). And this is exactly where the notion of framing comes in: **even though both endgames (29. ... Qxe2+ and 30. Qxe6) are identical, the second looks a lot more unpleasant for White due to the illusion created by Black's imposing pawn structure**. This might strike you as a load of psycho-analytic mumbo jumbo, but it caused my opponent visible discomfort. Even though the pawn structure could not matter less, it is hard to convince oneself that enabling Black to fix his doubled pawns and support d5 does not actually make a difference. To my pleasant surprise, the trick "worked":

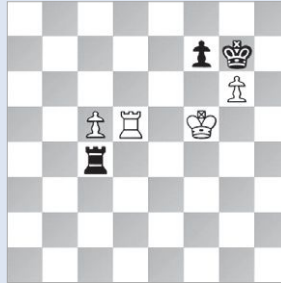
Find the !! move

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

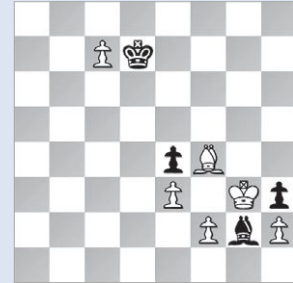
Savielly Tartakower
Peter Trifunovic
Paris, 1950



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Gilles Miralles (2260)
Eric Prie (2205)
Schiltigheim, 1982



WHITE TO MOVE

30. Ke1?! Na4!

Now behold the second psychological hack: having determined that my opponent is unwilling to trade queens, I give him this option once again. My hope is that the cognitive dissonance created by declining the trade will not allow him to soberly reevaluate the situation and correct his mistake.

31. Kd2?!

And so it is! Instead of trading the queen (going for the operation), my opponent has failed to resolve the fundamental deficiencies of his position. Now, with Black's knight optimized and the king placed awkwardly, it is time to punish White for his mistakes.

31. ... Qc6!

Chess psychology at its best. This move was accompanied by a visible sigh of disappointment from my opponent, who was doubtless regretting not trading queens! With the queen on c6, 32. Qe5 is no longer effective due to 32. ... Bd6, and White's queen is pushed back because 33. Qf6?? fails to 33. ... Bxf4+, winning the queen. But without the possibility of active defense, White has no choice but to wait for ... b4 and hope for the best.

32. Kd1?



Total collapse. The only way to sustain the fortress would have been, of course, 32. a3. This is not quite as effective with the queens

on the board, as Black can first improve his position with 32. ... Bd6 (preventing any Qe5 business) and then slowly, ever-so-slowly, prepare ... b5-b4. I invite you to analyze this position deeply, but for now, suffice it to say that White's drawing chances would have remained very significant.

Presumably mired in regret at having missed the chance to trade queens, my opponent loses the thread entirely. Allowing ... b5-b4 with the queens on the board and with the knight on a4 is simply suicidal.

32. ... b4



33. Qd2

Alternatively, 33. cxb4 axb4 34. Qe1 would have brought little relief either; for instance, 34. ... c3 35. b3 Nb2+! 36. Bxb2 cxb2 37. Kd2 Qc3+ and wins.

33. ... b3!

The crushing blow. Black carves out White's queenside, creating holes on the light squares that are soon to be occupied by the queen and knight.

34. axb3 cxb3 35. Ne3 Nb6 36. Qe2 Nc4 37. Nxc4 dxc4

The rest is a matter of straightforward technique: Black plants his queen on d5, and then pushes the a-pawn through to a3, when White's queenside collapses.

38. Ke1 Bd6 39. Kf2 Kf8

Patience! The immediate 39. ... Qd5 allowed unnecessary complications with 40. Qe8+.

40. Qd1 Qd5 41. Qe2 a4 42. Ke1 Qe6!

No, the irony of this move is not lost on me either. With Rome burning, even a queen trade can hardly save White.

43. Kd1 Ke7 44. Ke1 Bc7 45. Kd1 Qxe2+ 46. Kxe2 Ba5



The last finesse. White has to buttress the c3-pawn, but there is no good way of doing so, since 47. Kd2 will result in a quick *Zugzwang* after 47. ... Kd6 and 47. Bd2 allows 47. ... a3 48. bxa3 b2.

47. Kd1 a3 48. bxa3 Bxc3 49. Be3 Bb2 50. a4 c3 51. Bc1 Bxc1

The easiest. Black's king is "in the square" and catches both of White's pawns.

52. Kxc1 Kd6, White resigned.

After 53. a5 Kc6 there is no way to parry the threat of ... Kb5 (54. d5+ Kxd5 is equally bad).

Bobby Fischer famously claimed that he does not believe in chess psychology ("I don't believe in psychology. I believe in good moves"), but I will dare to disagree with Bobby the Great. I don't know about you, but I believe in psychology and good moves. ♠

Safe and Secure

With few pieces on the board, even grandmasters can't take king safety for granted.

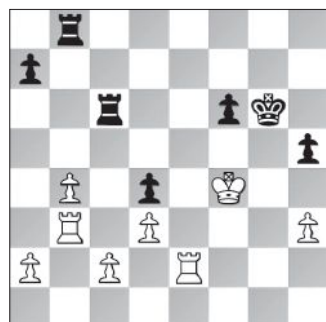
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

WHEN THE QUEENS LEAVE THE BOARD, a tiny part of our subconscious breathes a sigh of relief. As challenging as endgames are, there is a tiny voice in your head that goes *"alright, at least I don't have to worry about getting checkmated anymore."* Although it is true that sustained mating attacks occur rather infrequently with only a few pieces left on the board, they are far from impossible. Indeed, one of the most common—and costliest—psychological mistakes one can make in the endgame is to take king safety for granted.

In this month's column, we will examine a recent encounter in which a strong grandmaster made this exact mistake and paid a fatal price.

A CRITICAL MOMENT

GM Benjamin Bok (FIDE 2608, NED)
GM Vladimir Dobrov (FIDE 2499, RUS)
Tata Steel Challengers 2017 (3), Wijk aan Zee, Netherlands, 01.16.17



AFTER 30. gxf3

We join the battle at a critical moment. White has a pawn to the good, and Black's pawn structure does not exactly inspire confidence. Indeed, if White can set his queenside pawns in motion with an eye toward vacating the b4-square for his rook, Black will end up in a world of hurt.

To be a good endgame player, you do not necessarily have to possess a wealth of hard knowledge. Rather, you must continually sharp-

en your intuition and understanding to the point where you are able to make your opponent's life difficult no matter how dire the circumstances. Realizing that things are about to go downhill, Russian Grandmaster Vladimir Dobrov plays his last trump card.

30. ... Rb5!

Mobilizing the rook and physically preventing White from pushing the b-pawn. Furthermore, the tempting 31. Rg2+? now meets with 31. ... Rg5!, and the trade works in Black's favor: 32. Rxf5 fxf5+ 33. Ke4 and now the easiest way to draw is 33. ... Rxc2 34. Ra3 Re2+ 35. Kxd4 Re7, when Black's kingside pawn majority will eventually compel White to sign the peace agreement.

31. a4!

Bok is unfazed, and rightly so. Operating without assistance, Black's rook cannot do any serious damage ... yet.

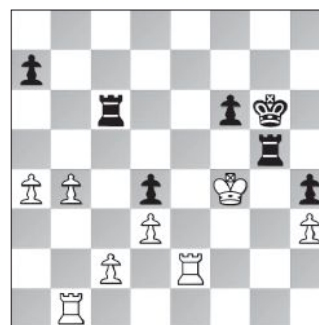
31. ... Rg5 32. Rb1?!

It is hard to criticize such a natural move, and indeed it cannot be called a mistake. However, White would have been better advised to employ this rook as a security guard (rather than, err, a freewheeling mercenary?!) with 32. Rb2!, freeing up its colleague. This is more effective than 32. Rb1 because White is already threatening to penetrate with Re7 or Re4. Black has nothing better than something along the lines of 32. ... Rd6, when play might continue 33. Kf3 (withdrawing the king from the danger zone) 33. ... Rdd5 34. Re4 Rg1 (34. ... Rdf5+ 35. Rf4 leads nowhere) 35. b5 and the pawns should eventually decide the game in White's favor, though there is still a lot of work to be done.

32. ... h4!

(see diagram top of next column)

First-rate defense by Dobrov. What is the rationale behind ... h4? On the surface, it might



seem like a random pawn move, but Dobrov's motives are actually far more insidious. If you look closely, you might realize that Kf3 is no longer possible (or at least no longer good) on account of ... Rg3+, when White loses the crucial h3-pawn. A few moves ago, this would not have been particularly significant, but with both of Black's rooks now in the game, this development undoubtedly sent a shiver up Bok's spine.

33. Rbe1

Nerves of steel. For the moment, White's king is still safe, so Bok takes this opportunity to mobilize his second rook.

33. ... a6

Now it is time to play the waiting game.

34. Rb1!

Exceptionally high-level chess from both sides. Bok exploits the only chink in Black's armor, preparing to use the a6-pawn as a "hook" to maximize the effectiveness of the b4-b5 break. Black cannot wait any longer; if his counterplay falls through, White will crash through on the queenside.

34. ... Rf5+ 35. Kg4 Rc8!

Generally, I believe that awarding too many exclamation marks cheapens the quality of the annotations, but in this case I have no choice! Notice how deftly Dobrov maneuvers his rooks. Now, White's king is confined to an even tighter

Practicum

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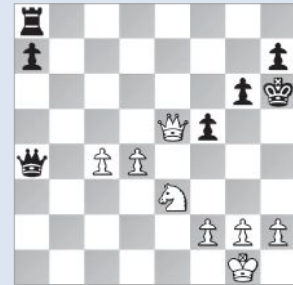
GM Ivan Cheparinov (2678)
GM Dmitri Jakovenko (2760)
Jermuk, 08.09.2009



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2620)
IM Alexander Donchenko (2523)
Qatar Masters, 11.30.2014



WHITE TO MOVE

space, and 36. Kxh4 is impossible on account of 36. ... Rg5!, with mate to follow.

36. b5

The computer criticizes this move, though I believe the “refutation” is so inhuman as to render this move fully adequate from a practical point of view. Now, the real race begins: will White crash through on the queenside, or will Black catch the king in some kind of perpetual (or something more sinister than a perpetual)? Not as thrilling as the latest John Grisham paperback, true, but entertaining and instructive nonetheless.

36. ... Rh8



From a purely objective standpoint, this move is a grave error. Put simply, it turns a drawn position into a losing one. But the dangers of blindly following the computer, especially in a situation in which the practical merits of a move transcend its objective deficiency, can hardly be overstated. This is just such a situation.

The “correct” way to play would have been 36. ... axb5 37. Rxb5 (37. axb5 Rh8 is similar to the game, but with the crucial difference that White can no longer capture on a6 and vacate the b6-square—see the actual game for a more thorough explanation) 37. ... Rxb5 38. axb5 Rb8 when it transpires that 39. Re4?? is impossible due to 39. ... f5+. White has to try 39. Kxh4 Rxb5, but after something like 40.

Kg3 Rg5+ 41. Kf2 Rh5 Black should hold the draw without too much trouble. Note that 42. Re4 almost always meets with 42. ... Rc5!, and White has to return.

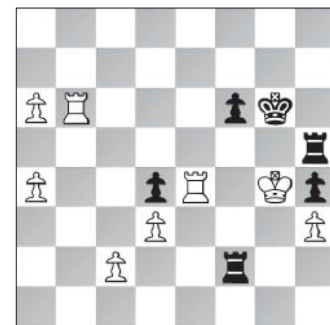
All of that is well and good, but the beauty of endgames lies in their rebellious nature (yes, Mr. smart aleck, endgames are inanimate and so cannot have natures, but indulge me for a moment). To simply comb through a complex endgame with a computer is to overlook the fascinating battle of human minds that goes on below the surface, with all of the mistakes and misgivings and miscalculations attendant to it. Dobrov’s move seems rather innocuous—it appears that he is preparing some kind of last-ditch attempt to deliver a perpetual with ... Rg5+ and ... Rf5+, but the king will easily escape via f3. In acute time pressure, Bok most likely consoled himself with the thought that magic does not exist on the chessboard.

37. b6??

In such situations, I like to tone down the verbiage and let you try to understand what is going on. Suffice it to say that Dobrov’s intentions were far more violent, and this move falls prey to a devastating (and highly pleasing) mating sequence. Instead, 37. bxa6—a move which seems to be virtually indistinguishable from the text—actually contains a tremendously subtle difference that would have enabled White to salvage his ailing monarch. After 37. ... Rhh5, preparing the same mating sequence that we will see in the game (Black threatens 38. ... Rhg5+ 39. Kxh4 Rf4 mate), White can now respond 38. Re4 Rf2 and now comes the moment of truth: 39. Rb6!!!

(see diagram top of next column)

All is now crystal clear. Black is deprived of the possibility of ... f6-f5+, and the rooks can trouble the king no longer. Following 39. ... Rg5+ 40. Kxh4 the king is perfectly safe, and Black can resign. But if this wins the game, what is so bad about the game move, 37. b6?



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 39. Rb6!!!

37. ... Rhh5 38. Re4 Rf2

And there’s the rub: unfortunately for Bok, the rules of chess do not permit one to place a piece on top of another one. Had the wretched pawn been anywhere but on b6, Rb6 would have decided the game in his favor. And that is the entire reason White should have preferred bxa6 over b6: not because the pawn is somehow faster, but because the b6-square has to be vacated for the rook! Of course, to find such an idea in acute time pressure can only be done through chance alone. And perhaps Bok did run an “eeny, meeny, miny, moe” and simply settled on the wrong advance. Chess is a cruel game ...

39. Rf4 Rg5+, White resigned.

To be sure, my blurb at the beginning was somewhat misleading: Bok was undoubtedly aware that his king was in grave danger, but I had to make you keep reading somehow! I can only hope that this game was a worthwhile experience, and that you will forgive me for my authorial mischief ...♠

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Blood From a Stone

In the endgame, the role of nearly imperceptible positional characteristics is magnified a hundredfold.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IF YOU ARE ENGAGED IN A COMPLICATED middlegame battle with queens, rooks, bishops, and knights still on the board, then the difference between a pawn on a2 and a pawn on a3 might have no bearing whatsoever on the course of the game. Since we spend the majority of our chess career disentangling the complexities of a practical endgame, we often subconsciously filter out certain features of the position that would indeed be quite extraneous in a complicated middlegame battle.

Our ability to intuitively home in on the important aspects of a position is what keeps us sane, but **overusing this process in the endgame frequently leads to our downfall**. In this month's column, we are going to a wonderfully instructive game in which nearly imperceptible features of the position determined the outcome.

IGNORANCE IS BLISS ... NOT

Arturo Gonzalez Pruneda (FIDE 2249, ESP)
Enrique Alvarez Fernandez (FIDE 2055, ESP)
'Asturias' Indv.Ch.2002 (3), Gijon, Spain,
05.17.2002



WHITE TO MOVE

The position on the board is as boring as it gets. White has a space advantage on the kingside, but it is counterbalanced by the annoying pawn on c4 and Black's possession of the d-file. In short, it appears that the time is ripe to call it a day. While a draw is indeed

the most likely outcome of the game, Gonzalez Pruneda—a hardened Spanish master—has one *truco* left in his sleeve.

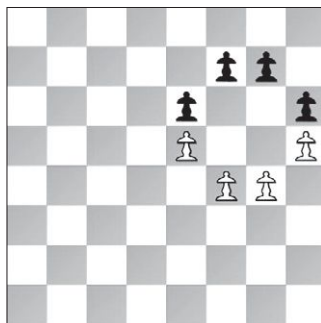
23. Rd1!

On the surface, this move looks like an admission of the inevitable: Black trades rooks, gets his king to d5, and ... it is time to sign the peace agreement. Most likely, Alvarez Fernandez adopted precisely this sort of thinking pattern when considering his reply. After all, what could possibly go wrong in the ensuing pawn endgame?

23. ... Rxd1??

The introduction to this column should have led you on to the notion that things are rarely this simple in the endgame. At this point, I would encourage you to lay down the magazine, set this position up on a board, and try to figure out why this capture is a terrible blunder.

The crux of the matter is that this king position is *not* what dictates the course of the game here; rather, it is the kingside pawn formation, which commonly arises from the Open Caro-Kann (1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6 6. h4 h6 7. Nf3 Nd7 8. h5, and, later on, Ne5 ... Nxe5 dxe5). For convenience, let us examine it in isolation:



Optically, it might appear that the pawn structure is symmetrical, but that is merely an illusion—there is nothing symmetrical about it. Our eyes are drawn to the similarity in pawn

configuration (i.e. the f4-pawn is one square diagonally away from e5, f7 is one square diagonally away from e6, etc.), but what's important here is that White's pawns are far-advanced. This means that in the absence of confounding factors (such as a Black king on e4), Black cannot stop White from creating a faster passed pawn with f4-f5 (on the e- or h-file), giving Black two equally unappealing choices:

- 1) Either he captures on f5, giving White the option to break through with gxf5-e6, or
- 2) He does not react, allowing White to push the pawn through to f6. After ... gxf6 exf6, there will be no way to stop the pawn break g4-g5 followed by h5-h6.

Now, let us return to the text position. We see that the queenside pawn structure is not all that important (neither side will be able to make any headway), so—in theory—Black will not be able to stop White from creating a passed pawn on the kingside. It transpires that his outwardly active king position and queenside space advantage are entirely useless. Of course, some calculation is necessary: one cannot arrive at the conclusion that White is winning simply through this line of general reasoning. However, I hope that by digesting all of this text, you are able to see how strong players can make fairly accurate evaluations simply through the strength of their positional understanding.

Before we see the finale, let us mention that the cold-blooded 23. ... Rg8! would have basically drawn on the spot.

(see diagram next page)

After 24. Rd4, Black can even sacrifice the pawn with 24. ... g6, when White is unable to hold his kingside together. For instance, 25. Rxc4+ Kd7 26. hxc6 (26. g5?! looks fancy but leaves White in some trouble after 26. ... hxc5 27. h6?! [27. hxc6 Rxc6 28. Kd2 is still drawn] 27. ... g4!) 26. ... Rxc6 27. f5 Rg5 28. Rf4 h5!

Practicum

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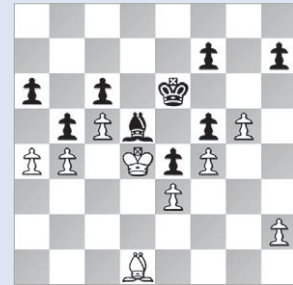
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2640)
GM Santosh Gujrathi Vidit (2630)
Tsakhkadzor, 04.20.2015



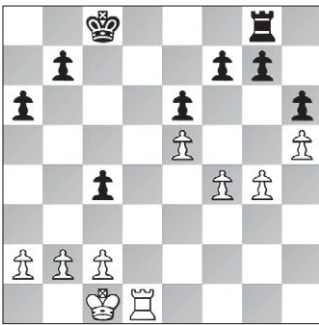
BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

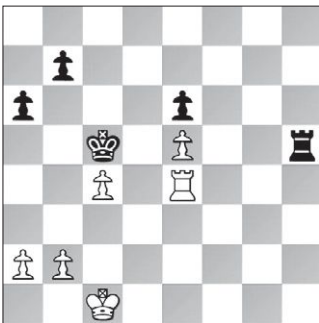
GM Savielly Tartakower
GM Vasja Pirc
Saltsjobaden Interzonal 1948



WHITE TO MOVE



29. fxe6+ fxe6 30. gxh5 Rxb5 31. Re4 Kc6 and the e5-pawn cannot be saved, since 32. c4 Kc5 followed by ... Rh2 is actually rather annoying for White.



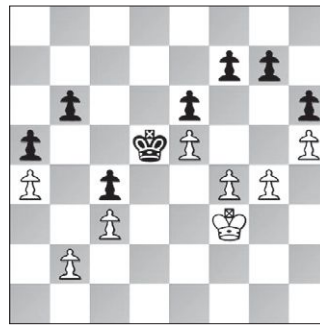
Now, even Magnus Carlsen can hardly be expected to calculate this entire line, but had Alvarez Fernandez stopped to examine the finer elements of the position, he would have undoubtedly realized that the pawn endgame leaves him in far more treacherous territory than even a rook endgame a pawn down.

24. Kxd1 Kc7 25. Kd2 Kc6 26. c3!

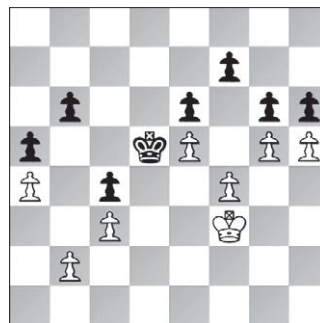
A nice touch, freezing the kingside pawns. 26. Ke3 unnecessarily allowed 26. ... c3, and even though White still wins with 27. b4, there is no need to allow additional chances.

26. ... Kd5 27. Ke3 a5 28. a4 b6 29. Kf3!

(see diagram top of next column)



Game, set, match. The only thread keeping Black alive was his well-placed king, and now he has no choice but to concede the inevitable. One additional point to notice is that 29. ... g6 fails to 30. g5!, with a classic breakthrough situation.



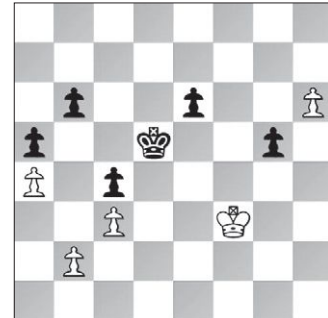
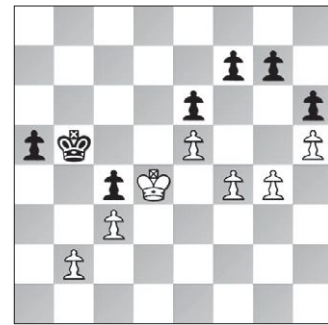
After 29. ... Kc5 30. Ke4 b5! White can simply ignore the queenside and proceed with 31. f5 (in this particular situation, 31. axb5 Kxb5 32. Kd4 also wins in virtue of Zugzwang).

(see diagram top of next column)

Had Black arranged his pawns on a6 and b5, the f4-f5 plan would have been the only path to victory) 31. ... bxa4 32. f6, engineering a breakthrough that is already quite familiar to us!

29. ... f5 30. exf6 e.p., Black resigned.

Following 30. ... gxf6 31. g5! hxg5 32. fxg5 fxg5 33. h6 White promotes.



One of the reasons that I love exploring endgames so much is that one can always find a treasure trove of lessons in the unlikelyst of places. I doubt that either Gonzalez Pruneda or his opponent would remember this obscure game from more than a decade ago, yet to the dedicated endgame analyst and tournament player, it offers an enduring lesson that can go a long way toward improving one's endgame understanding.

Remember: while you can often get away with ignoring certain aspects of a position in the middlegame, such ignorance can cost you immensely when there is little material left on the board! ♠

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No Fortress for Old Men

A fortress is an invaluable defensive tool, especially in the endgame.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

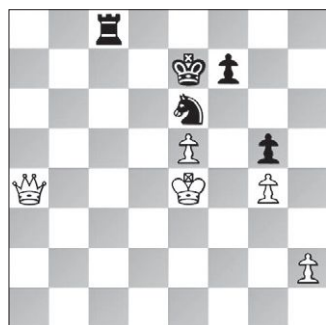
ON MANY OCCASIONS, GM MAGNUS Carlsen has sagely proclaimed that he does not believe in fortresses. At first sight, this sounds like something a hustler in Washington Square Park would direct at his quivering opponent (my perception of Washington Square Park may or may not be influenced by *Searching for Bobby Fischer*). But when Magnus speaks, he is listened to. As a rule, the things he says contain more than a grain of wisdom.

Make no mistake: the fortress is an invaluable defense tool, especially in the endgame. It frequently enables the tenacious player to salvage a half-point out of the most desperate situations. Conversely, the sudden realization that your opponent has erected an unbreakable defensive construction can be a real stab in the heart.

With that said, Magnus is definitely on to something: **players tend to falsely assume that a solid-looking position which cannot be directly infiltrated is a fortress.** What makes Magnus “Magnus” is that he simply refuses to believe that a position is completely impenetrable until he has exhausted each and every resource. In this month’s column, we will zero in on one fortress-breaking resource that often hides in the shadows: *Zugzwang*. Need I say anything else?

FORTRESS I

Christobal Dominguez
IM Rene Letelier Martner
Mar Del Plata (10), 1961



AFTER 46. ... Ne6

Materially, White should be completely winning. He has a queen and a pawn for Black’s rook and knight, but it is evident that a simple material count does not tell the whole story. In fact, a closer look at the position reveals that the wily Chilean master has constructed a fortress. Put simply, White’s queen alone cannot make any real progress: neither a check on d6 nor a check on f6 causes Black any real problems after ... Ke8, and a potential h2-h4 pawn break will not achieve anything either: Black simply captures on h4, and White’s winning chances will dwindle even further.

In such positions, it is important to act on a step-by-step basis: by improving your position to the maximum before attempting to breach the fortress, you will maximize your chances of crashing through. Dominguez does just that:

47. Kf5!

An excellent start. The king eyes one of the two penetration squares (the other being d6), and is perfectly comfortable with Black’s knight tied down.

47. ... Rc5

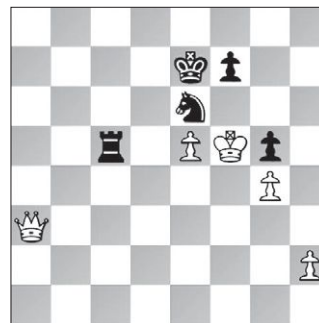
But where does White go from here? If you are unfamiliar with the role that *Zugzwang* can play in penetrating a fortress, the winning plan can be tremendously difficult to find. The course of the game is a case in point: Dominguez, a strong player in his own right, was probably so intent on trying to calculate his way to a win that he failed to identify the principal flaw in Black’s position.

48. Qa7+?!

This does not ruin anything in and of itself, but it probably gave Letelier Martner a glimmer of hope. By now, my not-so-subtle hints should have directed you to the correct move: 48. Qa3!

(see diagram top of next column)

To me, *Zugzwang* is still one of the most beautiful endgame concepts. White poses



ANALYSIS AFTER 48. Qa3

no direct threat, yet Black’s rook and knight are totally paralyzed. He must either move his king, enabling his vis-à-vis to infiltrate the crucial f6-square, or he must voluntarily compromise the integrity of the fortress with 48. ... f6. In both cases, he goes down in flames:

48. ... Ke8 49. Kf6 Rc7 50. Qa8+! forces further material concessions after both 50. ... Kd7 51. Kxf7 or 50. ... Nd8 51. Kxg5, when the h-pawn rolls down the board.

48. ... f6 looks scary, but falls prey to a cute tactical refutation: 49. Qa7+ Rc7 50. Qb6! Ng7+ 51. Kg6! and Black can surrender.

Now, let us follow the course of the game. Surely, Dominguez will eventually get back on track, right?

48. ... Rc7 49. Qa3+ Rc5 50. Qa7+ Rc7 51. Qa3+ Rc5 52. h4??

A flaw in the game notation? A conspiracy? Hardly. If someone had approached Dominguez and whispered “52. Qb4” in his ear, he would have undoubtedly seen the light. But without a prime of some sort, he was most likely unaware that the possibility of inducing *Zugzwang* even existed. The text move, an obvious attempt to break through with brute force, fails miserably.

52. ... gxh4 53. g5 h3! 54. Qxh3 Rc4

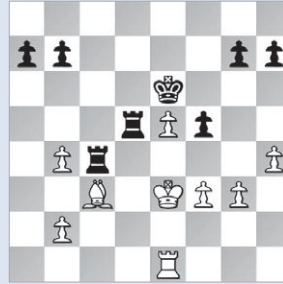
Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

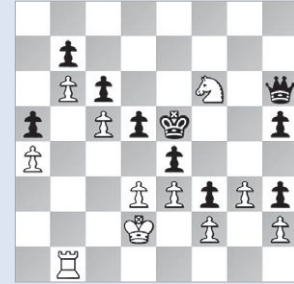
GM William Lombardy
GM Robert Fischer
U.S. Championship, New York, 1960



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Josef Hasek—Study
Prague, 1951



WHITE TO PLAY AND DRAW

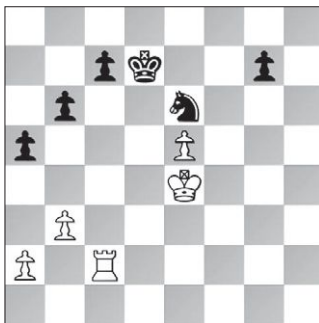
Uh-oh! Now, Black is the one threatening checkmate, and White has no choice but to repeat moves in disgrace:

55. Qa3+ Ke8 56. Qa8+ Ke7 57. Qa3+ Ke8, Draw agreed.

To be sure, this is a fairly one-sided game, and it was clearly not Dominguez's best day. But now, armed with the *Zugzwang* mentality, you will have all the necessary tools to come up with ways to breach even the most stubborn fortresses. Take a look:

FORTRESS II

FM Daniel Naroditsky (2308)
Robert Rowley (2200),
2008 Frank K. Berry USA Ch. Qualifier
FIDE Open (4), Stillwater, Oklahoma,
04.29.2008



ANALYSIS AFTER 37. ... Kd7

Interestingly, this position did not actually arise on the board. My opponent had lost on time before executing the move 37. ... Kd7 (which would have led to this position), and was extremely annoyed at himself for doing so. I was utterly relieved, because I was convinced that his fortress was impregnable. Upon going home and analyzing the position (which you can also find, by the way, in a certain book called *Mastering Positional Chess*—I can't recall the author though), I was shocked to discover that White has a beautiful plan that enables him to expose hidden

cracks in Black's position, a plan that even the farsighted computer struggles to find.

Let me say at the outset that there is no immediate breakthrough: in order to win, White must first construct an abstract plan that is broken down into three stages:

Take the c5-square under control.

Optimize rook and king placement.

Induce *Zugzwang*, forcing Black to weaken his position by advancing the c-pawn, g-pawn, or allowing further king penetration.

This is the kind of guiding plan that an experienced endgame player should come up with rather quickly. Its execution will be challenging, but only a matter of discipline and sober calculation. Onto step 1:

38. Rc3!

An important move. 38. a3? would have been a grave error due to 38. ... Nc5+, when 39. Kd5 c6+ 40. Kc4 Ke6 is probably a draw.

38. ... Ke7

Black has to sit: 38. ... Nc5+ is useless due to 39. Kf5, and now the cheeky 39. ... g6+ falls prey to the even cheekier 40. Kf6! Ne4+ 41. Kf7 Nxc3 42. e6+ and the pawn promotes.

39. a3 Kd7 40. b4 axb4 41. axb4

Step one has been accomplished. Black's knight is now restricted and all of White's pawns are secure, but there still seems to be no clear way to break through.

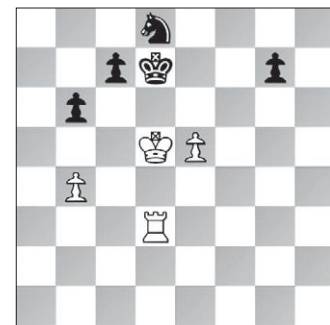
41. ... Ke7 42. Rd3

Cutting off the king.

42. ... Nd8 43. Kd5 Kd7

(see diagram top of next column)

Phase 2 has been accomplished: the rook and king are in picture-perfect position, but yet again, we seem to have made no further progress than before. At this point, the



Zugzwang neurons in your brain should start firing. In order to penetrate, White must either somehow advance the pawn, which is a tall order at the moment, or force Black to weaken the seventh rank by pushing the g-pawn. Considering how little breathing room Black has, that second goal is far more realistic.

44. b5! Ne6 45. Rf3 Ke7 46. Rf2!!

Boom chakalaka. The *Zugzwang* finally comes, 10 moves after the initial position! And what a beautiful *Zugzwang* it is: 46. ... Nd8 loses immediately to 47. e6 (e.g. 47. ... Ke8 48. Rc2), so Black must bite the bullet:

46. ... g5 47. Rh2 Nf4+ 48. Ke4 Ne6 49. Rh7+ Ke8 50. Kf5 Nd4+ 51. Kf6, and White wins.

How fitting that the monarch's sally decides it all.

Perhaps Magnus Carlsen had a point after all! The next time you are up against a seemingly impenetrable fortress, remember that a brute-force breakthrough is not the only way to make it collapse. Inducing *Zugzwang* can be just as effective as pulling out the foundational brick from a building's foundation, making it topple just the same. ♦

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Logical Illogicality

This month, an ending selected for its beauty and instructive value.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IT WAS ONLY ON THE FLIGHT BACK TO San Francisco, somewhere in the turbulent skies above Colorado, that the exhaustion and stress of the preceding 12 days fully caught up to me. I was halfway into *Better Call Saul* Season 1, Episode 3, when I felt an overpowering urge to shut my laptop, stretch out my legs (taking full and unabashed advantage of United Airline's two inches of legroom—after all, you never know when you'll be dragged off the plane!), and drift off into a deep slumber. Despite my mediocre performance in the tournament, and despite the massive amount of school catch-up that needed to be done, it was a satisfying slumber indeed. The 2017 U.S. Championship, like its predecessors in years past, was a special event in every way, and it has been a great honor and pleasure to play a role in its unfolding.

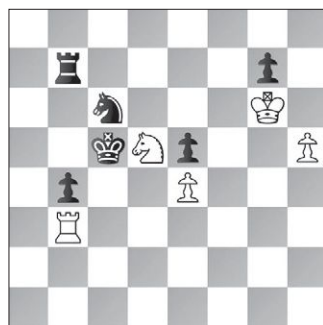
This month I present a fascinating endgame from my third-round battle against GM Var Akobian, who would go on to have a fantastic tournament (finishing third overall). Before we plunge in, a disclaimer is in order: I have selected this game not because I think it is somehow the best endgame played at the championship (far from it), but for the beauty of its ideas and for its instructive content. Was there any ego involved in the selection process? Nah ...

BREAKING THROUGH THE RAMPARTS

GM Varuzhan Akobian (2739)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2731)
2017 U.S. Championship, St. Louis,
Missouri, 04.04.17

(see diagram top of next column)

After a long and sloppy endgame slog, I finally managed to break through Var's defensive ramparts. Black has a pawn to the good, and what a pawn it is: White's rook and knight are powerless in the face of its impending advance. Indeed, Black threatens ... Kc4 (not to mention



AFTER 49. ... Kc5

the alternative plan of ... Kd4-xe4), followed by ... Nd4, b4-b3, and, well, you get the point. In order to prolong the game, White must find a source of counterplay on the other flank, but my rook seems to be permanently deterring any h-pawn related shenanigans.

Endgames, as I have repeatedly stressed in this column, are as much about creativity and grit as they are about technical calculation and theoretical knowledge. Var Akobian, one of the most tenacious players that I have come across in my career, uncorks a fantastic defensive concept:

50. Kh7??!!

Objectively speaking, this is a grave error that costs White the game. But two exclamation marks are nonetheless in order: Akobian had the right intention, and it was only the tiniest imprecision in execution that made the difference. Once this move is made, White's idea becomes evident: he will give up his knight for the b4-pawn(!), and then send the newly-liberated rook off to g3, where it will aid the king in cornering the g7-pawn. After it is eliminated, White will be the one possessing a far-advanced passer, and the battle will revolve around whether or not Black's combined forces can unite in time to stop it (gee, that sounds like some B-movie plot). Let's watch the events unfold.

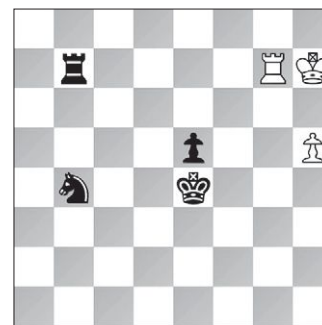
50. ... Kd4!

An important detail. The naïve 50. ... Kc4? would have fallen right into the mousetrap after 51. Rg3 and it turns out that 51. ... b3 meets with 52. Rc3+ when Black has to be careful not to lose: 52. ... Kd4 53. Rxc6 b2 54. Nc3 b1=Q 55. Nxb1 Rxb1 56. Kxg7 Kxe4 57. h6 Rb7+ 58. Kg6 Kf3 59. h7 Rxh7 60. Kxh7 e4, and Black draws by the skin of his teeth.

51. Nxb4

Now this is forced, since 51. Rg3 no longer does the trick on account of 51. ... Kxe4 and 52. Rxg7 falls well short: 52. ... Rxg7+ 53. Kxg7 and during the game I intended the simple 53. ... Kxd5 54. h6 b3 55. h7 b2 56. h8=Q b1=Q, and Black is completely winning. White can give a few perfunctory checks, but he is down way too much material to put up any actual resistance.

51. ... Nxb4 52. Rg3 Kxe4 53. Rxg7



This is where things get interesting. I had about 10 minutes on the clock at this point, and I could sense that Black should be winning. After all, I have some extra time to consolidate because White's king will inevitably get in the pawn's way. The key, then, is to find the optimal squares for the rook and knight. Fortunately, with a bit of precise calculation, this is not too hard to do.

53. ... Rb6

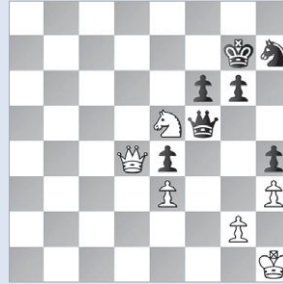
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See the solutions on page 79.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

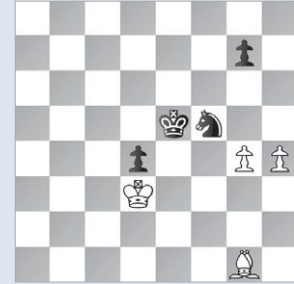
GM Varuzhan Akobian (2739)
GM Fabiano Caruana (2895)
U.S. Championship, 04.07.2017



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

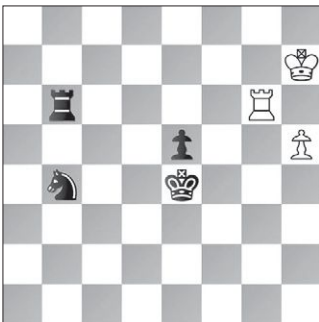
WIM Jennifer Yu (2336)
WFM Emily Nguyen (2280)
U.S. Women's Champ., 04.08.2017



WHITE TO MOVE

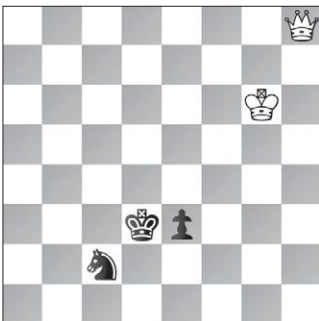
Avoiding 53. ... Rxg7+?? 54. Kxg7 when Black cannot stop the pawn!

54. Rg6!?



54. ... Rb8

Permanently ending White's hopes. For a moment, I was actually tempted by 54. ... Rxg6?!, when I had calculated 55. Kxg6 (55. hxg6 Nd5 is easy) 55. ... Nd5 56. h6 Ne7+. Now, I saw that 57. Kf7 Kf5! 58. Kxe7 Kg6 wins for Black, but, right in the nick of time, I realized that White has 57. Kg5!! and the knight is beautifully circumscribed by the king. It is worth mentioning, though, that Black can still salvage the game with 55. ... Kd3 (instead of 55. ... Nd5) 56. h6 e4 57. h7 e3 58. h8=Q Nc2!



White will not be able to make progress against the knight and far-advanced passer. I cannot help but mention that the ultra-natural 58. ... e2 actually loses according to the table

base: the breathtaking zigzag maneuver that the queen must undertake to separate the king from the pawn is left as an exercise to the reader.

55. h6 Nd5 56. Kg7 Rb7+ 57. Kf8 Kf5!

The last finesse; Black's monarch closes in for the kill.

58. Rg1 Nf6, White resigned.

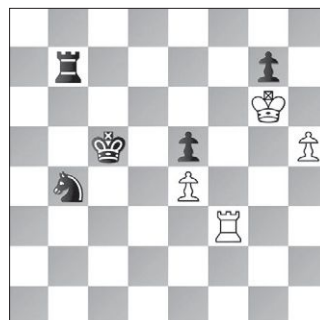
Due to the presence of the h-pawn, White does not even have any stalemate traps. With his clock ticking down, Akobian threw in the towel.

Gee, I told myself when I got back home. If only my Var could have salvaged a draw with some sort of study-like idea, this would make a great game for my next column! Of course, such to-good-to-be-true moments never happen in real life. Oh wait ...

Let's return to the initial position for a moment. Var was onto something with his knight-sacrifice idea: the only issue is that his implementation was too unwieldy; first he had to bring his king to h7, then maneuver his rook to g7, then remove his king from h7, but that takes about as much time as our president's handshake. What if there was a way to accomplish this idea in half the time?

Behold:

50. Nxb4!! Nxb4 51. Rf3!!



Like most paradoxical ideas, this one takes a bit of getting used to. White voluntarily gives

his knight away, and then casually brings his rook to f3? Surely, Black must have a way to stop the prosaic threat of Rf7, followed by Kxg7 and h6-h7! Well, he doesn't (and don't call me Shirley). By keeping his rook on f7, and his king on g7, White will guarantee safe passage for the pawn and simultaneously block off both Black's knight and king from reaching any meaningful squares. In my opinion, the reason this idea is so beautiful (and so difficult to see) is that it appears so ineffective: for the moment, White is actually down a full piece, and the g7-pawn is still intact! And yet, Black can do nothing but bail out. Take a look:

51. ... Kd4 52. Rf7 Rxf7 53. Kxf7 is an immediate draw: 53. ... Nd3! 54. Kxg7 Nf4 55. h6 Ne6+ 56. Kf6 and Black has to repeat.

51. ... Nc2 52. Rf7 (52. Rc3+ also draws.) 52. ... Rb6+ 53. Kxg7 Nd4 is somewhat more testing, but similarly futile: the cleanest draw is 54. Rf6! Ne6+ 55. Kf7 Ng5+ 56. Kg6.

51. ... Kd6 52. Rf7 Rb8 would probably be my choice, but 53. Kxg7 Ke6 54. Rf6+, is once again, an easy draw.

A fourth possibility is 51. ... Nd5! which is a draw but the path is tricky.

And there we have it: every rational, logical, human indicator points to the initial position being totally won for Black, but the beauty of chess (and of endgames in particular) often consists in this kind of logical illogicality (Yeah, sorry. Sue me). And it is only with the kind of creativity and even playfulness demonstrated by those at the very top that we can begin to grapple with Caissa's irascible spirit. ♠

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A Work of Art

Remembering one of Bisguier's greatest endgame performances

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IT IS UNFORTUNATE THAT 20TH-CENTURY American chess players are overshadowed by the fearsome specter of one Robert James Fischer. Though Bobby dominated the scene, he was far from the only shining star. Bisguier, who became a grandmaster in 1957 and remained an active tournament player for more than 50 years thereafter, led an illustrious chess career and became one of the first truly universal players. What better way to pay our respects than to analyze one of Art's greatest endgame performances, a true work of ... art. Fear not: the game is better than the pun.

WEAVING A NET

Arthur Bisguier
Weaver Adams
U.S. Open, Pittsburgh, 1946



AFTER 39. ... Kh6

17-year-old Arthur Bisguier has not fared particularly well against one of the most prominent American masters of the early 20th century. White has a pawn to the good, but his meager material advantage hardly compensates for Black's total positional domination. One look at Black's picture-perfect knight alone seems to portend bad news indeed for the teenage boy commanding the white pieces.

Many a strong player would have lost their cool at this point, but Bisguier uncorks a tremendous sequence of moves that wipes the smile right off Adams' face (okay, I don't think

Adams was actually smiling, but you get the point):

40. Qe6!

A fantastic decision. Sensing the potency of Black's queen-and-knight tandem, Bisguier forces the exchange of queens. The ensuing minor piece endgame resembles a textbook example of good knight dominating against bad bishop, but Bisguier has seen past the deceptive façade.

White had several other ways to hold the balance; for instance, 40. Bf3 Ng6 41. c4 Qa1+ 42. Ke2 Qb2+ 43. Kf1 Qc1+ 44. Kf2 Qxc4 45. h4! and my silicon friend gives the rather perplexing assessment of "0.00" that we all know too well. From a human perspective, though, 45. ... Qd4+ 46. Ke1 Qf6! saddles White with a Herculean defensive task.

40. ... Qxe6 41. dxe6 Kg7 42. Ba4!

Without this pretty bishop maneuver, White's position would have been near-hopeless. As it stands, the bishop flies to d7, securing the e6-pawn and permanently tying down Black's king.

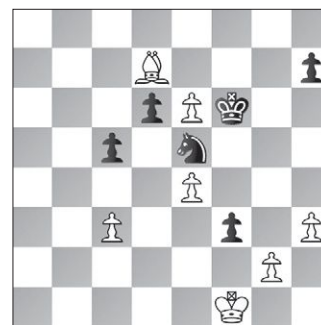
Before we move on to the fun part, I would like to draw your attention to the fact that the evaluation of the position hinges not on its salient positional characteristics, but on a serendipitous tactical resource. This is no freak occurrence:

Endgame masters intuitively understand that a single, outwardly insignificant element of the position—be it a hidden maneuver or a passed pawn or even a single weak square somewhere in Timbuktu—often bears more weight than all other features of the position put together.

42. ... Kf6 43. Bd7 f3?!

(see diagram top of next column)

With this move, Adams initiates a furious campaign to breach White's flimsy defensive



line. The issue with ... f4-f3 is more psychological than objective. In particular, Adams commits a psychological fallacy that every one of us has doubtless experienced more than once: having turned the game around after an opening debacle, Adams must have assumed that he no longer ran any risk of losing the game. As we've noted many times in this column, endgames are highly unpredictable animals: even when all static indicators seem to point your way, you can count on one hand the situations in which you truly can play without any risk.

Of course, there might be a simpler explanation to Adams' audacity: perhaps he was hoping that the young man sitting across from him would buckle under the pressure. But then again, who hasn't had similar thoughts before sitting down across from a 12-year old. And that didn't turn out too well, did it?

44. g3!

My guess is that Adams underestimated or overlooked this powerful retort. White isolates the f3-pawn, tasking the knight with yet another defensive job. All of a sudden, it transpires that White is the one with a clear plan of improvement: Kf2, followed by g4, Kg3, and h4 (when both ... Nxg4 or ... f3-f2 resources are not available to Black), and Black's defenses will be stretched awfully thin.

44. ... Nd3

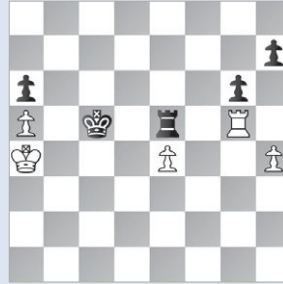
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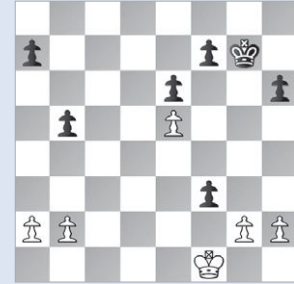
Ariel Mengarini
Arthur Bisguier
U.S. Championship, New York, 1954



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Arthur Bisguier
Vladimir Raicevic
Sombor, 1974



WHITE TO MOVE

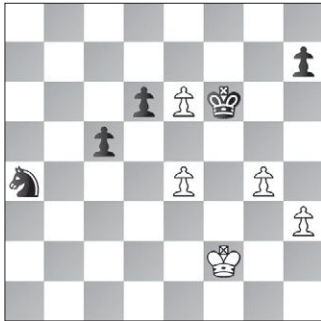
Adams stays on top, harnessing the knight's power to lock out White's king.

45. Bb5 Nb2?!

According to the computer, this move is just as good as 45. ... Ne5, which would have forced a repetition. But as we've established time and time again, simply consulting the engine's evaluation rarely tells the whole story. In fact, this unnecessary knight sally brings Black to the very precipice, and this time, Adams is not up to the challenge.

46. Kf2!

Excellent. Bisguier is not put off by the intimidating appearance of 46. ... Nd1+ after 47. Kxf3 Nxc3 48. Bc4! Na4 49. g4.



Black is busted: there is no way to stop g5+ followed by h4-h5-g6. The bishop can simply plant itself on d5 (after ... Nb6 or ... Nb2).

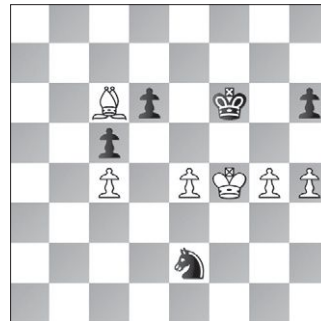
46. ... Kxe6 47. Kxf3 Ke5 48. g4

Yet again, Bisguier finds the only way to maintain the pressure. Black's knight has talked the talk, but has little to show for his efforts. The path to the draw now resembles a European alley rather than an American freeway—it's become awfully hard to breathe.

48. ... Nd1 49. c4 Nc3 50. Bc6 Nd1?

Adams continues to pin his hopes on the knight, but time has officially run out for the hapless cavalier. The cold-blooded 50. ... h6!

51. h4 Kf6, putting the emergency brakes on White's kingside pawn advance, was the only way to hold the draw. Adams might have missed that 52. Kf4 allows 52. ... Ne2+!, when the knight finally redeems itself and pushes the king back.



Otherwise, White has no way to make progress: the adventurous 52. g5+?! hxc5 53. h5 leads nowhere after 53. ... Nd1, while initiating a knight chase with 52. Ke3 is similarly futile: 52. ... Nd1+ 53. Ke2 Nc3+ 54. Kd2 Na2! and the knight escapes to b4 with room to spare.

51. g5!

No mercy. The hunter, as it were, becomes the hunted. By controlling the f6 and h6 squares, the pawn freezes Black's entire army. From d5, the bishop will come to the pawn's aid, permanently stopping the knight from mounting any counterplay on its own. White's plan is simple and deadly: he wants to play ...eh, why don't you show us yourself, Art?

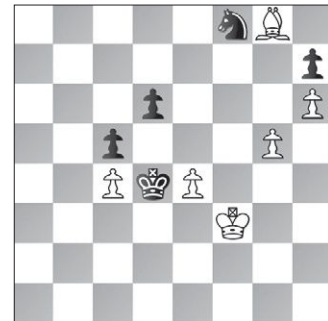
51. ... Nb2 52. Bd5 Nd3 53. h4 Nf4

The knight has finally admitted the futility of its manifold sallies and feints, but the sentence has already been handed down.

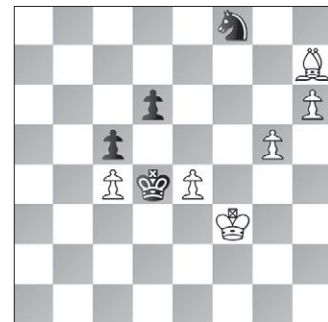
54. Bg8! Ng6 55. h5 Nf8

Or 55. ... Nh4+ 56. Kg4, with similarly tragic consequences.

56. h6 Kd4



57. Bxh7!



Do me a favor and compare this position with the initial diagrammed one. Did anyone say anything about bad bishops and good knights?

57. ... Nxh7 58. g6 Ng5+ 59. Kg4 Nxe4 60. h7 Nf6+ 61. Kg5, Black resigned.

What impresses me about this endgame is not only the fact that 17-year-old Bisguier soundly outplayed a reputable master, Magnus style, from a slightly worse position. It is also that the 17-year-old in question was way ahead of his time in both the accuracy of his calculation and the universality of his style. This guy, folks, was no pushover. ♠

Registered US Chess voters must return their Executive Board election ballot no later than 3:00 p.m. CDT on Tuesday, July 18, 2017.

The Power of Desperation

The more you believe in miracles, the more you doggedly search for resources even when all of the odds are stacked against you, the more Caissa will smile upon you.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

ONE THING THAT HAS CONSISTENTLY bugged me about endgame literature is the absence of advice on surviving lost positions. By lost positions, I mean *lost* positions. Now, it would seem that there is little to write about on this topic. If you're lost, little remains other than to set a perfunctory trap or two; once your opponent defeats this final show of desperation, you take your hat off, stop the clock, and extend your hand. Case closed.

The reality of the situation is a bit more complex. As we have seen time and time again:

Endgames are tremendously rich in defensive possibilities, and you can use this abundance of resources to mount a seemingly miraculous resistance in hopeless situations.

While this phrase borders on painful cliché, it is worth reminding yourself once in a while that—in the words of the immortal Yogi Berra—“it ain't over 'til it's over.” Let the following battle, which I have had on my bucket list of positions to analyze for quite a while now, serve as just such a reminder.

120-60

GM Ray Robson (2700)
IM John Daniel Bryant (2549)
2013 U.S. Championship (2), St. Louis,
Missouri, 05.04.2013



AFTER 36. bxc7

Black's position reminds me of the apocalyptic landscape from the movie *The Road*, or, for the TV-show minded readers, from *The Walking Dead*. Black is toast. Utterly, completely, totally, entirely lost. At the risk of belaboring the obvious, let's enumerate the various reasons for Black's imminent downfall:

- He is down, to be precise, a piece and two pawns.
- White threatens to play Rb8, and to promote the c-pawn.
- White has perfectly-placed pieces, and can develop fatal threats along the seventh rank in a matter of a few moves.
- The knight on d3 ensures that Black's so-called kingside “counterplay” is doomed to failure.

Stockfish 8, on a high depth, evaluates White's advantage to be in the range of +15. No, that is not a typo.

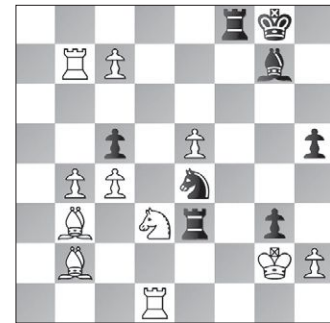
The time is ripe, in other words, to play something like 36. ... Rf2+, and to stop the clock after 37. Nxf2 Rxf2+ 38. Kh1! (38. Kg1?? gxh2+ 39. Kh1 Ng3 mate would be painful indeed) 38. ... Rxh2+ 39. Kg1.

If this were a basketball game, the score would be something like 120-60 (Warriors-Cavaliers, anyone)? However, this is chess, not basketball, and one of the most amazing—as well as one of the most cruel—properties of the game we love is that one moment is all it takes to irreversibly turn the tables. In basketball, there is only a three-pointer; in chess, you can score 60 points in one second.

36. ... Re3!

(see diagram top of next column)

From a computer standpoint, this move is indistinguishable from the rest. But from a practical standpoint, it presents White with a small challenge: he must deal with the threat of ... Re2+. In such a situation, the temptation to win as quickly as possible is immense. Let



us try to put ourselves in the shoes of GM Ray Robson and reconstruct his thinking process:

All right, Black is threatening ... Re2+. First thing that comes to mind is 37. Re1. But, wait a minute, after 37. ... Rxe1 38. Nxe1 Rf2+ 39. Kh1 Black has perpetual with 39. ... Rf1+. Okay, so the issue here is that I didn't have a rook on the first rank. So if I have a rook on the first rank, is there a reason to stop ... Re2+? What about 37. Rb8? After 37. ... Re2+ 38. Kh1 Rxh2+ 39. Kg1, we have a familiar situation, and Black is at a dead end. Time is ticking down, let's finish this one off.

Of course, we have no idea what Ray was actually thinking in this position, but something along these lines is quite conceivable. It would seem, in other words, that White is so winning that Black can't possibly have any freak defensive resources after 37. Rb8; the move just *feels* right. Doesn't it?

37. Rb8??

Believe it or not, this move loses by force. Which brings me to perhaps the most important thought of this month's column:

Chess is not a “linear” game. A small advantage can be a million times more stable than a large one. Oftentimes, simply looking at the computer's evaluation or judging a position by its superficial appearance is a recipe for failure.

Sure, White is completely, totally winning in this position, but that does not mean that

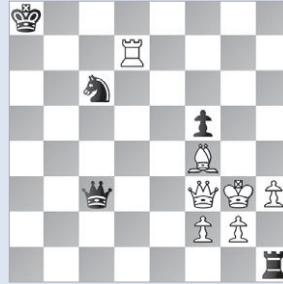
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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

WGM Masha Klinova (2353)
David Spence (2221)
Gibraltar Masters, 01.31.2006



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Vishnu Prasanna (2463)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2622)
Gibraltar Masters, 01.29.2015



BLACK TO MOVE

finding the path is easy. In fact, the correct move (instead of 37. Rb8) was far from simple: 37. Kg1!!, prophylaxis against the second-rank check. It transpires that after 37. ... Re2 38. hxxg3 Black's attack instantly fizzles out, while other tries on move 37 are similarly uninspiring:

- 1) 37. ... gxh2+ 38. Kxh2 Re2+ 39. Kg1 is game over;
- 2) 37. ... Nf2 38. Nxf2 gxf2+ 39. Kf1 and Black can resign.
- 3) 37. ... g2?! accomplishes nothing after 38. Rb8.

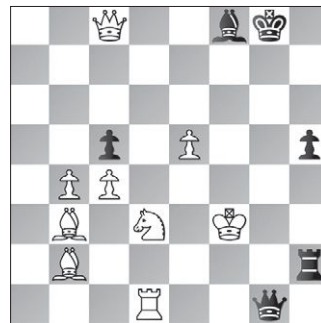
Before moving on, take a second and try to fully soak in the significance of this moment. Perhaps you can hark back to situations in your own career in which you either felt too safe in a completely winning position, or resigned (either physically or mentally) because the situation appeared too hopeless for any kind of resources.

37. ... Re2+ 38. Kh1 Rxh2+ 39. Kg1 Ng5!!



A dagger. Once this move is made on the board, it seems rather simple; *of course Black has ... Ng5, threatening ... Nf3+ soon followed by ... g3-g2-g1; how could one miss it?* However, in acute time pressure, it is infinitely easy to stop one's calculation after 39. Kg1, because Black is out of checks and White is just one square away from promotion. Believe it or not, White is dead lost, since there is no way to cover both the h3- and f3-squares simultaneously.

40. Rxf8+ Bxf8 41. Kf1 Nf3 42. c8=Q g2+ 43. Ke2 g1=Q+ 44. Kxf3



White has gone from the frying pan into the fire. While he has escaped immediate checkmate, Black has a rook and a queen right next to the naked king. This leads us to our second important lesson:

When you sense that the tables have turned, it is easy to let emotion dictate your subsequent moves. Try to stay as focused as possible, and to forget what happened previously.

One would think that, having turned the tables, it is actually easier to concentrate and finish off your opponent, but the reality is not as simple. Having swindled your opponent, we become susceptible to juvenile psychological errors, such as playing too fast or trying to win even if the correct decision is to make a draw. In this situation, Black has a forced mate, but there are several dead ends and Black has to fully calculate out the position in order to embark on the right path. While I do not know how long Bryant spent on this position, my guess is that it is somewhere in the realm of 15 minutes, as he found the forced mate and then conscientiously checked it over and over again. In chess, there are rarely second chances.

44. ... Qg2+ 45. Ke3

Even worse is 45. Kf4 Rh4+, since 46. Ke3 Re4 mate is curtains.

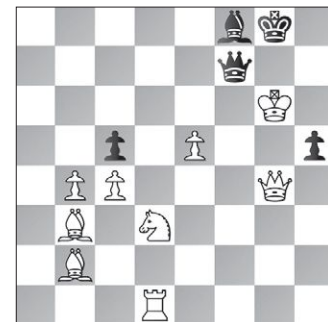
45. ... Qg3+!

Avoiding the naïve 45. ... Rh3+?!, which would have allowed 46. Qxh3. Black is still winning after 46. ... Bh6+, but work remains to be done after 47. Nf4.

46. Ke4 Rh4+ 47. Kf5

47. Kd5 Qf3+ with mate to follow.

47. ... Qf3+ 48. Kg6 Rg4+ 49. Qxxg4 Qf7+!



The last finesse. The king is driven into a corner and checkmated.

50. Kg5 Be7+ 51. Kh6+

Check!

51. ... hxxg4, White resigned.

Ugh. Black can "premove" 52. ... Qh7 mate.

Now, Daniel, I hear you say. *What you just showed me is a game in which one of the best and most talented American players simply had an unfortunate moment, probably due to acute time trouble.* While that is undoubtedly true, much of endgame mastery is psychological. The more you believe in miracles, the more you doggedly search for resources even when all of the odds are stacked against you, the more Caissa will smile upon you. You might not swindle every single game, but many players make a living off of their opponent's sloppiness. One of them is sitting behind a certain computer, typing the very words you are reading right now. ♠

“Endgame”: A Play in One Act

This month, a little bit of endgame theater

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

BOBBY FISCHER, a grandmaster and world champion from 1972-1975

DANIEL NARODITSKY, a patzer
STOCKFISH 8, a beast

ACT I, SCENE I

GM Paul Keres
GM Bobby Fischer
Curacao, 1962



AFTER 55. ... Qg5

56. Nf1?

BOBBY: A blunder on the last move of the second time-control. Perhaps Keres has allowed me to get a little too much out of the position, but he can still hold a draw with 56. Qe5+ Qxe5 57. dxe5 (threatening Bd7) 57. ... Rxa3 58. Nxe4, etc.

DANIEL: Makes sense. Maybe Black can try 56. ... Qf6, hoping for 57. Qxf6+ Kxf6 58. Bd7 Kg5. Ah, but then White plays 57. Qc7+, forcing a draw with 57. ... Qf7 58. Qe5+. If Black tries 57. ... Kh6, then 58. Qxg3! wins.

STOCKFISH: I'm not sure one can call 56. Nf1 a blunder, but yes, 56. Qe5+ draws.

56. ... Rh3+?

BOBBY: I had a feeling this might be a mistake, but time was short and I had to make a move—any move. “Patzer sees a check, gives a check.” But now the game can no longer be won. Correct is 56. ... Rxa3! 57. d5 g3 58. d6

(if 58. Bd7, then 58. ... Ra1 59. Kg2 Ra2+ 60. Kg1 Qf6 61. Bf5 Rf2 wins) 58. ... Ra1 59. Qe7+ (if 59. Kg1, then Qc5+ wins) 59. ... Qxe7 60. dxe7 h3! 61. e8=N+ Kf8 wins.

DANIEL: Wow, that is some fascinating stuff. Let's play these variations out on the board. It seems that the idea of ... Rxa3 is not so much to snag a pawn, but rather to jump to the first rank as quickly as possible. In the position after 58. ... Ra1, though, my intuition keeps telling me that White has some defensive resource that Bobby is missing. If only White can hold back the avalanche for a move or two, he will have enough time to mount some sort of counterplay against Black's king. Let's rifle through the options:

- 1) 59. Qd4+ Qf6 60. Qg4+ Kh6 and Black escapes the checks. *Darn.*
- 2) Okay, I like the idea of Qe7+, so why don't we start with 59. Kg2? Then, if 59. ... h3+, I can play 60. Kxh3 Rxf1 61. Qe7+, with at least a draw. If 59. ... Ra2+, then I have a nice little square on h3. So after 60. Kg1 g2 61. Qd4+ I think I have a perpetual. Could Bobby be wrong?! (*Saliva trickles down Daniel's chin.*)

STOCKFISH: (*Laughs metallically*) Well, well, well. Where shall we start? First of all, 56. ... Rxa3 is a mistake. After the incredibly stupid response 57. d5 (you humans never cease to amaze me, 57. Qe6 is best, drawing), Black wins with 57. ... Rf3 58. Kg1 Qf6 59. Qxg4+ Kh6. Bobby, your line 57. ... g3 58. d6 Ra1 actually gives White the draw with 59. Qd3! (not Daniel's idiotic suggestion 59. Kg2 h3+ 60. Kxh3 Rxf1 61. Qe7+ due to 61. ... Kh6) and if 58. ... Qf6 (58. ... Qg6 is +1.78 for Black), the simple 59. Kg2 ends Black's winning chances. Daniel, I will begrudgingly admit that your intuition served you right, though, to be quite frank, woe betides the organization that awarded either of you the grandmaster title.

Oh, I forgot to add one more thing. 56. ... Rf3 was the only way to maintain winning chances. The line 57. Kg1 Rf4 58. Qe5+ Qxe5

59. dxe5 is forced, and now 59. ... Rf5! 60. e6 Re5 yields decent chances.

57. Kg1 Rxa3 58. d5 g3

DANIEL: Was there any point in pushing the other pawn with 58. ... h3? I guess not: White could respond as in the game with 59. Bd7, and now 59. ... h2+ 60. Kxh2 doesn't look promising in the least.

59. Bd7! Ra1 60. Bf5!

BOBBY: The idea is to advance the pawn to d6 without allowing ... Qc5+. I must confess that I still expected to win. But now Keres really starts to find moves!

DANIEL: I can see why Bobby still expects to win. White's defensive construction looks real flimsy.

60. ... Qf6 61. Qf4 Re1

DANIEL: This looks forced too. Black stops Qc7+.

STOCKFISH: To be exact, there are 16 other moves that lead to the same evaluation. Want to know what is forced?

DANIEL: What?

STOCKFISH: Your face.

62. d6 Re5 63. Qg4+!

BOBBY: Not 63. d7? Rxf5 64. Qxf5 Qxf5 65. d8=Q Qf2+ and mate next.

DANIEL: Makes sense to me.

STOCKFISH: Actually, 63. Ne3 also drew. 63. ... Qxd6 64. Qxh4 and you can figure the rest out yourself.

63. ... Kf8 64. d7 Rd5

BOBBY: Now 64. ... Rxf5 65. d8=Q+ Qxd8 66. Qxf5+ draws.

DANIEL: Okay, the line makes sense. But what about 64. ... Ke7? I really don't want to tie the rook down. Oh, fudge, 65. Qg8 is game over.

65. Kg2!

DANIEL: Why is this so good? Well, I guess Keres is simply improving the position of his

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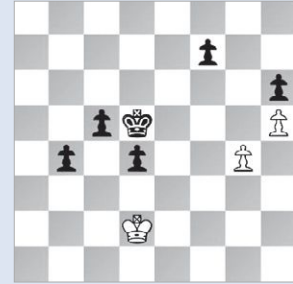
IM Twan Burg
FM Daniel Naroditsky
Wijk aan Zee 2009



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Kling & Horowitz, Study, 1851



WHITE TO MOVE

king and preventing a possible ... h3. Now that Black cannot give a second-rank check with his rook, this move becomes possible.

65. ... Rxd7!

BOBBY: On 65. ... Qb2+ 66. Kh3 Qf2 67. Be4! Qxf1+ 68. Bg2 Qf2 69. Qb4+! holds and possibly wins.

DANIEL: What a line! This king maneuver to h3 seems to be a recurring theme in this endgame. I faintly remember Nimzowitsch mentioning this concept of the king acting as a “dentist” and plugging cavities created by pawn chains. But ... wait a minute. In the position after 68. Bg2, can Black try 68. ... Qd1? Now, 69. Qb4+ Rc5! saves the rook and covers up the check. If White tries 69. Bxd5 instead, I can recapture on d5 and I don't see how White promotes the pawn. If, after 69. ... Qxd5 White tries 70. Kxh4, I can play, at the very least, 70. ... g2. Following 71. Qxg2 Qxd7 I'm not so sure that White has an easy draw. Could Black be winning after all?

STOCKFISH: Nice try, Patzer. After 68. ... Qd1, White draws with 69. Qf4+ Ke7 70. Qe4+. Didn't you see the hanging rook? I can recommend some good eye doctors in the area!

66. Bxd7!

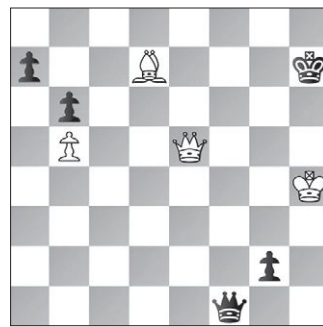
BOBBY: I thought this was a mistake at the time, but that he was lost anyway. Keres, however has seen just one move further—

66. ... Qf2+ 67. Kh3 Qxf1+ 68. Kxh4 g2 69. Qb4+ Kf7! 70. Qb3+ Kg7 71. Qg3+ Kh7!

BOBBY: Haven—at last. Now I was sure I had him. Surely he would go in for 72. Bf5+ Qxf5 73. Qxg2 Qf4+! 74. Qg4 (on 74. Kh3, Qh6+! wins) 74. ... Qxg4+ 75. Kxg4 Kg6! gaining the opposition and winning White's last pawn by force.

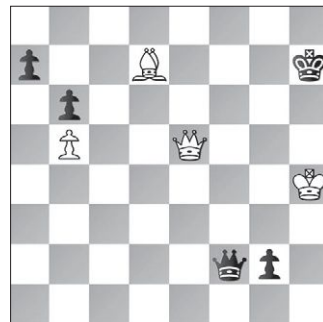
72. Qe5!!

(see diagram next column)



BOBBY: What's this? He makes no attempt to stop me from queening!? Gradually my excitement subsided. The more I studied the situation, the more I realized Black had no win.

DANIEL: No. Way. I can see that 72. ... g1=Q 73. Bf5+ is a draw, but in these situations, one can usually give a check to force the king onto an exposed square. What about 72. ... Qf2+? ...



... Then, the king can't move onto the g-file. Check. If 73. Kh5, I can play 73. ... Qf7+ and then promote. So that leaves 73. Kh3. But then Black can promote to a knight, 73. ... g1=N+! Surely the ensuing attack must be winning? Let's take a look: 74. Kg4 Qg2+. This looks like game over. 75. Kh5 Qg6+ followed by ... Nf3+. Otherwise, queen and knight just have to get the better of the king in such a situation. So what am I missing?

72. ... Qh1+?

DANIEL: WHAT?

BOBBY (*scoffs*): The main line also draws—by a miracle: 72. ... Qf2+ 73. Kh3 g1=Q (making a knight with check also doesn't win) 74. Bf5+ Kh6 75. Qf6+ Kh5 76. Bg6+! Qxg6 77. Qg5+!! Kxg5 Stalemate!

DANIEL: Have you gone mad, Bobby? Guards, take him away!

STOCKFISH: You're right about one thing. Bobby has gone mad. But, apparently, so have you: take a good, close look at the position after 74. ... Qg2+. Did you consider 75. Kf5?

DANIEL: Yes, I did! Then 75. ... Qh3+ wins a bishop.

STOCKFISH: ...

DANIEL: Oh, no. 76. Kf6 Qxd7 77. Qh5+ Kg8 78. Qg6+ with a perpetual.

73. Bh3 Qxh3+

BOBBY: 73. ... g1=Q 74. Qh5+ Kg7 75. Qg6+! forces stalemate or a perpetual.

DANIEL: That's pretty cool. Note to self: always watch out for stalemate if you have no more pawn moves left.

74. Kxh3 g1=Q 75. Qe7+

DANIEL: Alright, now this is obviously a draw.

75. ... Kh8 76. Qf8+ Kh7 77. Qf7+, Draw agreed.

NARRATOR: Today's column, as you could probably tell, featured something a little bit different. Daniel didn't have a clear goal in mind, but he's seen these sorts of chess articles in the past and always thought they were quite amusing, and sometimes even instructive. Please note that Daniel's own lines were not “made up”; he fully analyzed the position before turning on the beast. As for Stockfish's sass, I think Daniel might live to regret his asinine behavior.

Daniel's computer flickers to a Blue Screen of Death as an inhuman roar emanates from the screen.

THE END

Cliffhanger! Part I

Taking a look at one of the most fascinating endgames of recent times.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

AT THE TIME OF WRITING, THE 2017 Sinquefeld Cup is still ongoing, with GM Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (MVL) holding a narrow lead. A photo finish undoubtedly awaits, but endgame fans already have more than enough fodder to chew on. In round four, pre-tournament favorite GM Magnus Carlsen faced Vachier-Lagrave with the white pieces. After a quick exchange of queens, Magnus put on a vintage positional display, performing breathtaking gymnastics with his pieces to reach a dominating position by move 40. ~~And then he went on to convert his advantage smoothly.~~ No, let's not kid ourselves. What happened after move 40 was one of the most fascinating endgame (queenless middlegame) battles of recent times. Let's plunge in.

A FASCINATING BATTLE

GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2822, NOR)
GM Maxime Vachier-Lagrave
(FIDE 2789, FRA)
2017 Sinquefeld Cup (4), St. Louis,
Missouri, United States, 08.05.2017



AFTER 43. Nc4

We join the battle at a time of major crisis for the Frenchman with three names. Why is Black in trouble? Optically, Black's position looks more than acceptable: material is even, his pieces are well-coordinated, and there does not seem to be any obvious threats. As a matter of fact, two of these statements are wrong, and

understanding why is the first step in getting to the bottom of the position:

Black's pieces *look* active, but the knight on d3 is actually on the brink of death. It has no way to escape, and the simple plan of Rd2 followed by Kb1-c2 will make the cavalier regret the day it nonchalantly galloped into the lion's den.

It *appears* that White has no threat, but take a closer look. White threatens the prosaic Bb5-c6, winning the Exchange. More importantly, this threat is very hard to deal with, since removing either rook from the d-file will weaken the knight even further!

In light of this assessment, MVL realized that the time is ripe for desperate measures.

43. ... e5!

A savvy psychological decision. Besides its objective merit, this move also has the benefit of introducing an element of tactics into the position, which was beginning to resemble a one-sided game of cat and mouse. Of course, Black's pieces are not exactly ready to deal with the opening of the position, but the alternative was far less appealing.

44. fxe5

I like this move more than the myopic 44. Bc6, winning an Exchange but enabling Black to construct a monster fortress with 44. ... e4.

44. ... Bxe5?

MVL falls prey to a familiar illusion: the knight on d3. Now was his opportunity to rid himself of this plague for good with 44. ... Nxe5, when the technical task ahead of Carlsen would have been tremendously difficult. After 45. Bf4 Kg7 46. Ne3 ...

(see diagram top of next column)

... Black's position is on the brink of collapse, since 46. ... R5d6 is crushed by 47. Nxg4 fxg4 48. Re2 with decisive threats.

A few columns ago, I spoke about the dangers of "going with the flow," a psychological error



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 46. Ne3

that is highly related to the common error of assuming that a certain line is forced. But by now, you should be well aware that a complex endgame features twists and turns at every juncture, and this position is no exception: Black has the fantastic rejoinder 46. ... c4!!, sacrificing the Exchange to wrest the initiative from White's hands. Following 47. Nxd5 Rxd5 48. Be8 (48. Bxe5 Bxe5 49. Bxc4 Ra5+ is a mess) 48. ... Bf3! the bishop re-routes to e4, ensnaring the king in a sudden mating net. To maintain the edge, White must sacrifice back the Exchange with 49. Rxf3 Nxf3 50. Re2, but 50. ... Ne5 keeps decent drawing chances. White should probably win with precise technique, but that knight and rook are awfully active.

45. Bg5!

Crunch! This move, attacking the rook and hinting at Ne3, just feels right. Now, 45. ... Bf6 46. Bxf6 Kxf6 47. Bc6 loses the Exchange—this time for no compensation at all—so MVL picks up the gauntlet.

45. ... Bxg3

(see diagram next page)

This is the famous position seen round the world. First things first: 46. Rd2 would have finished off the game in just a few moves. Black's position simply collapses at the seams: after 46. ... Rf8 several moves win, but the classy 47. Ka3! creates the unstoppable threat of 48. Ne3,

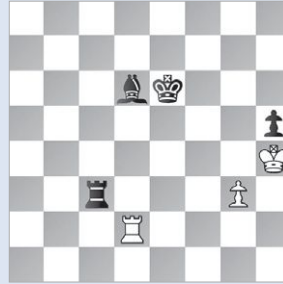
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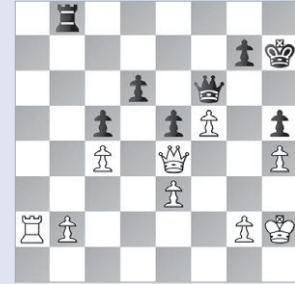
GM Levon Aronian (2799)
GM Fabiano Caruana (2807)
Sinquefeld Cup (2), 08.03.2017



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (2789)
GM Peter Svidler (2751)
Sinquefeld Cup (3), 08.04.2017



BLACK TO MOVE



winning a piece (that knight on d3 again). The immediate 47. Ne3? would have allowed needless complications after 47. ... Nc1+.

Black can try leaving the rook on d8 with 46. ... Ke6, but the same mechanism seals the deal: 47. Ka3! f4 (to stop Ne3) 48. Nxb6! axb6 49. Bc4, with a rather tragic situation in which Black's position literally collapses like a house of cards.

And that is all there is to it. But Magnus, after nine minutes of thought, spotted an easier path. All roads lead to Rome, right?

46. Rg2??

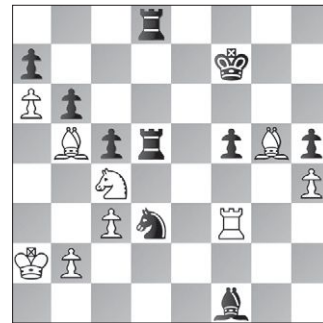
Observing this game without a computer, I was initially not very surprised when Magnus played this move. As Russians like to say, though, it is always easier to kibitz than to play, so it took me just a few moments to spot the massive tactical blunder contained in his calculations. This move does not give Black any choice: two pieces are attacked, so MVL must oblige.

46. ... Bh3! 47. Rxc3 Bxf1 48. Rf3?¹

(see diagram next column)

This was the fulcrum on which Magnus' concept pivots. I turned on the live commentary at this point, and—at the risk of sounding like an armchair general—I was a bit disappointed with the way the commentators interpreted this move. Once you see the computer's evalu-

¹In the interest of objectivity, I should mention that 48. Bxd8 Rxd8 49. Rf3! still held a draw.



ation it is easy to assume that Magnus simply lost his mind, and that is precisely the conclusion that the commentators arrived at:

Maurice: "He's just forcing Black to make good moves! ... Be2 what is he do—what is his plan? What has just happened?"

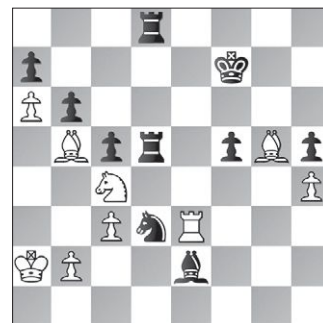
Yasser: "... Be2, (White) resigns."

Jen: "He was thinking about something on b6, I gather."

But now imagine that this game was played in 1972, and that the moves were arriving to the commentators via telegram. If you turn off the silicon fiend and set the position up on a real, wooden board, the situation becomes a little bit easier to diagnose.

48. ... Be2

This is forced, and now—once I looked at this position on my own for a second—I realized that Magnus' intention is 49. Re3.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 49. Re3

In the absence of all tactics, the game is simply over: for instance, 49. ... Bf1 (49. ... Bg4 50. Bxd8 Rxd8 51. Rxd3) 50. Re7+ Kf8 51. Rxa7 and Black can resign. What Magnus missed, as MVL made clear in the post-mortem, is the ghastly resource 49. ... f4!, when the bishop is untouchable due to ... Nc1+. Now, 50. Re7+ Kg6 51. Rxa7 no longer works because the passer is so far-advanced: 51. ... Rxc3 52. hxc3 f3! and Black is winning. Without this resource, White is simply an Exchange down with nothing to show for it!

The explanation for the disastrous chain of moves that led to White's downfall is a straightforward one: the c1-square simply fell out of Magnus' field of vision.

Two cautionary thoughts come to mind here. The first is Bent Larsen's famous quip "long variation, wrong variation." The second is the notion that unorthodox knight forks, especially those occurring on unexpected squares, can be very difficult to spot, especially when your king is safe and there is nothing to prime your tactical detector.

Magnus did not hallucinate, and he did not lose his mind. He doubtless saw Rd2, but chose Rg2 because it is a bit more forced and takes some of the chaos off the board. But, as we see time and time and time again, everything always hinges on that one tactical detail.

If you think that the game is over, and that Magnus went down without a fight, you are very wrong. The intrigue, in many ways, is just beginning. White is objectively lost, but Magnus found a brilliant way to breathe some defensive life into his position. And you, my dear reader, will have to wait another month until we conquer the remainder of this incredible endgame.

By the way, I hate cliff-hangers too ... ♠

Cliffhanger! The Conclusion

If you are late to the party and have not read last month's column, doing so—while not strictly necessary to follow this month's notes—would greatly enhance your experience.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

A CLIFF HANGER IS THE MOST MADDENING, teeth-rattling, insomnia-inducing literary entertainment device that ever graced the face of the earth. The last time I thought of this phrase was on a faceless Sunday evening last winter break, when I binge-watched season one of *Stranger Things* and came to the unfortunate realization that it was 7 p.m., I had not yet brushed my teeth, and—most infuriating of all—I would have to wait more than a year until I could repeat this experience all over again. O tempora! O mores!

Being the devious little wretch that I am, I decided to orchestrate my own little cliff hanger. Last month, we examined the first part of a fascinating endgame battle between GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2850, NOR) and GM Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (FIDE 2789, FRA) at the 2017 Sinquefeld Cup. Upon reaching the climax, at the very moment when the position was about to erupt in tactical fireworks, we stopped. Well, season two has arrived.

SEASON TWO

GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2850, NOR)
GM Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (FIDE 2789, FRA)
2017 Sinquefeld Cup (4), St. Louis,
Missouri, 08.05.2017



AFTER 48. ... Be2

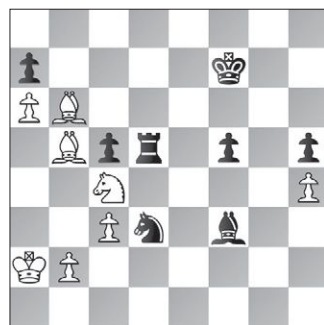
We pick up right where we left off. Magnus, having put on a brilliant display to reach a

winning position, initiated a seemingly decisive combination that actually contains a fatal flaw. Recall that his intended move 49. Re3, which seems to create the unstoppable threats of Rxe2 and Re7+, falls prey to the devastating shot 49. ... f4!!, when the bishop is untouchable due to the fork on c1 (a crucial detail that Magnus overlooked). Without Re3, White is down an Exchange and a pawn with little to show for it. So, game over?

49. Bxd8!

Not by a long shot. There is a reason why Magnus is Magnus; many reasons, actually. One of them consists in his ability to “stop the bleeding.” **Where others would fold over and die, Magnus will hunker down and unearth every last tactical resource.** After this capture, the rooks will leave the board, but White's minor pieces will be ideally placed to mount a furious resistance.

49. ... Bxf3 50. Bxb6



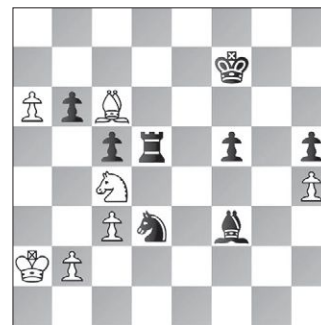
The point. The pawn that Magnus so assiduously marched to a6 finally begins to pay dividends.

50. ... axb6

Declining the sacrifice is not an option: something like 50. ... f4 would very clearly play into White's hands after 51. Bxa7. For instance, 51. ... Be4 52. Bb6 f3 53. a7 Nc1+ (simply temporarily stopping the pawn requires a

tremendous feat of positional gymnastics; 53. ... Rf5 fails to 54. Nd6+ and 53. ... f2 54. a8=Q f1=Q 55. Qe8+ is quite sad) 54. Ka3 Rd1 55. Ne3 Re1, and now a straightforward tactical sequence clears off the final obstacle: 56. Bc4+ and any king move (or, to be more precise, any move at all) is met by 57. Nd5, winning.

51. Bc6!



This is the point. Magnus refrains from the naïve 51. a7, which loses instantly to 51. ... Rd8. Black is now a full rook up, but his pieces have seemingly gone absent without leave. How, exactly, does MVL stop the pawn from promoting?

This position is a good illustration of the tiresome “endgames are all tactics” platitude. Even in endgames that start out in deeply positional waters, there is bound to be at least one moment in which the outcome will be decided by tactical vision and calculation alone.

51. ... Be4!!

A brilliant move, aesthetically pleasing and objectively powerful at the same time. It is actually very logical: the immediate 51. ... Rd8 is impossible because the bishop is hanging, so MVL moves the bishop to a protected square.

While observing this game live, I remembered, with a measure of satisfaction, a very similar motif that made its way into one of my own games. And what better way of

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Magnus Carlsen (2827)
GM Bu Xiangzhi (2714)
World Cup, 09.09.2017



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM S.P. Sethuraman (2543)
IM Daniel Naroditsky (2472)
Wijk aan Zee, 11.25.2011



BLACK TO MOVE

showing it than to give it as an exercise? (See the Practicum.)

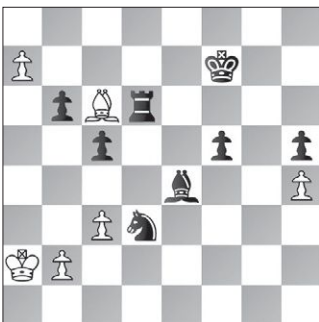
52. a7

Forced. The “clever” 52. Nxb6 would actually be a terrible mistake: 52. ... Rd8 53. Bxe4 fxe4 54. a7 e3 55. a8=Q Rxa8 56. Nxa8 e2 and White has missed the forest for the trees. It also bears mentioning that 52. Bxd5+ Bxd5 loses on the spot because the knight is pinned, and 53. b3 b5 54. Nb6 Bc6 leads to a familiar situation. The bishop will give itself up for the pawn and the f-pawn will promote.

52. ... Rd8 53. Nd6+!

Magnus being Magnus. Indeed, this seems to be the saving grace: taking the knight allows promotion, while after something like 53. ... Ke6 54. Nxe4 fxe4 55. Bxe4 White is going to promote and leave the worst behind him. Right?

53. ... Rxd6!

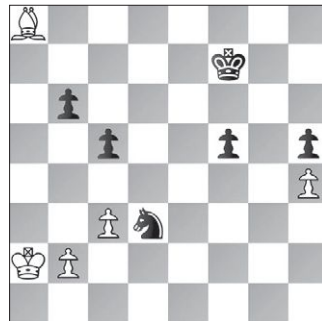


Top-tier, mind-expanding chess. Many players would rule this move out due to 54. a8=Q, but MVL isn't fooled for a second. After 54. ... Rxc6 Black slices off White's last remaining minor piece, and he is left with a lone queen against Black's fearsome army of pieces and pawns.

White's only chance is to deliver some sort of perpetual, but with so many pieces able to lend protection, he has no hope. I played this position out against the computer, and our

game is a rather sorry sight: 55. Qh8 f4 56. Qxh5+ Ke7 57. Qg5+ Rf6 58. Qg7+ Rf7 59. Qg5+ Ke6 60. Qh6+ Rf6 with ... f3 to follow.

54. Bxe4 Rd8 55. a8=Q Rxa8+ 56. Bxa8



Even Magnus cannot pull any more rabbits out of the hat. Certain commentators called this endgame easily winning for Black. It certainly looks that way; how on earth is White going to stop that passed (and extra) f-pawn? While the bishop's blockade is a sorry sight indeed, it will give White just enough time to mobilize the sleeping king. In order to finish off the beast, Black will have to demonstrate some finesse.

56. ... Ne5 57. Kb3 f4 58. Kc2 Kg7

It takes the computer some time to warm to this move, but from a human perspective, the Frenchman's technique is beyond reproach. The immediate 58. ... Ng6 meets with 59. Bf3, when the pawn cannot be defended. MVL recruits the monarch to solve this problem. A slightly more precise way to do the same thing would have been 58. ... Kg6, forcing 59. Be4+ (59. Kd2 Kf5 is even worse). Now, after 59. ... Kh6 Black has relocated his king to the optimal square and has saved a tempo in doing so.

59. Kd2 Ng6 60. Kd3 Nxe4 61. Ke4 f3 62. Ke3

This is why 58. ... Kg6 would have been more precise. Magnus, being Magnus, has found

the peskiest way to defend. Black is now two pawns up, but disentangling the Gordian knot on the kingside is actually harder than it looks.

62. ... Kf6 63. b4 c4!

Keeping all of the pawns alive. The dreadful 63. ... cxb4?? would have actually let the win slip, since Black will need as much material as possible on the queenside in order to guarantee the success of the ensuing diversionary plan.

64. Bd5 Kf5

It might seem that MVL is spinning his wheels in mud: after 65. Kf2 Kf4 66. Bc6, the bishop maintains contact with the f3-pawn and makes further progress impossible. For the non-materialists among you, the illusion should be easy to perceive: with 66. ... Nf5! 67. Bxf3 h4 Black simply brings the curtain down.

There isn't even anything to calculate: the outside passer is simply too much to handle. For instance, 68. Bg2 Ne3 69. Bf3 h3 70. b5 Ng4+! 71. Ke2 Nf6 with the devastating 72. ... Ne4 to follow. Note that this variation, while not particularly exciting, reinforces the notion that piece activity is often worth sacrificing for in the endgame, **even when material is limited**.

65. Bxc4 Kg4 66. Kf2 Ng6!

Same drill. Knight reactivated, game over.

67. Be6+ Kf4 68. Bf7 Ne5 69. Bxh5 Nd3+ 70. Kf1 Kg3 71. Bf7 Nf2, White resigned.

Magnus has actually equalized material, but the situation is more one-sided than ever. The knight has two paths to e3—via Paris (Charles de g4) and Rome (d1 International Airport), and the bishop cannot ground both flights at the same time!

Unfortunately, the final episode of Breaking Carlsen has come to an end. ♠

See this game annotated by GM Robert Hess in our Sinquefeld Cup story on page 27.

A Heartwarming Narrative

Examining the final stage of Tarjan's defeat of Kramnik

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

DURING MY SENIOR YEAR OF HIGH school, I took an elective history class called "The Power of Memory." The class offered a fascinating look into the way that historical events and individuals are remembered—and misremembered—by the public.

The final project for the class was to "contribute to an individual or institution dedicated to public memory." As luck would have it, the project time frame corresponded with a request put out by IM John Donaldson, Director of the Mechanics' Institute Chess Club in San Francisco. Donaldson was looking for a volunteer to decipher more than 100 score sheets.

There was a twist. These were not obscure encounters between club players. They were heretofore unpublished games played by one GM James Tarjan during his tour of American open tournaments in the 1970s.

Thirty years after retiring from chess to become a librarian, Tarjan reentered the world of competitive chess. And in September 2017 he defeated none other than Vladimir Kramnik in round three of the Isle of Man International. Let's celebrate this heartwarming narrative by examining the brilliant final stage of Jim's immortal win. (*Note: the first part of this game is reviewed on pages 20-21 by GM Robert Hess. ~ed.*)

THE RETURNED

GM James Tarjan (FIDE 2412, USA)
GM Vladimir Kramnik (FIDE 2803, RUS)
Chess.com Isle of Man International Masters 2017, 09.25.2017

(see diagram top of next column)

In a rare departure from custom, we join the battle in a marvelously complex middlegame. Worry not, friends—I have not forgotten the title of this column. Kramnik has played a model positional game, and he has built up a dominating position. Smelling blood, he mounts a fantastic decisive positional combination. Or so it seems.



AFTER 30. exd4

30. ... Bf3?

Imaginative, impressive, imposing, and—tactically flawed. On a better day, Kramnik would have undoubtedly chosen to calmly nourish his advantage with 30. ... b6, protecting the c5-square and preparing the maneuver ... Ng5-f3. White can hold on with 31. Rb2, but the defensive task facing him after 31. ... Ng5 32. Bd2 Nf3+ 33. Bxf3 Bxf3 will be a difficult one indeed.

31. Bxf3!

Viewing the course of the game in the comfort of one's room, with the engine coldly illuminating the extent of human imperfection, it is tempting to label the 30. ... Bf3 move a horrifying, inexplicable hallucination. How could a player of Kramnik's caliber overlook that 31. ... Qxf1 meets with 32. Be2, trapping the queen? While such a mishap is undeniably rare, it is also perfectly understandable.

During a game, we use certain mental heuristics in order to streamline the thinking process. One of these cognitive shortcuts is intuition, and the position after 31. ... Qxf1 appears so one-sided, so visually appealing, that Kramnik most likely didn't even entertain the possibility that his scheme contains a fatal flaw.

It should also be pointed out that Tarjan deserves credit for not trusting his opponent. The moral of the story is simple: **never take**

your opponent's word, especially when it comes to tactics.

31. ... Nxg3?

Having diagnosed the severity of the situation, Kramnik furiously backpedals ... straight into a technically lost position. It turns out that 31. ... Qxf1 32. Be2 is not game over; Black has a surprising resource in 32. ... Nxg3!. Following 33. Bxf1 Nxf1+ 34. Kg2 Rxe1, we reach a fascinating tactical position.



ANALYSIS AFTER 34. ... Rxe1

In his postmortem analysis, Tarjan revealed that he had calculated this line and considered 35. Qf4 to be winning for White. It sure seems that way: after all, the knight is entombed on f1 and White is one move away from ravaging Black's position with Rc7. However, it transpires that the knight—paralyzed though it may be—still possesses massive attacking potential. This potential can be realized by mobilizing the rook with 35. ... R8e6!, creating the massive threat of ... Rg6+. White is actually in big trouble, since the stubborn 36. Rc8+ Kh7 37. Qxf7 loses material after 37. ... Rg6+. White has a rather unappealing choice between 38. Kf3 Nd2 leading to mate and, for the masochistically-minded, 38. Kh1 Ne3+ 39. Kh2 Rg2 mate which means White must play 38. Qxg6+.

For this reason, White should prefer the tame 35. Qb2, intending to meet 35. ... R8e6 with 36. Rc1. White threatens to root out a

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See the solutions on page 69.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Ian Walton (2205)
GM James Tarjan (2479)
Pokerstars Isle of Man Masters, 2015



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM James Tarjan (2415)
GM Duncan Suttles (2485)
Chicago, 1973



WHITE TO MOVE

vital cog in Black's attacking machine, so he must deliver perpetual with 36. ... Rg6+ 37. Kh1 Ng3+ 38. Kh2 Nf1+.

That both Kramnik and Tarjan misevaluated this position is no coincidence. The temptation to conflate endgames with the absence of tactical or attacking opportunities is immense. It is my sincere hope that readers of this column will be among the select group of individuals who are cognizant of this fallacy.

32. fxg3 Qxf1 33. Bf2

Black has saved his queen, but it is a pyrrhic victory if there ever was one. Tarjan correctly recognizes that any endgame will be lost for Black, since the uncontested pair of bishops will dominate with no regard for enemy pieces.

33. ... Qd3 34. Rc3 Qf5 35. Kg2 Rf6 36. Qc2!

Classy. Tarjan continues to use the threat of liquidation in order to induce further concessions.

36. ... Qd7 37. g4 Rc6 38. Rc5 Rd8



Even in crisis, Kramnik is a very tough customer. It is precisely in this technical stage—when a player must find a concrete way to build on his decisive advantage and carve out an actionable path to victory—that many players struggle. Yet Tarjan is more than up to the task.

39. Qf5!

Liquidation for the win! A lesser player might have been scared by the passed pawn that Black is able to create, but Tarjan sees right through any illusions.

39. ... Rxc5

A sad necessity: avoiding the queen trade with 39. ... Qe7 would have brought on defeat even faster after 40. Rxd5.

40. Qxd7 Rxd7 41. dxc5 d4 42. Kf1!

Yet another excellent move, recruiting the monarch to freeze Black's last remaining source of counterplay. The path to victory is conceptually simple: create a passed pawn on the queenside. However, when facing a giant like Kramnik, one can be assured in the notion that sharp rocks will be hiding even under the shallowest of waters.

42. ... d3 43. Ke1 d2+ 44. Kd1

As per usual, sober calculation transcends all appearances. The pawn is permanently contained, and now White must skillfully maneuver his bishops in order to pick it off while preserving the queenside pawn majority.

44. ... Kf8 45. Bg3

Razor-sharp precision. The myopic 45. Be3?! led to unnecessary complications after 45. ... Rd3!, when White actually loses a bishop. However, he is still winning after 46. Bxb7 Rxe3 47. c6, but why complicate the task?

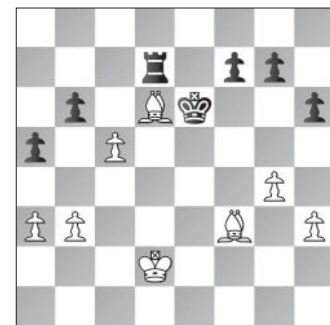
45. ... Ke7 46. Bd6+ Ke6 47. Kxd2

Mission accomplished. Now, onto the decisive stage.

47. ... b6!

(see diagram next column)

Like thousands of other fans, I was watching the live transmission with bated breath. *Come on, Tarjan*, I thought. *48. b4 and game over!* And then, in a flash of realization, I realized that the evil man handling the black pieces had set



a vicious trap. Do you see it? After 48. b4, Black orchestrates a brilliant liquidating operation with 48. ... axb4 49. axb4 bxc5 50. bxc5 Rxd6+!! 51. cxd6 Kxd6, and the tables have turned! There is no way to stop ... Ke5 and ... f7-f5, when White will be left with the wrong-color pawn. For instance, 52. Ke3 Ke5 53. Be4 g6! 54. Bb1 f5 55. Kf3 fxg4+ 56. hxg4 Kf6 57. Kf4 g5+! followed by ... h6-h5.

48. Ke3!

Played quickly and confidently. Just so we know who we're dealing with.

48. ... bxc5 49. Bxc5

Now, it is all over. The pawn simply marches onward, powered by the bishops.

49. ... Rd8 50. b4 axb4 51. axb4 f5 52. b5 fxg4 53. hxg4 g6 54. b6 h5 55. g5!

The last finesse. Maintaining a pawn on the kingside ensures that there will be no miracle draw to speak of.

55. ... Kd7 56. b7, Black resigned.

There is no stopping Ba7 followed by b8=Q, after which White will feast on Black's remaining pawns.

Perhaps 30 years from now another student will now take Power of Memory and finish what I started, deciphering Tarjan's scoresheets with the help of an application on his iPhone 436! ♠

Lombardy's Endgame Skills

The teenaged William Lombardy shows his talents in the World U-20 Championship.

By GM DANIEL NARODITSKY

NEWS OF A GRANDMASTER'S PASSING fills the chess community with deep sadness, serving as a reminder that no title or rating can insulate a chess player from the harsh reality of death. Yet "as a day well spent brings happy sleep," remarked Leonardo da Vinci, "a life well spent brings happy death."

The life of GM William Lombardy, who passed away at age 79 on October 13, 2017, was certainly well spent. He is most famous for his role as Bobby Fischer's second and confidant, a role that would come to be immortalized in book and film after the 1972 World Championship match between Fischer and Spassky. Make no mistake: Lombardy was a fearsome player in his own right, attaining the grandmaster title in 1960 after scoring 12/13 to lead the United States to a gold medal at the 1960 World Student Team Championship.

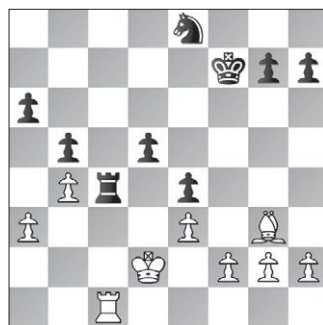
The assiduous chronicler of Lombardy's rich life would be remiss without at least a passing mention of Lombardy's skill in the endgame. It was often precisely in the final stage of the game when Lombardy's brilliant positional understanding and devilish eye for tactical nuance came to the fore. In this month's column, we will pay our respects to this humble servant of American chess by reaping the instructive value from one of his most memorable endgame performances.

MEMORABLE

William Lombardy
Erkki Makelainen
World Junior Chess Championship (10),
Toronto, Canada, 1957

(see diagram top of next column)

Having started the World Under-20 Championship with a lackluster 9/9, Bill has come up against a stalwart opponent in the talented Finnish junior Erkki Makelainen (*sometimes his name is given as Timo O. Makelainen or Erkki Makinen. ~ed.*). The position appears totally lifeless: the c-file is permanently closed off and



AFTER 27. ... Rc4

there are no points of entry for either side. Unwilling to concede to a draw just yet, Lombardy mounts a display of virtuosity that would make Bobby Fischer himself jealous.

28. Rxc4!

This move does not change the objective evaluation, but it is only the way for White to make progress. Black will have a rather fearsome passed pawn in the ensuing minor piece ending, but the price he will pay for it rivals the monthly rent of an apartment in San Francisco (or the yearly Stanford tuition rate ... not that I would know).

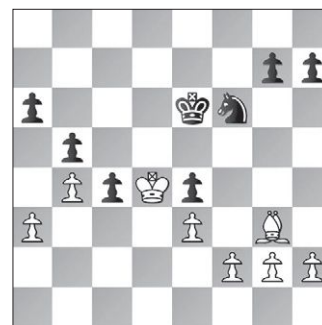
28. ... dxc4

This is forced, since 28. ... bxc4? allows White to create a monstrous passed pawn on the queenside. After 29. Kc3 Ke6 30. Kd4, the combined threats of f2-f3, undermining Black's pawn chain, and a3-a4 followed by b4-b5 should decide the game in White's favor.

29. Kc3 Ke6 30. Kd4 Nf6

(see diagram top of next column)

The point of the rook trade is clear: Black's knight is squarely relegated to defending e4, and White's king has permanently sealed off the center. The logical question, of course, is whether or not White can do anything with his positional trumps. Straightforward attempts



to win the e4-pawn by eliminating the knight lead nowhere: 31. Bh4 meets with 31. ... Kf5, when 32. Bxf6 gxf6 is a dead draw and any other move is met by ... g5, kicking the bishop away. But at least this is better than 31. Be5??, which is a terrible blunder on account of (do you see it?) 31. ... c3!! 32. Bxf6 c2, and the pawn promotes (that dang king on d4!).

It is at this juncture that Lombardy—still a teenager—demonstrates a practical and psychological awareness well beyond his years.

31. h3!

I'm in love with this move, even if it is not, objectively speaking, all that good. It is a rather impetuous overture, implying that White is so comfortable with his present state, so dismissive of Black's fearsome protected passer, that he can bide his time with esoteric pawn moves. But this move also contains a more insidious intention: given enough time, White will move his bishop to h2, and will threaten to run the g-pawn up the board and pry the knight's fingers away from the e4-pawn. This is nothing that Black can't deal with, but Makelainen may have felt a pang of anxiety creep up his spine. And he decides, understandably enough, to resolve the situation before it gets messy.

31. ... Nd5?

Makelainen must have assumed that 32. Kxe4 is forced, and correctly judged that after 32. ... Nc3+ 33. Kd4 (33. Kf3 Nb1 will also lead to a

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

William Lombardy
Abe Turner,
New York, 1957



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM William Lombardy
IM Kick Langeweg
Siegen, 09.12.1970



WHITE TO MOVE

draw, since anything other than 34. Ke4 or 34. Ke2 is asking for trouble) 33. ... Ne2+ 34. Ke4 Black draws comfortably, either by repetition or by snatching the bishop. But Lombardy has cooked up a divine tactical resource. Before the big reveal, it is worth mentioning that 31. ... g5 (among other moves) prevented White's plan and kept the status quo. And after something like 32. f3 exf3 33. gxf3 Nd5 34. e4 Nf4 35. Bxf4 gxf4, it is time to shake hands.

32. Be5!!

How about them apples? The king and bishop—laughably awkward as they appear—nonetheless join forces to corner the e4-pawn and restrain Black's passer in the process. The immediate tactical justification is that 32. ... c3 no longer works: 33. Kxe4 c2 34. Bb2 and the pawn is easy pickings for the king.

But Black has embarked on a path of no return, because 32. ... Nf6 meets with 33. Bxf6 and Kxe4, when the pawn ending offers a real-life example of a classic study motif (more on this below). Believe it or not, 31. ... Nd5 is—yes—a decisive mistake.

32. ... g6

Makelainen tries to limit the damage as best he can, but the disappearance of the e4-pawn heralds utter devastation. It was probably worthy muddying the waters with 32. ... Nc3, though Black's prospects are similarly grim after the smoke clears: 33. Bxg7 Nd1 (33. ... Nb1 34. Kxe4 Nxa3 35. f4 is crushing) 34. Kxe4 Nxf2+ 35. Kf3 Nd3 36. e4 and White should win by slowly advancing the kingside pawn majority. I'll employ a cringe-worthy authorial cop-out and encourage readers to check my conclusion on their own. Sue me.

33. Kxe4 Nf6+?!

This accelerates Black's defeat, though converting the pawn ending will nonetheless demand rather impressive precision from White. Still, it was worth keeping the minor

pieces on the board with 33. ... c3. To be fair, following 34. f4 c2 35. Bb2 the win is quite straightforward.

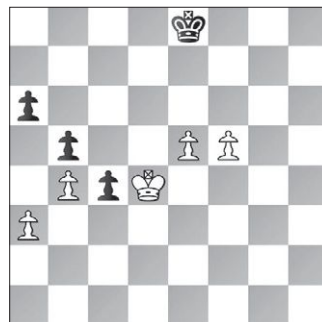
34. Bxf6 Kxf6

At first blush, it might appear that the position is utterly drawn, since White's king can never move too far from the pawn. But conscientious students of the endgame will quickly realize that this assessment is specious. And Lombardy, of course, was a conscientious student of the game indeed.

35. f4

The first phase of the winning plan is straightforward: White needs to create a pair of connected passers and push them as far as they will go without the monarch's support.

35. ... h5 36. g4 hxg4 37. hxg4 Ke6 38. Kd4 Kf6 39. e4 Ke6 40. e5 Ke7 41. f5 gxf5 42. gxf5 Ke8



The easy part is done, but what now? White can go so far as to push one of his pawns to the sixth rank, but Black's king will simply waltz between e7 and f6 (or e6 and f7).

The crux of the matter is that White *can* use his king to help the pawns, resulting in simultaneous promotion. This paradoxical statement is actually the subject of a great many classical pawn endgame studies. The skeleton line goes something like this: 43. e6 Ke7 44. Ke5! c3 45. f6+ Ke8 46. Kd6 c2 47.

f7+ Kf8 48. Kd7 c1=Q 49. e7+ Kxf7 50. e8=Q+, etc.

But there's a problem: simultaneous promotion is cool, but White is actually trying to win. The challenge, then, is to modify the initial conditions such that the extra tempo White obtains from promoting with check becomes decisive.

43. a4!!

Simply brilliant. Lombardy is not undermining anything with this move; he is simply pushing the pawn through to a5. The point is that once White's newly-minted queen picks up the defenseless pawn on a6, he will be only a few steps away from promotion. Take a moment to conceptualize this idea in your own terms. Now, let's see how it actually plays out:

43. ... Ke7 44. a5 Ke8 45. e6! Ke7 46. Ke5! c3 47. f6+ Ke8

The try 47. ... Kf8 goes down to a different study-like motif: 48. Kd6 c2 49. e7+ Ke8 50. Ke6! c1=Q 51. f7 mate.

48. Kd6 c2 49. f7+ Kf8 50. Kd7 c1=Q 51. e7+ Kxf7 52. e8=Q+ Kg7 53. Qe7+

Snap, crackle, pop! On any king move, Qe6+ or Qf6+ will pick up the a6-pawn, when White will finally be able to reap the rewards of his intricate labor.

53. ... Kg8 54. Qe6+ Kg7 55. Qxa6 Qd1+ 56. Qd6 Qf1 57. a6

What was that about the pawn being a few steps away from promotion?

57. .. Qc4 58. a7 Qa2 59. Qe7+, Black resigned.

A wonderful game from a wonderful player. The teenage Lombardy so effortlessly navigated the various twists and turns of this endgame that the "crookedest" street in the world should have a "y" affixed to it. You will be missed, GM Lombardy! ♠

The Power of Simplicity

When trying to find your plan in an endgame, follow the KISS principle: Keep It Simple Stupid.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THERE'S A BIG DIFFERENCE, THE OLD cliché goes, between easy and simple. Eating healthy is simple—just order the kale salad rather than the triple-decker burger—but it is a tremendously difficult exercise in self-control.

Many endgames, believe it or not, fit a similar mold: they are simple but not easy. Many players make the mistake of assuming that complex, convoluted endgame positions require a correspondingly complex and convoluted line of thinking. **In fact, I firmly believe that the opposite is usually true: a straightforward, simple train of thought will often enable you to find your way even in the most outwardly complicated situations.** In this month's column, we will examine a game in which one of the greatest endgame players of all time made it look easy.

KEEP IT SIMPLE, STUPID.

GM Anatoly Karpov (2690)

GM Jan Smejkal (2575)

Leningrad, 06.27.1977



AFTER 22. ... N7g6

We join the battle in a rather humdrum middlegame position. Smejkal has ably handled

the black side of a classical Pirc, and his powerful knights seem to more than compensate for White's bishop advantage. Of course, a brief glance at the position rarely tells the whole story. Black's ostensibly rock-solid position is actually riddled with weaknesses: the entire light-square complex surrounding Black's king (h5, f5, g4, e4, etc.) is dreadfully weak due to the absence of Black's light-square bishop.

However, if Black can plant a knight on f4, then these weaknesses will become insignificant in the face of Black's immense piece activity. Karpov, true to his reputation, acts with filigree precision and simplicity: Black is threatening ... Nf4, so let us prevent the threat!

23. Be3!

This is a powerful move, but one that the lazy analyst is bound to skirt over. *Of course Karpov prevents ... Nf4, one might think.* What else can he do? In reality, this is a rather committal decision because Karpov allows Smejkal to trade rooks, ostensibly mitigating the effect of any potential kingside assault along the light squares. In reality, White's cornucopia of minor pieces, supported by an active queen, will provide ample firepower to inflict serious damage upon Black's seemingly unassailable fortress. Should the opportunity arise, that is.

23. ... Rxf1+ 24. Bxf1 Qf7

Seeking greener pastures. The queen still controls the f5-square, but from f7 it also renews the possibility of ... Nf4, as well as setting a precedent for various tactical shenanigans involving knight jumps to various undesirable squares around White's king.

25. Qc2!

Simple. Karpov, in turn, renews the threat of Nf5 and forces Black's hand.

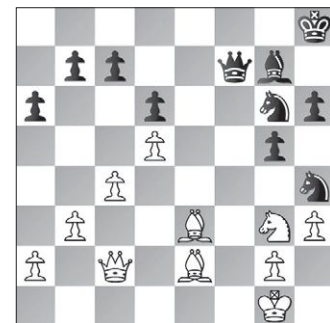
25. ... Nh4

Black has nothing better than to relegate the knight to a dreary defensive task. Of course, the knight still has some attacking potential on h4, but its main job is to stand guard over the f5-square. The stubborn 25. ... Nf4 would have been coolly rebuffed by 26. Nf5, when 26. ... Bf8 (26. ... Qg6 27. Qe4! Nh5 28. g4 Nf6 29. Qg2 is rather nasty as well) 27. Bxf4! gxf4 28. Qe4 Ng6 29. Nd4, when the knight penetrates to e6. White will follow up with Bd3, when a decisive kingside attack is near.

26. Be2

Another straightforward move, hinting at an eventual Nh5. Additionally, it is a good idea to overprotect the f3-square, especially given the fearsome reputation of the queen-knight(s) tandem in the endgame.

26. ... Neg6



Smejkal continues his quest to optimize the placement of his knights. The threat of ... Nf4 is once again renewed, and it seems that Karpov's piece shuffling has led him nowhere.

Practicum

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Anatoly Karpov
GM Jan Smejkal
Leningrad 1977 (Variation)



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Anatoly Karpov
GM Jan Smejkal
Leningrad 1977 (Variation)



WHITE TO MOVE

But let us attempt to put ourselves in Karpov's shoes and reason in a more rational, coldhearted manner:

OK, my opponent is threatening ... Nf4. What, exactly, is he achieving by doing so? Well, he is attacking g2 and potentially setting a precedent for various tactical shots like ... Nxf2 and Nxf3(+). Isn't it interesting how all of these threats and shots are occurring on light squares? g2, h3, f3, etc. So if I could patch up the light-square situation around my own king without compromising my piece activity, then my hands would be more or less untied. And what piece is more natural for this task than the dominant light-square bishop? A great example of prophylactic thinking!

27. Bd3!

By transferring the bishop to e4, Karpov is not immediately attaining a decisive advantage, but he is hindering Black's counterplay.

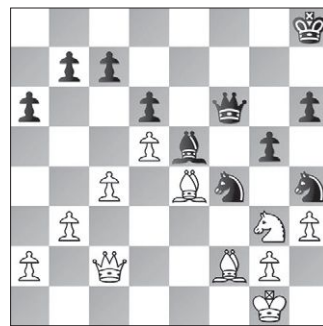
27. ... Be5?!

As a matter of fact, this tempting move is a serious inaccuracy. By centralizing his bishop, Black creates the illusion of activity, but what he does in actuality is merely aid White in buttressing his kingside even further. The immediate 27. ... Nf4 was preferable, intending to meet 28. Be4 with 28. ... Qe7 (see why ... Be5 is bad now?). White is best advised to parry the threat of ... Nfxg2 with 29. Bf2, and now Black starts the waiting game with 29. ... Kg8. Stockfish is very optimistic about Black's chances here, assigning White only a small edge (.3 or so). From a human perspective, of course, White still holds all the cards: he can combine pressure along the light squares (with 30. Qd1, for instance) with an eventual pawn storm on the queenside (by means of b3-b4 and c4-c5, etc.). Still, for the time being Black's position is quite solid, and those knights might eventually play an integral role in a game-saving tactical operation.

28. Bf2!

Of course, the e4-square must be reserved for the bishop.

28. ... Nf4 29. Be4 Qf6



White is the one who has made all the progress: the bishop is reliably safeguarding all potential penetration squares; the only piece that is unemployed is the white queen.

30. Qd1!

Power chess by Mr. Karpov. The queen not only cinches the h5-square, but also maneuvers its hulk to g4, from where it will threaten to wreck Black's position with check on c8. In placing the bishop on e5, Smejkal has closed off the only file through which he can truly initiate meaningful counterplay.

30. ... b6 31. Qg4 Kg7

Prophylaxis against Qc8 (+). Now, the myopic 32. b4?! would enable Black to obtain a semblance of counterplay with 32. ... Qe7. If only that pesky knight wasn't on f4 ...

32. Be3?!

Even the giants occasionally fall short. Consistent with the theme of this column, it seems that Karpov's first mistake comes precisely at the moment when he outthinks himself; **in fact, when you're feeling that you're on a roll, it is easier than ever to drift into the sort of hubristic, self-congratulatory thinking by which you risk committing a tactical blunder.** I'm not suggesting that Karpov engaged in this sort of thinking. Rather, I'm trying to make a larger point about the psychological nature of our

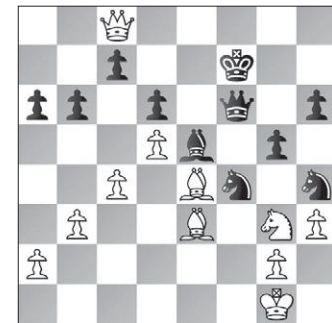
thinking process; playing five excellent moves in a row in no way guarantees that the sixth will not be a mistake.

In a departure from convention, I will ask you, dear reader, to find the correct move as the first exercise in the box above. Remember: the more straightforward and healthy your thinking process is, the likelier you are to unearth the correct continuation.

32. ... Kf7!

Smejkal rights the ship, bringing his king out of the danger zone and preparing to meet Qd7+ with ... Qe7.

33. Qc8



Optically, it looks like White is on the verge of a victory.

33. ... Qe7? 34. Bh7!

A crushing shot, threatening 35. Qg8+ and inducing decisive concessions.

34. ... Nxf3+

This is simply a blunder, but the relatively more tenacious 34. ... Qf8 did little to change the outcome after 35. Qxc7+ Qe7 36. Qxe7+ Kxe7 37. Bxb6.

35. Qxh3, Black resigned.

So, what *should* have Black done instead of ... Qe7? That will be the second exercise you will have to solve! And the tool that will enable you to solve this exercise correctly is—you guessed it—the power of simplicity.♠

Move of the Year, Endgame Edition

For your consideration, the world champion's defensive gem

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

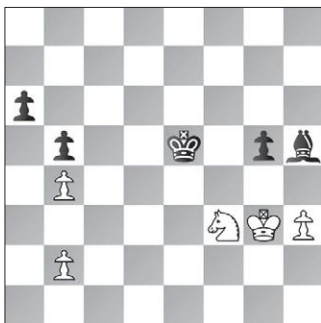
AMONG MY FRIENDS AND RELATIVES, I am known as the proverbial alarm-snoozer. One Sunday during exam week last quarter, I slept through so many early morning alarms that I finally woke up to my roommate standing at my bedside and repeatedly stabbing me with an imaginary knife. My math final that night did not go very well.

One thing I *will* get up for at 5 a.m., however, is the World Rapid and Blitz Championship. This exhilarating event features almost all of the world's top players going at each other's throats to the tune of heart-stopping time scrambles and, inevitably, tragic blunders.

This year, one of the endgames in the rapid championship—which I had followed live—featured one of the most beautiful defensive resources that I have ever seen. At the risk of jinxing it, let me say that this motif will be seared in your mind for weeks to come.

WATER FROM A ROCK

GM Vladimir Fedoseev (FIDE 2771, RUS)
GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2908, NOR)
World Rapid Chess Championship. Open.
(12), Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, 12.28.2017



AFTER 65. Nf3+

After a furious ascent that included a stunning victory at the 2017 Aeroflot Open, Russian GM Vladimir Fedoseev has established himself as one of the most promising talents in Russia. At the time of this game, he was leading the rapid with a massive 8½/11. At first blush, it seems that he has held his own against the World Champion. In fact, the time seems ripe for a handshake. The king is tied to the g5-pawn, the pawn ending after 65. ... Bxf3 66. Kxf3 is a dead draw, end of story.

True to his ability to squeeze water from a rock, Magnus sees past this myopic assessment and plays his last trump card.

65. ... Kd5!

Why not? This move is not only a good practical chance, but especially savvy given Fedoseev's acute time pressure: Fedoseev had a minute or so left and was playing "on increment." The king's intentions are decidedly malevolent: the monarch intends to eat up White's defenseless pawns, relegating to his subordinate the task of restraining White's h-pawn.

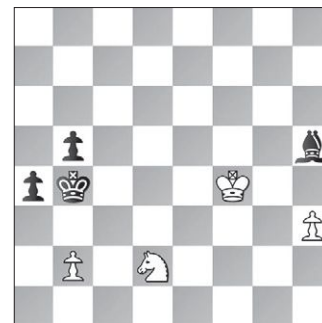
66. Nxg5

The point of this move is not so much to capture a pawn as to halt the king's path with some timely gymnastics. This does the trick, though 66. b3! was even more straightforward. The king has to detour with 66. ... Ke4, and after 67. Nxg5+ Kd3 68. Ne6 Kc3 69. Nc5 White achieves his aim with a tempo to spare. The game would end following 69. ... Kxb4 70. Nxa6+ Kxb3 71. Nc7 b4 72. Na6 and White liquidates the final pawn.

66. ... Kc4 67. Ne4 Kxb4 68. Kf4

Obviously, 68. ... Kb3 meets with 69. Nc5+. This is somewhat of a stopgap blockade, but it gives White just enough time to bring his own monarch to the rescue.

68. ... a5 69. Nd2 a4



70. Ke4

Fedoseev played this move almost instantly, and who can blame him? The king aims for d3, but the problem is that it temporarily deprives the knight of its rightful place on e4! Carlsen now has a brief respite in which to reorganize his forces and confront Fedoseev with a whole new class of problems.

If Fedoseev had used Waze instead of Google Maps to decide on a route for the king, he would have undoubtedly sidestepped the trouble with 70. Ke3!. After 70. ... Kc5, White hits the king with 71. Ne4+. Black has a few tries, but everything fizzles out quickly:

- 1) 71. ... Kc4 72. Nd6+ Kb3 looks intimidating, but after 73. Nxb5 Kxb2 74. Kd4 Be8 75. Nc3 a3 76. Kc4 White brings the king to b4 and follows up with a check from either d1 or a4.

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

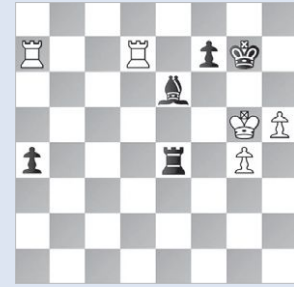
GM Erard Dervishi
GM Gadir Guseinov
World Rapid Chess Championship



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Boris Savchenko
GM Peter Svidler
World Rapid Championship



WHITE TO MOVE

2) 71. ... Kd5!? would probably have been Magnus' attempt. The "blunder" is, of course, deliberate: the point is to lure the knight offside after 72. Nf6+ Kc4 73. Nxh5 Kb3. But following 74. Kd4 Kxb2 75. Nf4 a3 76. Nd3+ the knight is in time, and Black is the one who must demonstrate caution.

70. ... Kc5! 71. Ke3 b4

Er-oh. All of a sudden, Magnus has erected an impassable barrier along the h7-b1 diagonal. ... Bg6 followed by ... a4-a3 looms large, when the king will be permanently cut off and the knight, no longer able to jump to e4, will trip over its own haunches. With time running out, Fedoseev starts to flounder.

72. Ne4+ Kd5 73. Nd2 Bg6!

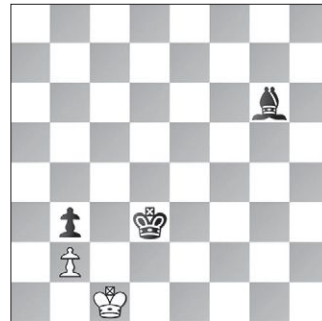
This is the critical moment, and, in many ways, the reason I chose this endgame. Now, it is not immediately clear why ... a4-a3 is a decisive threat: White will, after all, be able to restrain the pawn from b3. It turns out that the ensuing position is lost for White, and that should not be a surprise: once the knight is reduced to utter passivity and the passer advances past the sixth rank, White's prospects are not very promising.

But there doesn't seem to be any conceivable way to stop ... a4-a3, or to breach the diagonal blockade. It transpires that the first of these assumptions is correct, but the second, believe it or not, is false. The drawing idea—rendered all the more stunning by the fact that it is the only path to salvation—is so jaw-dropping that it took me a long, long time before I accepted its objective value.

The theoretical underpinning of this idea can be found in the following stem position, featured in Karsten Müller and Frank Lamprecht's classic work, *Fundamental Chess Endings*:

(see diagram next column)

This is a draw with either side to move, and regardless of the bishop's color (!). See for yourself: put a bishop on any square on the



EITHER SIDE TO MOVE

board, and the fortress remains watertight. At the first opportunity, White's king wriggles its way to a1 and stays there, awaiting stalemate or (with a dark-square bishop) liquidation to a drawn king-and-pawn ending.

Now, back to the text. At first, it may be difficult to understand the link between the two positions. But as GM Alex Yermolinsky explained to me many years ago, theoretical positions will not necessarily arise in pure form every time; the true endgame virtuoso knows how to use theoretical positions as beacons of light, guiding his play in outwardly dissimilar positions. And in this case, just such an approach can be used to uncork one of the most brilliant ideas in recent endgame memory:

74. Nb3!!! No, this is not a typo. Yes, three exclamation marks. What makes chess so attractive to me is that even the wildest ideas can be understood with enough persistence and logical thinking. This is just such an idea: after 74. ... axb3 75. Kd2, we reach the exact same theoretical position as the one shown above, with a few inconsequential differences. You can even put black pawns on b5, b6, and b7, and the situation remains the same: White will push the h-pawn until Black is forced to take it, and *voilà!* Skepticism is encouraged, but the fact of the matter is that 74. Nb3 is the only drawing move.

Now, if Black does not take the knight, then White is well in time to stop the pawns, since a direct route to the queenside is now open for White's king. Some illustrative lines:

a) 74. ... a3 75. bxa3 bxa3 76. Kd2 Kc4 77. Na5+ Kb4 78. Nc6+ Kc5 (78. ... Kb3 79. Na5+ leads nowhere, since 79. ... Kb2 80. Nc4+ is a draw) 79. Kc3! and it is time to shake hands. Even if 79. ... Kxc6 80. Kb3 did not happen to win the pawn, it would still be a draw since Black has the incorrect bishop for the a-pawn.

b) 74. ... Kc4 75. Na5+ Kb5 76. Nb3 is probably the most unconventional repetition of all time.

c) 74. ... Bc2 is useless: 75. Nd4 Bd1 76. Kd2! with a draw.

Alas, with just a few minutes left on his clock, Fedoseev did not exploit the opportunity. However, I think it is safe to bet that a team of 500 grandmasters with two hours on the clock would be quite unlikely to see it either.

74. Ke2?

The king takes the long route to c1, and Fedoseev was relying on a cute stalemate trick to save the day, but allowing the pawn to a2 simply places too large of a burden on White's pieces.

74. ... a3 75. bxa3 bxa3 76. Kd1 a2 77. Nb3 Kc4 78. Na1 Kc3 79. Kc1 Bf5 80. h4 Bg6!

Zugzwang numero uno. Get rid of the pawn.

81. h5 Bxh5 82. Nc2 Be8 83. Na1 Ba4 84. Nc2

This was Fedoseev's intention all along, but the king simply repositions itself.

84. ... Kb3, White resigned.

After 85. Na1+ Ka3 it is *Zugzwang* numero dos, since 86. Nc2+ no longer works for obvious reasons.

OK, maybe I overhyped it. But to me, ideas like 74. Nb3 offer a direct refutation to the common endgames-are-boring trope. No, they are not. And they're happy to punch you in the face if necessary. ♠

A Mouthwatering Affair

The PRO Chess League provides a feast for endgame lovers.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

WHEN IM GREG SHAHADE FOUNDED the United States Chess League (USCL) in 2005, the concept of an inter-city chess league contested over the internet was anything if not avant-garde. I fondly remember my own trips to the century-old Mechanics' Institute Chess Club in downtown San Francisco (SF), where I played for the SF Mechanics to the tune of 30 or so online kibitzers.

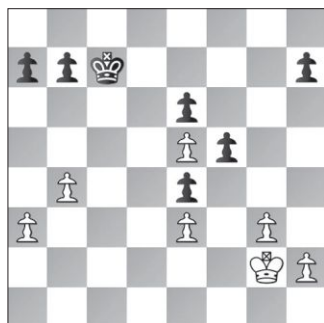
Times have changed, and the U.S. Chess League (now called the PRO Chess League) has matured. Today, it is a fan favorite that includes teams from across the world and features the participation of virtually every top player, including King Magnus himself.

As you can probably guess, the PRO League is a feast for endgame lovers, as it is precisely in the final stage of the game that time scrambles occur and that the outcome of entire matches is decided. Today, we examine just such a mouth-watering affair.

PAWN SHOP

GM Jorden Van Foreest (PCL 2607, Montreal Chessbrahs)

Dan Smith (PCL 2070, Montclair Sopranos)
Pro Chess League, 01.31.2018



AFTER 28. ... Kxc7

Poker buffs, behold: the Dan Smith handling the black pieces is, in fact, *the* Dan Smith—currently one of the best poker players in the world. He has not made it as far in the world of chess, but a cursory glance at this pawn endgame seems to indicate that he has given the young Dutch grandmaster all he can handle. In fact, it appears that resignation is a viable option: Black threatens ... Kc6-d5, capturing the helpless pawn and winning easily.

It is important to note, however, that **pawn endings are volatile in the sense that a single breakthrough can instantly change the character of a position.** This position is a case in point: Van Foreest has prepared a nasty surprise.

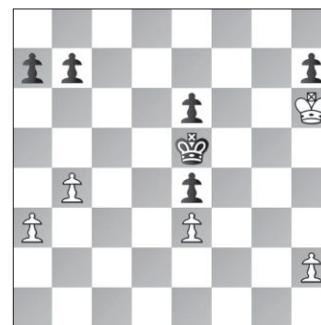
29. g4!

The only hope. The only alternative, 29. Kh3, led to a very long and forced variation that results in a winning queen ending for Black. I would urge resisting the temptation to play through the following line on a board; it is a fantastic opportunity to train your visualization. After 29. ... Kc6 30. Kh4 Kd5 31. Kg5 Kxe5, White can exploit his temporary superiority in king placement with 32. h4! (32. Kh6 goes down immediately after 32. ... Kf6 33. Kxh7 e5, followed by ... f4). The line continues 32. ... Kd5 33. Kh6 Kc4 34. Kxh7 Kd3 (now the pawn race begins in earnest!) 35. h5 Kxe3 36. h6 Kf3 37. Kg6 e3 38. h7 e2 39. h8=Q e1=Q. Phew! What have we here? Well, suffice it to say that Black has a healthy extra (passed) pawn and White has no immediate way of winning it back. Furthermore, g3 is bound to fall. The machine holds out some hope for a resistance, but practically speaking White is busted.

29. ... fxg4 30. Kg3

As after Kh3, both kings begin their march to create their respective passed pawns.

30. ... Kc6 31. Kxg4 Kd5 32. Kg5 Kxe5 33. Kh6



Pawn endings are devilishly tricky. Most people assume that the reason for this is that they involve a lot of (long) calculation. That is true, of course, but it is far from the only factor. In my view, an equally critical characteristic of pawn endgames is the presence of what I call the “long variation disease” (LVD). **Long variations, especially when they occur in pawn endings, often seem forced, making players unwittingly lax in their search for candidate moves and other subtleties at every critical juncture.**

With this cautionary note in mind, let us turn to the diagrammed position. It is plain that Black's monarch must circle around to the e3-pawn. There are two routes: d5 and f5. When compared side-by-side, 33. ... Kd5 looks terribly unnatural; why choose that direction when Kf5-g4 furthers his plan while holding up White's passer? To his credit, Dan Smith spent 1.5 of his remaining five minutes on this decision, but my guess is that all of them were spent evaluating the ensuing pawn race.

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Eduardo Iturrizaga
GM Shakhriyar Mamedyarov
PRO Chess League, 02.03.2018



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Le Quang Liem
Bryan Tillis
PRO Chess League, 02.07.2018



WHITE TO MOVE

33. ... Kf5?

Despite my first impression, this is not a decisive mistake. Nonetheless, recovering from the ensuing ordeal will be a tall order, especially in acute time pressure. The first order of business is to understand what is wrong with ... Kf5; I suggest that you lay down the magazine and try to figure that out for yourself before proceeding. Now, let us calculate the outcome of the pawn race that Smith was hoping for (don't lose track!): 33. ... Kd5 34. Kxh7 Kc4 35. h4 Kd3 36. h5 Kxe3 (as Smith anticipated, this position could be reached from the ... f5-g4-f3 route) 37. h6 Kd2 38. Kg6 e3 39. h7 e2 40. h8=Q e1=Q.



ANALYSIS AFTER 40. ... e1=Q

Phew! What have we here? To answer this question, we must make an important distinction: **There is a big difference between an objective evaluation and a practical evaluation. During the game, it is often more productive to ask yourself, "Is this a position I want to have?" rather than trying to ascertain whether your advantage is slight or big. In this sense, the annotator and the player are not aligned in their goals.** The diagrammed position is hard to objectively evaluate, especially if you miss that White can win back the pawn with 41. Qd4+. But in *practical* terms, it is clear that Black is out of the woods and firmly in the driver's seat: material equality or not, that pawn on e6 is going to give White grief and guarantee at least

a draw. Objectively, it turns out that Black does, indeed, have some winning chances after 41. ... Kc2 42. Qxa7 Qe4+ and 43. ... Kb3.

34. h3!

The baby-faced assassin strikes again. As we discussed two columns ago (see "The Power of Simplicity," February 2018), simple is not the same as easy, and the simplest moves are often the easiest to overlook. This move highlights the beauty of chess: one can change the entire war with the scantest of military force. It is too late to "apologize" with 34. ... Ke5 (the loss of two moves in an "endgame" race is fatal), so Black's only hope is to capture the h3-pawn via g5 and return with enough time to save the rest of the army. Doing so requires filigree precision, and Smith goes fatally astray.

34. ... Kf6?

This is the decisive mistake, and, in a certain sense, another instantiation of LVD. To unearth the only drawing move, we first have to understand why ... Kf6 loses. Once again, I would encourage you to answer this question independently. Assuming you have done so, let us (wordlessly, for the time being) follow the course of the game:

35. b5! a5 36. bxa6 e.p. bxa6 37. a4 a5 38. Kxh7 Kg5 39. Kg7 Kh4 40. Kf6 Kxh3

This is the final critical moment. Intuitively, one's eye is drawn to 41. Ke5, saving the easy pickings for last. But this enables Black to save the draw with 41. ... Kg3 42. Kxe4 Kf2, etc. In order to sidestep this illusion, you must consciously return to the critical moment and put your intuition aside. Is 41. Ke5 *really* forced? Would it hurt to briefly investigate other options?

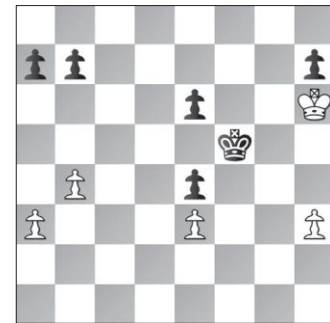
41. Kxe6!

Pawn endgames are unkind to the lazy chess player. Even though Black's king can make contact with the e4-pawn, the absence of extra moves means that he will inevitably end up in *Zugzwang*. Watch:

41. ... Kg3 42. Ke5 Kf3 43. Kd4

Boom. All over. Smith played on for 12 more meaningless moves and then **Black resigned**.

And now, for the finishing touch, we return to the position after White's 34th move:



AFTER 34. h3

Hopefully, you were able to spot the key phrase in the note to White's 41st move: *absence of extra moves*. Any seasoned endgame player knows that the best way to preclude the possibility of *Zugzwang* is to keep as many extra pawn moves as possible for a rainy day, or, conversely, to take away said extra pawn moves from your opponent. If we look very closely at the diagrammed position, there is a way to do just that: 34. ... b5!! This is why I love endgames: moves can be very hard to find, but they're almost always possible to understand if you try hard enough. After 35. Kxh7 Kg5 36. Kg7 Kh4 37. Kf6 Kxh3, it transpires that 38. Kxe6 actually loses: 38. ... Kg3 39. Ke5 Kf3 40. Kd4 and we have the exact same position from the game, with one massively important exception: Black can push that little pawn on a7 one square forward, and the joke, ladies and gentlemen, is on White. For this reason, White must bail out with 38. Ke5, and after 38. ... Kg3 39. Kxe4 Kf2 things peter out into a draw.

This game may not be so catchy to the superficial eye, but it is packed with intrigue and instructive moments. And for Mr. Smith, maybe it even rivaled the excitement of a high-stakes round of poker. ♠

What Am I Missing?

Chess psychology and objective evaluation are two entirely different things.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

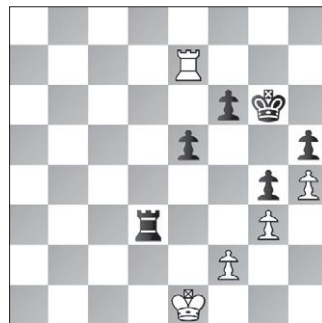
IN EIGHTH GRADE ENGLISH, I READ *TO Kill a Mockingbird*, a rite of passage for most middle-schoolers across the country. Over the course of the novel, Jem and Scout Finch, the prepubescent main characters, discover gifts hidden in the knothole of a tree. These mysterious happenings are not relevant to the main plot and themes of the book, but my teacher saw in them an opportunity to allay the drudgery of early-morning class. “Class,” Ms. Wilsey exclaimed, “You will have a chance to play the role of Sherlock Holmes.” We had one day to uncover the identity of the mysterious benefactor.

The solution to the mystery is painfully obvious: the gifts, as everyone in the class duly figured out, were left by an enigmatic character named Boo Radley. But I had grossly overthought the entire business and had woven together an intricate argument to the effect that the gifts were, in fact, left in the knothole by a minor character named Walter Cunningham. Needless to say, Ms. Wilsey was not impressed by my self-indulgent drivel, as evidenced by the angry, red “C-” at the top of my paper.

Believe it or not, this unfortunate vignette parallels a common chess narrative. Two players are locked in a complicated endgame when one of them uncorks an ostensibly brilliant plan. He is absolutely, utterly convinced that he has seen to the bottom of the abyss. And sometimes, the best thing to do is get the heck out of his way and give him a C- (or the chess equivalent).

BRILLIANT—MAYBE?

IM Sunil Dhopade Swapnil (FIDE 2438, IND)
GM Daniil Lintchevski (FIDE 2553, RUS)
05th Kolkata Open GM Chess,
Tournament (9), Kolkata, India, 12.11.2012



AFTER 53. Re7

This is no usual day at the office for the Indian international master: a draw would ensure a second grandmaster norm. However, four versus three rook endgames are difficult to defend, especially in a high-pressure situation against a Russian grandmaster who is out for blood.

At the same time, the level of difficulty is determined (in large part) by the pawn structure, and this metric certainly favors Swapnil. Black's pawns are sluggish, h5 is permanently weak, and White has erected an ideal pawn chain whose base is supported by the king. The coveted grandmaster norm certificate, to put it another way, is close at hand. But a wily endgame player will always make you work for it.

53. ... Rd8!?

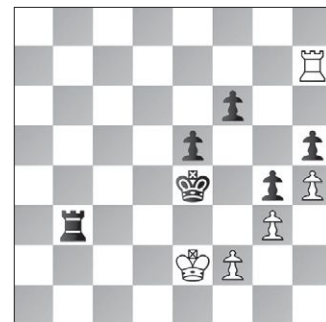
A sensible try. Lintchevski temporarily consigns his rook to an inglorious reclusive existence on h8. All in the name of progress, eh?

54. Ke2 Rh8 55. Ke3 Kf5 56. Ra7 Rb8 57. Rh7!

No, the exclamation mark isn't misplaced. And no, nothing tragic would have befallen Swapnil had he adopted a waiting strategy with

57. Ra3. At the same time, it's a good idea to keep the drawing margin as wide as possible, nipping any aggressive overtures in the bud. In this case, blindly toggling between a3 and c3 needlessly complicates White's task. For instance, 57. ... Rb6 (after 57. Ra3) 58. Rc3 Ke6 59. Ra3 f5 would be one unwelcome development. And after the pigheaded 60. Rc3 (60. Ra5! keeps the position within the bounds of a straightforward draw) 60. ... Rb4! there is no way of stopping ... f4+, when the path to a positive White result is problematic.

57. ... Rb3+ 58. Ke2 Ke4?!



As you can probably intuit, this is the Walter Cunningham moment. Lintchevski undoubtedly realized that 58. ... Kg6 59. Ra7 would lead absolutely nowhere. The familiar 59. ... f5 isn't nearly as effective here because White can simply lateral check *ad nauseum*, starting with 60. Ra6+. Otherwise, Black is out of ideas: the king is pinned to g6, and the rook can only deliver a few anemic checks. So Lintchevski decides that he will exploit his material safety blanket and make one last attempt to muddy the waters. After all, with such a mouthwateringly active

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Anish Giri (2752)
GM Sergey Karjakin (2771)
Stavanger 2014



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Ruifeng Li (2577)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2646)
Pro Chess League 2017



WHITE TO MOVE

tandem, only White can be in danger. Or am I missing something?

59. Rxh5 Rb2+ 60. Kf1

Obviously, 60. ... Kf3? would be a terrible oversight on account of 61. Rf5+. But Lintchevski has a far more sophisticated scheme in mind.

60. ... f5

It is at this point that the fault in Black's strategy announces its presence. Lintchevski's plan is transparent: he wants to push the pawn to f4, a development that seems to entail highly unwelcome consequences for White. However, a sober look at the position indicates that the danger is illusory. To this end, I would encourage you to lay down the magazine and find the (short) sequence of maneuvers that permanently disables Black's initiative.

61. Kg1

Step 1: White awaits ... f4, keeping the rook on the fifth rank. 61. Rg5 also would have done the trick.

61. ... f4 62. gxf4 exf4 63. Ra5!

Step 2: Prepare a barrage of lateral checks. There is, it seems, a little more to discuss. Black can bail out in a few different ways:

- A. 63. ... g3 is an immediate draw after 64. fxf3 65. Ra3;
- B. 63. ... Rb1+ 64. Kg2 f3+ might look scary for a hot second, but after 65. Kh2! (avoiding the egregious 65. Kg3?? Rg1+ 66. Kh2 Rg2+) 65. ... Rf1 66. Ra2, White has every threat defended. If anything, it is Black who must demonstrate an iota of caution, lest he allow White's king to reach f4;
- C. 63. ... Kf3 64. Ra3+ Ke4 is, of course, the start of a three-fold repetition.

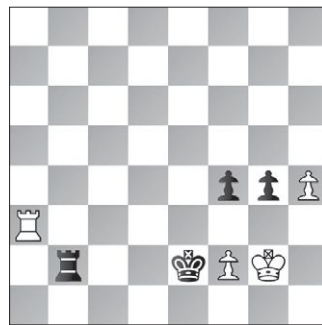
These are but a few examples. In light of this outcome, one might argue that my criticism of Lintchevski's ambitiousness is groundless. **However, chess psychology and objective evaluation are two entirely different**

things. Once you have become convinced that there is nothing to fear—and that you can probe your opponent with—the seeds of disaster have already been sown. Don't believe me? Watch this.

63. ... Kf3 64. Ra3+ Ke2?!

Another Walter Cunningham moment. Lintchevski's pawn army (pawn militia?) still looks imposing, and it's hard to imagine that White's feeble passer can do anything other than spectate. But the problem is that Lintchevski's king is restricted to the first and second ranks, and his pawns—regardless of their appearance—are horrifically defenseless entities.

65. Kg2



Houston, we have a problem. It is now clearer than ever that Black has gone absolutely nowhere. In fact, a chill must have gone down Lintchevski's spine as he realized that moves like 65. ... f3+ might put Black in—horror of horrors—danger of losing. Alright then, time to shake hands.

65. ... Ke1??

A disclaimer is in order here. My intention is not to mock Lintchevski for an inexplicable series of blunders. If I've been properly doing my job, then you can see that these psychological inaccuracies—and now this dreadful blunder, which instantly loses the game—are more than understandable. When one is convinced that there is no danger, calculation

and logic often go out the window. This is especially true with limited material. White has two isolated pawns left, for God's sake! But such is the devilish nature of endgames. It transpires that Black had only one clean return path via 65. ... Rb1!. After 66. Ra2+ (66. h5 f3+ draws with room to spare) 66. ... Kd3 67. Ra4 f3+ 68. Kg3 (68. Kh2 Rf1 69. Kg3 transposes, while 69. Ra2 Ke4 is a near-transposition to a position already considered in the note to White's 63rd move) 68. ... Rg1+ 69. Kf4 Rg2 70. Ra2, a cute little tactic comes to the rescue: 70. ... g3! 71. Kxf3 (71. Ra3+ Ke2 is futile) 71. ... Rxf2+ 72. Rxf2 gxf2 73. Kxf2 Ke4 and Black is more than in time.

66. Ra1+ Ke2

Lintchevski was hoping for a repetition, but he misses the forest for the trees.

67. Ra4!

The essay has been graded. Amazingly, Black doesn't even have an inkling of a chance: 67. ... g3 68. Rxf4! picks up both pawns, while the game continuation leads to a similar fate.

67. ... f3+ 68. Kg3 Kf1

Or 68. ... Rb1 69. Ra2+, with similar consequences.

69. Ra1+ Ke2 70. h5

What was that about the feeble passer?

70. ... Rb5 71. Rh1 Rb7 72. h6 Rh7 73. Rh2!

The final blow. White picks up the g4-pawn.

73. ... Kf1 74. Kxg4 Kg1 75. Kg3, Black resigned.

It's *Zugzwang*: after 75. ... Rh8 76. h7 Black will have to move his king, when White eats up the last pawn.

I'd hesitate to call a game like this a "tragedy-comedy," one of the late and great IM Mark Dvoretsky's favorite terms. It is an instance of the deep-seated flaws in human nature that we must seek to understand and make peace with. ♠

The Devil is in the Detail

Attention to detail—in the sense of provoking and holding your opponent accountable for seemingly insignificant errors—is an indelible component of practical endgame mastery.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

A FEW WEEKS AGO, UPON RETURNING to my dorm after a calamitous math exam, I spotted a parking citation neatly pinned to the windshield of my car. For several minutes I stood motionless, every bone in my body disgorging righteous anger at the injustice visited upon me. What gall, what gall indeed, Stanford University has in oiling its swollen financial coffers during finals week!

In the end, saner heads prevailed. After all, an expired parking permit is an expired parking permit, and pending the rejection of a pitiful, excuse-laden appeal, \$45 will be deposited in the appropriate piggybank.

But the consequences of negligence are altogether different in the endgame realm. In today's column, I argue that **attention to detail—in the sense of provoking and holding your opponent accountable for seemingly insignificant errors—is an indelible component of practical endgame mastery.** This is not exactly a controversial statement. However, as the following instructive encounter shows, attention to detail, while easy to preach, is remarkably difficult to practice.

A FABI-LOUS ENDGAME

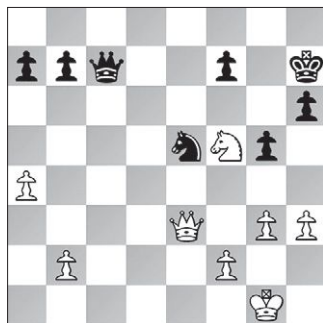
GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2784, USA)

GM Arkadij Naiditsch (FIDE 2701, AZE)

GRENKE Chess Classic 2018 (4), Karlsruhe & Baden-Baden, Germany, 04.04.2018

(see diagram top of next column)

Fabiano Caruana is in the midst of a memorable stretch in his career. As if emerging as Magnus Carlsen's next challenger was not enough, Fabi supplemented his victory at the Candidates with a dashing gold medal campaign



AFTER 29. Qe3

at the GRENKE Chess Classic. As the fourth round of the classic played out, it seemed that Fabi's crusade was beginning to lose its vigor. In only 29 moves, Naiditsch has swapped off most of the pieces and steered the game into an anemic queen-and-knight endgame. White's active knight is tough to make good use of while protecting his king and is made all the more pronounced by the specter of a check on f3. Aiming to curtail any last shreds of ambition that Fabi may have been harboring, Naiditsch initiates a small tactical operation.

29. ... Nc4?!

Naiditsch spent 2½ of his remaining six minutes on this move, presumably in an effort to ensure that all of White's manifold queen sorties could be effectively neutralized—and they can:

30. Qe8 Nd2! creates immediate and highly effective counterplay against White's king, leading to a perpetual in every line:

A1) 31. Ne7 Qc1+ 32. Kh2 (32. Kg2?? Qf1+ 33. Kh2 Nf3 mate would be an effective strategy if it were loser's chess) 32. ... Nf3+ 33. Kg2 Ne1+.

A2) 31. Kh2 is Stockfish's initial recommendation, but the circumspect 31. ... b6!, preparing ... Nf3+ followed by ... Qb7, forces White's hand. After 32. Ne7 Nf3+ 33. Kg2 Ne1+ 34. Kf1 (34. Kh1 Qb7+ 35. Nc6 Nd3 36. Kg1 Kg7 is similarly uninspiring) 34. ... Qc4+! 35. Kxe1 Qe4+ Black delivers perpetual with room to spare. Note that with the black queen on d3, the king can never escape via b4 due to ... a5 (mate!).

30. Qd4 Qe5! is the simpler tactical justification. Either trade leads to a dead-drawn single-piece ending.

These are impressive amounts of variations to calculate in time pressure, but the very fact that it is *necessary* to calculate so many lines in a fairly balanced position is an unwelcome omen. Therein lies the rub: It is tempting to assume that the only risk attendant to a complex tactical operation is that of a straightforward blunder. **However, a more insidious downside is that in your quest to avoid a blunder, it is easy to overlook (or underestimate) a subtler option whose aim is to bring about practical problems rather than to win the game immediately.**

To this end, Naiditsch has several options that obviated the need for such risk. The most precise of them was 29. ... f6!, buttressing the knight and pumping in some *luft* for the king. White does not have much in the way of serious practical attempts: 30. Qe4 Qc6 forces the trade (or perpetual after 31. Qb4 Qc1+), while 30. f4 gxf4 31. Qxf4 (31. gxf4 Ng6 is asking for trouble) 31. ... Qb6+ 32. Kf1 Qa6+ is yet another perpetual (do you see why 33. Ke1 fails?). My guess is that Caruana would have played 30. Qe4 and offered a draw, since there will be hell to pay if Black's queen safely lands on c6.

Practicum

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

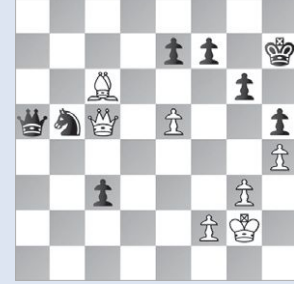
GM Anatoly Karpov
GM Garry Kasparov
World Championship 1987



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Shakhriyar Mamedyarov
GM Alexander Grischuk
Berlin Candidates 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

30. Qc3 Qe5



31. Qd3!

Er-oh. There's that yellow envelope on the windshield. This move doesn't *look* intimidating; after all, Black can deliver a check on e1 and capture on b2 with tempo. And besides, is White even threatening a serious discovered check? As discussed above, the point to remember is that Fabi is not trying to win the game immediately. Rather, he avoids a draw and confronts Naiditsch—who by now has four minutes for 10 moves—with unanticipated problems. Indeed, something like 31. ... Na5 does not lose, but after 32. Ne3+ Kg7 33. b3! White establishes a positional bind that reaches biblical proportions in the event of 33. ... Nc6?! 34. Qd7!. So Naiditsch has little choice other than to continue burning bridges in search of an immediate resolution.

31. ... Nxb2 32. Qc2 Qe1+

And the German maestro rises to the task! Now White is the one who must resolve a thorny dilemma: 33. Kh2 Nxa4! is an immediate draw, since Black's pieces are active enough to take the sting out of any discovered check. Note that White can keep the extra piece with 34. Ne3+ Kg7 35. Qxa4 Qxf2+ 36. Ng2, but after something like 36. ... Qc5 all three results are possible.

33. Kg2 Qd1?

This is the sort of move that might have been accompanied by an exclamation mark in the

1950s (says the ingrate who slept with a leather-bound first edition of *Zurich 1953* under his pillow). After 34. Qxb2 Qd5+ it is handshake time, and this time it seems that there just isn't any more room for shenanigans. But once again, the devil is in the detail. The tactics may be impressive, but you cannot allow yourself to be swayed by sharp tactical play. And impressed Fabiano was not: his reply came before Naiditsch so much as finished writing down his move.¹

34. Qe4!

What a scheming little imp this Fabiano Caruana is! The queen escapes the last accessible square, on the diagonal, and this time the threats are immediate and deadly. And while Black is far from lost, the problems he is facing are, practically speaking, virtually insurmountable.

34. ... Qxa4?

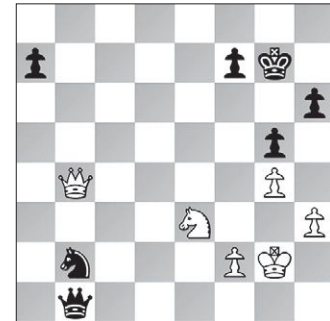
I'm going to do you the liberty of revealing that 34. ... Qd7 was the only saving move. There is no real logic behind this move, but the fact of the matter is that all other moves lose. The point is that 35. Qe5 meets with 35. ... Qc6+ 36. Kg1 and while there is no more perpetual, Black saves the day with 36. ... Qg6!. In light of this, White should prefer the prophylactic 35. Kh2!, renewing the threat of Qe5. I analyzed this position with a certain anonymous friend, and the verdict seems to be that after 35. ... Nxa4 36. Qe5 Kg6! Black hangs on by the skin of his teeth, though 37. h4! once again brings Black to the precipice and demands inhuman precision. That is why I assigned a question mark to Naiditsch's previous move; 34. ... Qxa4 may be the decisive mistake from an objective standpoint, but in a practical sense the battle was lost on move 33.

35. Qxb7 Qa2 36. Ne3!

Quiet but absolutely deadly. With this move, White completely seals in Black's tandem, since 36. ... Nc4 is not possible due to 37. Qe4+. It might not seem intuitively obvious that White is winning, but it is wrong to think of this

position in terms of immediate threats. White's plan of attack (g4, Nf5, Qb4-d4, etc.) may be slow, but Black can do absolutely nothing to stop it.

36. ... Kg7 37. Qb4 Qb1 38. g4



Having done its job, the knight prepares to reenter with deadly effect.

38. ... Kg8 39. Nf5

With the knight independently supported, White's queen is finally free to deliver the final blow.

39. ... Qc2 40. Qb8+ Kh7 41. Qb7 Kh8

Or 41. ... Kg6 42. Qa6+ f6 43. Qb7! with mate to follow.

42. Qe7, Black resigned.

Black stops mate with 42. ... Qc6+ 43. Kh2 Qg6, but 44. Qe5+ picks up the hapless knight.

Hopefully, it is evident that my intention in dissecting Naiditsch's downfall is not to act as an armchair critic. Faced with problems of such magnitude, yours truly would have undoubtedly gone down even with hours left on the clock. Instead, I hope that this game hammers in the notion that what ends as a calamity frequently starts with a tiny inaccuracy. Oh, and don't park without a permit if you're ever in Stanford.♠

¹ For the sake of completeness, it bears mentioning that 33. ... Qb4! was the final chance to secure a surefire draw. For instance, 34. a5 Qc4! and this time, liquidation is truly forced.

The U.S. Championship Effect

Shankland's road to the title included a crucial endgame victory.

By GM DANIEL NARODITSKY

THERE IS AN OBSCURE PSYCHOLOGICAL phenomenon that is known in scientific literature as "The U.S. Championship Effect." It was coined after economists observed that there is an annually-occurring two-week period in which the global workforce vastly underperforms. Scores of employees are caught shirking their duties or calling in sick. Lunch breaks extend for hours past the allotted end time. Economic productivity and output take a gut-wrenching beating.

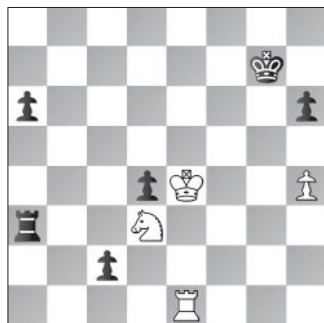
The scientific community breathed a sigh of relief when it was determined that an addiction to chess was the benign cause behind this downturn. This year, as GM Samuel Shankland surpassed the Big Three with a magisterial performance, the effect was especially pronounced. It turns out that one of Shankland's crucial victories came down to a tremendously instructive, nail-biting endgame. But then again, that's just par for the course.

OF KNIGHTS AND MEN

GM Samuel Shankland (2671)

GM Yaroslav Zherebukh (2640)

2018 U.S. Championship (9), St. Louis, Missouri, 04.27.2018



AFTER 52. ... Rxa3

We join the battle ... wait, is there even a battle left to join? Black has three pawns for the knight, and it seems to be a matter of time until the measly pawn on h4 is eaten up. Black will eventually have to prove his mettle in a rook versus rook plus knight showdown, but many players can do so while skydiving above the Himalayas.¹ To this end, 53. Kxd4 Ra4+ is one quick way to sign the peace accord.

However, a closer look at the position tells a different story. It is true that Black is within a hair's breadth of securing the draw, but if White avoids taking on d4, the h-pawn is actually quite safe. The knight is the method behind the madness: it imprisons the rook, discourages a potential king sortie (since ... Kg6 can be met with Nf4+), and singlehandedly blockades the pawns. Indeed, they are totally immobilized and essentially available for consumption on-demand.

The position is well within the bounds of a draw, but White has nothing to lose. Why not keep the h-pawn alive for a few more moves?

53. Rc1!

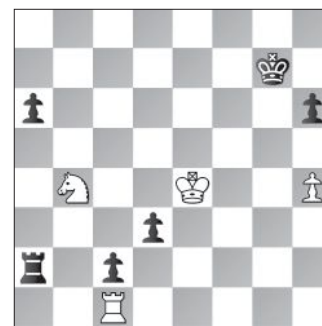
The mechanism keeping the d4-pawn alive is rather flimsy; in fact, a4 is the only accessible square along the fourth rank, so Black is unable to keep both c2 and d4 alive.

53. ... Rc3?!

Years ago, my coach GM Lev Psakhis shared a piece of advice that has stuck with me ever since (and that I've probably repeated several times in this column). **If you are close to securing a draw, it is tempting to assume that "anything will do the trick." In reality, you frequently have only a handful of chances to draw by force. Once they are**

squandered, the draw becomes exponentially more difficult to achieve.

Zherebukh's desire to keep his far-advanced passer is understandable, but it puts him on a very narrow course. Instead, Black had an elegant way to force the draw: 53. ... Ra2 54. Nb4 (54. Ne1 Kg6 and there is no way to stop ... Kh5) 54. ... d3!!



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM

Endgame tactics 101. The cooperative 55. Nxa2?? bears tragic consequences after 55. ... d2 56. Rg1+ Kh7, so White's hand is forced:

55. Nxd3 Ra4+ wins the pawn immediately;

55. Kxd3 Ra4 56. Kc3 a5 57. Nxc2 Rxh4 draws as well.

55. Rg1+ Kh7 is a futile insertion, since 56. Nxa2 is still impossible and the "tricky" 56. Kxd3 Ra4 57. Rg4?? would be, err, rather neglectful for obvious reasons.

It should be noted that 54. ... Ra3 is a lot less convincing on account of 55. Rxc2 Rh3 56. Rg2+ followed by Rg4, and some work is still required before Black can easily draw.

54. Kxd4 Rc8 55. Nc5 Kg6

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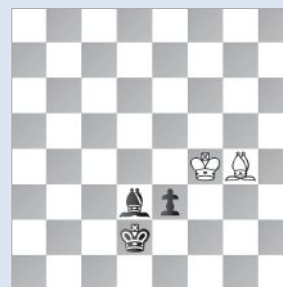
GM Alexander Onischuk
GM Varuzhan Akopian
U.S. Championship, 04.18.2018



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

WGM Sabina-Francesca Foisor
WGM Anna Sharevich
U.S. Women's Championship, 04.23.2018



BLACK TO MOVE

Once again, it appears that Black has inched within a hair's breadth of securing the draw. In fact, the drawing line seems laughably easy to calculate. But there is a fly in the ointment ...

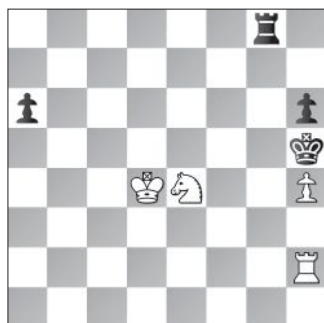
56. Rxc2 Kh5 57. Rh2 Rg8?

With this move, Zharebukh ostensibly proceeds along the finish line, preparing ... Rg4-xh4. In doing so, he walks right into a devilish trap and squanders his second opportunity to make a draw by force. To this end, 57. ... a5! would have diverted White's forces just enough to render h4 indefensible. After 58. Ne4 a4, Black's king cannot be effectively dislodged while keeping the a-pawn in check:

1) 59. Nf6+ Kg6 60. Ke5 looks impressive, but 60. ... Rc5+ 61. Nd5 a3! is a prosaic way to keep White's activity in check. After something like 62. Ke4 Ra5 White has no way to progress.

2) 59. Ke5 Kg4! 60. Rg2+ Kxh4! is a draw; Black's king is perfectly safe, since a menacing advance by his king can be warded off with a check along the f-file.

58. Ne4!!



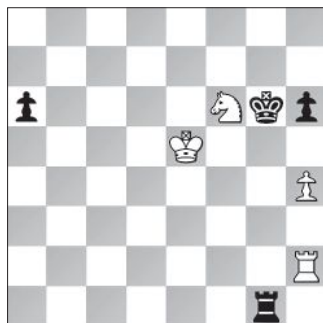
Once this move is made, the concept is rendered plain: after 58. ... Rg4 59. Ke5, the draw offer that will accompany 59. ... Rxh4 will be soundly refused, as 60. Nf6+ Kg5 61. Rg2+ is—yes—a jaw-dropping mating construction. As beautiful as this position is, the practical-minded of you may be wondering how one can reliably find such unusual patterns

in the endgame. In my view, this question already contains the seeds of a misunderstanding, since this pattern isn't all that unusual. If you regularly solve endgame studies (especially by such luminaries of the field as Genrikh Kasparyan and Alexey Troitsky), a pattern of this sort will probably not elicit more than a raised eyebrow. **More generally, serious endgame study reinforces the notion that powerful tactical ideas can be generated with relatively little material.**

58. ... Rg1?

Panic. Zharebukh tries to switch over to the back rank, but in doing so he allows White to push back his king and consolidate his decisive material advantage. It appears that a different strategy—that of checking along the side—was still enough to eke out a draw: 58. ... Rb8! 59. Nf6+ Kg6 60. Ke5 Rb5+ 61. Nd5 Kh5 62. Ke4 a5 and White is once more hard-pressed to make any sort of progress in the face of the a-pawn's advance. Interestingly, White is very close to delivering checkmate after 63. Nf4+ Kg4 64. Rg2+ Kxh4 but he has no way of doing so, since 65. Kf3 is handsomely met by 65. ... Rb3+ (but not the dreadful 65. ... h5 on account of 66. Rh2+ Kg5 67. Rxh5+).

59. Nf6+ Kg6 60. Ke5!



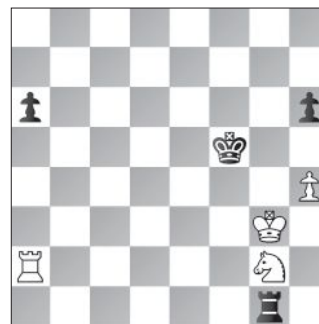
In addition to their tactical potency, the king and knight tandem is also capable of some impressive feats of gymnastics. White threatens h5+, with imminent consolidation. The rest,

as lazy commentators are wont to say, is a matter of straightforward technique.

60. ... Re1+ 61. Ne4 Kh5 62. Kf4 Rf1+ 63. Kg3 Re1 64. Nf6+ Kg6 65. Nd5

Some more acrobatics, this time to permanently keep the king out of h5.

65. ... Rd1 66. Nf4+ Kf5 67. Ra2 Rg1+ 68. Ng2!



And a final act of calisthenics! Notice how many hats the knight has worn throughout the game: first a blockader, then a vicious attacker, and finally a key component in White's consolidation campaign.

68. ... Rb1 69. Rxa6 Rb3+ 70. Kh2 Kg4 71. Rxh6, Black resigned.

Black's "activity" will be warded off in a matter of two or three moves. For instance, 71. ... Rh3+ 72. Kg1 Rb3 73. Rg6+ and Black has a rather unpleasant choice between instant death with 73. ... Kh3 74. h5 or prolonged yet equally one-sided agony after 73. ... Kh5 74. Rg5+.

This is the sort of meat-and-potato endgame struggle that will not contend for a brilliancy prize, but carries great instructive and entertainment value. Congratulations, Sam! ♠

¹Note that rook versus rook plus knight is an easier draw than rook versus rook plus bishop, which has regularly bedeviled some of the world's best players (see, for instance, Caruana-Svidler, Moscow, 2016, in which the evaluation changed multiple times, with Caruana missing several textbook wins).

The Ambushing Tactic

Chess psychology and objective evaluation are two entirely different things.

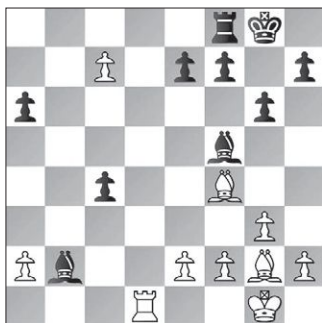
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

ENDGAME TACTICS ARE TO CHESS WHAT death and taxes are to real life. We shall, as before, leave to the philosopher the arduous task of understanding why so many positions with nary a piece left on the board are possessed of an almost maliciously tactical nature. As practical students of the game, we have little choice but to accept and coexist with this state of affairs.

The most infuriating—and exhilarating—thing about endgame tactics is that they seem to operate on an entirely different set of principles than your garden-variety mating combination. And it is more than worthwhile to understand some of the tactical patterns that show their faces only in the final stage of the game. In today's column, we will examine one such pattern—a breathtaking tactical motif that, to my knowledge, does not yet have a name. But it should, for it is not only quite common, but also absurdly easy to miss.

AUXILIARY TACTICS

GM S.P. Sethuraman (FIDE 2543, IND)
IM Daniel Naroditsky (FIDE 2472, USA)
Cultural Village Toernooi 2011 (5), Wijk aan Zee, Netherlands, 11.25.2011



AFTER 29. ...Rf8

As a consequence of some disgraceful opening play, a rather melancholy fate has befallen yours truly. It appears that White has several ways to finish the job—and he does. The most “businesslike” approach is 31. Bd5, which would have forced immediate resignation. It is curtains after both 31. ... c3 32. Bh6 and 31. ... Bf6 32. Bh6 Bg7 33. Bg5! (more accurate than 33. Bxg7 Kxg7 34. Bxc4, which is, of course, also completely winning) 33. ... Bf6 (33. ... c3 34. Bb3! changes nothing) 34. Bxf6 exf6 35. Kf1, when Black's position is too painful to look at. The king will slowly wend his way to b6, with Bb7 to follow. Black, I am sad to report, is consigned to the distinctly unglamorous role of shuffling his king between g7 and g8.

My opponent undoubtedly saw this line, but decided on an even more prosaic transformation:

30. Rd8 Bc8 31. Rxc8 Rxc8 32. Bb7 Rf8
33. c8=Q Rxc8 34. Bxc8 c3 35. Be5



On the face of it, this approach seems decidedly easier than keeping the rooks on the board. My opponent had not overlooked 35. ... f6, which is cruelly met by 36. Be6+! Kf8 37.

Bd4, when there is no ... e5. Most importantly, the dark-square bishop seems to be doing a marvelous job along the a1-h8 diagonal: Black will never, in the lifetime of this or any other universe, be able to push the c-pawn. Any overture with the a-pawn is dreadfully cumbersome and can be met with a2-a4.

It is at this point that the mysterious tactic to which I referred in the introduction announces its presence. **This tactic, which I will call “Ambushing,” works as follows:**

1. As a prerequisite, there is a passed pawn that is barred from advancing by an enemy piece(s). Let us call this situation the “passed pawn blockade.”
2. An ambushing tactic works one of two ways. If you are the one with a passed pawn, ambushing involves **paving the way to promotion by tactically disrupting the passed pawn blockade**. Conversely, if you are the one aiming to erect a passed pawn blockade, ambushing involves **moving one of the blocking pieces onto a defended square**.

Phew. One thing I know for certain is that I will not be working for Merriam-Webster's dictionary anytime soon! As confusing as this definition may seem at the moment, I hope that you will have a much better sense of what I'm talking about after we work through the examples.

The diagrammed position is a classic case of a passed pawn blockade: the bishop on e5 is (indirectly) stopping the pawn from advancing. One's instinct is to look for ways to physically remove the bishop from e5, but we already know that no such way exists. But let us consider the issue from the opposite end: what

Practicum

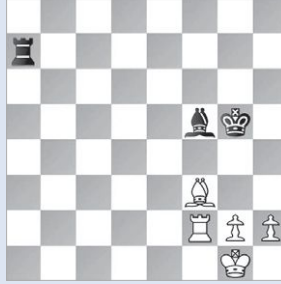
Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Gioacchino Greco

Study, 1621



BLACK TO PLAY AND DRAW

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Dmitrij Jakovenko (2737)

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2628)

Qatar Masters, Doha, 12.28.2015



BLACK TO MOVE

if we were to remove the bishop's control over b2?!

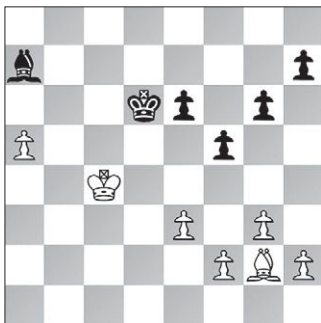
35. ... Ba1!!

The bishop on e5 has, in the purest sense of the word, been ambushed! It has wandered, fully confident and suspecting nothing, straight into the path of hell and brimstone. ... c3-c2 is now a threat, and 36. Bf4 meets with 36. ... Bb2, when White has no choice but to repeat the dance. The reason ambush tactics are so hard to see is because they involve unusual ways to remove the defender. To this end, we often think of a passed pawn as a "linear" entity: either it can move forward, or it cannot. What we fail to account for are the auxiliary tactics that surround a passed pawn's path to glory: moves that *indirectly* pave its way to promotion.

36. Bf4 Bb2 37. Bxa6 c2

Of course, the a-pawn will be handily restrained by Black's bishop (this time for real). The rest is straightforward.

38. Kf1 Kf8 39. a4 c1=Q+ 40. Bxc1 Bxc1 41. Ke1 e6 42. Kd1 Ba3 43. Kc2 Ke7 44. Kb3 Bc5 45. e3 Kd6 46. Kc4 Ba7 47. a5 Bb8 48. Bb7 Kc7 49. Bg2 Ba7 50. Kb5 f5 51. Kc4 Kd6



White has no way of making headway on the queenside, since Ka6 will always be met with ... Bb8.

52. Kd3 g5 53. f4 gxf4 54. exf4 e5 55. Ke2 exf4 56. gxf4 Kc5 57. Bb7 Kb5 58. a6

Kb6 59. Bc8 Bb8 60. Kf3 h6 61. h3 Ka7 62. h4 Kb6 63. h5 Ka7 64. Bxf5 Kxa6 65. Ke4 Kb6, Draw agreed.

White has the wrong-color bishop, but that is a moot point since Black's king will make it to the kingside with room to spare.

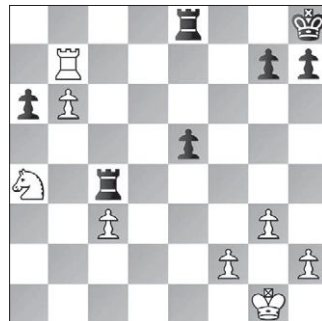
As you hopefully gleaned from my sorry attempt at a definition, ambushing works both ways. A game between two masters at this year's Russian Higher League offers a beautiful illustration of its second application.

HUNTING THE HUNTER

FM Dmitrij Rodin (2390)

IM Sergey Okrugin (2334)

Russian Higher League (9), Yaroslavl, Russia, 07.05.2018



AFTER 39. ... Rc4

White is in a serious tizzy, but the situation can likely be salvaged with some sober defense. To this end, 40. Nb2! Rxc3 41. Ra7 Rb8 42. Rxa6 would have given White excellent drawing chances, especially if he can manage to trade off the e5-pawn for the b6-pawn.

But Rodin was understandably turned off by the prospect of a torturous defense. So he decided to resolve his problems with a *petite combinaison*:

40. Ra7 Rxa4 41. b7 Ra1+ 42. Kg2

The point is not that White promotes: Black can stop the pawn with the straightforward

42. ... Rd1 (with ... Rdd8 to follow). But Rodin had seen one step further: after 43. c4! Rdd8 44. c5 the connected passers get the better of Black's two rooks. Indeed, Black is the one who barely evades defeat by a hair's breadth: 44. ... Rbb8 45. c6 Kg8 46. c7 Rbc8.

As you can guess, that isn't the whole story. We have a typical passed pawn blockade with several heavy pieces in the picture, and that should immediately raise the ambush alert. This time, the hunted becomes the hunter.

42. ... Rb1

And now White's 43. Ra8 is met by Rg8!!

How about them apples? What makes this move so hard to see is its aesthetic awkwardness; you don't even consider such a move in the vast majority of circumstances. Yet it is a classic example of ambushing: the rook on a8, which had pinned its hopes on the defenseless of its vis-a-vis, is left in total ignominy.

As a matter of fact, I lied to you. In the game, Rodin realized what awaited him, so the game ended in somewhat less glamorous fashion:

43. c4 Rb8, White resigned.

Notice that even here, one tempo decides the outcome: had the pawn been on c5, c5-c6 would have instantly turned the tables. Such is the nature of life chess, I am afraid.

The point of this article is not just to introduce a tactical pattern that is omnipresent in almost every type of endgame. Hopefully, I was able to instill an awareness for the idiosyncratic nature of endgame tactics as a whole. Those who attain endgame mastery constantly hone their ability to think outside the box, developing a sixth sense for ambushing and countless other tactics that, when overlooked, can visit upon their victim destruction of an unspeakable kind. ♠

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Concrete Calculations

A curious endgame reminds us to delve past superficial observations and form evaluations steeped in deeper thought.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

A FEW DAYS AGO, I WAS ABSENT-MINDEDLY leafing through my copy of David Bronstein's heralded classic *Zurich 1953* when a curious endgame caught my eye. The game in question was contested in the 22nd round between Bronstein himself and Swedish Grandmaster Gideon Stahlberg. I am in the process of collecting material for my upcoming book, so I figured that a closer look at this intriguing endgame was worth my while. The results of my analysis, which I would like to share with you in this month's column, are monumental in both beauty and instructive value. In the words of Los Angeles Clippers announcer Ralph Lawler: Seat belts on and mandatory.

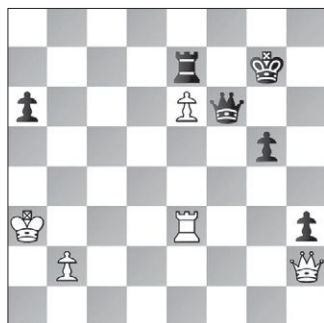
FASTEN YOUR SEATBELTS

GM David Bronstein

GM Gideon Stahlberg

Zurich Candidates' Tournament (22),

Zurich, Switzerland, 10.10.1953



AFTER 54. Kxa3

Get ready for a profound remark. Two remarks, to be more precise. Are you ready? Here goes:

1. Black is up a pawn.
2. Black has far-advanced, connected passed pawns.

I was obviously being sarcastic; these observations take no more than a few seconds to make. And they seem to indicate that White is utterly busted. However, one of the reasons I decided on this game is that **it underscores the importance of delving past superficial observations and forming an evaluation steeped in deeper thought and concrete calculation.** If we put this principle into practice, several additional factors announce themselves. The first is that White's pawn on e6, advanced and under fire as it is, ties down Black's pieces and may become a significant source of counterplay. In addition, Black's far-advanced passers do not have a clear way forward: Black can play ... g4, but g3 is squarely under White's control (pun intended). More concretely, 54. ... g4 can be met with 55. Qd6, when there seems to be no clear way for Black to disentangle the Gordian knot in the center. Having observed all of this, the Swedish grandmaster decides to change the landscape of the position.

54. ... Rxe6?

Doing away with the scoundrel on e6 is, on the face of it, an understandable decision. It seems to be tactically justified as well: 55. Qxh3 fails to 55. ... Qe7+, picking up the rook, while 55. Rxh3 meets with 55. ... Re1! 56. Qc7+ (56. Ka2 Qe6+ 57. Rb3 Re3 is curtains, as White will quickly run out of checks) 56. ... Qe7+! 57. Qxe7+ Rxe7, and White's king being in Timbuktu renders this endgame entirely hopeless. Note that White will never be able

to win the pawn on a6, as Black can simply station his rook on the sixth rank.

But there's a catch. **Transformations of any sort—be they liquidations, changes in pawn structure, or any other means of changing the nature of the position—almost invariably create tactical fireworks in their wake.** This position is no exception: by taking on e6, Stahlberg has left his king temporarily exposed, and this feature enables Bronstein to save the game with a vicious intermezzo.

55. Qc7+!

As Bronstein notes in *Zurich 1953*, Stahlberg anticipated this check, but missed that 55. ... Kg6 meets with a second intermezzo: 56. Qc2+!! (not 56. Rxh3 Qe7+), transferring the queen to an invulnerable square where it simultaneously protects White's king and threatens an incursion along the h-file. After 56. ... Kf7 57. Rxh3, Black can continue to press with 57. ... Re1, but it is clear that White has survived the worst of the storm. Following 58. Qh7+ Kf8 59. Qh5, Black has nothing better than 59. ... Qe7+ (59. ... Ra1+ 60. Kb3 Qe6+ 61. Kc2 leads nowhere: Black can try to trick White with a series of checks, but that is the best he can do) 60. Kb3 Re3+ 61. Rxe3 Qxe3+ 62. Kb4!, when Black's winning prospects seem decidedly grim. Note that the presence of additional queenside pawns favors White, as Black's queen is now burdened with the additional task of ensuring that the a6-pawn is not falling prey to any double attacks. Stockfish's evaluation of 1.85 in Black's favor is obviously inconclusive, so it would be great if a reader with access to

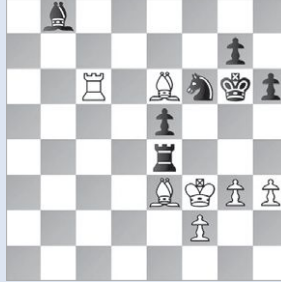
Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Robert James Fischer
Samuel Baron
Manhattan, 1956



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Anatoly Karpov
GM Garry Kasparov
Seville, 1987



WHITE TO MOVE

the 7-piece Lomonosov Tablebases could confirm my intuition.

In any case, 55. ... Kg6 was the only way to salvage winning chances. Instead, Stahlberg heads to the peace table:

55. ... Qf7?! 56. Qc3+

This position seems identical to the one after 55. ... Kg6 but the crucial difference is that White's queen controls the e1-square, making it impossible for Black to whip up any kind of activity against White's king. The draw becomes even more straightforward.

56. ... Rf6 57. Rxh3 Qe7+ 58. Ka2 Qe6+ 59. Ka1 Kg8 60. Rh1 Qc6 61. Qh3 Qa4+ 62. Kb1 Qe4+ 63. Ka1, Draw agreed.

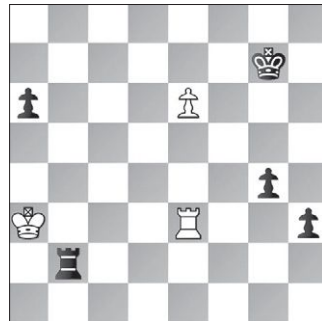
As predicted, the threats along the h-file are so powerful that Black cannot even dream of playing on.

This, of course, is not all. Returning to the initial diagrammed position, the real question that the serious analyst must answer is whether Black is, in fact, winning after 54. ... g4 55. Qd6.



Realistically, Black has only one way to disentangle himself: 55. ... Rb7, creating a counter-threat against the b2-pawn. Then, 56. Re2 fails to 56. ... Qf3+, so White has no choice but to move his queen back to d2. This is where the party begins in earnest. The keen tactician should notice that Black has a seemingly decisive liquidation tactic: 56. ...

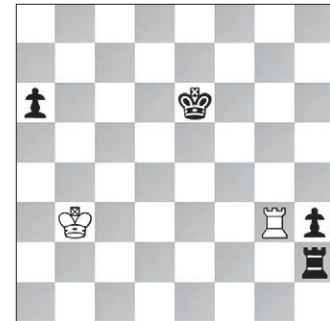
Qxb2+ 57. Qxb2 Rxb2, when Black's passers seem to prevail despite the presence of the e6-pawn!



The point is that after 58. Kxb2 Kf8, the e-pawn is useless, and so is the rook: for instance, 59. Re2 g3 60. Re1 h2, and White can resign. The same exact thing happens after 58. e7 Rb8. And so it seems that we have solved the mystery of the position.

But recall, for a moment, the point we made in the beginning. After 56. ... Qxb2+, the position radically transforms: pieces are hanging, pawns are being promoted; the position is in a state of flux. As they did in the actual game, these factors converge to make possible an absolutely stunning idea that saves the game: 58. Re4!! Take a moment to let this move sink in. White is two pawns down, Black is promoting both of his pawns, and yet White calmly takes his rook and moves it one square up. The point, of course, is that White will capture on g4 with *check*, and then move the rook to h4 in order to restrain Black's remaining kingside passer. There is nothing Black can do about that, as he must attend to the e6-pawn to ensure that it does not slip by. After 58. ... g3 59. Rg4+ Kf6 60. Rxg3 Rh2 (60. ... h2 61. Rh3 Rg2 62. Rh6+! Ke7 63. Kb3 and there is no way to make progress!) 61. Kb3 Kxe6, we reach a well-known theoretical position called *Vancura's Position*.

(see diagram next column)



Obviously, we have no time to delve into the actual drawing mechanism, but googling Vancura will open up a wealth of articles that explain the mechanism.

To me, this sequence is amazing because it shows just how concrete chess really is, when all is said and done. If a single piece was placed on a different square, this mechanism would fail: for instance, if White's king were on a2, the rook capture on b2 would come with check, and White would have no choice but to go capture the rook and let Black's pawns promote.

In retrospect, then, it is important to play 56. ... Kf8, refraining from taking on b2 and bringing the king over to e7. I analyzed this position for quite some time and concluded that Black is indeed winning, though he will still have to demonstrate accurate technique. But I find it hard to imagine that anyone playing this position would be able to find a move like Re4 over the board!

The moral of the story is not a new one: we have discussed the importance of concreteness many times in these pages. But as one of my friends likes to remind me, sometimes it is important to tell ourselves things that we already know. By doing so, we can ensure that we consistently practice what we preach, even if the author of these words does not. ♠

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How to Write an Endgame Thriller

Endgames carry remarkable entertainment value, especially when they are contested between top players and feature unique imbalances.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

LET ME START WITH A CONFESSION: I love airplane thrillers. There is nothing like a fresh Dan Brown hardback to tide one through an exhausting transatlantic journey. A successful thriller keeps you on the edge of your seat, not because of the author's masterful turns of phrases, but rather because you want to know what happens next. Yet the element of suspense is not enough: the author must also make you care about the fate of the main character. Dan Brown does both things exceptionally well.

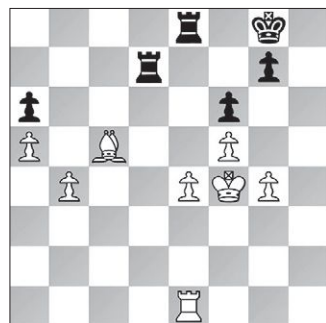
So, it turns out, do certain chess players. Endgames carry remarkable entertainment value, especially when they are contested between top players and feature unique imbalances. One such endgame, which occurred in the second round of the recently-concluded Sinquefeld Cup, checks both boxes, as well as many others. It is the quintessential chess thriller, one that we can both enjoy and learn from.

WATER FROM A ROCK

GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2842, NOR)

GM Sergey Karjakin (FIDE 2773, RUS)

2018 Sinquefeld Cup (2), St. Louis, Missouri, 08.19.2018



AFTER 67. Re1

For most of the game, Magnus had been nursing a tiny positional advantage that he transformed into a more tangible superiority with the aid of an Exchange sacrifice. In theory, White should be clearly better: he has two pawns for the Exchange, beautifully-coordinated pieces, and the possibility to rapidly execute one of three pawn breaks: g4-g5, e4-e5, or b4-b5. All of them carry potentially fatal consequences for Black. But Karjakin, living up to his reputation as the Minister of Defense, uncorks a lovely shot that dashes White's hopes for an advantage.

67. ... g5+!

This move is yet another demonstration of the transcendental power of concrete thinking. White is suddenly faced with a soul-crushing dilemma: voluntarily ruin his pawn structure with 68. fxg6 *e.p.*, or retreat the king and bid farewell to any possibility of a breakthrough. As a matter of fact, after 68. Ke3 Kf7 69. Rh1 Kg7, it is White who must tread carefully. One possible way for the game to end is 70. b5 axb5 71. Rb1 Red8 72. Rb3 (the cavalier 72. Rxb5 would have led to unnecessary difficulties after 72. ... Rd3+ 73. Kf2 Rd2+ 74. Ke1 [74. Ke3?? R8d3 mate would be a tragic outcome indeed] 74. ... Rd1+ 75. Ke2 R8d2+ 76. Kf3 Rd3+ 77. Ke2 [77. Be3 Re1 wins] 77. ... R1d2+ 78. Ke1 Rc2!?, and White must continue with razor precision to avoid a back rank calamity) 72. ... Rh8 73. Rxb5 Rh3+ 74. Ke2 Rh2+ 75. Ke3 Rh3+ with a repetition.

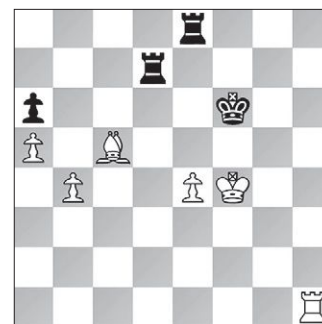
In any case, it is clear that Black is the only one who can push after a king retreat, so Magnus bites the bullet.

68. fxg6 e.p. Kg7

Karjakin was visibly relieved at this point, as it is hard to imagine that technical difficulties

of any sort lie in his path any longer. With his next few moves, Magnus seemingly acquiesces to a peaceful result.

69. g5 Kxg6 70. gxf6 Kxf6 71. Rh1!



It hardly bears mention that Magnus does not choose to yield quietly. Against a player of Karjakin's caliber, I would have undoubtedly played something like 71. Re2, accompanying my move with a knowing smile and silent draw offer. In fact, draw offers were not allowed at the Sinquefeld Cup, but that is beside the point. Even if they were permitted, the d-word would not escape the Norwegian's mouth until two bare kings were left on the board.

Here's the rub: even though the computer evaluates this position as dead drawn—and even though commentators and viewers were convinced that the game would end in a draw—Black's position is actually quite a bit more difficult to play. **More generally, the concept of a position being easy or hard to play is an oft-underestimated tool that you can use to shoehorn your opponent into unforeseen difficulties.**

White is risking nothing here. Even if he loses the e4-pawn (which he will not), the draw will still be within his reach. Black, on the other

Practicum

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

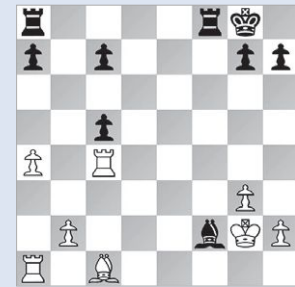
WGM Olga Girya
WGM Natalia Pogonina
Russian Women's Superfinal, 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Fabiano Caruana
GM Wesley So
Sinquefeld Cup (playoff), 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

hand, has to watch out for a myriad of threats, including pins and skewers. If he loses the a-pawn, the game will essentially be decided in White's favor.

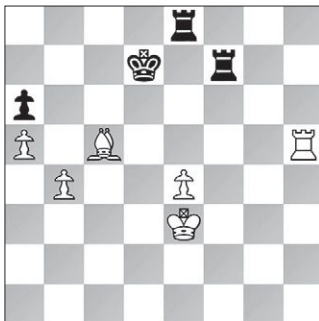
71. ... Rf7!

A fantastic response from Karjakin, who used up nothing out of his remaining one minute and seven seconds. He prepares to meet 72. Rh6+, which is now a blunder, with 72. ... Kg7+ (check!), and after 73. Kg5 Re5+ Black wins the rook.

72. Ke3

Another vintage Magnus move, maintaining the tension and giving Karjakin opportunity to trip on his own feet. The computer myopically recommends 72. e5+?!, which would have absolved Black of all troubles after 72. ... Rxe5 73. Rh6+ Kg7+ 74. Kxe5 Kxh6 75. Kd5 Kg6 76. Kc6 Kf5 and the pawn is untouchable, as 77. Kb6 is met with 77. ... Rf6+.

72. ... Ke6 73. Rh4 Rf6 74. Rh7 Rf7 75. Rh5 Kd7



76. e5!

Another terrific move, whose power lies in its psychological worth rather than its objective value. By advancing the pawn, Magnus creates the illusion that he is making progress. In acute time pressure, it is easy to imagine horror scenarios in which White plays Kd4, Rh6, and picks up the pawn on a6. With less than a minute on the clock, Karjakin decides that the best

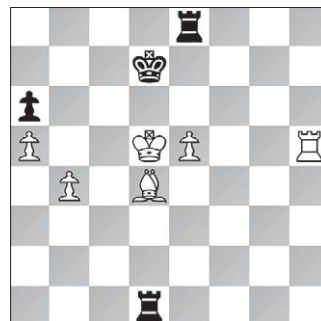
course of action is to mobilize his rooks before it is too late.

76. ... Rf1

But that plays right into Magnus's hands. The position becomes sharp, and concrete threats begin to materialize on the board. A safer route would have been 76. ... Kc6, intending to meet 77. Rh6+ (77. Ke4 Re6 is a fortress) with 77. ... Kd5 when White has absolutely nothing. 78. Rxa6 Rxe5+ 79. Kd2 may look intimidating, but after 79. ... Kc4! Black is the only one with any chances.

77. Ke4!

Houston, we have a problem. Karjakin most likely missed that after his intended 77. ... Re1+ 78. Kd5 Rd1+, White has the reply 79. Bd4, cutting off the rook and creating a rather unpleasant face-off with Black's king.



ANALYSIS AFTER 79. Bd4

Imagine having 30 seconds here: White threatens Rh6-Rxa6, and there seems to be no defense to speak of. It transpires that Black draws with 79. ... Rd8!!, a phenomenal defensive resource that is essentially inconceivable to find with no time on the clock. Black threatens to retreat his king with check, essentially forcing 80. Kc4 or 80. Ke4. Black plays 80. ... Rc1+ or 80. ... Re1+, respectively, when White has nothing better than to repeat moves.

At this point, everyone was on the edge of their seats ... literally. But even the Minister of Defense is human.

77. ... Kc6??

It is hard to believe, but this move loses on the spot. That is what I meant when I said that the initial endgame was easier to play for White: both the consequences and probability of blunder were squarely in Magnus' favor.

78. Rh6+

We saw a few lines where giving up the a6-pawn does not result in tragedy, but here, Black cannot recover the e-pawn in return. White will be left with two devastating connected passers, in addition to his longtime friend on e5.

78. ... Kb5

The only reasonable try. After 78. ... Kc7 79. Rxa6 Re1+ 80. Be3 Black loses without a fight.

79. Rb6+ Kc4 80. e6!

Filigree precision. Carlsen avoids the terribly greedy 80. Rxa6?!, which allows 80. ... Re1+ 81. Be3 Rxe3+! with an immediate draw. Karjakin cannot stop the pawn from ultimately reaching e7, where it will permanently tie down Black's rooks and ultimately cost him the game.

80. ... Re1+ 81. Kf5 Rf1+ 82. Ke5 Re1+ 83. Kf6 Rf1+ 84. Kg7! Ra8 85. e7 Re1 86. Kf7 Re4 87. Rd6

The rook is bound for d8!

87. ... Rh8 88. Rxa6, Black resigned.

Obviously, 88. Rd8 was also winning, but Magnus sees no reason to burn any bridges. The rook will return to d8 at its leisure, and following promotion, White will be up a full piece and two pawns.

Hopefully, this game—entertainment value aside—supplies a more nuanced picture of Magnus' famed ability to squeeze water from a rock. Ultimately, concreteness is everything, especially when it is combined with a fine intuition for moves that confronts your opponent with the greatest possible difficulties. ♠

False Narratives

It's easy to lose track of your objectives when you get caught up in self-narration.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

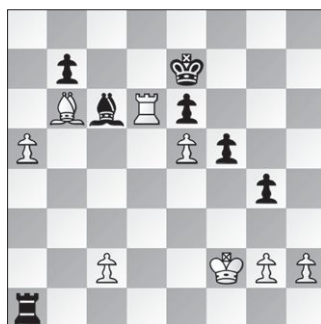
WHEN PEOPLE ASK ME TO NAME MY favorite chess book, I almost invariably respond with *Chess for Zebras*, written by the Scottish GM Jonathan Rowson and originally published in 2005. The reason I harbor such a fondness for this work is that Rowson offers an analysis of chess psychology and chess thinking that, in both depth and practical value, is unequalled in all of chess literature. It is hardly a surprise that Rowson holds a degree in philosophy from Oxford University and is the founder of Perspectiva, a cutting-edge and multidisciplinary research institute.

One of the themes Rowson introduces is the notion of storytelling. Rowson defines storytelling, or chess narratives, “as the background ‘noise’ that permeate our thoughts during play. Narratives,” he continues, “are the guiding stories that give us a sense of what we are trying to do and why. (...) Many players get lost in these stories, trapped by their own narrative, and completely lose track of the objective state of affairs on the board” (Rowson, *Chess for Zebras*, 46).

Endgames constitute a particularly fertile milieu for storytelling. To understand what these narratives look like, and why they are so insidious, I will present a recent episode from my coaching experience. It started rather innocuously, as I flipped open my copy of Ger van Perlo's magisterial work *Endgame Tactics* in search of new training material, and found a rather elegant combination:

UNEXPECTED

GM Vlastimil Hort
Hans-Joachim Deuker
Simultaneous Exhibition, 1986



BLACK TO PLAY

In this unassuming endgame, Deuker has just connected his pawns with ... **f7-f5**. It may seem that Black's tremendous piece activity handsomely compensates for White's extra pawn—and it does. The problem is that Black's last move allows an unexpected—and rather brilliant—tactical refutation:

1. exf6+!! e.p. Kxd6

Black has little choice but to accept the sacrifice, as 1. ... Kxf6 fails straightforwardly to 2. Rxc6 followed by Bd4+ (in either order).

2. Bc5+!

By now, the point of the combination should be clear. After 2. ... Kxc5 3. f7, Black's entire army must play spectator to the pawn's coronation. Moreover, the pawn promotes with check, so 3. ... Bb5, intending ... Rf1+, leads nowhere.

Seeing this, Deuker came up with an ingenious improvement:

2. ... Ke5 3. f7 Bb5!

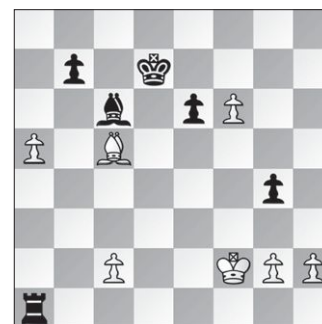
Now, the pawn no longer promotes with check, so 4. f8=Q Rf1+ picks up the newly-

minted queen and leads to an immediate draw. But Hort saw one step further:

4. Kg3!, Black resigned.

The bishop proves its worth, preparing to meet 4. ... Rf1 with 5. Bf2.

This combination presents excellent material, as the conscientious student must not only see the first move, but also spot 4. Kg3 at a distance, which is no trivial matter. I presented this game as a warmup exercise to one of the high-rated groups at the Castle Chess Camp in Atlanta this past June. Five minutes after I had set up the position, no one had uttered a word. That is when something terrifying occurred to me. No, the position was not set up incorrectly. Rather, all the parties involved had seemingly overlooked a trivial defensive resource. After 2. Bc5+, Black can simply respond with 2. ... Kd7!



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 2. ... Kd7!

This resource, unmentioned by Van Perlo, solves all of Black's problems. After 3. f7 Bb5, the proximity of Black's king to the pawn renders 4. Kg3 futile: 4. ... Rf1 5. Bf2 Ke7 picks up the pawn and wins the game. White therefore has no choice but to acquiesce to

Practicum

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 74.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Oscar de la Riva Aguado
GM Rafael Leitao
43rd Chess Olympiad, Batumi



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

FM Dagur Ragnarsson
Gauti Pall Jonsson
Reykjavik Championship

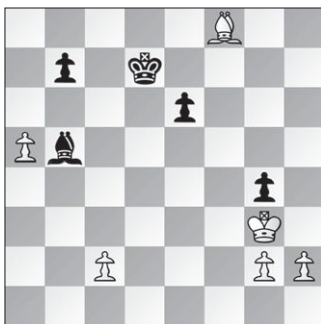


BLACK TO MOVE

the ostensibly drawn opposite-color bishop endgame with 5. f8=Q (or 4. f8=Q Rf1+ 5. Kg3, transposing) 5. ... Rxf8 6. Bxf8. A classroom poll confirmed my worst fear: everyone spotted the idea in a millisecond, and was trying all sorts of extravagant resources, from a5-a6 to h2-h4, in order to prevent this devilish resource.

"Keep thinking," I responded. "Keep your mind churning."

Meanwhile, I was turning red with embarrassment. *This can't be*, I thought to myself. *There must be something I'm missing*. I had computer-checked all of the material. To admit such an error after subjecting students to over 15 minutes of useless thought would constitute pedagogical disaster. It was at that point, as I pondered the best way to exonerate myself from this gaffe, that something occurred to me. Let's take another look at the bishop endgame that occurs after Black captures White's newly promoted queen:



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 6. Bxf8.

White is still a pawn up, and Black can reduce further material losses by tying his bishop to the g2-pawn with, for instance, 6. ... Bc6. Given the presence of opposite-color bishops, an extra pawn seems to have no bearing on the evaluation. But what if we consider this position a bit more concretely? After 7. Kxg4 Bxg2, a deadly—and rather straightforward—plan of action announces its presence. It consists of five steps:

1. Push the h-pawn as far as it will go, preferably to h6. The goal is to tie down Black's king. White's bishop is ideally stationed on e3, supporting the pawn and blocking Black's own passer.
2. Maneuver the king to b6 or c7, where it will assist in the creation of a second passed pawn.
3. If Black's bishop stays on the long diagonal, create a passed pawn with a5-a6. If the bishop moves to a6, push the c-pawn to c6.
4. Push the new passer until Black is forced to give up his bishop. Recall that Black's king is firmly tied down to the h-pawn.
5. Finally, maneuver the king to the other flank and finish Black off. Crucially, the h-pawn is of the right color!

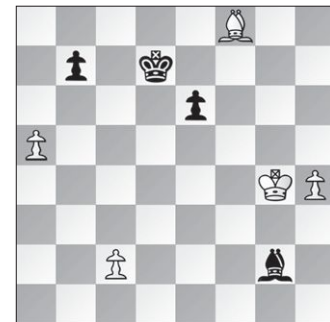
I was overjoyed when I discovered this plan, and so was the first student who arrived at a similar revelation. To combat the somewhat skeptical expressions on everyone else's face, I asked that student to play this position out with a nonbeliever. The game, roughly reconstructed below, proceeded along predictably one-sided lines: 8. h4 Ke8 9. Bc5 Kf7 10. h5 Kg8 11. h6 Kh7 12. Kg5 Bd5 13. Be3 (stage 1 accomplished) 13. ... e5 14. Kf6 e4 15. Ke5 Bc6 16. Kd6 Bb5 17. Kc7 (stage 2) 17. ... Ba6 (17. ... Bc6 18. a6) 18. c4, and Black threw in the towel.

The demonstration worked. Everyone now seemed convinced, and I patted myself on the back for my quick thinking. As a matter of fact, I thought to myself, this would be a terrific training position for titled players.

As you might guess, the *dramatis personae* of this charade, save Hort—the unwitting instigator of the whole business—all committed the vice of storytelling. Deuker, as well as Van Perlo, may have simply overlooked 2. ... Kd7, but it is equally plausible that his opponent's title, coupled with the shock value of the *en passant* itself, convinced him that such a combination

is bound to succeed. I took the farce one step further, persuading myself—and, in the process, my students that it was not possible that such a banal resource had slipped through the cracks.

And, perhaps, I even persuaded you. The five-step plan outlined above is not wrong; indeed, it offers a striking instance of the potency of long-term thinking. But its success hinges on Black's unquestioning cooperation, which he by no means has to provide. Let us, for the last time, revisit the endgame after the g-pawns have been captured, and the h-pawn has made its first menacing step toward coronation:



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 8. h4

It seems a bygone conclusion that Black's king must station himself on the kingside, but that is an illusion. Black achieves the draw by running his monarch to the opposite flank: 8. ... Be4 9. c3 (9. c4 Bd3 leads to an even quicker resolution) 9. ... Kc6!! 10. h5 Kd5! (10. ... Kb5? allows 11. Kf4 followed by Ke5) 11. h6 Kc4 12. Bb4 e5 13. Kg5 Bh7. That is all she wrote. As soon as White's king reaches f6, Black marches the e-pawn down the board, forcing White's bishop to abandon its post and give up the c3-pawn. That leaves him with a pawn of the wrong color. Even if he manages to pick up the e-pawn, the resultant endgame is a classical theoretical draw, in which White has no way to "un-a-file" his pawn without stalemate.

And that, my friends, is the perils of storytelling. ♠

The Olympiad Express

Even when the logic is flawless, the smallest imprecision in execution bears calamitous consequences.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

RECENTLY, IT OCCURRED TO ME THAT several parallels can be drawn between the U.S. Olympiad team and the starting lineup of my favorite basketball team, the Golden State Warriors. In the past few years, both entities broke out of an extended slump and mounted a furious ascent to the top of their respective fields. I will leave the task of comparing specific players to you, my dear reader, though I firmly encourage you to pair Stephen Curry with an enigmatic lookalike who is known only by the initials F.C.

At the 2018 Olympiad, the United States came within a hair's breadth of repeating their magisterial performance in Khanty-Mansiysk. A few tough breaks, coupled with an unfortunate loss against Poland, enabled the Chinese squad to squeeze by with a favorable tiebreak. Still, no one in their right mind can call silver medal a failure, especially if the U.S. completes the medal sandwich with a gold in 2020.

Predictably, the Olympiad supplied a basinful of tremendously instructive and entertaining endgame battles. One of them, brought to us by the aforementioned F.C.—who played the game in a cloak to avoid being seen—is too fun to pass up.

THERE WAS NOTHING AND THEN IT EXPLODED

GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2827, USA)

GM Shakhriyar Mamedyarov

(FIDE 2820, AZE)

43rd World Chess Olympiad 2018 (8),

Batumi, Georgia, 10.02.2018

(see diagram top of next column)

If the players agreed to a draw in this position, no one—and I mean no one—would bat an eye.



AFTER 42. ... hxg6

Material is equal, the pawns are immobile, and both kings are so weak that neither side can mount any sustained pressure against the opposing monarch.

However, there is a reason why Fabiano Caruana paid a visit to London in November, and it wasn't to ride a double-decker tour bus. As lifeless as this position seems, there is one last ember left in the fire. If White can mobilize his rook via d4, he will be only one move away from creating massive threats along the h-file. The immediate 43. Rd4 is not possible due to the check on e1, so Fabi decides to give his monarch a chance at redemption.

43. Kf1!

To me, the most elegant moves are those that can be explained through crystal-clear logic. All of a sudden, a concrete threat—Rd4—has materialized out of thin air. Not one to panic, Mamedyarov makes an astute observation in his own right: Rd4 can be met with ... Re4, intercepting the rook and inviting a transition into an utterly drawn queen endgame. A check on the eighth rank is similarly interposed with ... Re8. Unwilling to compromise

his defensive construction, Mamedyarov decides on a healthy waiting move:

43. ... Re6?



His logic was flawless, but, as often happens at the highest level, the smallest imprecision in execution bears calamitous consequences. The problem with this move is that the weakness of the eighth rank will cost Mamedyarov dearly, since ... Re8 comes with the additional problem of abandoning the c4-pawn. The only way to truly maintain the integrity of Black's defensive mechanism was 43. ... a5!, which should not strike you as a mindless computer move. White is in a kind of *Zugzwang*: he has plenty of ways to bide time, but no further way to make progress:

1. 44. Rd4 Re4 holds the fort. After 45. Rxe4 fxe4 there is no way to exploit Black's isolated pawns, e.g. 46. Qg5 a4 47. Ke1 Kf7 48. Ke2 Qb7 and the queen's activity ensures a comfortable draw.
2. 44. Qh4, as was played in the game, no longer makes as much sense. Black responds with 44. ... Kg7, and White has nothing better than 45. Rd4 Re4.

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 69.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Sam Shankland (2722)
GM Jorden Van Foreest (2624)
43rd World Chess Olympiad 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Luka Paichadze (2564)
GM Parham Maghsoodloo (2649)
43rd World Chess Olympiad 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

3. 44. Qf4?? has the noblest of intentions, but would be a terrible error. The reason for this has been left as an exercise to the reader.

44. Qh4!

This is the move that Mamedyarov overlooked. Having done its job on h6, the queen removes itself to a more dominant post, where it eyes the c4-pawn and reinforces the d8-square. It transpires that 44. ... Kg7, which seemingly takes the sting out of 45. Rd8, actually does no such thing: 45. ... Re8 46. Rxe8 Qxe8 and White picks up the pawn on c4, with a completely winning queen ending. Note the difference: after 43. ... a5 44. Qh4 Kg7 45. Rd8 would have made no sense. The devil, as always, is in the detail.

44. ... Re8

An unfortunate necessity.

45. Rd4!

Fabiano pounces on his opportunity, ganging up on the c4-pawn. Already, the Azeri juggernaut is in dire straits.

45. ... Rc8?

I challenge you to find a single human that would not make this move within a few seconds. To his credit, Mamedyarov spent eight minutes, a clear indication that he had, by this point, realized the full extent of his difficulties. The problem with this move is that it abandons all hopes of active counterplay, thereby giving White *carte blanche* on the kingside. The correct move was 45. ... a5, which—unlike its move 43 twin—does fall under the category of “mindless computer move.” The main point, it seems to me, is that after 46. Rxc4?! Qb7 White no longer has 47. b4 on account of 47. ... a4. White is therefore best advised to jump-start the attack with 46. g4, and following 46. ... fxe4 47. Rxe4 (47. Qxe4?? Qh1+ 48. Qg1 Re1+ picks up the queen) 47. ... Qd6 48. Rd4 Qe5 49. Rxc4 White has excellent winning chances (approximately .7 according to Stockfish). From a human perspective, this position is

virtually impossible to defend, since Black will have to display all sorts of queen gymnastics *ad infinitum* just to stay alive.

46. Qh6!

Straightforward and terribly powerful. The queen's toggling action between h4 and h6 leaves quite the pleasant impression.

46. ... Qe6 47. Rh4 Kf7 48. Qh7+?!

One can hardly blame Fabi for delivering this check, but it actually gives Black a sliver of life. The switchback maneuver 48. Qd2! would have instantly decided the game, as Black simply cannot deal with the litany of threats. The most human defense seems to be 48. ... Rg8, and after 49. Qd4 Rg7 (to stop Rh7+) 50. Rh8 g5 51. Rd8 Black is utterly busted.

48. ... Kf6 49. Rd4

The power of heavy pieces on full display. Even though material is equal, it appears that White is playing with more pieces!

49. ... Qe7



Mamedyarov returns the favor. His chance to extend the game lay in 49. ... Re8, which would have compelled White to satisfy himself with an extra pawn after 50. Qh4+ Kg7 51. Rxc4. This is a similar position to the one discussed in the note to Black's 45th move; from a practical perspective, I doubt that a human—even Magnus—would be able to survive for more than a few moves.

50. Qh6!

Back to home base! When trying to make sense of positions like these, it is important to understand that the decisiveness of White's advantage does not lie in any immediate threats. The threats will come in due course; Black is so passive and paralyzed that the indefensibility of his king is rendered permanent.

50. ... Kf7 51. Qd2 Rc7 52. Rh4

Another pleasing switcharoo, though 52. Rd8! was an even more straightforward win.

52. ... Kf6

The last chance to prolong the agony was 52. ... Rd7, after which the simplest is 53. Rh7+ Kg8 54. Qxd7 Qxh7 55. Qc8+, with a familiar queen ending that offers little in the way of hope for Black.

53. Qd4+ Qe5 54. Qb6+ Kg7 55. Qb8!

Crushing. The queen has patiently wormed its way to the eighth rank, and now it is time to reap the rewards.

55. ... Kf6 56. Qh8+ Ke6 57. Qg8+ Kf6 58. Rd4!

Razor-sharp precision! The rook swings around to the eighth rank to deliver the final blow.

58. ... Qe7 59. Rd8 Kg5 60. f4+ Kh5 61. Rd2 Qg7 62. Rh2+ Kg4 63. Kg2!

The last finesse. In fact, the banal 63. Qd5 also did the job, but why not end the game in style? The queen is obviously untouchable due to Rh4 mate.

63. ... g5 64. Qe8!, Black resigned.

A phenomenal effort by Caruana. Together with Sam Shankland's victory over Rauf Mamedov, the United States was able to nullify Teimour Radjabov's impressive effort against Wesley So and triumph over the monstrous Azeri team. ♠

Chess GPS

When you are not sure how to evaluate a position, sometimes it's better not to evaluate it.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE NEXT TIME THAT YOU HAVE A FEW hours (and marbles) to spare, try using your GPS to navigate around Stanford University. For the few of you who have better things to do in your spare time, I will divulge a sneak preview. The campus contains a staggering number of pedestrian-only alleys, bike-only roundabouts, one-way streets, unnamed streets, and dead ends—not to mention the equally Byzantine system of parking permits. If you want to see what Google Maps is like on LSD, you know where to go.

Though we can laugh about the relative imperfections of modern technology, it is no joking matter when your internal GPS starts to malfunction at the chess board. The equivalent of a confusing university campus is, of course, a complex and highly unbalanced position, in which standard metrics of evaluation are either useless or altogether inapplicable. In this month's column, we examine just such a position. Both players are monstrously strong, yet even their GPS pointed them in the wrong direction for several critical moves in a row. Can we learn from their mistakes and prepare our own chess navigators for an epic challenge? Let's find out!

WRONG DIRECTIONS

GM Ray Robson (2760)

GM Dariusz Swiercz (2769)

2018 Fall Chess Classic (9), St. Louis, Missouri, 10.18.2018

(see diagram top of next column)

In general, a good place to start a surface-level assessment of a position is by counting the material and evaluating relative king safety.



AFTER 29. Rxc3

Unfortunately, both metrics yield more questions than answers: White has two rooks for a queen, and it is entirely unclear whose king is safer in the long run. Great! What now?

When you are not sure how to evaluate a position, the solution can be straightforward: don't evaluate it! Rather, pool all of your efforts into first checking for tactics and then generating the best move with the aid of calculation.

Common chess wisdom teaches us that evaluation is the necessary first step in determining the course of action in a critical position. The process of weighing and comparing factors like material, king safety, pawn structure, piece placement, and the like is indispensable because it guides our thinking in the right direction. While that is all true, some positions—like the one above—resist this sort of logic. Imagine if someone tapped GM Swiercz on the shoulder and sagely whispered, “Dariusz, you might want to know that your pawn structure is worse, but your king placement is marginally better!” Would that help him find a move? Probably not. But now imagine if the same person came up and whispered, “Dariusz, you have a

tactical blow in this position!” Would that question fare any better? I certainly believe so!

29. ... f5?!

After this move is executed, king safety truly does become an important matter of consideration. Though he defends the e4-pawn, Swiercz permanently opens up the long diagonal, creating a rather alarming opportunity for a vicious attack along the seventh rank. It transpires that Swiercz actually did have a tactical sequence, based on the fact that the bishop on c6 is unprotected. There is a reason why LPDO (Loose Pieces Drop Off), an acronym coined by GM John Nunn, is so well-known. Black exploits the vulnerable bishop by sacrificing his own: 29. ... Bxb3!! 30. Rxb3 Qe6, hitting the newly-unprotected rook and bishop. After 31. Ba4?! Qc4, we reach a remarkable position in which White cannot protect his bishop despite the massive amount of material clustered on the queenside. Hence, White should prefer 31. Rb5 Qxc6 32. a4, freezing up the queenside and leading to a very drawish position. Black can try to push with 32. ... f5, intending ... f5-f4, to which White should reply 33. Be5! (inducing a further weakening) 33. ... g5 34. Bd4 Bxd4 35. exd4 Qc3 36. Rab1 (36. Rd1 f4! 37. Rxb6 e3 gives Black a marginal initiative, though the game should still end in a draw with best play) 36. ... e3 37. fxe3 Qxe3+ 38. Kh1 Qxd4 39. Rxb6 with a perpetual to follow.

30. Bb5?

Understandably enough, Robson evacuates his bishop from the danger zone. But human logic does not produce very good results here; everything is based on concrete tactical re-

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

WGM Shiqun Ni (2436)
GM Alexandra Kosteniuk (2543)
Women's World Championship, 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Ray Robson (2760)
GM Dariusz Swiercz (2769)
2018 St. Louis Fall Classic, 2018



BLACK TO MOVE

sources. To this end, White had to strike first with 30. b4!, sacrificing a pawn to pave the pawn for an immediate incursion along the a-file. Following 30. ... axb4 (refusing the sacrifice with 30. ... Bd6 is not a very good idea due to 31. Rc2 and Black has to take the pawn anyway) 31. axb4 Bxb4 32. Rcc1, a critical position arises.



ANALYSIS AFTER 32. Rcc1

Once again, it is nearly impossible to evaluate this position in human terms. To come up with a suitable plan of defense for Black, one must adopt a concrete prophylactic approach. What is the threat? Well, it seems to be Ra8+ followed by Rca1, with impending infiltration on a7. Therefore, Black must respond with 32. ... Kh7!. White has several tries, all of which necessitate filigree precision:

- A) 33. Ra8 creates the serious double threats of Rca1 and (more importantly) Rb8. To defend, Black must once more adopt a prophylactic mindset: 33. ... h5!! is the only way out, creating some luft for the king. After 34. Rca1 (34. Rb8? is no longer scary due to 34. ... Qd6! 35. Rb7 Qd2 36. Rxb7+ Kh6 and White must grovel for a draw) 34. ... Qd6 35. Be8 (35. R1a7 loses to the stunning sequence 35. ... Qd1+ 36. Kh2 Bd6+ 37. g3 Bxg3+!! 38. fxg3 Qd2+, picking off both "loose" bishops) 35. ... Qd2 36. Bd4 Bc3 with a dead draw after the bishops are exchanged.
- B) 33. Bd4!? is the computer's recommendation, and requires equally insane pre-

cision from Black. The immediate 33. ... Bc5 runs into trouble after 34. Bxc5 bxc5 35. Bb5, when White will gradually pick off the c-pawn. Therefore, Black should start with 33. ... Ba3!, and only after 34. Rd1 play 34. ... Bc5. Following 35. Bxc5 Qxc5 36. Bd7 (FYI: White can actually start with the mind-boggling 35. Bd7) 36. ... Bxd7 37. Rxd7, Black is just in time with 37. ... f4! 38. exf4 e3 39. fxe3 Qxe3+ 40. Kh1 Qxf4, and White cannot make progress on account of the constant threat of perpetual.

30. ... Qd6?



To continue our GPS analogy, Swiercz recognizes that he must take the freeway, but goes in the wrong direction. More specifically, this move discourages b3-b4 because of ... Qd2, but it does not prevent it entirely. The right approach was to ... wait a minute. Now develop your own ability to think concretely: How can you counterbalance the impending onslaught? *The solution can be found on page 71.*

31. b4! Qd2 32. Rb1 axb4

This is forced, since the immediate 32. ... Ba2 is coolly rebuffed by 33. bxc5 Bxb1 34. cxb6! Qxb2 35. Rc5! (even more accurate than 35. Rc8+) 35. ... Qxa3 36. Rc8+ Kh7 37. b7.

33. axb4 Bxb4 34. Rc7

So far, all has gone according to plan for both players. At this point, the cowardly 34. ...

Bf7 would fail to keep the lid on due to 35. Bxg7! Kxg7 36. Be8, picking up the bishop with interest. Swiercz delivers what seems to be a shattering blow:

34. ... Ba2



It seems reasonable to surmise that Dariusz expected 35. Bc4+, leading to a familiar type of position after 35. ... Bxc4 36. Rxc4 f4!. That is indeed what my own GPS squarely indicated when I first looked at this position. However, it is easy to forget that White has assembled a massive attacking force, and all of his pieces—save the rook on b1—are entirely unburdened. As always, *tactics vincit omni*—the presence of a tactical sequence renders any sort of verbal evaluation or logical thinking futile.

35. Rxb7+ Kf8 36. Ra7!!

Simply divine. Not only is the mating net cast, but it is done with a simultaneous attack on Black's bishop. Following 36. ... Bxb1, the mating sequence is straightforward, yet quite gorgeous: 37. Bg7+ Kg8 38. Bc4+ Kh7 39. Be5+ Kg6 40. Rg7+ Kh5 41. Bf7+ Kh4 42. Bf6 mate.

36. ... Qc2 37. Rc1!, Black resigned.

The bishop is untouchable due to the back rank mate, so Black has no choice but to part ways with his queen.

By simply recognizing the incredibly complex nature of a most unbalanced endgame, we can come closer to optimizing our chess GPS. ♠

Procrastinate at Your Own Risk

When you sense that the result of the game is hanging in the balance, do not put off important decisions.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

CHESS PLAYERS OFTEN ASSUME THAT blitz games, entertaining as they are, carry little instructional value. It seems to me that this assumption is motivated by two considerations. The first one is self-evident: the quality of the game is necessarily circumscribed by the time control, which affords virtually no possibility for deep calculation. The second reason is that top players are unlikely to reveal their main opening preparation in a blitz game, and they are also unlikely to treat the game with quite the same level of intensity as they would a classical game.

But there are games that defy both of these considerations. In today's column, we examine just such an exception: a tremendously instructive endgame that featured objectively powerful chess and supreme fighting spirit from both players. Make no mistake (no pun intended): mistakes *were* made, in non-trivial quantities. But as we have previously discussed, learning from others' mistakes while reclining in a comfortable armchair can be equally effective—and certainly more fun—than drawing lessons from our own failings at the board.

FIGHTING SPIRIT

GM Hikaru Nakamura (FIDE 2893, USA)

GM Wesley So (FIDE 2771, USA)

India Chess International Blitz open,
Kolkata, India, 11.13.2018

(see diagram top of next column)

We join the battle in a position that looks about as interesting as, uh, one of the chapters in *Moby Dick* on the art of whaling. However, a quick draw is not in Hikaru's vocabulary, and he finds the only way to inject a modicum of life into the position:



AFTER 21. ... Rd8

22. Qf3!

That's right, take the queens off the board and we have ourselves a ballgame!

22. ... Qxf3 23. gxf3

The queen trade has not altered the objective evaluation, but it has confronted Black with a concrete problem: once he moves the knight, his queenside pawns will find themselves in a rather uncomfortable position. Not only does Nxa7 become possible, but also a rook infiltration to the seventh rank can lead to even greater material losses. Sensing the danger, Wesley decides to move the knight with tempo:

23. ... Ne5!

Now, 24. Nxa7 leads exactly nowhere due to 24. ... Rd2, when it is White who must worry about maintaining the balance.

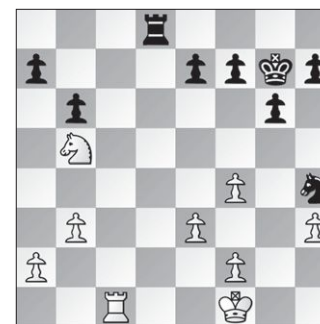
24. f4

Hikaru chases away the knight and renews the aforementioned threats.

24. ... Nf3+?!

Believe it or not, this natural-looking move is the source of all of Black's subsequent difficulties. But, as a matter of fact, it does not give away the draw. Rather, it makes the draw harder to find. From a conceptual standpoint, the problem with this move is that the knight will have an extremely difficult time reentering the game, saddling the rook with a herculean defensive task. To this end, the most convincing path to a draw was 24. ... Nd3, a move that Wesley almost certainly rejected on account of 25. Rd1 (The line 25. Rc7 a6 26. Na7! is an interesting try, but after 26. ... Nb4! 27. Rxe7 Rd1+ 28. Kg2 Rd2 it is once again White who must tread carefully), creating a deeply unpleasant pin along the d-file. To Black's rescue, however, comes a pretty tactical resource: 25. ... Rd5! 26. Nxa7 (26. Nc3 Rd7 with ... Nc5 to follow is an immediate draw) 26. ... Nxf4!, restoring material equality and unpinning the rook. Following 27. Rxd5 Nxd5, White can try to create an outside passed pawn with 28. Nc8!?, but after 28. ... b5 29. a4 bxa4 30. bxa4 Kf6 31. Kg2 Ke6 Black's active pieces more than compensate for the passed a-pawn. If anybody must exercise caution, it is White.

25. Kg2 Nh4+ 26. Kf1



Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Wesley So (2808)
GM Santosh Gujrathi Vidit (2660)
India Chess International, 2018



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Hikaru Nakamura (2893)
GM Wesley So (2771)
India Chess International, 2018



BLACK TO MOVE

Black has succeeded in disentangling his knight, but now he needs to make a pivotal decision between the measured 26. ... Rd7 and the more active, but potentially more dangerous, 26. ... Rd2. The correct move keeps objective equality, but that is beside the point. By taking the most precise route two moves earlier, Wesley could have avoided this decision in the first place. This leads me to an important observation, which I have shared before in this column and which I originally heard from my coach GM Lev Psakhis: **When you are fighting to make a draw, it is important to demonstrate precision from the get-go. By procrastinating, you will make the draw harder and harder to attain, and risk totally losing control over the position.**

26. ... Rd7?

In a blitz game, it is incredibly difficult to resist this move. However, with the knight offside, White is afforded a golden opportunity. After 26. ... Rd2!, White simply does not have enough firepower to keep his own queenside together, and he has nothing better than to settle for 27. a4 Rb2! 28. Nxa7 (28. Rc3 Rb1+ 29. Ke2 Rb2+ and White should not avoid the perpetual) 28. ... Rxb3 29. Nc8 Nf5! 30. Rc6 Rb1+ 31. Kg2 Rb2 and Black musters up just enough activity to keep things together.

27. Rc7?

Hikaru responds with an instructive mistake in his own right. The logic behind this move is ironclad: White eliminates the piece that keeps Black's position together, leaving him with a terribly awkward knight and a wide-open queenside. However, this move fails concretely, as Black has just enough time to bring his knight back into the game. The cold-blooded 27. Ke2!, defending the d2-square and preparing Rc8, would have essentially compelled Black to enter an extremely unpleasant rook ending with 27. ... Nf5 28. Rc8 Nd6 29. Nxd6 exd6. His drawing chances here are excellent, but defending this position in a blitz game is no trivial task.

27. ... Rxc7 28. Nxc7 Nf3

The move 28. ... Nf5 was slightly more circumspect, but Wesley has the right idea.

29. Ke2 Ng1+ 30. Kf1 Nf3

Not falling for the prosaic trap 30. ... Nxh3?? 31. Kg2.

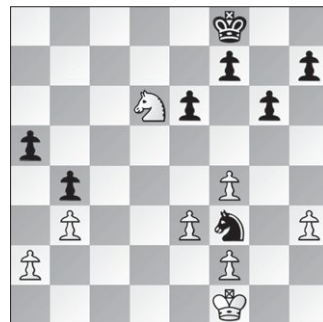
31. Nb5 a5 32. Ke2 Ng1+ 33. Kf1 Nf3

He doesn't fall for it again!

34. Nc7 e6

Stopping Nd5. White's problem is that the knight, as a general rule, is not particularly good at hunting down pawns. Hikaru can—and does—force the pawns onto more vulnerable positions, but the possibility of ... Nd2+ means that White's pawns are not safe either.

35. Ke2 Ng1+ 36. Kf1 Nf3 37. Na8 b5 38. Ke2 Ng1+ 39. Kf1 Nf3 40. Nc7 b4 41. Ne8+ Kf8 42. Nd6



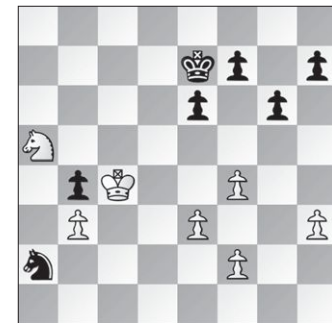
It is in this position that GM Psakhis' maxim truly shines through. Hikaru has finally succeeded in forcing Black's pawns onto extremely vulnerable squares, and he threatens to pick one of them off with Nc4 or Nb7. If the a5-pawn falls, it will only be a matter of time until White creates a passed pawn on the queenside, effectively deciding the game. From the computer's perspective, nothing special has occurred: yes, Wesley played imprecisely here and there, but the correct move in this position keeps the balance. And therein lies the rub:

from a *human* perspective, with seconds remaining on the clock, it is virtually impossible to unearth the correct move. Doing so requires following a complex logical process that will take even a top grandmaster several minutes. In fact, you, dear reader, will have the opportunity to find this move in the second exercise. Suffice it to say that all of the preceding draws—whether 24. ... Nd3 or 26. ... Rd2—were incomparably more straightforward.

42. ... Nd2+?

Wesley maneuvers his knight to c3, from where it will pick off the a2-pawn and keep b4 defended. However, the b4-pawn will become easy pickings for the king and knight.

43. Ke2 Nb1 44. Nc4 Nc3+ 45. Kd3 Nxa2 46. Nxa5 Ke7 47. Kc4



The game is effectively over. Black is completely tied up, so White can slowly maneuver his knight around to d3. After the booty has been secured, the extra passed pawn decides in straightforward fashion.

47. ... Kd7 48. Nb7 Nc3 49. Nc5+

The immediate 49. Kxb4 also did the trick, but Hikaru prefers to err on the side of caution.

49. ... Kc6 50. Nd3 Nd1 51. Nxb4+ Kd6 52. Nd3 f6 53. b4 g5 54. fxg5 fxg5 55. Kb3!

The last finesse.

55. ... h5 56. Kc2 g4 57. Kxd1 gxh3 and Black resigned. ♠

Computer Moves

Humans make plenty of illogical moves, but computers are motivated by an ironclad chain of reasoning.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THESE DAYS, THE PHRASE “COMPUTER move” is thrown around a great deal. It generally refers to a move suggested by a silicon monstrosity such as Stockfish or Houdini, whose logic is so inscrutable that a human being has no conceivable way of finding said move at the chess board. Now, saying that the logic behind a move is difficult to understand is decidedly not equivalent to stating that a move is illogical. Indeed, while humans make plenty of illogical moves throughout the game, every computer move is motivated by an ironclad chain of reasoning. The process of reconceptualizing this chain of reasoning in human terms is a frustrating one, yet the player who masters it can supercharge his chess improvement.

In today's column, we consider an endgame that cannot be understood without extensive collaboration with the computer. Hence, the format will be somewhat unusual, but my hope is that it will enable me to fully bring out this game's instructive value.

MAN VS. MACHINE

GM Vladimir Kramnik (FIDE 2777, RUS)
GM Sam Shankland (FIDE 2725, USA)
Tata Steel Chess Tournament 2018 -
Masters (11), Wijk aan Zee, Netherlands,
01.27.2019

(see diagram next column)

We join the battle in a wild endgame that can only be described as imbalanced. Shankland has three pawns for the piece, two of them passed and one of them ready to visit upon Kramnik the cruelest of fates as it marches down the board. On the other hand, White's rooks are tremendously active and his bishop



AFTER 42. RA8

will wreak utter havoc along the light squares if it carves out a sliver of daylight. To play this position accurately, both sides will have to demonstrate a mix of ironclad positional logic and impeccable calculation. A tall order indeed!

42. ... Ree6?!

Human logic: Sam defends the a6-pawn, paving the way for the real star of the show to run down the board.

Computer logic: At a high depth, Stockfish prefers 42. ... b4!, which Shankland almost certainly rejected due to 43. R8xa6. However, it transpires that after 43. ... Rxa6 44. Rxa6 Rb7 White's material advantage will be counterbalanced by the monstrous b-pawn: 45. Ra2 b3 46. Rb2 Ke6 47. f3 Ke5! (keeping the bishop out of it as long as possible) 48. Kf2 Kd4 49. fxe4 fxe4 (49. ... Kc3 50. exf5! and White secures the draw by giving up the rook for the b-pawn. Note that 50. ... Rf7?? actually loses to 51. Rxb3+! Kxb3 52. Bd5+) 50. Rd2+ and Black must settle for a repetition (50. ... Ke5 51. Rb2), since 50. ... Kc3? lands Black in trouble after 51. Bxe4.

Lesson: The computer often chooses to prioritize activity over material, even in the

endgame. Far-advanced passed pawns that tie down the enemy pieces are generally worth it!

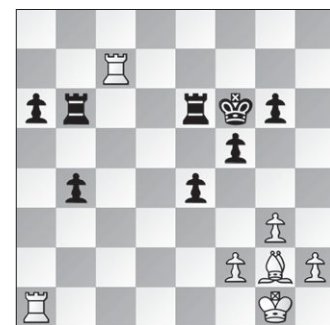
43. Ra7+?!

Human Logic: Since Black's pawns are not yet far-advanced, Kramnik seizes the opportunity to gobble up the vulnerable pawn on h7.

Computer Logic: Stockfish argues that this move relinquishes White's advantage, preferring to open the bishop with 43. f3! The logic behind this move is clear: after 43. ... exf3 44. Bxf3, White's bishop becomes an invaluable asset in both attack and defense. Something like 44. ... Kf6 45. Rb1 b4 46. Bd5 Red6 47. Bc4 is likely to follow, when White is the only one who can push. The pawns are immobilized and Black has to deal with the unpleasant possibility against f7 or a sustained assault against the a6-pawn.

Lesson: Once again, piece activity reigns supreme. When dealing with passed pawns, it is better to be safe rather than sorry.

43. ... Kf6 44. Rxh7 b4 45. Rc7?



Human Logic: Having secured his loot, Kramnik brings his rook back around to deal with the passers.

Computer Logic: Stockfish claims that this move puts the draw in jeopardy, insisting on the

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

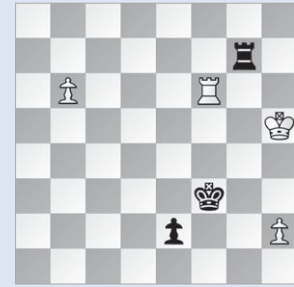
GM Vladimir Kramnik (2777)
GM Sam Shankland (2725)
Tata Steel, 01.27.2019



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM Temur Kuybokarov (2513)
GM Eltaj Safarli (2676)
Pro Chess League, 01.30.2019



BLACK TO MOVE

already-familiar 45. f3. It is easy to understand why 45. f3 is superior from a conceptual standpoint, but a human is bound to reject this move on account of 45. ... e3. After all, who in their right mind will consider a move that yields a *third* far-advanced passer? The justification behind 45. f3 is steeped in the fact that Black's king is a lot more vulnerable than it appears. In the few tempi that Black must take to promote, White can MacGyver a sudden mating net: 46. f4! b3 47. Bd5! and it transpires that Black's rook cannot depart the e6-square due to the threat of Rf7 mate! Hence, he must go for a forcing line that terminates in a dead draw: 47. ... b2 48. Rb1 e2 (48. ... Re7 avoids the mate but gives White an easy pass after 49. Rxe7 Kxe7 50. Kg2, when the king picks off the e-pawn and the bishop renders the a-pawn's march innocuous.) 49. Bxe6 Rxe6 50. Re1 b1=Q 51. Rxb1 e1=Q+ 52. Rxe1 Rxe1+, and it is time to shake hands.

Lesson: The computer is never put off by appearances and neither should you. Furthermore, do not assume that the lack of pieces equates to an absence of attacking potential; hopefully, this column has convinced you otherwise! Reduced material means fewer chances for an attack, not none.

45. ... b3 46. Bf1 Rec6?!

Human Logic: Sam's intention is obvious: by trading off White's lone active rook, he leaves Kramnik with two pieces that seem ill-equipped to hold off the pawn phalanx.

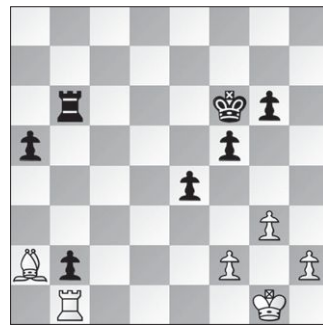
Computer Logic: According to Stockfish, the direct 46. ... a5! was a far superior way to fight for the win. To secure the draw, White would have to find a long sequence of semi-only moves that starts with 47. Bc4 b2 48. Rb1 Re7 49. Rc5! a4 50. Ba2 (the tempting 50. Ra5? meets with 50. ... Rb4! followed by ... Rc7, winning). Even here, Black has practical winning chances connected with a timely ... e4-e3.

Lesson: It turns out that White's tandem will provide enough firepower to check Black's pawns. The presence of rooks is not altogether in White's favor.

47. Rxc6+ Rxc6 48. Rb1 Rb6 49. Bc4 b2 50. Ba2

This move is not an objective mistake, though it needlessly complicates the drawing process. Kramnik was clearly harboring intentions of playing for a win; otherwise, he would have undoubtedly found the cleanest way to secure a draw, which I invite you to solve as the first exercise.

50. ... a5



51. Kf1??

Human Logic: Kramnik inches his king closer to Black's pawns. It seems to me that he was under the impression that once the king reaches d2, the onus will be on Black to hold his position together. Sensible, right?

Computer Logic: Stockfish laughs at the state of humanity. The problem with Kramnik's approach is that the king will be utterly useless on d2. To be sure, it will protect the c1-square, but there will be myriad other ways in which Black will be able to make inroads. The only way to hold the fort was to aim for the center with—you guessed it—51. f3! This move may appear inconceivable until you fully comprehend the motivation behind it: by undermining the pawn on e4, White carves out key defensive squares for his king and rook. Black has several attempts, but all of them lead to a draw if White defends cautiously.

A. 51. ... exf3 52. Kf2 Ke5 53. Kxf3 Kd4 looks imposing, but White holds on with 54. Rd1+! Kc3 55. Ke2. Herein lies the point of 51. f3: White threatens to push back the king with

Rd3+, a move that is impossible with the black pawn on e4! A possible continuation is 55. ... a4 56. Rd3+ Kb4 (56. ... Kc2 57. Rd2+ is equal) 57. Kd2 Rc6 58. Rd4+, when Black cannot make any further progress.

B. 51. ... e3 also looks terrifying, but is handily subdued by 52. Kf1 g5 53. f4! (preventing 53. ... f4) 53. ... gxf4 54. gxf4 Rb4 55. Ke2 when Black is the one who must exercise caution.

Lesson: Do not fall for illusions! A piece that appears active may, in fact, turn out to be utterly useless.

51. ... a4 52. Ke2 a3 53. Kd2 Rc6!

A devastating blow, permanently cutting off the king and paving the way for the decisive invasion. Note that it is too late for 54. f3, since Black wins in straightforward fashion with 54. ... exf3 55. Ke3 Rc2 56. Kxf3 Rxh2, when the kingside pawn majority decides the game.

54. h4 Ke5 55. Re1 Kd4 56. Bb1 Rc3 57. Rh1 Rd3+ 58. Kc2 Rc3+ 59. Kd2 Rf3 60. Ke2 Rd3!

Another cut-off, this one even more devastating than the last.

61. h5 gxh5 62. Ke1

Or 62. Rxh5 Rc3.

62. ... Rc3 63. Kd2 f4! 64. Ba2

Hopeless is 64. gxf4 Rc1.

64. ... e3+ 65. fxe3 fxe3+ 66. Ke2 Rc2+, White resigned.

Of course, we will never be able to entirely imitate computer logic. But striving toward perfection in our thinking is the only way to conquer the treacherous waters of practical endgames. ♠

Did you know you could read archival copies of "The Practical Endgame" (and all columns and features)? Go to uschess.org, click on "Chess Life Magazine," and then "Archives."

Process of (Un)elimination

Understanding the nature of transitions is a key component of practical endgame training.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

"He examined the chess problem and set out the pieces. It was a tricky ending, involving a couple of knights. 'White to play and mate in two moves.'"
~George Orwell, 1984

EVEN IN A DYSTOPIAN WORLD WHOSE denizens are deprived of the right to generate independent thought and make decisions, the study confronts Winston Smith with the task of finding a path to victory among a legion of tempting options. Though I doubt that Orwell intended for his reader to construe this passage literally, it serves as an effective reminder of a topic that has come up repeatedly in our endgame adventures: the complexity and risk inherent in decision-making.

A recent PRO Chess League game brought this complexity and risk to the center of my attention, teaching me an invaluable lesson about the importance of properly framing decisions. I am convinced that it is impossible to master the practical endgame without attaining a keen awareness of the subconscious biases and harmful mental patterns that each and every one of us possesses. By sharing my experience, I hope to play a small part in our lifelong struggle to eradicate these cognitive imperfections.

DECISION FATIGUE

GM Anton Smirnov (2569, "Australia Kangaroos")

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2616, "San Francisco Mechanics")

PRO Chess League, 02.20.2019

(see diagram next column)

My opponent, eager to reestablish material equality, has just captured a pawn on a7. This



AFTER 26. Qxa7

leaves his king wide open, and I spotted just the way to capitalize:

26. ... Bxh3+!

Simple and devastating. The bishop gives itself up to draw the king out of its shell, and, more importantly, to vacate a passageway for the queen. After 27. Kxh3 Qf5+ the attack is utterly overwhelming.

27. Kh2!

Clever. Now, ... Qf5 no longer comes with check, and the bishop will hang if the queen penetrates any further. With only three minutes left, I swiftly pruned my list of candidate options down to two: 27. ... Qf5 is one, embarking on a forced line that culminates in a queen endgame (as a bonus exercise, cover up the rest of the text and work the line out for yourself). The other is 27. ... Rd2+, which leads, after 28. Re2 Rxe2+ 29. Nxe2, to a multipiece endgame that retains a decidedly tactical character. Having decided at the outset not to go under two minutes, I realized that further calculation carried an unreasonable risk-to-reward ratio. The choice had to be made on the basis of intuition.

27. ... Qf5?

The difficulty inherent in maximizing the accuracy of intuitive decisions is obvious. In some situations, one's instinct, no matter how finely-tuned, is bound to lead one astray. **I believe that many errors in the realm of intuitive decision-making stem from a lazy (or nonexistent) evaluation of one or more candidate moves.** Even though I *thought* that I had given sufficient thought to both 27. ... Qf5 and 27. ... Rd2+, in reality I never seriously considered the latter option upon discovering that the former led to a risk-free queen endgame with (seemingly) excellent winning chances. Why burn time contemplating an unclear ending when a simple and forcing option presents itself? Even in the absence of time pressure, we often pay lip service to all of the options in a given position, while secretly knowing which move we will end up making all along. Had I *allowed* my intuition to evaluate 27. ... Rd2+ properly—even for a few seconds—I would have almost certainly realized that after 28. Re2 Rxe2+ 29. Nxe2 Bg4 Black is completely winning. 30. Qe3 is essentially forced, since both 30. gxf6 Bxe2 31. fxf7 Qg4 and 30. Ng3 Nd5 lose on the spot. But after the prosaic 30. ... Nd5 31. Bxd5 cxd5 32. a4 c5! 33. c3 Qa6 (followed by ... Qd3) White can choose between getting mated or letting Black promote one of his pawns. There is nothing messy or unbalanced about this endgame; the mere presence of minor pieces affords White no relief. Now, let us see what transpired after I chose the safe option:

28. gxf6 Qxf4+ 29. Kxh3 Qg4+ 30. Kh2 Qh4+ 31. Kg2 Qxe1 32. Bxf7+!

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Josh Friedel (2595)
FM Luke Harmon-Vellotti (2469)
World Open, 2013



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Anton Smirnov (2569)
GM Daniel Naroditsky (2616)
PRO Chess League, 2019



BLACK TO MOVE

A pretty shot, without which White loses on the spot. But I had factored it into my calculation.

32. ... Kh7?!

As an aside, the (inhuman) 32. ... Kh8! would have retained some winning chances. After 33. Bc4 gxf6 34. Ne2, you will be confronted, in the second exercise, with the difficult task of finding the sequence of study-like moves by which Black keeps practical chances.

33. Bxh5 e3 34. Qxc7 Rd2+ 35. Ne2 Rxe2+ 36. Bxe2 Qxe2+ 37. Kg3



At this point, I had about a minute on the clock, ample time to find the sequence of checks that finishes White off. Finding that sequence took only five seconds.

37. ... Qf2+ 38. Kg4

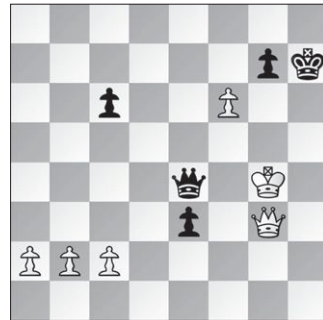
Suddenly, I discovered that the “crushing” 38. ... Qxf6 allows the devastating 39. Qh2+, posing Black with an irresolvable ultimatum: 39. ... Kg6 requires no elaboration, 39. ... Kg8 allows 40. Qb8+ Kf7 41. Qb3+, while 39. ... Qh6 actually loses to 40. Qxh6+ followed by 41. Kf3, when the a-pawn, forsaken since the beginning of the game, exacts a lethal vengeance.

The only remaining option was to stumble around with my queen, hoping that a decisive maneuver lay under the surface.

38. ... Qg2+ 39. Qg3!

The queen returns from its ill-fated excursion at a perfect moment.

39. ... Qe4+



40. Kh3?

My opponent took less than one out of his remaining 43 seconds to make this move, perhaps a consequence of exhaustion or of the distracting realization that he was knocking on the door of an epic comeback. A few seconds of reflection would have certainly enabled Anton to find 40. Kg5!, when Black cannot punish the king for his audacity without giving up the e3-pawn.

40. ... Qh1+?

Utter incompetence! Why I did not capture the pawn on f6, with a totally winning position, is a complete mystery to me.

41. Qh2!

How pretty! After 41. ... Qxh2+ 42. Kxh2 e2, White cannot stop the pawn but he promotes his own with 43. f7.

41. ... Qf3+ 42. Kh4?

This stage of the game certainly harms the game's aesthetic appeal, though such instances of mutual blundering are rather common when fatigue, time pressure, and emotions are considered. 42. Qg3 would have forced an immediate draw.

42. ... gxf6 43. Qc7+ Kh6 44. Qe7 Qf4+ 45. Kh3 Qf3+ 46. Kh4 Qf2+ 47. Kg4

f5+ 48. Kh3 Qf3+ 49. Kh2 Qf2+ 50. Kh3 Qf1+ 51. Kh2 Qf4+ 52. Kh3 Qg4+ 53. Kh2 e2 54. Qf6+ Kh5 55. Qh8+ Kg6 56. Qg8+ Kf6 57. Qf8+ Ke6 58. Qe8+ Kd6 59. Qf8+ Ke5 60. Qc5+ Kf4 61. Qf2+ Ke4 62. a4 Qf3?!

A step in the wrong direction, missing the obvious 62. ... f4! followed by ... Qg3+.

63. Qe1 Qf1??

At this point, I realized that I had allowed the unsavory possibility of 64. Qb4+, but with 3. 7 seconds on the clock I could not muster up the self-control to revert to 63. ... Qg4 followed by ... f4.

Such is the nature of queen endings! While my move dislodges White's queen, my own Lady will be unable to interpose any checks, allowing a miraculous opportunity to deliver perpetual check.

64. Qb4+ Ke5 65. Qe7+ Kf4 66. Qh4???

But this move, once again played instantly, lets me off the hook for good. **Generally, perpetual check follows a set pattern where one or two potential escape pathways must be covered at all times.** In this case, 66. Qb4+ would have done the job, since the king cannot escape via e3 on account of Qc3+. Black must resort to 66. ... Ke5, when 67. Qe7+ Kd5 68. Qf7+ draws in straight-forward fashion.

66. ... Ke3

At last, the promised land!

67. Qg5+ f4 68. Qe5+ Kd2 69. Qc3+ Kd1 70. Qd4+ Kc1 71. b4 e1=Q 72. Qa1+ Kxc2 73. Qa2+ Kd3 74. Qb3+ Qc3, White resigned.

My hope is that the final stage of the game, ugly as it was, hammered home the inescapable value of concrete thinking. To rule out a possibility, and to take mental shortcuts of any kind, is to put yourself on a collision course with disaster. ♠

To the Ladies

Vera Menchik, the first women's world champion, challenged the strongest male players of her day.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE VOICES OF THOSE WHO CLAIM women cannot play chess, voices that once formed a deafening clamor, now constitute little more than a whimper. It would suffice to mention the likes of GMs Judit Polgar and Hou Yifan to show that women have not only excelled—and will continue to excel at the royal game—but also that females are not consigned to playing second fiddle when it comes to objective measures of chess performance. The immense contribution that female chess players have made to our beloved game extends, of course, to the final stage of the game. In today's column, we pay homage to this contribution by examining a delightful and instructive endgame drawn from the highest annals of women's chess.

DEVASTATING POWER

Reginald Pryce Michell

Vera Menchik

Scarborough, 05.26.1928



AFTER 30. ... Rxe3

We draw this endgame from the practice of Vera Menchik (1906-1944), the first Women's World Champion and the first female player to challenge the strongest male

players of the day. Although her life was tragically cut short, she would undoubtedly be proud to look upon the strong tradition of female chess that she contributed to so richly.

We join her battle with the eminent British master Reginald Michell in an unremarkable rook ending. But that the wily Michell harbors sanguinary intentions is revealed through the following cunning maneuver:

31. Rc8+

The point of this move hardly requires elaboration. The careless 31. ... Ke7 meets with 32. Rc7+, when the consequences of losing a7 are clearly disastrous. The problem, however, is that 31. ... Re8 allows a transition into a pawn endgame that appears, at first blush, to be hopeless for Black. The script is a predictable one: White will create an outside passer on the queenside. While Black's king is saddled with the task of containing the wretched peon, White's own monarch will saunter over to the kingside and have himself a feast. A prognostication of this sort was undoubtedly on Michell's mind when he delivered the check on c8.

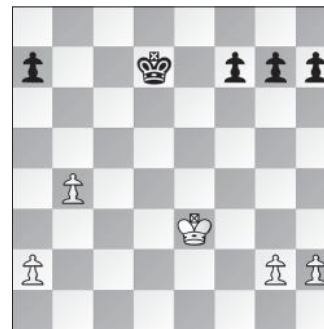
The problem with this sort of reasoning, which I call long-term calculation, **is that it undervalues concrete features of the position—such as piece activity—that may radically change the arc of the game.** In pawn endgames, the importance of king placement is just such a feature, one that may render all other considerations entirely inconsequential. The proof, as they say, is in the pudding.

31. ... Re8! 32. Rxe8+?

In hindsight, the most prudent approach would have been to call a truce with 32. Rc7

Re7 33. Rc8+. Michell, however, is certain in the rectitude of his plan.

32. ... Kxe8 33. Kf2 Kd7 34. Ke3



So far, all is going according to plan. Michell probably expected 34. ... Kd6; after 35. Kd4 f5. White paves the way for the decisive plan with 36. h4!, crushing Black's hopes of rapidly creating his own passer. After 36. ... g6 (36. ... h6 37. h5!), White sets in motion the decisive plan: 37. b5 h6 38. a4 g5 39. hxg5 hxg5 40. a5 f4 (40. ... g4 41. g3! wins) 41. Ke4 (avoiding the sloppy 41. b6?? axb6 42. axb6, when Black salvages a draw with 42. ... g4 43. Ke4 f3!) 41. ... Kc5 42. b6 axb6 43. axb6 Kxb6 44. Kf5, and the steak has been served.

But Menchik has not come to the board to help her opponent write an endgame manual:

34. ... Kc6!

The devastating power of this move may not be immediately apparent, but it must have dawned on Michell after a few minutes of thought that his opponent was not on board with a neat conclusion to the game. Rather than aimlessly wander about in the center, the king mounts a sudden assault on White's outwardly unassailable pawn majority. Indeed,

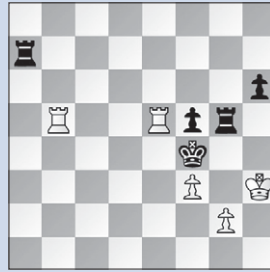
Practicum

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 75.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

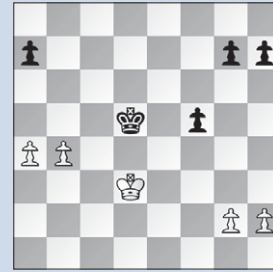
GM Pia Cramling (2516)
IM Irina Krush (2470)
Women's World Championship, 11.16.2012



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

Reginald Pryce Michell
Vera Menchik
Scarborough, 05.26.1928

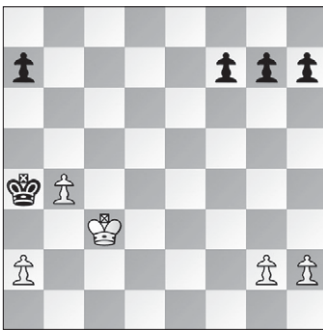


WHITE TO MOVE

Black threatens 35. ... Kb5 36. a3 Ka4, which essentially forces White's hand.

35. a4

This seems to stabilize the situation, but it enables Black to reveal the second, more subtle, idea behind her previous move. The alternative was 35. Kd4, but it offered White no relief after 35. ... Kb5! 36. Kc3 Ka4!



ANALYSIS AFTER 36. ... Ka4!

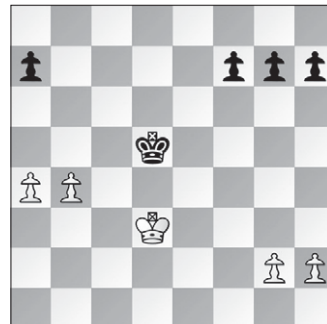
A study-like position indeed: Black's king singlehandedly takes on White's entire queenside, supported by his own monarch, and emerges victorious. There is no way to keep b4 defended and stop ... Ka3. For instance, 37. Kc4 Ka3 38. b5 Kxa2 39. Kc5 Kb3 40. Kc6 (40. b6 axb6+ 41. Kxb6 Kc4 leads to a rather one-sided king race) 40. ... Kc4 and Black safely restrains the pawn from behind. White is powerless to stop the march of the as-yet-unborn kingside passer.

35. ... Kd5!

It is only after this move is executed that the king's bloodthirsty intentions become fully evident. The positional point of 35. ... Kc6 was to win a tempo so that Black's king could occupy the center before his vis-à-vis could himself reach a dominant post. As a result, even though White can still create a passed pawn, it will be snatched from the board long before White's king is able to run over to the kingside. In an ironic turn of events, it is now

Black who seeks to create a passed pawn on the kingside, to distract White's king and to gobble up the a- and b-pawns. As in many other pawn endgames, the pawn structure itself has no bearing on the outcome of the game. **The ease with which a passed pawn can be created is only one factor, no more or less important than the speed at which the king can pick this passed pawn up.** Once this point is taken into account, the game's arc is far less surprising.

36. Kd3



36. ... f5?

This move is as natural as it gets. After all, Black has optimized the position of his king; what else is there to do, other than to get down to business? The mistake is tactical rather than conceptual: there is nothing inherently wrong with getting down to business, but Menchik allows White to effect a favorable modification of the kingside structure, one that will enable him to hold the fort by the narrowest of margins. This saving resource is so instructive and intricate that I have repurposed it as the second exercise.

The correct move would have been 36. ... h5!, paralyzing White's pawns before embarking on the creation of a passer. If White stays put with 37. Kc3, the win is straightforward: 37. ... g5 38. Kd3 f5 39. Kc3 f4 40. Kd3 g4 41. Kc3 f3 42. gxf3 gxf3 43. Kd3 f2 44. Ke2 Kc4 and the rest is obvious. White

can try to resist actively with 37. h4, but this only brings about swifter resolution after 37. ... f6! 38. g3 g6! (inducing a mini-Zugzwang; the immediate 38. ... g5?! led to a draw) 39. Kc3 g5 40. Kd3 gxf4 41. gxf4 f5 with a familiar conclusion.

That Menchik failed to perceive this detail certainly does not speak to her incompetence in the endgame. No matter how aware we are, it is impossible to account for every concrete detail all of the time.

37. Kc3?

My guess is that Michell had, by this point, lost all hope in the game, for this move is tantamount to capitulation. As I mentioned above, I will leave the task of determining the drawing line up to the ambitious reader.

37. ... g5!

Now, Black is back on the winning path, and Menchik gives Michell no more glimpses of hope.

38. a5

A clever little trap.

38. ... Kc6!

Which Menchik easily parries. With his last move, Michell expressed a desire to revive the specter of a queenside passer, a desire that Black's king can only laugh at.

39. Kc4 a6!

Forget it, old man!

40. g3 f4 41. gxf4 gxf4 42. Kd4 Kb5 43. Ke4 Kxb4 44. Kxf4 Kxa5 45. Ke3 Kb4 46. Kd2 Kb3 47. Kc1 Kc3 48. h4 h5!, White resigned.

The irony has been put into reality: Menchik, not Michell, has forced her opponent to write a chapter of the endgame manual. Let's raise our glasses to the ladies, who have for over a century produced combative, inspirational chess. ♠

What Am I Missing?

Sometimes less is more.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

ON APRIL 19, I HAD THE PLEASURE OF listening to a debate between Jordan Peterson and Slavoj Žižek, two polemical figures who have captured the attention of the modern public. Peterson is a professor of psychology and a self-improvement guru whose commentary extends into the sphere of philosophy and politics. Žižek, on the other hand, is a kind of modern Hegel, a fiery philosopher who has defended the ideals of Marxism with unflagging fervor and whose recondite writings have fascinated readers for decades.

To nourish my feeble mind in preparation for the debate, I decided to comb through a few pieces of Žižek's writing. The extent to which my intellect is unable to grapple with true genius was quickly revealed when I stumbled upon the following sentence from Žižek's book, *The Parallax View*, of which I will only reproduce the first few lines:

"Unfortunately, there is also a Lacanian version of the philosophy of finitude: when in a tragic tone, we are informed that we have to renounce our impossible striving for full *jouissance* and accept 'symbolic castration,' the ultimate constraint of our existence ..."

The sentence goes on for four more lines. What's more, it is contained in parentheses, an explanatory gloss to another, still longer sentence. Go figure.

My intellectual journey made me think of our beloved game and how less is very often more. In chess, as our dear old Lasker reminded us, the ability to reason from first principles—to act on the basis of prosaic logic—is often (paradoxically) more difficult than metamorphosing into Slavoj Žižek. The temptation to overcomplicate things, to apply labels and preconceived notions, is one that even the greatest regularly struggle with. The best way to overcome this

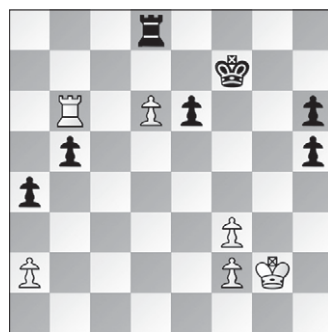
temptation is, as always, to learn from the misfortunes of others!

THE PERILS OF OVERCOMPLICATION

GM Samuel Sevian (FIDE 2642, USA)

GM Lenier Dominguez Perez (FIDE 2739, USA)

2019 U.S. Championship (8), St. Louis, Missouri, 03.28.2019

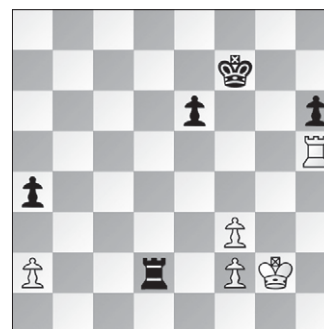


AFTER 37. ... Kf7

"All rook endgames are drawn," goes a famous aphorism commonly attributed to Dr. Tarrasch. Hackneyed as it may be, this maxim certainly contains a grain of wisdom: rooks are uniquely skilled at picking off pawns, so any rook ending in which both sides are saddled with numerous vulnerable pawns—like this one—is likely to fizzle out into a colorless draw. Although White is down a pawn, his rook is poised to pick off at least two, and maybe three, of Black's undefended pawns.

Sevian undoubtedly calculated the line 38. Rxb5 Rxd6 39. Rxb5 Rd2 (Analysis diagram), when Black picks off the a-pawn and retains some annoying pressure.

(see diagram next column)



ANALYSIS AFTER 39. ... Rd2

However, the word *annoying*—which we humans use a great deal in our calculations—frequently obscures the true state of affairs on the chess board, leading us to believe that we are facing a great deal more danger than we actually are. Let us take a sober look at the diagrammed position and ask ourselves whether Black's initiative may in fact be a figment of our imagination. A few thoughtful minutes later, one realizes that a figment it is, for White draws in a litany of ways. The simplest is 40. Rxb6 Rxa2 41. Rh7+ Kf6 42. f4 a3 (42. ... Kf5 43. Rf7+ Ke4 44. Re7 Kd5 45. Rf7 a3 46. f5 and the creation of White's own passer means a draw is imminent) 43. Ra7 Kf5 44. Kf3 and Black's king is permanently entombed. It should also be noted that 39. ... Kg6 leads to a similarly insipid draw: 40. Ra5 Rd4 41. Re5 Kf6 (41. ... Rd2 42. Rxe6+ Kg5 43. f4+ is drawn) 42. Rh5 and a repetition is in the cards.

38. a3?

In his attempt to obviate the difficulties he perceived in the straightforward approach, Sevian—in an unfortunate twist of irony—significantly complicates his task.

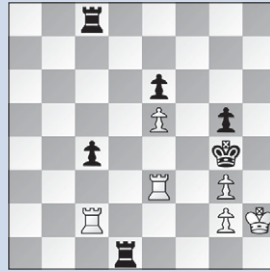
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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Hikaru Nakamura (2746)
GM "limitless9" (Chess.com 2935)
Chess.com 3-minute Blitz, 04.13.2019



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

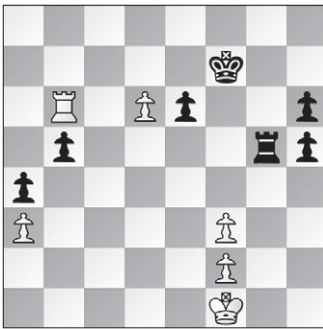
GM Sergei Azarov (2575)
GM Fabiano Caruana (2828)
Pro Chess League, 02.07.2019



WHITE TO MOVE

The position remains comfortably within the bounds of a draw, but the wily Dominguez, on the strength of a clever rook maneuver, is able to stave off total liquidation.

38. ... Rg8+! 39. Kf1 Rg5



In a certain sense, the game has followed a dictum formulated by my longtime coach Lev Psakhis. Let me reiterate it once more, this time in a formulation that is more germane to our current discussion: **when you are trying to make a draw, you are generally granted only one chance to draw in a simple manner. After that, the path is usually still there, but it grows ever narrower and more treacherous.**

This game follows just such a path: having missed an opportunity to draw in a straightforward manner, White must now exercise a high degree of precision.

40. d7?

It appears that this is not the decisive mistake, but salvaging a half-point will be a task decidedly unfit for a human. The problem is that Black's rook is more active than it was before, so White lacks the horsepower to effect a total or partial liquidation of Black's queenside before the a3-pawn falls. And allowing Black to obtain connected passers is, of course, a recipe for disaster.

The correct approach was to use the d-pawn as a decoy, forcing Black to delegate

his rook—rather than his king—to securing its capture. White accomplishes this with 40. Rb7+! Kf6 41. Rh7, initiating a furious hunt for Black's vulnerable pawns. Black has several tricky attempts, but no way to pose any serious problems:

After 41. ... b4 42. axb4 a3 looks intimidating, but an approach based on simple logic saves the day once more: 43. Rxh6+! Ke5 44. d7 a2 (44. ... Rg8?? 45. Rxh5+ gives White a winning edge) 45. d8=Q a1=Q+ 46. Ke2 and White has nothing to fear, e.g. 46. ... Qa2+ 47. Qd2 Qc4+ 48. Qd3 with a repetition.

The try 41. ... Rd5 poses a greater challenge, though 42. Rxh6+ Ke5 43. d7! is relatively easy to find. Following 43. ... Rxd7 44. Rxh5+ Kf4 45. Rxb5 Kxf3 46. Ke1 Rd3 47. Re5 Rxa3 both 48. Rxe6 and 48. Kd2 draw with room to spare.

The move 41. ... Kg6 may very well be Black's most serious attempt. Nonetheless, several roads lead to Rome, one of them being 42. Rb7 Rd5 43. d7 h4 44. Kg2! h5 45. Rxb5 Rxd7 46. Rb4.

40. ... Ke7

The king is more than happy to do the rook's bidding. Sevian may have relied on 41. Rd6 from afar, but this move accomplishes nothing due to 41. ... Kd8.

41. Rxe6+ Kxd7 42. Rxh6 Rc5!

Two developments have taken place in the past few moves. Not only is Black's rook poised to snatch off a3, but Black's king is close enough to the queenside to keep the pawns defended while the heist is underway.

43. f4 Kc7 44. f5?!

In desperation, Sevian uses his pawn to distract Black's rook. Amazingly, the computer indicates that 44. Ke2! would have made a draw, citing the following inscrutable line: 44. ... Rc2+ 45. Kd1! (moving the king to the third rank would have enabled the rook

to capture on a3 with check) 45. ... Rc3 46. Rxh5 Kb6 47. Ke2 Rxa3 48. f5 Rc3 49. f6 Rc8 50. f7 a3 51. Kd3 b4 (51. ... a2 52. Rh1 b4 53. f8=Q! Rxf8 54. Kc4 with a similar draw as in the main line) 52. f8=Q! (only now does White use the pawn as a decoy, breaking through the force field) 52. ... Rxf8 53. Kc4 Rf4+ 54. Kb3 and *LiChess.org's* seven-piece tablebases, available for free (!), informs me that the position is drawn even without the f2-pawn. Black simply cannot make any progress. Had a human reproduced this line, however, a cheating accusation would have likely ensued. To understand that Black's connected passers do not promote, even with the king cut off, is a very tall order indeed.

44. ... Rxf5 45. Ke2 Kb7!

The king saunters over to the edge of the board, preparing to hide out on a5 should he be subjected to a barrage of checks.

46. f3

The move 46. Rd6 would have staved off defeat, but not for long. After 46. ... h4 47. Rd3 Rc5 48. Rh3 Rc2+ 49. Kd3 (49. Ke1 Rb2 with ... Rb3 to follow) 49. ... Rxf2 50. Rxh4 Rf3+ 51. Kc2 Rxa3, and this time White has no shenanigans to lean on.

46. ... b4!

The final blow. Black has improved the position of his pieces so much that he does not even need to hunt down the a-pawn.

47. axb4 a3 48. Rd6 Rf8 49. Kf2 Ra8 50. Rd1 Kb6 51. Kg3 Kb5 52. Kh4 Rf8 53. Rf1 Rf5!

Creating an impenetrable force field.

54. f4 Kxb4 55. Rf2 Ra5 56. Ra2 Kb3 57. Ra1 a2 58. Rf1 a1=Q 59. Rxa1 Rxa1 60. Kxh5 Rf1 61. Kg5 Kc4 62. f5 Kd5, White resigned.

A fitting final act to the king's heroic journey! ♠

Typical Magnus?

Carlsen possesses an uncanny ability to find moves that burden his opponent and require a great deal of calculation.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE CHORUS OF *OOHS* AND *AAHS* that accompany Magnus Carlsen's dashing tournament victories are by now quite familiar. This is certainly true of the 2019 GRENKE Chess Classic, in which Magnus managed to conjure up a mere 7½/9—a score that most of us can certainly manage against a field consisting of super-grandmasters and young talents.

Yes, I am being sarcastic. Magnus' performance is still difficult to process, even a few months after the tournament's conclusion. And yet, the time has come to get our hands dirty. It is easy to recline in our armchairs and watch the show in progress, but the true student of the game must use these performances to extract valuable lessons about the underpinnings of Magnus' wizardry. And that is precisely what we are about to do.

MAGNUS MAGIC

GM Francisco Vallejo Pons (FIDE 2693, ESP)

GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2845, NOR)
GRENKE Chess Classic 2019 (2), Baden-Baden, Germany, 04.22.2019

(see diagram next column)

Ah, some of you may be tempted to gasp upon seeing the diagrammed position. *Typical Magnus: gets a dead drawn position and squeezes water from a stone. I couldn't do that in a million years!* The first part of this exclamation is correct: Magnus once more displays an ability to make something out of nothing. But in making the assumption that what Magnus does is wholly inimitable, we miss a golden opportunity to learn from his craft.



AFTER 38. Kh3

There is no doubt that White is worse: Black's pieces are incomparably more active, and White's king is in a world of hurt. What renders both of these advantages ostensibly symbolic, however, is the limited amount of material left on the board. With only a rook and two minor pieces, it is very hard to imagine that Black can rupture the defensive cocoon around White's monarch. This is evidenced by the line 38. ... f4 39. Nf1! Rf2 40. Be4 Ne5 41. gxf4+ Rxf4 42. Re8 Bd6 43. Rg8+ and it is time to shake hands.

38. ... Rd3!

Typical Magnus: rather than accept the inevitable, he begins by forcing White to make an annoying decision. The c3-pawn is under attack, and there seem to be two equally workable ways to keep the balance: 39. Be2 and 39. Bc6. With two moves left until the time control, Vallejo had no choice but to trust his instinct:

39. Be2?!

One of Magnus's finest qualities is his ability to lure his opponent into

following his instinct. In highly concrete positions like this one, intuition is unlikely to point out in the right direction. To this end, the advantage of 39. Bc6 is that after 39. ... Rxc3, White has the beautiful intermediate move 40. Be8!!



ANALYSIS AFTER 39. ... Rxc3

Finding this move is quite difficult in the position after 39. ... Rxc3, let alone one move before. It transpires that the bishop traveled to c6 not to snap off the pawn, but to neutralize the potency of ... f5-f4 by chasing the knight away. Following 40. ... Nf8 41. Re7 b4 42. Rg7+ Kf6 (42. ... Kh6 43. Nxf5 mate) 43. Rf7+ Ke5, the simplest option is not 44. Rxf8?! Rxe3 45. Bd7 Bd6 46. Re8+ because it is dead drawn therefore both ways draw easily, which leaves Black some (albeit very minimal) chances, but 44. Re7+! Ne6 45. Bd7 Rxe3 46. Rxe6+ Kd4 47. Rxe3 Kxe3 48. Bxf5 with an immediate draw.

39. ... Rxc3 40. Bxb5 f4!

With White's bishop offside, this break acquires a great deal of potency. Capturing is obviously impossible, so White must uncork a series of precise tactical moves to avoid calamity.

Practicum

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

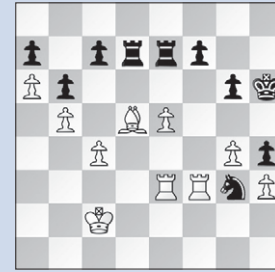
GM Timur Gareyev (2654)
GM Ray Robson (2737)
U.S. Championship, 03.30.2019



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Vladislav Artemiev (2754)
IM Ivan Bocharov (2568)
Russian Premier League, 05.01.2019



WHITE TO MOVE

41. Be8!

Vallejo is up to the task. This is a good time to mention that Magnus' opponents rarely lay down and die in the face of the Great One's technique.

41. ... Nf8 42. Rb6



An important follow-up, this time targeting the bishop! Now, Magnus had an opportunity to liquidate into a famous theoretical endgame: 42. ... fxe3 43. Rxb8 e2 44. Rb1 Re3 45. Re1 Rxe8 46. Kg2 (Black will lose the e2-pawn). Drawing this endgame is relatively straightforward; unlike the rook plus bishop versus rook ending, which carries far greater intrigue, the rook and knight are generally unable to put together a sustained attempt to corner the king. Nonetheless, I am convinced that most of us would have opted for this position, tempted by the prospect of torturing our opponent for another 50 moves. But Magnus exercises a great deal of self-control, and finds a move that faces Vallejo with far greater practical difficulties:

42. ... Be5!

Now, 43. gxf4+ Kxf4 leads to an endgame that will be very difficult to draw: the addition of a pair of minor pieces obviously favors Black. But Vallejo is once again at the top of his game:

43. Nf1! fxd3 44. Rc6 Ra3 45. Rb6?

From a "scientific" perspective, this is not a mistake. By staying put, White allows a liquidation into an endgame that is theoretically drawn. **This moment epitomizes the dangers of blindly following the game with an engine: as I have previously mentioned, practical and objective strength are two entirely different kettles of fish.**

To unearth the best continuation, White had to understand that ... Ra2 is a very serious threat. Playing 45. Rc4!! would have enabled White to play Rg4+. Vallejo was probably afraid of 45. ... Ne6, but after 46. Rg4+ Kf6 47. Nxd3 it transpires that Black has no winning follow-up, e.g. 47. ... Nf4+ (47. ... Ke7 48. Bb5 Nf4+ 49. Kh2! Nh5 50. Re4=) 48. Kh4 Ke7 and to the rescue comes 49. Nh5!, forcing a draw after 49. ... Rh3+ 50. Kg5 Ne6+ 51. Kf5, when the minor pieces will disappear from the board one by one.

Once more, Magnus consistently finds moves that burden his opponent with a difficult decision that requires a great deal of calculation.

45. ... Ra2!

Threatening ... g3-g2. And 46. Nxd3 is met by 46. ... Ra3, picking off the knight and reaching the type of position briefly discussed above.

46. Rb4 Ne6 47. Rg4+ Kf6 48. Bc6 g2!

49. Bxd3 Nf4+ 50. Rxf4+ Bxf4

The situation is a familiar one: a dead draw according to the tablebase, but an incredibly difficult one to make for a human after several hours of intense battle. Vallejo starts off relatively well, repositioning his pieces in a tight defensive construction:

51. Bf3 Bb8 52. Ng3 Kg5 53. Ne2 Bc7 54. Kg2 Kh4 55. Kf2

Rather than get discouraged, Magnus applies another layer of annoying pressure, transferring his bishop to a dominant square:

55. ... Bb6+! 56. Ke1 Be3 57. Kd1 Kg5 58. Be4 Kf6

Now, the king comes around to the other flank.

59. Bf3 Ke5 60. Bg2 Kd6 61. Be4 Kc5 62. Bf5 Rd2+ 63. Ke1 Rd8 64. Be4 Kc4

At this point, Vallejo had to realize that his construction, as it stands, is no longer tenable: the black king is too well-placed, and the rook has access to too many squares. Something like 65. Ng3 would have kept the game within the bounds of a theoretical draw, the point being to meet 65. ... Rg8 with 66. Nf5. But Vallejo finally cracks:

65. Kf1?

Technically, this move deserves two question marks, but let us cut the Spanish grandmaster some slack. He has been defending supremely well thus far, and he joins a long and distinguished list of chess players who have fallen prey to Magnus' wizardry.

65. ... Rf8+ 66. Ke1

Forced, since 66. Kg2 Rf2+ loses the knight.

66. ... Bf2+ 67. Kd2 Rd8+ 68. Kc2 Be3!

The key. White's minor pieces are temporarily uncoordinated, and this affords Black just enough time to launch a devastating attack against the king.

69. Bf3 Rd2+ 70. Kb1 Kb3 71. Nc1+ Ka3 72. Ne2 Rb2+ 73. Ka1 Rb8 74. Be4 and White resigned.

White is completely cornered, and Black has all the time in the world to transfer his bishop to any uncovered square on the long diagonal.

This endgame might not win any brilliancy prize, but any experienced endgame player worth his salt should treat this game as an epitome of the very pinnacle of human achievement (assuming, of course, that Magnus is in fact human) in the final stage of the game. ♠

Bad but Beautiful

Good annotations balance objectivity with beauty and practical value.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE ANNOTATOR HAS A DIFFICULT job indeed. His primary duty is to remain objective, lending a helping hand to the reader who wishes to understand what truly occurred in a chess game, and to extract as much instructive value as possible. Yet he must also respect the fact that chess is a game played between humans, in which beauty and practical value play an immeasurable role that is by no means less central to objective worth.

It is with these somewhat contradictory duties in mind that I tackle this month's game, which featured a jaw-dropping sacrifice that any chess enthusiast worth his salt cannot help but laud. And yet, hard as it may be, I cannot quite join in the party.

FLAWED SACRIFICE?

GM Zhongyi Tan (FIDE 2513, CHN)
GM Kateryna Lagno (FIDE 2554, RUS)
Women's Candidates Tournament 2019 (6),
Kazan, Russia, 06.06.2019



AFTER 67. Ng2

On the strength of an unimaginably tenacious defense, Lagno first turned a resignable

middlegame into an unclear ending, and then brilliantly pushed Tan's minor pieces from their dominant posts, securing a big advantage that Black is enjoying in the position before you.

A cursory inspection of this unbalanced ending may lead you to conclude that a colorless draw is in the cards, for after something like 67. ... Rf8, neither side can make progress. Black's rook and bishop must bear the thankless task of defending the f4-pawn, while White's minor pieces must remain on their posts to keep the fortress and blockade intact.

In the endgame, making general observations in an effort to evaluate the position is a one-way ticket to catastrophe. Frequently, dynamic features of the position that hide below the surface—such as *Zugzwang*, subtle maneuvers, and tactical possibilities—make superficial observations irrelevant at best, and fatally misleading at worst.

The position after 67. ... Rf8 is a case in point. White certainly has a fortress for the time being, but Black has two weapons in her toolbox that enable her to rapidly erode the foundation on which this fortress stands: the first is a kind of semi-*Zugzwang* that White will repeatedly experience. She can either move the knight from g2, opening up a path for the pawn and giving Black the devastating option of ... Rh8 and ... Bc5-e3, or slide the bishop from b3, abandoning the d5 and a2 pawns. The second is the possibility of opening a second front with an eventual ... c7-c6, clearing open the c-file. Let's see a couple of sample scenarios in which Black combines these ideas to break through:

1. 68. Nh4?! is suicidal because it relinquishes the grip on the f4-pawn, freeing both of Black's pieces simultaneously. The swiftest path to victory is 68. ... Bc5! 69. Ng2 Be3! 70. Bxe3 (70. Nxe3 fxe3+ 71. Kxe3 [71. Kxg3 e2] 71. ... g2 72. Bd2+ Kb2 and the pawn cannot be stopped) 70. ... fxe3 71. Kxe3 Rf2 72. Nh4 (72. Nf4 Rxf4) 72. ... Rb2! 73. Kf3 Rxb3 74. axb3 Kxb3 and the pawns will be unstoppable.
2. 68. Bd1 is quite a bit more resilient. Black responds with 68. ... Rf6, preparing to open up the c-file. After 69. Bb3 (note that White can never take on f4, e.g. 69. Bxf4 Bxf4 70. Nxf4 Rxf4+!) 69. ... Be5 70. Bd1 c5 (or 70. ... c6) 71. dxc6 *e.p.* Rxc6 Black's rook, now fully unfettered, wreaks utter havoc on White's dreadfully passive minor pieces. A possible continuation is 72. Ke4 (72. Nxf4 Bxf4 73. Bxf4 Kb2 74. Bb3 Rc3+ 75. Kg2 Rxb3! is game over) 72. ... Bc7 73. Kf3 Rd6 74. Be2 (74. Bb3 Rd3+ followed by ... f4-f3 loses even faster) 74. ... Rd4 75. Ne1 (75. Bxb5 Kc2 wins) 75. ... b3! 76. axb3 b4 and the rest is a straightforward matter of capturing the b3-pawn, moving the king, and marching its twin brother down the board.

Clearly, understanding that White's fortress has no long-term chance of survival is no easy matter, and Kateryna may have been fooled by the robust appearance of White's blockade: after all, the combination of the king on f3, knight on g2, and unassailable bishop on b3

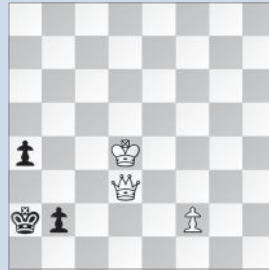
Practicum

Each month GM Naroditsky will present two problems taken from actual games that illustrate the theme of this month's column. Your task is to find the best line of play. Problem I should be solveable by a player at roughly a 1500 rating and Problem II by a player roughly at a 2000 rating.

See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

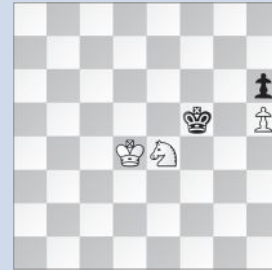
Frederick Yates
Frank James Marshall
Karlsbad 1929



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Lenier Dominguez Perez (2739)
GM Timur Gareyev (2557)
U.S. Championship, 03.31.2019



BLACK TO MOVE

lends a very convincing appearance to White's defensive construction.

It is to the bishop on b3 that Kateryna devoted her attention. Hidden underneath the surface of the position is a subtle flaw in the bishop's support base. But in the absence of a light-square bishop that can travel to b1, this flaw cannot be exploited ... right?

67. ... Rxa2



For over an hour, I was paralyzed with indecision about whether to supplement this move with two exclamation marks, two question marks, or to invent a new type of annotation that would capture its aesthetic beauty and practical strength while making clear its objective deficiency. Black sacrifices an entire rook for the sole purpose of removing the bishop's defender, paving the way for the passed b-pawns. Only a few moments of thoughts are necessary to realize that after 68. Bxa2 Kc2, White's minor pieces will be hard-pressed to prevent the march of the passed pawn and its loyal subordinate. I had the pleasure of commentating this game live on WFM Alexandra Botez's stream, and—along with most of the audience—my jaw dropped when I saw this move, and I could already envision the droves of chess articles that would be written in order to sing its praises.

The beauty of this move can hardly be disputed; I have to search deep within the recesses of my memory to uncover a game in which an entire rook was sacrificed in a similar fashion in the endgame. Neither can its practical value be assailed: as we will see, Tan collapsed almost instantly. Yet as I mentioned in the beginning, the annotator's duty is first and foremost to resist the urge to form an emotional attachment to the moves. That is why I decided to eschew a punctuation: this move's value and beauty compensate for its objective deficiency, but not more than that.

68. Bxa2 Kc2 69. Bxf4 Kb2

This, as the Russian expression goes, is the "salt" (i.e. fine point) of Black's dastardly scheme. The bishop is trapped, and after its inevitable death, White's forces will be powerless against the march of the b-pawn(s). Tan undoubtedly made these observations in a heartbeat, and it took her no more than three minutes to conclude that the game was essentially over. This is reflected in her next move, which is tantamount to capitulation:

70. Bc1+??

The ironic thing about this move is that Black wins on the spot by taking either bishop. While commentating this game live, I did not bother to properly excoriate this move, for I would have very likely made it myself: along with most of the viewers, I was convinced that resignation was imminent, that Black's idea was too beautiful not to work. And yet, there was one member of the audience who harbored no such illusions: this individual was none other than GM Robert Hess. Hess realized that the knight, incompetent as it is at containing passed pawns in the long run, can buy a few tempi with the threat of a fork. This enables White to draw the game with

a stunning, and highly counterintuitive, sequence that begins with 70. Bxd6 cxd6.



ANALYSIS AFTER 70. ... cxd6

The first step is to eliminate the d6- pawn: 71. Ne3 (or 71. Nh4) 71. ... Kxa2 72. Nf5 b3 73. Nxd6. All of a sudden, it transpires that the knight is able to return from its daring journey in time to stop the pawn from promoting. After 73. ... b2 there are two ways of doing this, but 74. Nxb5 runs into 74. ... Kb3 75. Nd4+ Kc3 76. Ne2+ Kc4. However, there is a second way of stopping the pawn: 74. Ne4!! The point is that the knight now has access to both c3 and d2, and Black has nothing better than to allow White to promote in time: 74. ... Kb3 75. d6 Kc2 76. d7 b1=Q 77. d8=Q Qd1+ with a draw.

Simply incredible!

70. ... Kxa2 71. Nf4 Bxf4

The simplest.

72. Bxf4 b3, White resigned.

The presence of a drawing line certainly does not detract from the aesthetic beauty and practical value of 67. ... Rxa2. But as a certified endgame guide, I must remain fully detached. Call me evil, I don't care. ♠

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Simplicity and Complexity

The search for truth in a position can follow varied and various paths.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

“HE CAME TO THE RIVER. THE RIVER was there.” ~ Ernest Hemingway, *Big Two-Hearted River*

“In some there was no evidence whatever that anything had been planted; in others, wilted brown stalks gave testimony to some inscrutable depredation.” ~ T. Coraghessan Boyle, *Budding Prospects*

A few days ago, I came across these two passages in Stephen King’s delightful memoir *On Writing*. King juxtaposes these excerpts to show that authorial mastery comes in a dizzying array of shapes; Hemingway’s genius consisted in his ability to say a great deal using the flimsiest and barest of linguist apparatus, while Boyle made a name for himself by employing every piece of heavy machinery that the English language has to offer.

King’s observation pertains rather directly to the world of chess, in which one finds an equally dizzying array of playing styles and methods that we can use to search for the truth in a position. What separates the virtuoso from the amateur is the former’s capacity to toggle seamlessly between these methods.

THINKING SIMPLE AND COMPLEX

GM Peter Svidler (FIDE 2737, RUS)

GM Evgeny Postny (FIDE 2601, ISR)

Netanya International Chess Festival 2019 (8), Netanya, Israel, 07.01.2019

(see diagram next column)

It is often difficult to make heads or tails of positions with material imbalances, for the obvious reason that standard metrics of evaluation such as king safety, piece placement and other comparative benchmarks are rendered moot. The position before you is a



AFTER 36. ... Bxc7

case in point: White has a queen for a rook and bishop, though it is hard to speak of a material advantage in the conventional sense. The d7-pawn, after all, is moribund, and the a5-pawn is hanging on by a thread as well. Given this reality, it appears reasonable to move the queen away from d2 so that ... Rxd7 will not come with tempo. Indeed, there is nothing logically wrong with the move 37. Qa2; after 37. ... Rxd7 (37. ... Bxd7 38. Qa3 Bd6 39. g3 is also rather grim) 38. Qa3! Bd6 39. Qf3! White sets up a rather unique double attack against the h5-pawn and the c6-square, facing Black with serious difficulties. However, as Dr. Mark Stock-Fishovich, M.D., Ph.D, indicates in his annotations, Black can stay above water with 39. ... Bg4 40. Qc6 Bf8!, preparing an absolutely vicious response against 41. Qxa6 (which I invite you to find in the first exercise). White retains a significant advantage with 41. h3, but much of the fight lies ahead.

This straightforward, sensible line of reasoning—let us refer to it as the Hemingway path—yields a perfectly logical conclusion. However, to reach the essence of a position, you must take a few moments to let your

brain run wild, to stray off the Hemingway path and onto the Coraghessan Boyle path.

If you put aside your preconceptions about the position, then an elegant and very profound idea quietly announces its presence. The pawn on d7, it turns out, can and should be saved.

37. Rxe6!!

A brilliant sacrifice that shows a deep understanding of the position. It is telling that Svidler spent only nine seconds on this and the following move; such is the potency of a super grandmaster’s intuition. In the absence of the light-square bishop, Black will need several moves to coordinate his pieces and mount a sustained attack against the d-pawn. That leaves White plenty of time to open up a vicious assault on the dreadfully weak pawn on e6.

37. ... fxe6 38. g3!

A powerful follow-up, preparing to perch his bishop on h3. In a desperate attempt to quench the fire, Postny involves his monarch.

38. ... Kf7

Black’s mission is obvious: if he can get his king to e7 and eliminate the pawn, he will be able to fully turn his attention to the task of containing White’s initiative. This he can accomplish by overprotecting the e6 pawn, which is the main entry point to Black’s camp. Realizing that time is of the essence, Svidler throws himself onto the pawn:

39. Bh3?

Svidler’s intention is very straightforward: if he manages to attack the e6-pawn with his queen, Black’s position will collapse like a

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Evgeny Postny (2601)
GM Luke McShane (2688)
Netanya Masters, 06.27.2019



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Shakhriyar Mamedyarov (2774)
GM Viswanathan Anand (2767)
Grand Chess Tour, Zagreb, 07.05.2019



BLACK TO MOVE



house of cards. However one-sided the situation may appear, hidden resources and tactical nuances hide behind virtually every position's façade. It transpires that the tool White has chosen to employ in order to shatter Black's defenses—the bishop—is not as effective as it appears. The somewhat paradoxical 39. gxf4! would have secured a crushing attack. Instead of using the bishop, White uses the pawn as a battering ram to tear open files and diagonals for the queen and bishop, which will only swoop in once the pawn has done its duty (the other difficulty in finding this idea is that it involves giving up the d-pawn which was White's idea behind 37. Rxe6). Following 39. ... Ke7 40. f5 exf5 (40. ... Rxd7 41. Qg5+ Kf8 42. fxe6 Re7 43. Qxc5 is curtains: Black is paralyzed, and White will swing his bishop around to g6 with a straightforward mating attack) 41. Qg5+ Kxd7 42. Qxf5+, it is clear that White's pawn has performed rather swimmingly. The bare king is easy pickings for White's vicious tandem, e. g. 42. ... Ke7 43. Qxc5+ Bd6 44. Qg5+ Kf8 45. Qf5+ Kg8 46. c5! with the devastating Bc4+ to follow.

I am by no means casting aspersions on Svidler for eschewing 39. gxf4 in favor of a move that most of us would probably make in a fraction of a second, but we can nonetheless learn from his mistake. When you catch yourself thinking that a position is straightforward, remind yourself that there is something you are probably missing.

39. ... Ke7

Postny spent one of his remaining two minutes on this move, and he, too, cannot be faulted for assuming that his position is hopeless. Paradoxically, the brilliant defensive resource Black had at his disposal can only be found by putting on one's Hemingway hat. That is, the defensive problem must be simplified down to its core: what is Black's overarching goal? The astute observer will realize that it is *not* to eliminate the d7-pawn; if White's queen and bishop tear out of their cages, Black is done for whether or not the d7-pawn is on the board. Rather, the most important task is to *keep the e6-pawn alive*; if Black can do that, then his position will stay intact and his king will retain his emergency supply of oxygen. It is clear that White's queen is too powerful to be restricted in any meaningful way, but the bishop has only a tenuous line of contact to the e6-pawn. This contact, it turns out, can be severed with the intrepid 39. ... g5!!.



ANALYSIS AFTER 39. ... g5!!

The only way that White has to stop ... g4 is 40. Qd3, aiming for h7. But Black responds with the cool 40. ... Rh8, renewing the threat. If White allows Black to drive a wedge into f3, his advantage will dissipate. Hence, he must settle in for the long game by means of 41. gxf4 g4 42. Bg2 Bxf4. The computer insists that White is clearly better, but I am quite sure that Black's drawing chances outweigh White's winning

chances if he exercises the utmost caution. To keep the fire going, White has to find 43. Bb7!, but Black holds on with 43. ... Bc7 44. Bc8 Bd8. On 45. Qd6?!, which I tried in a training game against the computer, Black launches into a vicious counterattack with 45. ... Rb1+ 46. Kg2 h4!!, when it is no longer clear who is better.

The position after 44. ... Bd8 is worthy of deep analysis, which I urge you to conduct on your own, preferably without the help of an engine (at least initially). But it is clear that Svidler would have had to win the game anew.

40. Qe2

Now it is all over. Black can stave off Qxe6, but the medicine is worse than the cure.

40. ... Rb1+ 41. Kg2 f3+ 42. Qxf3 Rf8 43. Qxh5 Bd6 44. Bxe6! Rb2 45. Qg5+ Kxe6



46. d8=N+!, Black resigned.

A gorgeous *coup d'grâce*! White could have promoted to a queen, but this wins much faster: after 46. ... Kd7 47. Qxg7+ Black loses the b2-rook.

Remember that variety is the spice of chess as well as life. Sometimes the greatest weapon in your arsenal is simplicity, but it is not applicable in every situation. ♠

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Calculation Fatigue

The dangers of delving too deeply into one particular variation

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

THE REALIZATION THAT ONE HAS squandered an opportunity to win the brilliancy prize spawns a kind of stinging pain that is among the nastiest sensations a chess player can experience. At the same time, it is a feeling that any chess player worth his salt has experienced countless times. For the brilliant tactician and flawless technician alike, what-ifs and could-have-beens are inevitable by-products of a long tournament career. In this month's column, we will examine a botched brilliancy of the most painful sort, a game in which White came within a hair's breadth of crushing his higher-rated opponent with a gorgeous tactical sequence. Yet we do so not to rub salt in GM Nico Georgiadis' wound nor to passively marvel at the beauty of the combination he overlooked. Rather, we seek to deepen our understanding of the logic that undergirds such a combination in an ultimate quest to make it possible for us to find such ideas with regularity.

BRILLIANCY OR BUST

GM Nico Georgiadis (FIDE 2488, SUI)
GM Santosh Gujrathi Vidit (FIDE 2689, IND)
Grandmaster Rapid 2019 (4.4), Biel,
Switzerland, 07.25.2019

(see diagram next column)

We join the battle right at its climax. After uncharacteristically misplaying the opening, Vidit managed to orchestrate a trade of rooks along the c-file and it appears that his last-ditch attempt at liquidation may just work. After 27. Qxa3 Bxe5 28. Qxe7, Black responds with 28. ... Qb8, constructing an impenetrable barrier along the dark squares. However, capturing on a3 is clearly not forced: White can instead



AFTER 26. ... Qxc8

attempt to promote his passed pawns in one of three ways: 27. b7, 27. Qxe7, and 27. d6. After spending over half of his remaining five minutes, Georgiadis decided to play it safe:

27. Qxa3

There is no doubt that Nico understood that Black's drawing chances in the position after ... Bxe5 and ... Qb8 would be quite high. At the same time, he probably also noticed the far-advanced b-pawn and the fact that Black has to simultaneously maintain the defensive construction along the dark squares and keep his king protected. Combine this with the additional presence of an (extra and passed) d-pawn, and the logic behind White's decision is rendered perfectly clear.

How does one approach this position with only five minutes on the clock? There is obviously no general algorithm to guarantee the correct decision; everything hinges on the ability to swiftly and accurately calculate a daunting amount of variations, having first made note of all relevant tactical patterns. Is this even hypothetically possible, given the stated time constraints? I believe that the answer is yes. By way of proof, let us

put ourselves in GM Georgiadis' shoes. We have exactly five minutes remaining (with a 30 second increment), and our task is to determine whether there is a forced win. The following is an attempt to construct a train of thought that would have enabled White to get to the bottom of the position:

Okay, I know that 27. Qxa3 gives me decent winning chances, so I will take the knight if I'm down to 30 seconds and don't see anything clear. 27. Qxe7 looks awesome: the passed pawns are clearly overwhelming after 27. ... Nc4 28. b7 Qb8 29. d6 Nxe5 30. Qc7. But ... wait a second, Black can try to exploit my weak king with 27. ... Qc1+ 28. Kg2 Nc2, threatening ... Ne1+. If my king runs to h3, Black has a check on h6. Unclear. What about 27. b7? Okay, then Black has 27. ... Qc1+ 28. Kg2 Bxe5. I can start with 27. d6 to avoid that sequence—after 27. ... exd6 28. b7 I'm winning. But Black has 27. ... Bxe5 and after 28. dxe7 something like 28. ... Nb5. But now I don't even have to hurry; I can just transfer my queen to c6 with 29. Qe4 and I really doubt that Black has enough firepower to stop all of the threats. Worse comes to worst, I can bail out by forcing Black to give up one of his minor pieces. Let's go for it!

"Pah," I can hear you saying, "you've got the cart before the horse. If you didn't know 27. d6 was correct, you would have come up with a completely different train of thought!" This point is reasonable, but I believe that what Georgiadis overlooked was not an esoteric tactical detail deep into the variation, but rather the fact that 27. d6 covers up the b8-h2 diagonal. Once this detail is noted, there should remain little doubt in White's mind that this line yields by far the most promise.

In fact, after 27. d6 Bxe5 28. dxe7, Black has a far more resilient defense in 28. ... Kg7!

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Zurkhon Rizvonov
Garry Kasparov
USSR Championship (U18), Vilnius 1975



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Varuzhan Akobian (2645)
GM Sam Shankland (2666)
U.S. Championship 2017, 04.02.2017



BLACK TO MOVE



ANALYSIS AFTER 28. ... Kg7

The reason *ChessBase News* called this game a missed game of the year candidate is contained in this position. When I first looked at it, the simple 29. Qd2 sprang to mind, intending 30. Qd8 (immediately or after b7). But the line given in the article is far more beautiful: 29. b7 Qe8 (Also losing is 29. ... Qb8 30. Bc6.) 30. b8=Q!! (a stunning distraction tactic!) 30. ... Bxb8 31. Qd4+ f6 32. Qd8 Kf7 33. Bd5+, winning. Surely, I figured, there must be something wrong with 29. Qd2, but upon checking with an engine, I discovered that it was just as effective as 29. b7!. The presence of this simpler, more utilitarian path to victory casts into serious doubt the notion that Nico was a millimeter away from playing the game of the year.

Furthermore, the post-mortem confirms that this narrative should be nuanced. Both players saw that 27. Qxe7 Qc1+ 28. Kg2 Nc2 is unclear, and that 27. b7 Qc1+ leads nowhere. However, the possibility of 27. d6 went unmentioned by either player, leading me to believe that GM Georgiadis fell prey to what I call "calculation fatigue." Calculation fatigue occurs when you delve too deeply into the intricacies of one particular variation. After failing to discover a favorable continuation, it becomes tempting to revert to the safe option without spending any time on the remaining candidate moves.

To this end, Georgiadis took the knight with over two minutes left on his clock.

Given the 30-second increment, there is no reason that he could not have waited until he had 30 seconds or even less, since Qxa3 and Qxe7 can be executed almost instantly. Yet having found none, he became discouraged. The lesson, then, is clear: as infuriating as a particular variation may be, it is crucial to allocate your time so that you give yourself at least a few moments to consider all of your candidate moves. Had Nico *looked* at 27. d6, I am practically certain that he would have chosen this continuation on the strength of his intuition alone. The fact that he took the knight has nothing to do with the presence of a brilliant continuation down the road, and everything to do with an understandable psychological error that we are all prone to making.

27. ... Bxe5 28. Qxe7 Qb8 29. Qa7 a5!



A pretty idea, even though Black would have remained within the confines of a draw even had he given up the pawn. After 30. Qxa5 Bd4 Black wins the b-pawn, so White will have no choice but to give up one of his pawns in order to kill off the pesky a-pawn.

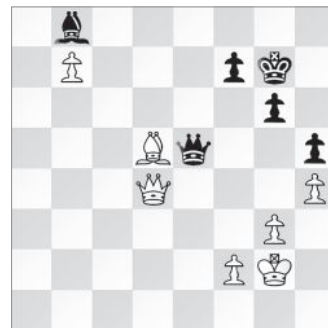
30. Qa6 Kg7 31. b7 a4 32. d6 Qxd6 33. Qxa4 Qb6

The computer assigns White an overwhelming advantage, but to my eye he has absolutely no way to make progress if Black exercises caution.

34. Kg2 Bb8 35. Bd5

Starting with 35. Qe8 would have led nowhere due to 35. ... Qd6, with 36. h4 always met by 36. ... h5.

35. ... Qd6 36. Qc4 Qc7 37. Qe4 Qe5 38. Qd3 h5 39. h4 Qd6 40. Qb3 Qf6 41. Qa4 Qd6 42. Bb3 Qb6 43. Bd5 Qd6 44. Qd4+ Qe5



45. Qxe5+?!

This is tantamount to a draw offer. It was perhaps more prudent to continue grinding with 45. Qc4, but I have no doubt that Vidity would have been able to hold the draw.

45. ... Bxe5 46. Kf3 Bb8 47. Ke3 Kf6 48. Kd4 Ke7 49. Kc5 Ke8 50. Kb6 Ke7 51. Ba2 Ke8 52. Bc4 Ke7 53. Bb3 Ke8 54. f3 Ke7

Avoiding 54. ... Bxg3?? 55. Ka7.

55. g4 hxg4 56. fxg4 Ke8 57. Kc6 Ke7 58. g5 Ke8 59. Kc5 Ke7 60. Kd4 Kf8 61. Ke3 Bc7 62. Kf3 Kg7 63. Kg4 Bb8 64. h5 gxh5+ 65. Kxh5 f6 66. g6 f5, Draw agreed.

And so, in the process of looking behind the scenes of a botched brilliancy, we have realized that there really was no botched brilliancy to speak of! Yet this realization contributes to, rather than detracts from, this game's instructive value. ♦

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The Endgame Terminator

Remembering GM Pal Benko

By GM DANIEL NARODITSKY

RECENTLY, A FRIEND OF MINE SHARED a wise remark that his longtime mentor made a few years ago. “There are three kinds of people,” his mentor began. “There are those who die, and no one cares. Then there are those who die, and their friends and family mourn. And then,” he finished, “there are those who die, and the whole community grieves.”

GM Pal Benko, who passed away on August 26 at age 91, belongs squarely in the third category. After obtaining the grandmaster title in 1958 and moving to the United States shortly thereafter, Benko commenced a decades-long reign of terror over open tournaments in America and regularly fought on equal footing with the likes of Bobby Fischer, Mikhail Tal, Tigran Petrosian, and other members of the world elite. Yet he was not only a fearsome tournament player: Benko’s immeasurable contribution to opening theory and his jaw-dropping endgame studies are as central to his legacy as his accomplishments over the board.

Furthermore, it is Pal Benko’s endgame shoes that I have the honor and privilege of filling since 2013, when Benko retired from over 30 years of his fascinating Endgame Lab column. The chess world has lost a titan. Let us honor Benko’s memory by examining one of his finest endgame performances, a game whose depth even modern computers struggle to comprehend.

A FINE PERFORMANCE

GM Pal Benko (2485)
GM Dragutin Sahovic (2490)
Lone Pine op Louis D. Statham Masters (7),
Lone Pine, California, 04.08.1978

(see diagram next column)

At first blush, White’s advantage appears symbolic at best. True, he has an outside passed pawn and a centralized king, but what



AFTER 37. ... Kc6

is this good for in the face of Black’s fortress? The pawn will go no further than b5, and as the following pair of moves shows, Black’s bishop will never be dislodged from e6:

38. Bc4 Kb6

Obviously, capturing the bishop on c4 would have resulted in a clearly lost pawn endgame. But now, 39. Bxe6 fxe6 is drawn, since White cannot penetrate the pawn shell: 40. g4 Kb5 41. f5?? actually loses to 41. ... exf5 42. gxf5 gxf5, when the pawns tie down White’s king.

At this point, many of us would have undoubtedly signed the scoresheets and gone home. But Benko was an endgame virtuoso whose creativity and eye for brilliant ideas extended way past the world of chess composition. In bishop endgames and especially in pawn endgames, **pawn structure is probably the single most important factor in deciding the outcome of the game. The slightest modification in structure frequently spawns new weaknesses and possibilities for pawn breaks, entirely changing the evaluation of the position.** In this case, it is important to understand that Black’s bishop is essentially tied down to e6; otherwise, Black’s pawn—all on light squares—would be

sitting ducks for its vis-à-vis. In an ideal world, White would advance his own pawns in such a way as to ensure the possibility of a breakthrough when the bishops are traded. But how on earth can this be accomplished?

39. h4!

With this move, Benko is not simply decorating his position before offering a draw. To the contrary, it is the start of a brilliant and stunningly deep plan on whose strength the Hungarian grandmaster achieves the unachievable. But let’s not get ahead of ourselves. For the moment, Black must decide whether to allow the pawn to travel further or to halt its progress with 39. ... h5. It may seem more precise to choose the latter, but it transpires that 39. ... h5 allows the pretty breakthrough 40. f5!, when all three captures introduce fatal weaknesses in Black’s position:

- 1) 40. ... gxf5 41. Be2! will create a deadly outside passed pawn, e.g. 41. ... f6 42. Bxh5 Kc6 43. Bg6 and the path is clear.
- 2) 40. ... Bxf5 41. Bxf7 and White wins by bringing his king to g5 and picking off Black’s defenseless pawns (this is very similar to the game).
- 3) 40. ... Bxc4 41. Kxc4 gxf5 technically wins a pawn, but the outside passer still guarantees White an easy victory: 42. Kd5 Kc7 43. b5 Kd7 44. b6 f6 45. b7 Kc7 46. b8=Q+ Kxb8 47. Kxd6 and a veritable feast awaits the white monarch.

In light of these variations, Sahovic decides to keep the status quo—and rightly so.

39. ... Kc6

(see diagram top of next page)

Upon playing this move, it is quite probable that Sahovic—an experienced Yugoslavian grandmaster in his own right—looked up at

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

Pal Benko
Geza Fuster
Budapest Centaris, 05.15.1948



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Arthur Bisguier
GM Pal Benko
New York, New York, 1967



BLACK TO MOVE



Benko with an expression of annoyance. How many empty moves will this guy make before offering a draw? It may have been only after Benko's next move that he began to suspect that something was afoot.

40. Be2!

Once more, there appears to be nothing particularly impressive about this move. Yes, White can push his pawn to h5 and perhaps even to h6, but what does that accomplish? It is only upon careful reflection, upon delving very deeply into the intricacies of the kingside pawn structure, that Benko's dastardly concept announces itself. White intends not to push his pawn to h5, but rather to g5! After 40. ... Kb6 41. g4 Kc6 (41. ... h6 42. Bc4 Kc6 43. f5! wins even faster, e.g. 43. ... gxf5 44. Bxe6 fxe6 45. g5) 42. g5 Kb6 43. Bc4 Kc6, the same question we have been asking all along rears its head yet again: what next?



ANALYSIS AFTER 43. ... Kc6

The reason it is hard to make heads or tails of this position is because the pawn structure still appears to be symmetrical. How can one engineer a pawn break in a symmetrical position? The answer lies in the bishops: by threatening to breach the fortress, White forces a breach in Black's defensive wall, and that is all that White's bloodthirsty pawns need. And this can all be accomplished with the beautiful shot 44. f5!! After 44. ... Bxf5 45. Bxf7, the point of advancing the pawn to g5 becomes clear: the h7-pawn is immobilized, and White's bishop can pick it off from g8. For example, after 45. ... Kb5 46. Bg8 (there isn't even the need to defend the b4-pawn with Kc3; it has done its job) 46. ... Kxb4 47. Bxh7 Black is powerless against the threat of h4-h5. The alternative, 44. ... gxf5, loses to 45. Bxe6 fxe6 46. h5 and Black's hapless king, tied to the b4-pawn for an eternity, pays the price in blood. White promotes after 46. ... Kd7 47. g6 hxg6 48. h6. It should be noted that 48. hxg6 also wins, creating a situation with passed pawns on either side of the board that Russians call "trousers." I will leave the etymological derivation up to you, dear reader.

There is absolutely nothing that Black can do to stop this from happening; 40. ... f5 merely brings on the inevitable after 41. Bc4 Bd7 42. Bg8.

40. ... h5 41. Bc4!

The winning plan is familiar to us, and the fact that White has spent a tempo toggling his bishop between c4 and e2 changes absolutely nothing.

41. ... Kb6

The move 41. ... d5 is easily rebuffed by 42. b5+ Kd6 43. Bb3 followed by b6 and b7, distracting Black's king and winning the kingside pawns.

42. f5 Bxf5 43. Bxf7 Kb5 44. Kd5 Kxb4 45. Kxd6

Black's pawns are a sad sight indeed.

45. ... Kc3 46. Ke5 Kd3 47. Kf6 Ke2 48. Bxg6 Bg4 49. Kg5, Black resigned.

This game was just one of the countless endgame gems that the great Pal Benko produced throughout his career. Let us hope that endgame lovers will learn from his tournament practice, compositions, and writings for centuries to come. Rest in peace. ♠

Bonus Baffler

"Benko's Bafflers" appeared in *Chess Life* (and its predecessor, *Chess Life & Review*) monthly from 1967 through December 2013 and was one of the magazine's most popular columns. See if you can solve this one:

No. 1049

O. Aarhus, MN



WHITE MATES IN 3

From Benko's Bafflers, *Chess Life & Review*, March 1979. See "Books and Beyond" on page 24 for more on Benko's books and Bafflers.

See solution on page 71.

False Narratives

It is exceedingly seldom that all roads lead to Rome—or is it?

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IN TODAY'S COLUMN, WE TAKE A LOOK at a game that, at first blush, seems like a garden-variety case of a strong player getting nervous and losing his way under pressure. Eh, I hear you say. *Nothing to write home about.* We'll see about that.

AN HONEST LIE

GM Luke McShane (FIDE 2682, ENG)
GM Fabiano Caruana (FIDE 2812, USA),
FIDE Chess.com Grand Swiss, Isle of Man,
10.14.2019



AFTER 56. ... Kxh6

For the first 56 moves of the game, GM Luke McShane reaffirmed that a career in finance was no insurmountable obstacle when it came to outplaying the second-best player in the world. After winning an Exchange in a scintillating tactical skirmish, McShane eschewed several winning (yet risky) continuations in favor of an endgame that appears laughably one-sided. The official commentators, WGM Anna Rudolf and GM Daniel King, were under the impression that Fabi would flick over his king at any moment. Yours truly, who was monitoring the broadcast on his phone while stuck in a

traffic jam, was under the same impression and decided to switch Google Maps back on.

In addition to being an Exchange down, Black has two devastating flaws in his position: the first is that the b4-pawn is on a dark square, where it permanently lacks the support of the bishop. The second, more catastrophic flaw is the fact that Black's bishop and rook are on the same file.

57. Re1?

On the surface, there is absolutely no difference between this move and 57. Re2. Both moves create a pin along the e-file, and both moves seem to force an eventual rook trade. As we have discussed several times, however, **it is seldom—exceedingly seldom—that all roads lead to Rome.** The corollary to this notion is that two moves containing the same idea are rarely equivalent in strength. And as we know, a nearly imperceptible drawback can radically alter the course of the game.

Black has two possible ways to extricate himself. The first is to give a check on the g-file and the second is to move the bishop (or the rook) in such a manner that both pieces are protected (... Bc6 for instance). Of course, 57. ... Bc6 loses on the spot: 58. Rxe8 Bxe8 59. Rd4 and White picks up the pawn. Fabi has no choice but to look behind door number two:

57. ... Re5!

Now, the myopic 58. Rde2 meets with 58. ... Rg5+, and Black will park his newly-liberated bishop on d5. White can hunt for the b-pawn straightaway by means of 58. Rd4 Rg5+ 59. Kf2, but this runs into somewhat irksome complications after 59. ... Rf5+ 60. Ke2! (60. Ke3? plays right into Black's hands after 60. ... Bd5 61. Rxb4 Rf3+) 60. ... Bc2 61. Rxb4 Rh5, when there is still some work to be done. Of course, White is

totally winning after 62. Kd2, but McShane was set on an entirely different course of action:

58. Kh2



The purpose of this move is obvious: ... Rg5 no longer comes with check, rendering the pin deadly once more. Indeed, McShane's calculations were flawless—Black is forced to acquiesce to a rook trade. What the English grandmaster failed to account for, however, is that a rook trade is far, far from tantamount to capitulation.

58. ... Rd5!

After the trade, Black's bishop will be glued to the pawn on b3, and its counterpart on b4 will make a miraculous fortress possible.

But before we go any further, let us perform a simple task of comparison. Let's imagine that McShane played 57. Re2 instead of 57. Re1:

(see diagram top of next page)

The reason McShane chose Re1 may have consisted in 57. ... Re6, but it is easy to establish that 58. Rf4 wins on the spot: 58. ... Rg6+ 59. Kh2 Bd5 60. Rh4+ Kg5 61. Rxb4, and with the king safely nestled on h2, Black has absolutely no counterplay. As a matter of fact, he cannot even prevent the rook trade without losing his bishop.

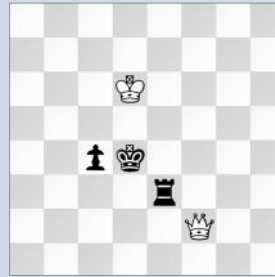
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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

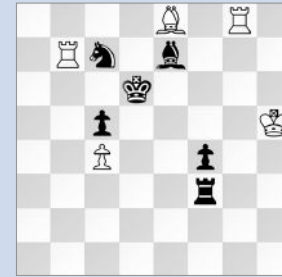
GM Magnus Carlsen (FIDE 2876, NOR)
GM Maxim Matlakov (FIDE 2716, RUS)
Grand Swiss, Isle of Man, 10.20.2019



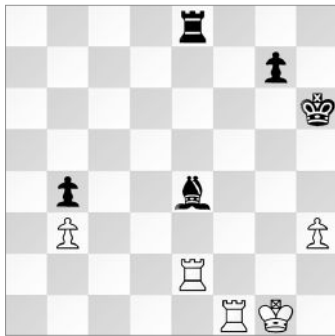
WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

WGM Alina L'Ami (FIDE 2359, ROU)
GM Jan Sprenger (FIDE 2506, GER)
Salento Open, Gallipoli, 05.22.2016



WHITE TO MOVE



AFTER 57. Re2

And what about 57. ... Re5? White responds with 58. Kh2, as in the game, and now Black is forced to perform the same action with 58. ... Rf5. After 59. Rxf5 Bxf5, it transpires that the bishop is no longer making contact with the b3-pawn, and White exploits this golden tempo to capture the b4- pawn: 60. Rd2! Kg5 (60. ... Be6 61. Rd6 pins and wins the bishop) 61. Rd4 and Black can resign!

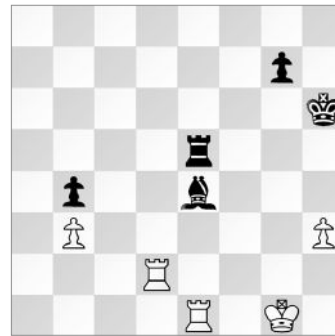
The point of this task is not to show the world that the next Sherlock Holmes has risen. Rather, it is to force your brain to perform the kind of detail-oriented thinking that often constitutes the only method for a human to pull out the most accurate sequence from an ocean of tempting possibilities.

I emphasize the word human here for an important reason. Let us return to the game position after 57. ... Re5 (before McShane played 58. Kh2):

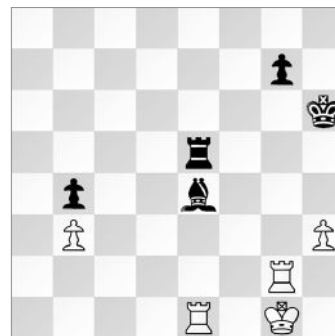
(see diagram top of next column)

Ladies and gentlemen, you have been had. Defrauded. Lied to in a manner most dastardly indeed. The entire narrative—of only one path leading to Rome—is, technically speaking, a lie.

Yet it is an honest lie, one that I was ready to publish and send out to the world in good faith until I decided to double-check this particular position with a computer. What I found blew my mind: not only has McShane done nothing wrong, but 57. Re1—at least from a purely



mathematical standpoint—is probably even the best. The reason is that White does have a way to exploit the pin without allowing Black's bishop to make contact with b3. When a human being identifies the threat of ... Rg5, however, the only moves that come to mind are 58. h4 (direct prophylaxis) and 58. Kh2 (indirect prophylaxis). And both, as we know, allow 58. ... Rd5. Yet there is a third method, one that makes our jaws drop: 58. Rg2!!



AFTER 58. Rg2!!

Once this move is made, its purpose becomes immediately clear: White stops the check, threatens Rg4, and forces 58. ... Bxg2. After 59. Rxe5, the bishop can no longer return to d5, and White does not care one whit about the pawn on h3. Following 59. ... Bxh3 60. Rb5, White picks off the most important pawn and sees the b-pawn through to promotion. Black can do nothing else to stop Rg4.

When I discovered this possibility, my first instinct was to start the column afresh. But then I realized that the presence of this incredible resource in no way invalidates my point. To this end, the endgame is the site of an entire underworld of computer-generated resources; anyone who tries to learn the endgame based on how Stockfish plays them would go mad in a matter of days. That is why looking at games from a purely objective standpoint can actually be harmful: **despite the existence of 58. Rg2, I still believe that McShane's first move was a serious mistake that set the stage for Caruana's miracle escape.** The method of comparison is still valid, and we should still firmly believe that one road leads to Rome.

And now, let us finally return to the game.

59. Rxd5

It was actually not too late to swerve with 59. Rd1, although White's technical task after 59. ... Rg5 will be annoyingly difficult.

59. ... Bxd5 60. Re3 g5!

A superb resource. Caruana has set up a fortress—as soon as White's king departs toward the queenside, his vis-à-vis will creep up to h4, snag the h-pawn, and the g-pawn will advance with devastating speed. Again, computer analysis indicates that White may still be winning.

61. Kg3 Kg6 62. Kf2

Liquidating the kingside with 62. h4 does not help: 62. ... gxh4+ 63. Kxh4 Kf5 64. Kg3 Be4 and White cannot make progress.

62. ... Kf5 63. Rg3 Be6 64. Ke2 Bd5 65. Kd2 Be6 66. Rf3+ Ke5 67. Re3+ Kf6 68. Kc2 Bf5+ 69. Kc1 Be6 70. Kd2 Bd5 71. Kc2 Be6 72. Kb2 Bf5 73. Rg3 Be6 74. Rd3 Ke5 75. Re3+ Kf6 76. Re4

McShane finally breaks.

76. ... Bxh3 77. Rxb4 g4 78. Re4 g3 79. Kc3 Kf5 80. Re1 Kf4 81. b4 Kf3 82. b5 Kf2 83. Kd2 g2 84. b6 Bc8 85. Re2+, Draw agreed.♠

The Goalkeeper's Glory

Sometimes saving a game feels no less sweeter than winning one.

By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

IN HIS EXCELLENT WORK *THE SEVEN Deadly Chess Sins*, Scottish GM Jonathan Rowson frames the notion of defense in terms of what he calls the goalkeeper's glory. "Your aim," Rowson explains, "is in one sense purely negative. You don't 'gain' anything by saving the goal and you might think that your role is merely to prevent your adversary from gaining. But actually if you save the penalty, you could say that you win and the striker loses, even though in actual fact the score of the game remains exactly the same."¹

It was on the strength of this analogy that I attempted to lift my own spirits as I faced a miserable defensive task at the hands of GM Jeffery Xiong, one of America's brightest young stars, at the recent Winter Chess Classic in St. Louis. Lifting one's own spirits, it turns out, is only the first in an endless series of steps both practical and psychological in nature that must be flawlessly executed in order to salvage an objectively lost endgame. In today's column, I would like to shed some light on what each of these steps truly entails.

SAVING THE GAME

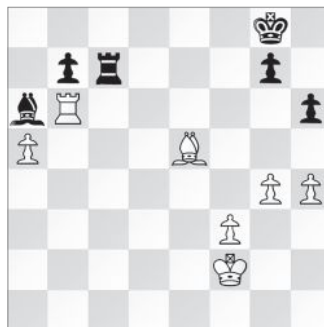
GM Jeffery Xiong (2789)

GM Daniel Naroditsky (2690)

2019 Winter Chess Classic (4), St. Louis, Missouri, 11.13.2019

(see diagram next column)

After missing a forced draw in a wild post-middlegame time scramble, I was forced to acquiesce to an endgame that is rather painful to look at. White is up a pawn, his rook-and-bishop tandem is ideally coordinated, and the only reason that Black can even dream of one day sharing the point is squarely contained in the presence of opposite-color bishops.



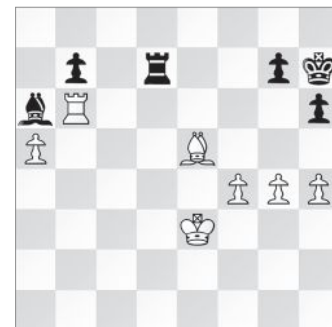
AFTER 53. Be5

I quickly realized that behind the superficial question of where to move the rook lay a far more important dilemma: I could choose between passive defense with something like 53. ... Rd7, or I could toss my chips into the center of the table with 53. ... Rc2+, in the hopes of mounting sudden pressure against White's kingside pawns. **When deciding between passive and active defense, it is important to remember that passive defense is generally less committal, since you leave yourself the option of "going active" at a potentially more opportune moment.** This consideration rendered my decision straightforward:

53. ... Rd7

It is easy to establish that 53. ... Rc2+ 54. Ke3 Re2+ only accelerates defeat after 55. Kf4!, when the cheeky 55. ... g5+ is coolly rebuffed by 56. Kf5! (leaving the weak h-pawn for later consumption) 56. ... Bd3+ 57. Ke6 gxh4 58. Rd6! Bc4+ 59. Kf5 and the h-pawn will fall, leaving Black on the brink of death. 55. ... Rf2 brings no relief either, since White simply picks off Black's pawn with 56. Rg6.

54. f4 Kh7 55. Ke3



And so, two moves later, I was once again facing a familiar predicament. This time, I was less keen on sitting still: in my mind, I could clearly envision a scenario where Jeffery simply ran his pawns up the board, starting with f4-f5 and ending with g4-g5 and g5-g6+.

Having decided that something needed to be done, I started to look for sources of counterplay. When you are performing this search, it is crucial to understand that you **should not limit your search to moves that look good**. If you are lost, you will not find anything that you truly like; your goal is merely to put on the goalkeeper's gloves and to defend against the next shot on goal.

55. ... h5!

This move sure looks like an act of pure desperation and guess what—it is! But when you are on the brink of death, there is nothing wrong with desperation! Saving an outwardly position is not something that one can do gracefully. The point of this move is easy to understand: I am trying to provoke the myopic 56. g5?, when Black swoops in with 56. ... Bd3! (not 56. ... g6?? 57. f5 when White breaks through), setting up an unbreachable fortress along the light squares. Of course, Jeffery saw right through this—but there is no way to avoid a certain degree of complexity.

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PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Hovhannes Gabuzyan (2709)
GM S.P. Sethuraman (2651)
Winter Chess Classic, 11.14.2019



BLACK TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

IM Cameron Wheeler (2406)
FM Andrew Hong (2357)
Pro Chess League, 02.27.2019



BLACK TO MOVE

56. gxh5!

White now has two pawns to the good, but his kingside pawns are permanently ruined. The battle will now revolve around Jeffery's ability to use these crippled pawns as battering rams to create a passer.

56. ... Rd3+

I have no choice but to initiate the hunt for White's pawns, come hell or high water. Sitting around with something along the lines of 56. ... Rf7 enabled White to instantly accomplish his main goal with 57. h6! gxh6 58. h5, fixing the weakness on h6 and spawning a passer that is unstoppable in the long run. For instance, 58. ... Bc4 59. Rd6 (threatening the deadly Rd8) 59. ... Rf5 60. Rd7+! Rf7 (60. ... Kg8 is nominally more resilient, but loses quickly after 61. Rxb7 Rxh5 62. Kd4) 61. Rd8, when the threat of Rh8 cannot be stopped without disastrous material losses.

57. Ke4 Rh3 58. Re6!

Jeffery stays on top, avoiding the dreadful 58. Rg6?? Bd3+.

58. ... Rxh4 59. Rg6

Only now, once Black's rook has left the third rank, is this square safe.

59. ... Rxh5 60. Rxb7+ Kh6 61. f5 Rh4+



This is as far as I had calculated when playing 55. ... h5. White has succeeded in his task of creating a far-advanced passed pawn, but I have

also managed to eliminate the rest of White's menacing kingside pawn army. Intuitively, it was clear to both my opponent and me that White is on the brink of victory. There remains only to find the right square for the monarch.

62. Kd5??

What could possibly be wrong with advancing the king, especially onto a square so outwardly unassailable? The error inherent in this move is one that we have seen time and time again in this column: **everything on the chess board is connected; even when nothing seems to be going on, the tiniest weakness or tactical feature can radically change the evaluation of the position.** What Jeffery had missed is that while the king might be unassailable, the pawn on a5 is not. Even more importantly, Black's king might look terrible, but it is virtually impossible to ensnare the wily monarch in a mating net, since the h5-square is very difficult to bring under control.

62. ... Ra4!

The flaw in White's previous move immediately becomes clear when this move is played: the a5-pawn is hanging *with check*! Thus, after 63. f6, Black responds with 63. ... Rxa5+ 64. Ke6 Bc4+!, and White has no choice but to acquiesce to a draw with 65. Kf5 (65. Kd6 Rd5+ is also drawn) 65. ... Bd3+ 66. Kf4 Bg6, when 67. f7 leads nowhere due to (among other things) 67. ... Ra8 68. Rg8 Ra4+!, and Black picks off the pawn. Jeffery—this time after spending almost all of his remaining time—tries to prevent this sequence of checks, but the damage has been done.

63. Ke6 Bc4+!

A crucial insertion, forcing the king onto a tremendously awkward square. 63. ... Rxa5 was also possible, but a lot messier after 64. Rc7!.

64. Kf6 Rxa5 65. Rg4 Ra6+ 66. Ke7

(see diagram top of next column)

At this point, Jeffery was still holding out hopes of winning the game. After all, moving



the bishop to a random square along the diagonal—say, 66. ... Bd5 results in near-disaster after 67. Bf6! Bf3 (the only way to stop Rh4 mate) 68. Rg3, and White follows up with Bg7+ and f5-f6. However, after making an effort to look at the entire board, and to examine all possible ways of defending the bishop, I realized that Black has a very straightforward way to bring the curtain down favorably.

66. ... b5!

The potential checking square on a7 makes all the difference, since White no longer has a way to push the pawn past f6 nor entrap Black's king in a mating net.

67. Bd6 Ra7+ 68. Kf6 Rf7+ 69. Ke5 Kh7 70. f6 Rd7

Some caution is still required, but drawing the game is essentially a matter of not blundering checkmate.

71. Rg3 Kh6 72. Kf5 Kh7 73. Be5 Rb7 74. Kg5 Bf7 75. Kf5 Bc4 76. Bd6 Rd7 77. Ke5 Bf7 78. Rg7+ Kh8 79. Rg4 Kh7 80. Be7 Kh8 81. Rh4+ Kg8 82. Bd6 Ra7 83. Rg4+ Kh8 84. Bf8 Rd7 85. Bd6, Draw agreed.

I won two games in this tournament, but this game felt by far the best. So the next time you are staring a lost position in the eye, remember that saving a goal is no less sweeter a feeling than kicking one. ♠

¹ Jonathan Rowson, *The Seven Deadly Chess Sins* (Gambit, 2000), 99.

Decoding the “Zen”

Intuitive assumptions without rigorous calculation can lead to tragic consequences.

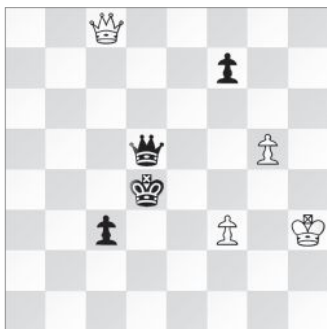
By **GM DANIEL NARODITSKY**

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 7, 2019, I HAD the pleasure of commentating a round of the Grand Chess Tour finals in London with the one and only GM Robert Hess. The great thing about live commentary, as I came to discover, is that you quite literally have a courtside seat, with fascinating action unfolding right before your eyes. On that particular day, just such fascinating action was supplied by an outwardly mundane affair between GMs Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (MVL) and Ding Liren. The Chinese ace displayed fantastic opening preparation and then filigree technique to reach a winning position. But then, with the curtain seemingly about to be drawn, Robert and I were treated to a display of brilliance and beauty that neither of us will forget anytime soon.

FOUR QUEENS

GM Maxime-Vachier Lagrave
(FIDE 2780, FRA)

GM Ding Liren (FIDE 2801, CHN), London
Chess Classic Grand Chess Tour Finals 2019
(2), London, England, 12.07.2019



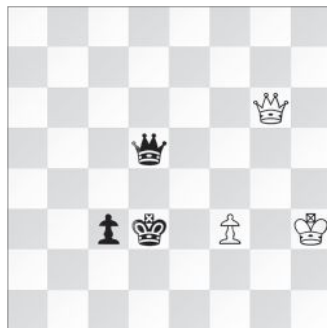
AFTER 64. ... Kd4

For the past 20 moves, Ding Liren's monarch has faced the unbridled wrath of the white

queen. The king has zigged and zagged throughout the board, deftly sidestepping every one of the queen's checks. The king is now a hair's breadth away from permanently escaping the queen's fury, which will pave the way for the pawn's coronation. **In general, it is exceptionally difficult to ensnare the king in a perpetual check, even in the absence of pieces in whose shadow the king can take shelter.** With a queen on d5, the king's potential to escape White's queen is a bygone conclusion.

65. Qg4+ Kd3 66. g6!?

To add insult to injury, White's own pawns were impeding the queen from exercising its full range of motion, not that that really makes a difference. To that end, Ding Liren undoubtedly understood that 66. ... fxg6 67. Qxg6+ should, theoretically, be a straightforward win for Black.



ANALYSIS DIAGRAM AFTER 67. Qxg6+

However, theoretical truth and practical truth are two entirely different kettle of fish. Thus, it is possible to evade the checks, but to do so Black has to continue to perform highly precise gymnastics with his king, jumping hither and thither until White's queen finally

runs out of gas. The winning line goes as follows: 67. ... Kd2 68. Qg2+ Kc1 69. Qg1+ Kc2! (the first finesse: the tempting 69. ... Kb2?! leads nowhere due to 70. Qb6+, and Black has to repeat) 70. Qf2+ Qd2 71. Qb6 Kd3! (initiating the second stage: Black's king walks over to capture the pawn, thereby opening up the possibility of interposing with check) 72. Qd6+ Ke2 73. Qh2+ Kxf3 74. Qg3+ Ke2 (the final stage begins: Black's king runs back to shelter) 75. Qg4+ Kf1! 76. Qf3+ Ke1 77. Qh1+ Ke2 78. Qg2+ Kd1 79. Qf1+ Kc2 80. Qf7 (80. Qf5+ Qd3+!) 80. ... Qd3+ 81. Kg2 Kc1 and the game is finally over: the king is completely safe and White cannot stop the pawn from marching to c2 and then, after the king slides over to d1, to the promised land.

Could Ding Liren calculate this entire line during the game? Absolutely not. Could he decode the “zen” of the winning plan one move at a time until he reached a position of this sort? Absolutely. After all, there is no way to do any permanent damage when trying to escape the checks; it might have taken him 50 moves, but Ding Liren would have eventually found his way to victory.

However, after playing such a long game, Ding was in no mood to enter yet another dull technical phase. Take a look at the position after g5-g6: Black's king is, for the time being, still out of the range of White's queen. With this in mind, and after performing a few calculations, Ding decided to “expedite” the process:

66. ... c2??

The motivation behind this move is very clear: in the event of 67. g7, we get a fascinating position with two queens on the board after 67. ... c1=Q 68. g8=Q. However, the intrigue is short-lived. **In the event of simultaneous**

Practicum

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

IM Hikaru Nakamura (2494)
GM John Fedorowicz (2509)
Imre Konig Memorial, 09.08.2002



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Zhang Pengxiang (2530)
GM Anatoly Karpov (2692)
FIDE World Championship, 11.27.2001



WHITE TO MOVE

promotion, the side with the first move after promotion generally has a huge initiative, and with more than one queen on the board, this initiative is virtually always enough to deliver checkmate or win the opponent's queen(s). This case is no exception: after 68. ... Qh1+ 69. Kg3 Qe5+ Black wins in rather routine fashion after both 70. Kf2 Qee1 mate and 70. Qf4 Qee1+ 71. Kg4 Qhh4+ 72. Kf5 Qe6 mate. Elegant to be sure, but nothing to write home about. After all, Black gets the first move in a position with four queens on the board, so it is not a big surprise that he delivers checkmate in every variation.

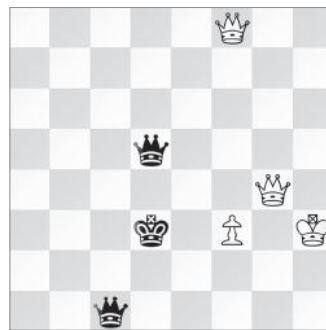
67. gxf7



At first glance, MVL's move seems to change exactly nothing. Recapturing the pawn would be disastrous: after 67. ... Qxf7 Black's queen retreats away from the center of action, enabling White's queen to initiate an unstoppable sequence of checks (a variation on the famous "sundial" motif where the queen pursues the king through a sequence of diagonal and vertical checks) with 68. Qe4+. After 68. ... Kc3 69. Qe5+ Kb3 70. Qb5+ Black's king is caught in a perpetual circuit. But that, of course, is not what Ding Liren was relying on:

67. ... c1=Q 68. f8=Q

Watching this game live with Robert, our initial reaction to this position was one and the same: there is absolutely no way on earth,



we reasoned, that Black does not have a way to deliver checkmate. And the next two moves seemed to confirm our intuition:

68. ... Qh1+ 69. Kg3 Qe5+

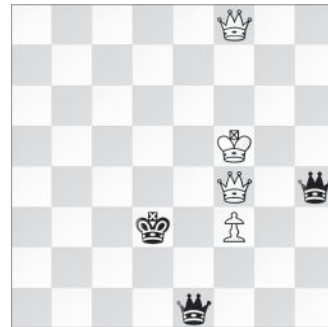
Both of White's queens are placed too awkwardly to prevent Black's queens from massacring White's king along countless files and diagonals. Indeed, it is checkmate on e1 after both f3-f4 and Qf8-f4. However, as we have discussed countless times in this column, chess is a game of exceptions. The moment you make an assumption without rigorous calculation, you open yourself up to the possibility of an unbelievably tragic turn of events. And that is exactly what happens here: instead of blocking with the pawn or the queen on f8, White has one more queen with which he can block the check:

70. Qgf4!!

In doing so, he opens up an avenue of escape for his king through g4 and f5. When Robert and I started to realize that Ding may have botched the win, neither of us could believe it for the longest time. Even with the king escaping, we reasoned, Black's queens must have a way to combine forces and compel White into giving away a queen to stave off checkmate. The more we calculated, however, the more we recognized that no such opportunity existed: it was a figment of our imagination, and it was undoubtedly a figment

of Ding Liren's imagination as well. Take a look at how the game unfolds:

70. ... Qg1+ 71. Kh4 Qh1+ 72. Kg3 Qee1+ 73. Kg4 Qhh4+ 74. Kf5



The point is that while the king can be dislodged from the queen, White's other queen will jump into the defense. If the queen had been anywhere but f8, the game would have been over immediately!

74. ... Qh5+ 75. Kf6!

Avoiding the dreadful 75. Qg5?? Qa5+.

75. ... Qa1+ 76. Ke6 Qa2+ 77. Kf6 Qb2+ 78. Ke6 Qb3+

Ding attempts a staircase checking pattern, but to absolutely no avail.

79. Kf6 Qb2+ 80. Ke6 Qb3+ 81. Kf6 Qc3+ 82. Ke6 Qg6+ 83. Q4f6 Qc6+ 84. Ke7 Qc5+ 85. Ke6 Qc6+ 86. Ke7 Qc7+ 87. Ke6 Qb6+ 88. Ke7 Qc5+ 89. Ke6 Qcf5+!?

Creating an absolutely fascinating picture: all four queens are locked in battle, but MVL hangs on with room to spare.

90. Ke7 Qc5+, Draw agreed.

What's amazing about this game is not only the aesthetic effect of four queens being on the board for so long. It is that the aesthetic value does not detract one whit from this game's *instructive* value, for it is as good an illustration as any of the danger of over-confiding in one's intuition. ♠

Are All Rook Endgames Drawn?

Siegbert Tarrasch's maxim is put to the test.

By GM DANIEL NARODITSKY

INCREASED CONSUMPTION OF SWEET tea and slow-cooked beef brisket are not the only by-products of my recent move to Charlotte, North Carolina. As the resident grandmaster of the Charlotte Chess Center and Scholastic Academy, I also have the privilege of observing the grandmaster (GM) and international master (IM) norm tournaments that the center organizes several times a year. These tournaments generally fly under the radar, but they invariably feature talented players who produce heady, fighting chess game after game.

In today's column, we will examine just such a fighting affair from the most recent IM-norm tournament. What could be better than two experienced players duking it out in a fascinating endgame with a potential IM norm on the line?

TITLE ON THE LINE

IM Roberto Martin Del Campo (2392)
Richard Francisco (2362)
CCCSA: Winter 2020 GM/IM Norm
Invitational (5), Charlotte, North Carolina,
01.18.2020



AFTER 36. Rh7

Mexican IM Roberto Martin Del Campo, a dangerous and experienced player who has

participated in several Olympiads, conducted the opening and middlegame in splendid fashion. At first blush, it appears that Black's best course of action is resignation: White is about to win a second pawn, and in both cases his massive kingside pawn phalanx should lead to an uneventful conclusion. Indeed, that White's position is objectively winning brooks no debate. **However, we are all familiar with Siegbert Tarrasch's maxim "all rook endgames are drawn."** These words are not to be taken literally, but there is something to be said for the notion that in rook endgames, the material situation is generally low on the list of evaluative criteria, far below piece activity and the state of passed pawns. To muddy the waters, Black resists the urge to cling to his pawns and find a way to exploit this feature of rook endings.

36. ... Rb1+!

And the strong master from Atlanta does just that! If you involve Mr. Stockfish in the conversation, you will find that 36. ... Ke3 is the best move by a country mile. The idea is clear: the threat of checkmate distracts White's rook from its hunt. However, after 37. Re7+ Kf4 (The try 37. ... Kd4 is even more hopeless, as after 38. h4 White simply runs his pawns up the board, e.g. 38. ... Rb1+ 39. Kf2 d5 40. g4 Kc3 41. g5 hxg5 42. hxg5 d4 43. Rc7+ Kd2 44. g6) 38. Re4+ Kf5 39. g4+ Kg5 40. Kf2 the win is elementary: White simply keeps his rook on the e-file and shoves his pawn phalanx down Black's gut. Black's best attempt is 40. ... Kh4, but a few precise moves seal the deal: 41. Re5! (threatening mate on h5) 41. ... Rb2+ 42. Ke3 Rb3+ (After 42. ... Rxh2 43. Rh5+ Kg3 44. Rxh2 Kxh2 45. f4 the promotion is unstoppable) 43. Ke4 Rb4+ 44. Kf5 Rb6 45. Rd5 Kh3 46. f4 Kxh2 47. g5 and Black is dead meat.

I have no doubt that Francisco spotted the possibility of 36. ... Ke3, but decided that pushing his passer as quickly as possible would constitute a far superior practical chance in his opponent's time pressure. The computer may laugh at him, but he is proven absolutely correct!

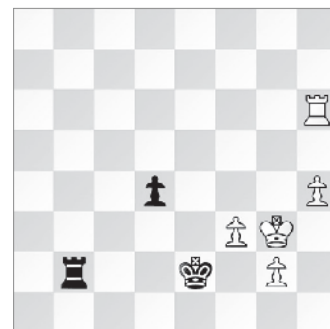
37. Kf2 d5 38. Rxh6

Del Campo remains unfazed, capturing the pawn and paving the way for his pawn army. From a general standpoint, his strategy is obvious: push the pawns and give up the rook for the d-pawn at the last possible moment. In practice, however, things are far more complicated than they seem.

38. ... Rb2+ 39. Kg3 d4 40. h4

Another precise decision. Pushing the other pawn—40. f4?!—was clearly inferior due to 40. ... Ke4, although White is still winning after 41. Re6+.

40. ... Ke2



At this point, a chill almost certainly went down Del Campo's spine. Black is only three moves from promotion and the pigheaded 41. h5 is not fast enough: 41. ... d3 42. Re6+ Kf1! 43. Rd6 Ke2 and 44. h6 leads nowhere after

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See the solutions on page 71.

PROBLEM I: 1500 LEVEL

GM Radoslaw Wojtaszek (2741)
GM Anish Giri (2793)
FIDE World Cup, 09.22.2015



WHITE TO MOVE

PROBLEM II: 2000 LEVEL

GM Viktor Korchnoi (2655)
GM Rafael Vaganian (2585)
World Cup, Skelleftea, 08.1989



BLACK TO MOVE

44. ... d2 45. h7 Rb8 and White is the one who must exercise caution.

Seeing this, Del Campo decides to free up the h-pawn's colleague before deciding which pawn to push. Logical, right?

41. Kf4?

This move is a brilliant illustration that what is logical is not always correct. White may have three passed pawns, but their progress will be incredibly cumbersome; they resemble a serpent laboriously slithering its way toward a faraway target. White had to buy himself as much time as possible with 41. Re6+!, forcing a disastrous concession. No matter where the king retreats, Black loses several crucial tempi:

- a) 41. ... Kf1 loses to 42. Rd6! (this is what Del Campo missed: White actually gives up the low-quality g2-pawn!) 42. ... Rxd6+ 43. Kf4 Rd2 (43. ... Rh2 44. Rxd4 Rxd4 45. Ke2 is curtains) 44. Ke4 Rh2 45. Rxd4 and White simply trades the h-pawn for the d-pawn, when Black's king will be way too far away to halt the f-pawn's progress.
- b) 41. ... Kd2 puts the king in front of the pawn and gives White just enough extra time: 42. h5 d3 43. h6 Rb8 44. f4 Kc2 45. f5 d2 46. Rc6+! (the same technique, buying a crucial extra tempo) 46. ... Kd3 47. Rd6+ Ke2 48. Kf4 d1=Q 49. Rxd1 Kxd1 50. h7 and the win is elementary.

In my view, these lines brilliantly illustrate the power of practical play. When your position is lost, **you must seek an opportunity that reduces your opponent's margin of error, and not necessarily the path that prolongs the game as much as possible.**

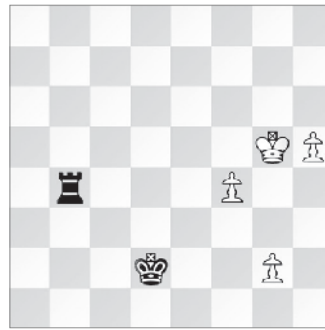
41. ... d3 42. Re6+ Kf2 43. Rd6 Rb4+!

An important check, clearing the way for Black's king to occupy a dominant stance on e3.

44. Kg5 Ke3 45. h5 d2 46. Rxd2

A sad necessity: 46. h6 met with 46. ... Rb5+ 47. Kf6 Rb6!, when only Black can win.

46. ... Kxd2 47. f4



47. ... Ke3?

At this point, both players were surviving on increment. Francisco understandably prioritizes his king, but the king does not possess either enough horsepower or enough speed to contribute to the defense. Instead, 47. ... Rb8! secured an immediate draw by creating the threat of ... Rg8+. Only after 48. g4 does Black involve the king: 48. ... Ke3 49. h6 Rg8+ 50. Kf6 Kxf4 (or 50. ... Rxd4) 51. h7 Rh8 with a draw.

48. f5 Rb8 49. f6

And therein lies the rub: after 47. ... Rb8 48. f5, Black could have immediately picked off the g-pawn with 48. ... Rg8+. Now, he is too late, since 49. ... Rg8+ 50. Kf5 Rxd2 51. f7 Rf2+ 52. Ke6 is clearly lost: the rook cannot hold both pawns at once. In a last-ditch effort, Francisco rushes the slovenly monarch to the new center of the battle:

49. ... Ke4 50. h6??

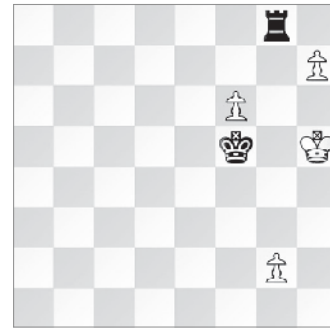
And it works! With his time ticking down, Del Campo forgets that this move deprives his king of both key squares along the sixth rank. He may have hallucinated that Black stops the pawns after 50. f7 Ke5 51. Kg6 Ke6, but the straightforward 52. h6 Rf8 53. h7 permanently ties Black down. The winning plan is to advance the pawn to g5, move the

king to h6, and finish the job with g6-g7. There is absolutely nothing that Black can do.

50. ... Rg8+! 51. Kh5 Kf5!

All of a sudden, the king is boxed in and the pawns have turned from three-headed monsters into sitting ducks.

52. h7



At this point, my eyes were transfixed on the live transmission feed. After 52. ... Rb8, Black actually wins: 53. Kh6 Kxf6 54. g4 and it may appear that the pawn's progress is unstoppable, but 54. ... Kf7!! 55. g5 Rb6+ 56. Kh5 Kg7 crushes White's dreams. With his hand shaking, and 15 seconds turning to 10 turning to 5, Francisco understandably decides to liquidate:

52. ... Rxd2

Given the complexity of the situation, as well as the heroic manner in which Black has fought back, I will spare Richard a question mark. As tempting as it is, this move leads only to a draw, since the threat of promotion will force Black to either give up his rook or acquiesce to a perpetual check.

53. Kh6 Rg6+ 54. Kh5 Rg1 55. Kh6 Rg6+ 56. Kh5 Rg1 57. Kh6, Draw agreed.

There are two things you should remember. The first is that Dr. Tarrasch was, err, a genius, and the second is that endgames can be plenty instructive and fun even if two grandmasters do not sit behind the wheel!♠